She-Ra: Aftershock

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31222055.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M, M/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Adora/Catra Angst (She-Ra), Glimbow, catradora, Queen Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow holds the group together, Lots of Angst, Mental Illness is present, this is my first fic pls be nice, no beta we die like shadow weaver, Catra probably would lose a life reading this., Canon Compliant, Hurt/Comfort, Self-Esteem Issues, They eventually work through it, Hurt Catra (She-Ra), Hurt Adora (She-Ra), OC villian - Freeform

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by LunaRay43

Summary

Re-write in Progress
PREVIOUSLY TITLED SHE-RA YEAR 1!!!
Directly following the aftermath of season 5 episode 13, follow Catra, Adora and crew as they navigate life after the war. Here come fights, games, love, angst, and trouble for the Best Friend Squad to conquer.
Catra and Adora struggle with feelings and everything done during the war. Glimmer and Catra work together to restore Etheria, without killing each other. Bow struggles to be the therapy friend. And a deadly force waits for Adora.

Arson and Nightmares

Chapter 1: Catra

"You love me?" Adora's word rang over and over in her ears. "I love you too." Her ears folded back as she attempted to keep her cheeks from burning. Adora had run out to take care of Prime's ending the world scheme. Catra now stood alone in Heart; its beating sound echoing her own.

She shook her head and started for the exit, back the way they had come. She clenched her fists as she passed the room where Shadow Weaver had died. She paused for a moment, staring at the mask on the floor. That mask has terrorized her all of her life and yet she still felt a weight on her heart. Why would she feel bad? Shadow Weaver was finally gone out of their lives for good. Her last words haunted Catra.

"Stop." She spoke out loud to herself. She took a deep breath and padded into the room. Picking up the mask, she starred it down. So many words fumbled around in her brain, but nothing came out. Anger, hurt, sadness, joy. How she could feel all of this for the woman who had spent all of her life tormenting her, she couldn't understand. She sighed. She didn't want to be the one to make this call.

She put the mask down and made a note to return with Adora at a later date. As she stepped outside, she was met with a new world flowing with new flora and fauna. Everything was so bright.

Adora as She-Ra stood tall and glowing as people around her celebrated. Prime was gone. Catra started towards her when she saw Scorpia. She took a deep breath and walked towards her. She was talking loudly with Frosta and Perfuma. When they saw each other, Catra tried for a shy smile. She had been preparing this and

she knew what she would say. If Scorpia would ever forgive her, that was another question.

"Hey, Scorpia. Look, I…" She was swooped into a big hug, crushing the words out of her. "Oh, there it is."

"You know, I'm a hugger." Scorpia smiled. Catra returned it. They still would need to talk but for now, Scorpia was saying everything was forgiven. Perfuma tackled them, calling for a "Princess Hug!" Frosta joined in, tackling them to the ground.

After Scorpia finally put her down, she talked with them briefly before she spotted Adora again. She had walked away from the others, shrinking back into the Adora she knew and loved. She stood looking over the new place she had created, a new, small slope in front of them. Catra excused herself and made her way over to Adora.

"Adora." The blonde smiled as Catra approached, the Horde behind her symbolizing Catra's journey from there back into Adora's arms.

"It's over." She breathed as they touched foreheads. Catra purred in response. "He's gone."

"Good riddance."

Suddenly, Glimmer and Bow yelled and tackled them. The four slid down the hill, laughter erupting into the air.

"So, what are we going to do now?" Bow propped himself up on an elbow.

"We can bring magic back to the Universe." Adora sighed happily. "What do you guys say to one more Best Friend Squad road trip?"

"I'm in!" Glimmer said.

"Obviously!" Bow chimed in.

"Of course, I'm going with you, dummy." Catra smiled.

"Then, let's do this, together!"

"Can we do that road trip now?" Glimmer groaned as she facepalmed the table.

"We gotta figure out what to do first." Bow said gently. He shuffled some of the papers and wiped some forgotten grime off his forehead. Catra looked on with a very bored look. Adora had fallen asleep, leaning against Catra's back. She should be worried about the weird angle of her body, but she couldn't bring herself wake her.

After everything, the Princess Alliance all returned to Bright Moon for a celebration and to get things in order. Most everyone was asleep. Catra could hear those who were still awake having whispered conversations. Apparently, Mermista had fallen asleep as well shortly after arriving back and it was starting to cause worry. Catra felt a phantom pain in her neck. She remembered what it was like under the chip. The first time she actually slept after she was free, she didn't wake for a while either. Adora had freaked out too. Against her better judgement, Catra got Bow to help her move Adora so she could go talk to Seahawk.

She hadn't really spoken to him before. She knew that he was at least something to Mermista as most of her encounters with him were because of her. That and the way he carried himself at the moment, it was evident. He loved her.

The pirate in question paced the room slowly beside the cot where the Water Princess slumbered. The green marks had finally receded, but the damage was done. Scorpia had also collapsed from exhaustion shortly after getting back and now rested nearby, her head on Perfuma's lap. Catra was glad Scorpia had someone who was nice to her in the way Catra couldn't have been.

“Hey.” Catra whispered, crossing her arms in insecurity. “How is she?” Seahawk didn’t even blink twice at her.

“She’s exhausted to say the least. I wish I knew what I could do the help. If she were awake, I could sing a sea shanty or tell her of adventures of past.” Catra wasn’t sure if that would help but she returned his tense smile.

“I don’t really know her but I’m sure that could help…” She gulped and rubbed her arm. With a sigh, she looked down. She at least couldn’t look at him and say it. “You know, when Adora… when she…. saved me from the chip…” She cleared her throat and looked down at the girl. “I slept for a while too. The nightmares were pretty bad but I’m sure she’ll be fine. She seems like a strong person.” It was so weird to be this nice!!! Catra wanted to punch a wall. She bit her tongue to stop the retort that wanted so badly to tag itself on her nice statement.

When she finally looked back up, Seahawk’s eyes were shining like Bow’s did when he called her cute. He sniffled a little before clearing his throat and returning to normal.

“Thanks, Catra. It means a lot.” He turned to start pacing again. “I’m glad you’re here. Adora definitely missed you.” He started off, leaving Catra alone with that. And she thought she was cruel.

Catra blinked herself back to reality and returned to her spot with Adora. Bow immediately asked for her help concerning some village before Glimmer answered. She smiled a little. Maybe life with them wouldn’t be too terrible. She took Adora’s hand by the pinky and held it quietly. She resisted folding her ears down and tried to focus. She didn’t want to let go again.

An hour passed with the three of them discussing what they would do about the Horde armies and what life would look like now. Finally, some food was brought in for everyone who was still awake. Catra reached for a steam bun, like the ones they had eaten on the ride back to Etheria. She looked towards Adora to

offer her one and panic welled in her. Green veins snaked their way up Adora's body as her eyebrows contorted in pain.

"Adora!" Catra dropped it and shook her awake. Adora jolted upright, sputtering a confused 'What?!'. Bow and Glimmer stood from their seats and the room hushed. Catra felt her fur spike, ending any chance she had of playing things off. Adora met her eyes and made Catra feel stupid. The green marks weren't there. She was seeing things.

"Catra, what's wrong?" Glimmer asked.

"Nothing." Catra took a breath and stroked her tail's fur down. "It's nothing." She stood and walked out the door.

As she stepped outside, she walked to the railing. She hung her head over it, letting the wind blow through her fur. That was exactly what she wanted to deal with today.

"Catra?" Adora stepped out. She was still pretty tired, but Adora was clearly not going to lay back down. "What's wrong?"

Catra shook her head. The pain in her abdomen from leaning over the railing helped ground her. This was reality. Everything was finally good for once. She wasn't going to be left behind anymore.

"Catra." Adora poked her side. "Catra~!" Poke. "Catra." Poke. Poke. "Are you just going to ignore me?" Poke. Poke. Poke. Catra felt her tail thrash a little and decided she was gonna have some fun.

"AH!" Adora squealed as the two suddenly fell to the ground. Catra, pinning Adora's arms to the ground and sitting on her chest, smiled proudly.

"Now what…Princess~." They laughed together before Adora slammed Catra's back into the ground.

"Now what yourself." Adora giggled. Despite the lame comeback, Catra chuckled. "Now tell me."

"I don't want to." Catra murmured.

"Please. I thought we agreed to talk about stuff." Leave it to Adora to bring up their discussion on Darla.

"Just…" Sigh. "Give me five minutes alone. I'm not leaving, I just need a moment to think." Perfuma's advice on how to deal with moments like this had come in handy. Maybe she should talk to Flowers more often.

Adora stared her down, clearly contemplating her options. After a long moment, she sat back. Wordlessly, she walked back into the room. Catra had her five minutes. She moved to sit back against the railing.

Why was this so difficult?! Catra had made up with Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta on Darla. She had made friends with Melog on Krytis. If that's what you call an entity imprinting on you suddenly. But who doesn't do that when someone is nice to them?!

Speaking of the Krytian, Melog mewed into view and curled on her lap.

"I'm glad you're alive too. Thanks for all your help, buddy."

"Catra." Melog headbutted her. "We saved each other."

"You've been talking to Flowers, haven't you?"

"Maybe." Melog snickered. "She does give good ear scratches. You should try one sometime."

"No thanks." Catra didn't even want to go there with her imagination. "So. What now?"

"Now we live here." Melog asked. "Is that not the plan?"

“I mean…” She didn’t think it’d stay with her past this point.

“Did you think I would leave as well?” Catra’s silence answered that question. “We imprint for life.” It licked her face. “As you would say, you are stuck with me.”

“Thanks, Melog. I’m gonna let what you said slide this time.”

“I only speak the truth. I do reflect your emotions.” Melog snickered again. Catra looked out to all the new scenery again.

“Melog, how do I even start to make this better?” She buried her face in its fur. Tears were unbecoming of Force Captains. Not when others were present, at least. She shouldn’t cry. Today has been a victory.

“Catra.” Melog purred louder. “You are free to cry. She was the only thing you had as a mother. She was not a good mother. Good mothers give lots of headbutts and cuddles.”

“That might have been your mom.” Catra said, muffled by the fur.

“Regardless, you are still allowed to cry. I would go get Adora, but I heard you asked for a few minutes alone.”

“Yeah, alone. That’s going well.”

“We are imprinted. You will never be alone again.”

“I don’t know how I feel about that.” Catra tried for a joke.

“I will always be here.” Melog headbutted her again. “Adora and I will make sure you are always loved.”

“You know I’m supposed to be sulking.”

“Ah yes. You were not given the proper outlet for teen angst with the Horde situation. Please continue as if I’m not here.”

"Where has this sass been?" Catra pulled back and stared Melog down.

"We are imprinted."

"Are you giving me my own sass then?"

"Yes." Melog chirped. Catra chuckled, wiping the tears from her eyes.

"Thanks." She could feel her cheeks growing red but didn't mind it. "How do I even explain anything to them?" The door to the War Room creaked open. "I still have another minute!" She rushed to bury her face again.

"Oh." The deepness of the voice forced her head back up. Seahawk shifted awkwardly. "I didn't realize you were busy…"

"Seahawk?" Melog asked.

"Yeah." Catra tapped Melog and they both stood. "Did Mermista wake up?"

"No. Adora tried another healing spell before collapsing herself again." Catra's fur stood up. Of course, she would do that again. Adora didn't know when to stop. "I saw you walk out here and Adora was upset when she came back in."

Adora and the others had described the Princess Alliance to her on their way back from Prime's ship. Loyal, Arson, Shanties, and Random were the words used to describe Seahawk. Since Catra had never really faced him in a fight, that was what she had to go off of. She was not expecting this.

"King Micah suggested those of us awake should try to relax. He took over some of the planning and sent the others to their rooms." Four minutes and she missed that much? "And I was wondering if you were busy." Catra blinked at him. Was…was he asking her for something?

"I mean I was going to go…" Her cheeks burned. She couldn't admit she was going to go cuddle Adora while she slept. That would be weird. The Princess Alliance was definitely weird but not that weird.

"Perfuma suggested something." Seahawk said. "If you're up for it." Flowers suggested something? Catra felt the anxiety creep up in her a little. Perfuma's help seemed to work half the time.

"You're okay with me?" She asked hesitantly. Melog's mane shifted to a muted red.

"Adora trusts you. As do Bow and Glimmer." Seahawk said. "It seems we wouldn't have won without you. If my beautiful Mermista didn't give me second chances, I would've never been her plus one at Princess Prom!" She resisted the urge to snort as he struck some weird pose.

"Fine." She agreed. Her instincts were all over the place. "Let's go."

"This wasn't what I had in mind." She admitted. Several piles of rubble laid before them. Seahawk had taken her and Melog on a skiff through the words toward the Fright Zone. There, she had parked it for him, and they disembarked. She held a small log that flickered with flames. Her eyes shifted between that and the person in front of her. "I guess they were telling the truth when they said Arson." She muttered to Melog.

"Okay!" Seahawk exclaimed before running back to her side. "Throw it as far as you can." He clasped his hands together, giving her those bright eyes again.

"Throw it?" Her eyes shifted between Melog and Seahawk.

"Yeah!" Seahawk picked up another small log and used her flame to light his. He drew his leg up as he wound up for a throw.

He grunted as he threw the small flame.

WOOSH! One of the piles of rubble exploded into flames. Catra's eyes widened.

“Man. There is nothing like setting things on fire. Though, boats are best for that. That’s what happened to the Dragon’s Daughter 1, 2 and 3.”

Catra listened as he proclaimed stories of ships he had set on fire. She vaguely remembered a burning ship ramming the Horde one she’d rode on during her first trip to Salineas. She glanced at Melog once more, who shrugged at her. She guessed it couldn’t hurt.

She wound up for her throw, aiming for the closest. She was fairly strong, but she didn’t dare go for a further back one yet. She chucked the flame as hard as she could. WOOSH! Another pire lit up the air.

“Good job!” Seahawk laughed loudly. He slapped her arm and reached for two more logs.

“I thought you all were the good guys. Didn’t expect you’d be good burning things.” Catra admitted.

“Perfuma told me Adora said you like to blow things up. What better way than controlled flames!” Seahawk finished with another pire exploding into flames. Catra realized all the rubble piles were set far enough away, no real damage could be done.

“Adora talked about me?” She smirked as she tossed another one. BLOOM!

“Not often other than the battlefield. Mermista told me of a time when they were planning…” BOOM! “An attack on a Horde fortress. Apparently, Adora was focused on how to take you down.” Seahawk laughed. “Mermista said they ended up storming the place.”

“Was that the Giant Plant Golem?” Catra felt the laugh escape her before she could stop it.

“YES! They said Perfuma conjured it!”

“Scorpia reported it. I never believed her.” The two openly laughed.

The two continued their game until all the pires were alit with fire, the flames rising through the smog of the Fright Zone close by.

“I’m glad you’ve joined us.” Seahawk panted after throwing his last.

“Really?” Catra grunted as her last stick flew towards the back right. “I thought you’d react more like Frosta did.”

“How can I?” He proclaimed to the sky. “You like to blow things up! We could set so many ships on fire!”

“Thanks.” She felt her cheeks burning and looked down. “Maybe we can do this again soon.” That felt weird to say.

“Of course!” Seahawk slapped a hand on her shoulder with a laugh. “Anytime you wish to blow something up, let me know!”

As they returned to Bright Moon’s castle, night began to fall. All the stars shone brightly in the sky. Maybe she did get a second chance.

Seahawk helped lead her back towards the War Room, which was their current hub of operations. As they entered the room, they realized most everyone was awake now. Adora slumped against the table, picking at her plate. Bow and Glimmer spoke with Entrapta and Micah. The other Princesses had created their own little posse in the corner of the room.

“MERMISTA~!!” Seahawk sang as he strode across the room towards her. Though she couldn’t see the Water Princess, she could hear the “UGH!!” that came from that corner.

“Catra!” Adora perked up and flew out of her seat. “Did you have fun?!” Someone must have told her. Catra nodded to keep herself under control. Force Captains didn’t show many emotions.

“Hey, Seahawk. Are we good?” Bow called. He laughed as the pirate gave him a thumbs up. “We asked him to take some of the rubble out to clear up some of the castle. We’ll have to start rebuilding soon.” He informed them as he and Glimmer joined them.

“Perfuma suggested the two of you go. Figured it’d help burn off any stress.” Glimmer winked.

“I’ll have to thank her later, then.” Catra stood a little straighter. No way Sparkles outdoing her today.

“I don’t know about you guys, but I’m ready for bed.” Adora yawned.

“Are we still doing the sleepover?” Glimmer asked.

“What sleepover?” Catra's fur bristled a little. She hadn’t heard of this, though she had been gone part of the day.

“Not tonight. I don’t think Catra would be up to it yet.” Adora clasped her hand and smiled. “Maybe another night?”

“Fine.” Glimmer said playfully. “Tomorrow night it is!” She poofed away.

“Go get some sleep. Celebrations start tomorrow and we’ll all need the rest.” Bow smiled before walking towards Micah.

“Why do I feel like I’m missing something?” Catra asked.

“Maybe I just want a minute to talk?”

"Oh no."

"Nothing bad." Adora led her from the War Room. Silence hung in the air until Adora stopped in front of a random door. "In here." She opened the door with a creak and pulled Catra inside. She shut the door quickly, which set off red flags.

"Adora…"

"I just want to talk." She sounded like she was trying to convince herself of it first.

Catra took in the room briefly. At least the Horde was good at teaching how to assess things quickly. The room flushed with pastels in a nauseating fashion. Colored curtains draped around the room with a random cot towards the back of the room. A waterfall bubbled quietly off to the side. No certain threats in the room, except for the blonde behind her.

"Okay?" Catra ended up taking a seat on the cot. Why would Adora chose to sleep on the hard beds like those in the Horde, she didn't know. Glimmer had said fluffy beds were standard in Bright Moon. Catra felt kinda gypped.

"Did you mean it?!" Adora blurted out. She slid down the doorframe and clutched her mouth.

"What?"

"Did…did you mean it?" Catra raised an eyebrow. "What you said."

"You're such an idiot."

"I…" Adora looked down. "I just can't believe it."

Catra's cheeks flushed for the umptieth time today as she remembered what she said at the Heart. How could she explain? She had spoken in the heat of the moment. All she knew was she had Adora back and she wasn't losing her again.

They sat in silence for a while.

"Forget I said anything." Adora finally spoke. She walked to the bed and crawled past Catra. "Goodnight."

"Adora…" Catra paused, hand outstretched. She wasn't good at this sort of thing. They sat in silence again. Catra sighed and curled up at the end of the bed, like they used to do.

"You can sleep up here."

"What?" Catra had barely heard the whisper.

"I said, you can sleep up here." Adora didn't turn around or anything. She laid perfectly still, legs pulled up like before. Catra contemplated it. She didn't mind sleeping at the foot of the bed.

"There's not a lot of room…"

"We've made it work before…on Darla."

Silence.

Catra, finally, crept up towards Adora. She laid down with her back to Adora. On Darla, they had slept cuddled together and it had been the best sleep she had gotten since Adora defected three years ago. But now it just felt too awkward.

"Mine." Adora rolled over and wrapped her arms and legs around Catra. Catra's claws sprung out and retracted quickly. She took a deep breath to calm herself.

"Adora. I'm not leaving tonight."

"Mine." She wrapped around her tighter.

"Whatever." Catra tried to hide her smile. "Goodnight."

"Goodnight."

“Hello Little Sister.” Horde Prime stood over her. She could feel the electricity jumping over the water behind her. The bright white of the ship nearly blinded her after he had thrown her in a dark room.

“I told you, you aren’t getting your hands on Adora.”

“I’m not?” Horde Prime smirked. “I beg to differ, Little Sister. She’ll come back.”

“No, she won’t.” Catra could still picture Adora’s ship indicator moving off his screen as she was dragged into this room last time. “She’s not coming back for me. We both saw her ship leaving. You won’t get your hands on the Heart of Etheria.”

“You don’t need to worry about that anymore, child. You’ll be in the light soon enough. Come and find peace.”

CAST OUT THE SHADOWS!

CAST OUT THE SHADOWS!

CAST OUT THE SHADOWS!

CAST OUT THE SHADOWS!

The chant grew louder and louder. Two of the clones picked Catra up by the chains that bound her hands to her back. Kicking and screaming, she thrashed around.

“Find peace, Little Sister.” The two clones dropped her chains as they threw her into the water.

The green water caked itself to her fur like mud and the burning smell of the electricity filled her nostrils. She broke the surface, gasping for air.

“You!!” Catra’s declaration turned into a scream as the electricity pulsed. As the surge stopped, she fell under the water again, her breath stolen from her. Her hands flew to her throat,

gasping for air. She clawed her way up to the surface again. As soon as she did, the electricity surged through her again. Her hands shook in front of her, framing Horde Prime's smirk that was glaring down at her.

"Little Sister. Do not fight me."

"Catra!" A voice broke through it. "Catra, wake up!"

"AH!" A scream echoed through the night as she bolted straight up. Her chest burned for air and claws raked the sheets, looking for her target.

"Hey!" Hands wrapped around her wrists. Catra jumped and pinned her target. Horde Prime had found her again. She wasn't going down like this. She moved one hand towards the throat of her target. She squeezed her fist and could hear Horde Prime choking for air. She wasn't being baptized again. She wasn't putting Adora at risk again!

"Get off her!" Glimmer's voice echoed loudly as the lights flashed on. Temporarily blinded, Catra hissed. A ball of sparkles hit her side, throwing her off balance.

"Catra. Wake up!" Bow's hands wrapped around her waist, lifting her in the air. She clawed at them. Everything was blurry and loud. What was happening…

"Are you okay?" Glimmer was leaning over Horde Prime. Why was she asking him if he was fine?! That was their enemy!

"I'm fine." Adora's voice rasped. Catra shook her head a second and blinked. The room finally came into focus. Pastels. Ripped cloth all over. Adora's bending over at the stomach.

It wasn't Horde Prime. Catra's stomach turned. What had she done?

"Hey." Adora stood, despite Glimmer's protests. She walked to Catra and waved for Bow to release her. He put her feet on the

ground but still held his arms tight. “I’m okay. It was a nightmare.” Adora wiped her cheek for her, when Catra realized she was the one crying. “You’re okay. We’re not leaving.” Adora hugged her tight.

“Goodness, what would’ve happened had we not still been up?” Glimmer pinched her nose. Catra buried her head in Adora’s shoulder. Bow’s arms finally released as he backed away. Adora hugged her tighter, supporting their body weight. She lowered them to the ground.

I haven’t seen one this bad since the trip back.” Bow whispered. Did he forget she had better hearing than them? “Adora, we’ll be right back.” Catra felt the air ripple as they teleported away.

Catra wanted to speak. What did she say? She had just made up with them all. She had finally told Adora she loved her. She thought maybe things would get better and here she was, messing everything up again.

Maybe this is what she deserved. Maybe she was still stuck on the Velvet Glove, chipped and at Prime’s command. She had done so many things to hurt people. She deserved every piece of hate she got. She figured if nothing else, in the morning she’d be forced to leave. Glimmer and Bow wouldn’t let her keep hurting Adora like this. Everything she had done up to this point was for nothing. All she did was hurt people. Adora, Scorpia, her old team in the Horde, herself…Catra wasn’t made for this life.

“Hey.” Adora’s voice cut through. “Catra.” No. She wasn’t listening. Adora was going to say something about how it didn’t matter. “It’s okay.” It wasn’t okay. Shadow Weaver was right. “I’m not leaving.” They all hate her anyway. “Talk to me.” How could she? “I’m not mad.” The love in Adora’s voice made her sick to her stomach.

“Adora, we should get that bandaged.” Bow said, announcing their return. Catra remembered seeing a bathroom to the right, by

the waterfall. She pushed Adora back, eyes closed so she wouldn't see the hurt in the blonde's eyes. She ran into the bathroom and slammed the door shut.

Air. She just needed some air. Too late. She reached for the toilet and threw up everything she had left. She could hear the pounding on the door. She could hear their voices. She felt the air ripple as Glimmer teleported into the room.

"We are not doing this tonight." The queen spoke sharply. She unlocked the door with her back to the cat girl, letting Catra have some privacy. Adora rushed into the room and immediately started rubbing circles on Catra's back.

"Get off!" Catra's voice went shrill as she pushed Adora away. "Just stop it."

"Catra." Bow spoke first. "How can we help?"

"Leave me alone." Catra curled into herself. Her ears folded down and her tail curled around her legs. "Just leave me alone. I'll leave in the morning and you won't have to deal with me."

"Why do you think I want you gone?" Adora's voice broke. "Did what happen today mean nothing?"

"All I do is hurt people!" Her muscles screamed as she held herself tighter. "If I don't go, you'll never be happy."

"You promised to stay with me."

"Catra." Bow's voice calmed spoke. "We need to get you cleaned up. Adora, would you move for a second?"

"I can do it."

"Adora, we need to clean your arm." Catra finally looked up when Glimmer spoke. She could see the gash on Adora's arm, blood dripping to the floor. How could they look at that and say she could stay?

I'll heal it with …"

"Adora." Bow said. "Let Glimmer bandage it. You're too tired from today to use She-Ra right now, safely."

"And even if you aren't, something tells me we're going to need our energy for the next few hours." Glimmer said. "Come on." Adora grumbled as she stood up. She squeezed Catra's shoulder and moved away for Glimmer to bandage her arm.

"Hey Catra." Bow's tone was calm, and it felt patronizing. She tried not to take it personally. She knew what he was thinking. She was like a cornered animal and he was trying not to die. "Can you turn towards me?"

No."

"We're not mad. Adora had this too." Catra froze a little and finally met his eyes. They were bright, despite the dark circles. "When she first arrived here, she had nightmares too. We slept in her room the first few nights because she couldn't sleep alone. She missed you sleeping at the end of the bed. She still sleeps with her legs up."

"How did you know that?"

"Know what?'

"That she missed me…"

"She's not good at hiding it." Catra snorted at his answer. "And neither are you."

"Wow. Didn't realize it was shoot Catra hour."

"I'm just speaking truth." Bow put his hands in the air. "but really, none of us are mad. Can we get you cleaned up?" Catra hesitated. "You can't really go back to sleep in those."

She finally looked down at herself. Her gray tank and shorts, standard in the Horde, were covered in blood, and remnants of dinner, and had several tears. She nodded a little and her body ached as she finally released her curled form.

"Adora. Do you have another set of these?"

"Yeah, let me grab them." Glimmer had been blocking Adora from walking back over. Adora exited the bathroom.

"It's a good thing we set that up." Glimmer sighed.

"We knew it would be needed." Bow chuckled. Adora entered with another set. Bow took them and handed them to Catra. "Go ahead with Adora. Catra and I will join in a second." With that, Glimmer poofed them away. Bow stood and pointed to the door. "I'll be right outside so you can change. Knock when you're ready."

"Why are you being so nice?" Catra whispered.

"Why wouldn't we be?" Bow answered. "You're one of us now, the Best Friend Squad." He closed the door.

Catra stood and went to the mirror. He was right. She hadn't had a nightmare like this since they first rescued her from the Velvet Glove. She could still remember the first several times she had woken up. She tore off the soiled versions and threw them to the trash. She grabbed a small towel, cleaning off herself with warm water. She may have hated it, but it was a necessary evil to avoid crusty fur.

She picked up the gray shorts and realized Adora had already cut out a hole for her tail. She wondered how many pairs Adora had like this. A few times when they were kids, Adora would accidently grab the wrong pair of shorts and Catra would tease her endlessly about it. She pulled them on and then the top. She sighed before knocking on the door. Bow opened it with a smile.

“Ready?” He held out a blue blanket. “Adora said you might like this.” She took it gingerly and sniffed it. It smelled like Adora. She threw it around her shoulders and held it close. “Let’s go.”

He led her out into the hallway. As they wound their way around, Catra vaguely realized they were heading back to the War Room. Of course, that is where they would kick her out. They’d do it in front of everyone. Hordak had done that when he banished her to the Crimson Waste. She figured they’d be no different.

She glanced out at the stars as they passed a window. Maybe they’d banish her off planet. Princesses were liars after all. She knew they didn’t mean it when they said they’d forgive her. Nothing she could ever do would fix everything she had done.

Bow finally stopped, in front of the War Room. She had guessed right. He knocked and waited for a voice to answer. He pushed the doors open. She hissed as the lights forced her eyes closed again. The hallway was barely lit for the hour of night it was.

“There she is.” Scorpia’s voice made her open her eyes again. Scorpia, Perfuma, Glimmer and Adora sat in a small semi-circle. They had set up beds nearby. Mermista and the others were nowhere to be seen. “Hey Wildcat.”

“What?”

“We’re having a sleepover.” Perfuma answered.

“I’m not really comfortable sleeping alone either.” Scorpia scratched the back of her head. “So, we’ll all sleep together, and it’ll be fun.”

Catra ignored the rest of the banter. Adora’s arm was properly bandaged and no longer was bleeding. She had changed clothes as well.

“Come on.” Bow’s hand brushed her arm. “Let’s go lay down.” He took a few steps in front of her and stopped.

“Why.” Catra swallowed hard. “Why aren’t you kicking me out?”

“We don’t do that here.” Glimmer answered. “I’m Queen and it’s my castle. I get to decide who stays and who goes.”

“But.”

“But nothing, Catra.” Glimmer smiled. “Now get over here and cuddle with Adora.”

“We weren’t cuddling!” Adora’s cheeks flushed. The others laughed and Catra felt a small smile form on her lips. “We were just sleeping.”

“In that small bed?”

“You and Bow cuddled on the way back! On Darla!”

“That’s different!”

“No, it’s not!”

“Cuddling is good for you. It’s okay to admit it.”

“Perfuma!” Adora whined. Snickers and giggles rose through the group.

“Are you coming?” Scorpia asked, pointing to the spot next to Adora.

What if’s ran rampant through Catra’s head. She didn’t want to wake from another nightmare and do this all over again?

“You have three seconds to get over here or I’ll teleport you over.” Glimmer threatened. That made her move. She sat next to Adora, as Glimmer smirked at her. “Now we know what to say to get Catra to move.”

“If you don’t want to talk about it tonight,” Bow chimed in. “We can talk tomorrow. But when you want to talk, we’re here.” It

reminded Catra of when she and Bow first talked on the ride back. He had said the same thing.

"I don't know. I might throw you off a cliff again." Catra repeated the memory.

"I guess Glimmer will have to get us both then, huh?"

The stories flowed and continued, laughter interrupting randomly. Catra felt herself relax. At least for tonight. If they wanted her to leave tomorrow, she would. As more stories were exchanged, she felt her eyelids grow heavy. She rested her head on Adora's shoulder. A soft purr vibrated through her.

"I love you too." Adora whispered. Catra couldn't bring herself to respond as sleep took hold.

The First Occurrence

Chapter Notes

So apologizes this is posted so late. It's 11:15 pm my time. I had a lot of family drama this week. Gotta love that, right? Anyway, I'd love to see if anyone can figure out what happens in this chapter. Also, have fun with another section. Before you ask, the dialogue tags were left out on purpose. :) Names are eventually listed but try and figure it out before that. :) Also, there's some plot stuff in here. Might want to pay attention. :) THANK YOU!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 2: Adora

Dawn came all too soon in Adora's opinion. She could hear the others whispering plans for the day but all she wanted was to cuddle Catra a while longer. Everyone had been shocked when Catra was the first to fall asleep last night. Adora had moved them to a makeshift bed and covered them with blankets before falling asleep herself. They currently laid with Catra's ear against her chest and Adora's head on top of Catra's. Their limbs wrapped around the other in a jumbled mess.

"I know you're awake." Catra murmured. "Your heartbeat picked up."

"Sorry. I didn't mean to wake you." Adora still had tender feelings about the day before but Catra's safety came first.

It had scared everyone when Catra had started screaming. Adora had woken when Catra had gashed her arm, trying to break free. Melog's mane had spiked red but it was clear they were unsure of what to do. Trying to pin Catra down and call her name had proven to be a bad idea. Catra seemed to wake up

and tried to strangle her. If Bow and Glimmer hadn't come in to help, Adora might've hurt Catra trying to get her off. Adora's throat was still sore from Catra's nails digging into the skin. Catra hadn't met her eyes since then and had seemed pretty upset. Adora didn't mind the gash or any scars she had collected from Catra. As long as they stayed together. She wasn't letting go ever again.

"Adora." Catra's muffled cry broke her from her thoughts. "I can't breathe." Adora apologized and released the grip she didn't realize had tightened. Catra sighed and got up without another word. Everyone stopped talking as Catra left the room. Bow and Adora shared a look.

"Catra!" Adora called out after her. She sprinted out of the room and saw Catra was already down the hall. "Hey!"

Catra ignored her and kept walking. Adora set her jaw and caught up with her. "Please talk to me."

"What's there to talk about?" The curtness in Catra's voice physically hurt. It felt like they were enemies on the battlefield again.

"I wanna talk about yesterday." Catra didn't respond. "Please?" Sigh. "I want to work things out." Catra moved to the closest window and hopped onto the perch. She nodded up and climbed up the window. Adora pouted before following her. She summoned the sword and changed its form to that of a grappling hook like she used to carry. Throwing it up to the ledge nearest, she gave it a tug. Secure. Unlike herself. She jumped out the window and let the rope catch her. The small drop she'd allowed gave her a rush and woke her fully. As she climbed after Catra, all she could think about was what would happen if Catra left.

After all this time, she thought they were going to be okay. They had been reunited after Catra's rescue and they had made up. She had made friends with both Bow and Glimmer, like Adora had wished for so long. They had gone to Krytis together

and found Melog. They came back and freed their friends from Horde Prime. They'd kissed. Adora felt tears well up in her eyes. What if Catra didn't want her like she had thought? What if Adora misunderstood? What was she going to do? She had loved Catra all her life and there was no one else she wanted to be with.

Finally, she reached the top of the spire, Catra perched and waiting. A black clawed hand was outstretched, waiting to pull her up. Adora remembered the same hand stretching out to her not even a day before, begging her to live.

"This feels nostalgic." Catra teased. The two of them sitting over the world, looking down.

"I don't remember ever sitting up there without normal uniforms though." Catra snorted and released her high-pitched laugh. Adora felt her heart stop for a second. What was she going to do if Catra didn't stay? It was all she could think of.

"Do you remember when we were on Darla?" Adora started, hoping this would go well. "When Entrapta had to remove your chip?"

"Oh, you mean when you two barged into my room and wanted to perform surgery? Yes, one of my favorite memories."

"Not what I was meaning…" Adora resisted to urge to hug Catra. Catra wasn't one for physical touch normally. Adora seemed to be an exception but she didn't want to push that. Not this moment. She wrapped her arms around herself, maybe she needed the hug instead.

"But yes." Catra sighed. "I do remember, and I know where you're going with this."

"You asked me to stay with you. You told me you wanted to go home. At the Failsafe, you begged me not to take it."

"Yeah, because I know you'd risk your life like you did."

"I had to! No one else could!"

"But is that what you wanted to do?!"

"I…" Silence ensued. They had fights before Adora defected, but they never lasted long. "I'm sorry."

Catra jolted next to her and looked away.

"I don't want you to go. I want to figure this out. You asked me yesterday to stay and I'm trying." Adora wiped a tear. "I'm trying to live. I wanted to give up and I'm happy I didn't, but I don't want to live if you're gone."

"You don't mean that."

"I DO! And yesterday, you said you did too."

Silence.

"All I do is hurt people. I've been trying to help people to make up for it, but everything just goes wrong." Catra sighed, throwing her hands into the air. "If I win the fight, I lose the war."

"I never hated you. I have always wanted you to join me here. I wanted us to be free and happy."

"I can't keep hurting you."

"You're only hurting me if you pull away." She reached for the black clawed pinky that was reaching out. "I want you to stay. Like you asked me to."

"What does this even mean though? Like what would we be?"

"I don't know." They looked out over the Whispering Woods. So much still needed to be fixed. So much work to be

done to heal the planet. “All I know is I don’t want to do this alone.”

“You have all of them.”

“But they aren’t you.”

“I’m a distraction.”

“No, you’re not.”

“I don’t matter like that.”

“You do to me.”

“You don’t want me…”

“Ye…”

“Not like I want you.” Catra finished, her voice breaking. Adora took a deep breath and steeled herself. She removed her hand and pulled Catra’s face to look at her. Catra’s eyes were wide and tearful. She was beautiful in the way the sunset could never be. Catra nodded ever so slightly and Adora kissed her.

“I want you. I want you to stay with me. I want you for the rest of my life.” Adora pleaded as she pulled back for air. She touched her forehead to Catra’s. “So please…stay.”

“Using my own words.” Catra choked out a laugh. “Very Adora.”

“I gotta do what I gotta do.” Adora shrugged.

“You really want me to stay?” Catra looked down.

“I look out for you. You look out for me. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.”

“You Promise?”

"I Promise."

They had stayed up there for a while before Catra's stomach growled. They laughed before Catra admitted she hadn't eaten in over a day. Adora remembered there being food most of yesterday. She looked at Catra.

"Ugh." Catra drew her hands down her face. "We had that talk, then I went with Seahawk and then I came back, and we went to bed. I just didn't get food. Nothing I'm not used to." Oops. Adora realized she was right and part of it was her fault. She hadn't been looking out for her again. Adora would get back to doing that like before.

"Well, let's go get some now. Glimmer said they're making this thing called Pancakes!"

"Pancakes?"

"Yeah, it's like fluffy, sweet bread."

"You are really bad at describing things, Adora." Catra snorted.

"Well, I don't know. It's something they haven't made since before King Micah was…" She paused. "But it's supposed to be really good! Let's go." She stood up and reached her hand down.

"Fine." Catra rolled her eyes. "I have one condition though."

"What?"

"We get a fluffy bed." It was Adora's turn to snort.

"Why?"

"I'm tired of sleeping on those hard ones and Glimmer promised me a fluffy bed." Catra pouted.

"I mean…we could…"

"Why don't you want one?"

"I killed the last one…" Adora whispered.

"You what?"

"I killed the last one! It was too big and weird, and I kept falling and I couldn't get up. What else was I supposed to do?" Catra started giggling, and Adora joined her after a second. Etheria above, she'd missed Catra's laugh. The more she heard it, the more she realized she couldn't live without it anymore.

"Let's go, dork." Catra stood and grabbed her hand. They made their way back down to the window, scaring Mermista and Seahawk when they hopped through it.

"Ugh! It's too early for this!" Mermista stalked off towards the dining room.

"Good morning!" Seahawk called as he followed Mermista. "My dearest, wait for me!"

"No!"

"They're a couple?" Catra shook her head. "I don't get it."

"People say the same about us." Adora giggled and pushed Catra a little. Catra's pupils grew wide, and she smirked.

"That's what we're playing?" Catra started to chase Adora down the hall. Their laughter echoed against the remaining walls. Catra leaped up and pushed off the wall to tackle Adora through the doors into the dining room. They skidded across the floor, stopping right before hitting the table.

"Whoa!" Scorpia jumped and almost dropped her plate of food. "Good morning!"

"Good morning!" Adora panted, Catra sitting on her stomach. Catra grinned.

"Hi. I won."

"No, you didn't!"

"Yeah, I did."

"Breakfast!" Glimmer interrupted. "Let's eat. Big day ahead!" The two stood up and moved to take plates from Glimmer. Catra gingerly sniffed hers and pulled back.

"You weren't kidding when you said sweet." She wrinkled her nose at it before poking it with a claw. Adora grabbed a set of utensils for both of them and motioned for Catra to follow to a set of seats. Scorpia and Perfuma sat next to Catra. Bow, Glimmer, Seahawk, Mermista and Frosta all sat on the other side of the table. Entrapta sat on Adora's left, tinkering around with something.

"This is your first-time having pancakes?" Perfuma asked.

"Yeah!" Scorpia chuckled anxiously. "I hope they're good."

"They are." Frosta spoke. She had been unusually quiet since they had returned yesterday. "We have them for special occasions in the Kingdom of Snows."

"Ooh!" Scorpia managed to cut some up and took a bite. "That's fantastic! Catra, you should try some!"

Catra still looked at them warily. Adora was wondering why she wasn't trying them. Before, Catra would eat anything new she could get her hands on. As long as it was edible and it

wasn't a ration bar, Catra had eaten it. She finally sighed and cut it into squares, like Adora had. She took a bite.

She cringed and blinked rapidly. She swallowed it and looked around to everyone. "Sweet." She smacked her lips and crinkled her nose.

"Is that a bad sweet?" Glimmer asked.

"Better than the jello thing." Catra smirked. Glimmer spit her drink out and coughed. This made Catra cackle, while everyone looked on confused.

"Are you okay?" Adora reached to try and help.

"Fine." Glimmer waved her off before glaring at Catra. "That's not fair."

"You asked for my opinion." Catra shrugged and stabbed another piece. She stared Glimmer down as she took a bite. "Is that a problem?"

"Well good morning everyone!" Micah walked in, followed by Wrong Hordak wheeling in a cart of more pancakes.

"Dad!" Glimmer got up and hugged him.

"Good morning, sir." Adora gripped her arm. She wasn't going to salute him, no matter how much she felt the urge to. Catra snickered at her and took another bite. She guessed that meant that Catra liked the pancakes.

"So, we have some business to discuss." Micah took the head of the table. Entrapta and Bow flanked his sides as everyone was finally seated. "Glimmer and I met this morning to decide what we are going to do about certain things." Adora felt Catra tense and took her hand under the table. If they demanded Catra leave for some reason, Adora was going with her. She knew they wouldn't, but she couldn't help the doubt that crept in. She felt a ringing in her ears but ignored it.

"Scorpia." Everyone turned to look at her. "Your kingdom is where the Fright Zone currently resides. We would like you to take your throne back and rule over it."

"Me? I'm not sure."

"You'd do a great job!" Perfuma grabbed her pincer and smiled.

"I'm not really suite…"

"You should do it." Catra said, shocking everyone. "You'd be a great Princess."

"You really think so?" Scorpia's eyes shone with tears.

"Yeah." Catra picked at her food.

"Thanks, Catra. I'll do it." Everyone cheered for a second before Micah brought the attention back to them.

"Okay. So that's the first order of business. Secondly, Princess Entrapta has agreed to take all of the clones back to Dryl with her while they adjust to life here."

"It'll be great!" Entrapta raised on her tendrils of hair. "They can help with all my experiments and we could learn so much about them! Dryl doesn't have that many people anyway so it's works out! As the Fright Zone is fixed, some of the drones could move there too!"

"Yes. That is the other plan. If Scorpia is okay with it, we'd like to have them help turn the Fright Zone into a habitable area again." Micah gestured to said princess.

"Sounds great." Catra muttered. "Having them all here to remind us…"

"Thirdly." Micah interrupted the grumblings of the table. "Force Captain Catra." She jumped to attention. Adora never

liked hearing that title. Too many bad memories that up until a few months previous, were active lived experiences.

"Here it comes." Catra said under her breath.

"Due to past…decisions…" Micah started slowly. "We can't just let you off the hook for actions taken in the war."

"King Micah," Adora started. They couldn't throw Catra out. They had helped Adora adjust. They were helping the clones of Horde Prime. It wasn't fair for them to just throw Catra out.

"Adora, please let me finish." Micah smiled as he motioned to her seat. She shot a look at Glimmer, who merely smiled and nodded to sit. Adora sat back down and gripped Catra's hand tightly. She hoped Catra understood.

"However. It seems that Adora has taken a fancy in you."

"A what?" Adora blinked. Glimmer and Bow giggled.

"You love each other." Perfuma clasped her hands loudly. "It's as clear as day!"

"I!" Adora's face grew red, and she looked down. Catra gripped her hand back and shifted a little.

"So, we have a proposition." Glimmer looked at her dad. He took his seat and she stood. "Catra. You are one of the us now, whether you like it or not. We have accepted you into the Best Friend Squad."

"That's not an easy thing to do." Bow whispered. Adora would beg to differ but let them continue.

"That said, Adora can't keep putting herself in harm's way."

"What?!"

"And you are an amazing strategist. One of the biggest reasons the Horde started winning was because of your plans. You held your ground for a long time and your plans were hard to beat."

"Thank you?" Catra narrowed her eyes.

"We are offering you the position of Royal Strategist and Keeper of She-Ra."

"Keeper of She-Ra?! Why does that sound like a bad thing?!"

"It's not…" Bow's voice cracked.

"Pretty much your job would be to help me make plans to fix things and to make sure Adora doesn't die."

"Sounds doable." Catra took a bite.

"Hey!" Adora interjected. "Don't I get a say in this?!" Memories flashed before her eyes. Light Hope came to mind and how they originally found out about the Heart of Etheria. She felt a pain in her chest. She had just been speaking with Catra about choosing for herself and now they didn't want her to pick!?

"Catra seems to be the only one who can persuade you to change your mind when it comes to things like this." Bow said. "And you two do make a good pair in fights. Would you rather have one of us constantly with you?"

Adora paused for a second. Catra would be with her all the time. They wouldn't really be apart anymore. Catra could still make up for the stuff she did, and they'd get to be together.

"What's the catch?" Adora asked. She hated herself for going with it, but she couldn't think of anything better. She wanted to be with Catra, but she didn't like this idea that didn't give her the option.

"Nothing. Catra's free to roam the castle as this would count as her recovery program." Micah answered. "We believe everyone gets a second chance. It's up to them if they take it or not. It's clear to me that Catra wants that chance. But it's up to her."

"Also, you'd get paid." Glimmer pulled a small bag of coins from her side. "And if you want to go on dates with Adora, that might be something you'd like."

"That's true." Catra grumbled. She reached out and took the bag, looking inside. She glanced at Adora. "Fine. I'll do it."

"It's decided then!" Glimmer clapped her hands. "Thanks, Dad, for the advice."

"Anytime. You make an excellent queen. Your mother would be proud." The ringing became shrill suddenly. Adora's hand flew to her forehead.

"So, she gets off the hook like that?" Mermista stood. "She destroyed my kingdom. And Frosta's during Princess Prom!"

"Yeah!" Frosta finally spoke up.

"And she just gets to stay here?!"

"We aren't kicking her out!" Adora raised her voice a little. "You gave me a second chance, why won't you give her one?! Frosta, you saw how she helped us win! Mermista, we wouldn't have won if she weren't there!" She could feel everyone's eyes on her, but she didn't care. The pain in her chest throbbed. Everything hurt. It was too bright. Too loud. "If you kick her out, then you kick me out too!" Adora slammed her fist on the table.

Gasps sounded around and she looked down. She had broken through the wood. Her hand was bleeding. When did she do that? She couldn't feel it. She lifted her hand and looked at it. Why was she glowing?

"Adora." Catra's eyes were all she could see. "Stay with me." Everything hurt so badly. She needed out. She couldn't breathe. Why couldn't she breathe? The pain grew again, making her double over at the stomach. Why did this feel like what happened at the heart?

"Back up," Micah's voice came through the noise. Adora realized she had collapsed to the floor, curled into a ball. Just stop it. She wanted to scream. Why was this happening? First Catra's nightmare and now this? "Adora, can you hear me?" She felt his hand wrap around hers. "If you can, I need you to move your fist." She heard Catra hiss but did as she was told.

"Dad, what's happening?"

"I'm not sure. Let's move her to her room. Catra, don't let go of her hand, okay?"

"Of course." What was he saying? She still couldn't see anything; she could barely feel the floor beneath her. "Does this have something to do with the virus? I thought it went away after yesterday."

"For now, we need to move her to the room." She bit back a scream as something crushed her arms. She couldn't stand this pain.

"Ca-catra." She whimpered. She hated sounding weak. Shadow Weaver always punished them for sounding weak. She couldn't be. She had to protect Catra.

"I'm here." Catra's voice was the last she heard.

"It's been hours. We should try to wake her?"

"And risk what happened earlier? No way."

"But we need to know she's okay?!"

"You made me Keeper of She-ra and I'm saying no."

"Catra's right, she needs rest." Pause. "I wonder if this is like last time."

"What last time?"

"When you two were on Prime's ship, Adora refused to rest…" The rest faded in and out. She couldn't make sense of it.

Everything was black. The pain was there but it had dropped to an aching numb type of pain. Everything was sore. Like she had healed a hundred people none stop. When she tried to open her eyes, the world spun and closed they went again. She hated being in the dark like this. It hurt to think. All she could do was listen.

"Do you need a break?" The voices were back. "I can take over."

"You heard Micah. Whatever is happening, this might be the only thing grounding her right now."

"I don't know why she freaked out like that. She just started yelling."

"I mean, did anyone even understand what she was saying? She felt a hand brush her cheek. "I'm worried." She heard a mewing sound and the sound of fabric rustling. "Melog's right. She'll wake up soon."

"Swift Wind hasn't seemed too out of it either."

"What does that mean?"

"When the Heart was activated and we moved out of Despondos, Swift Wind collapsed as Adora was forced to move planets. I guess they're linked more than we thought."

"I never heard of that. But that's good right?! That means she's okay then."

"I don't know. There's no way of knowing if their bond is like Melog and Catra."

"What are we supposed to do then? Sit here until she wakes up?"

"It's fine, Glimmer. If you guys need to go, I'll stay."

"Don't think you're off the hook from last night?"

"Do we have to?"

"We should. Only if you want to." Another mewing sound. "See, Melog agrees with me."

"No, they were saying I should eat something soon."

"Oh. Let me go get something then."

"For real though, do you want to talk about it?"

"Not really." Mew. "I know I should but I'm not ready yet, okay? Kinda occupied with this!"

"Alright. Then make me a deal, when Adora wakes up and everything is calmed down, you'll talk to someone other than Adora about this?"

"When are things ever calm on this planet?" Adora realized one of the voices had gone silent.

"Fair point. But still. You can talk to Adora about it and I'm sure she wants you to, but you should also talk to someone else. Perfuma's really good at this and good at meditation. Or you can talk to me?"

"Sorry Arrow Boy, no hard feelings but I'm not really comfortable talking to either of you about this type of thing. Or

anyone in general."

Footsteps. "Just think about it?"

"Fine. Deal. If it gets you off my case for now?"

"For now."

"Here." The other voice returned. "It's all I was able to grab from the kitchen for now."

"Better than the ration bars from the Horde." A door opened.

"Dad!"

"Hello," Now there were four voices to keep track of. Adora's head hurt from trying to stay conscious, let alone remember voices and memories.

"Anything?"

"Not yet. Castaspella's on her way. We're hoping she might know something but it's unlikely. Adora is the first She-ra in a thousand years. We don't really know much in that department."

The pain was steady growing again. Adora curled in on herself. She hated this. She could practically hear the Heart of Etheria beating around her, the electricity of Prime's virus running through her veins. What if Catra had never come to save her? She was still in the Heart, dying. That's why everything hurt. Catra never came back. Everything was a vision like before. That had to be it. She never woke up.

"Adora?" One of the voices called softly. She could feel something next to her. "Please wake up." She wanted to. She didn't want to die here. Prime was right. She had failed. She didn't deserve to be She-ra and she didn't deserve to be alive. Mara was wrong. She didn't deserve love too. "I love you."

Catra?

She finally placed the voice. It was Catra. She could feel it now. Catra's hand in hers. Catra laying next to her. She could feel the purr vibrating through her. She hadn't been able to feel it in the dream.

The pain flared and she grunted, trying to hold back. Shadow Weaver had always punished them. She wouldn't let Catra be hurt anymore. She had to wake up, if only to protect her friends. If that was all she was good for.

"Glimmer." Another new voice.

"Aunt Casta. Please say you can do something?"

"I don't know. Let's see if I can sense any magic?"

"Do you think it could be the aftermath of Prime's virus?

"But she was fine all of last night, Bow! Wouldn't it have happened earlier?"

"Adora." Catra spoke again. "If you can hear me, please. Stay with me. You don't get to be all sappy on me and then do this. You asked me to stay earlier. Stay with me? I love you."

"There's a strong magic presence different from She-ra magic."

"Is that a good thing?"

"I'm not sure what it is."

"Adora." Catra. She wanted to be with Catra. She had finally gotten her back. She wasn't losing her again. The world lit up and she flinched. She could practically feel Catra coming from

that light. She let herself float into it and out of this dark painful place around her.

"Ah!" Adora jolted upright. She bonked heads with Casta and fell right back down.

"ADORA!" Several voices spoke at once. She held her head and tried to wait for the ache to pass.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer spoke.

"What happened?" Bow asked.

"Give her some space." Catra demanded.

"I'm fine." Adora finally sat up, making sure she wasn't going to bonk her head on anything else. She gingerly looked around the room. Her room. She and Catra were laying on her cot with several people flanked around her. Bow and Glimmer stood with hopeful expressions to the right. Micah was holding Casta on the left of them. "What happened?" Catra was propped up behind her.

"You collapsed." Glimmer exclaimed loudly. Adora winced as her head was still pounding.

"I did?"

"Adora, what's the last thing you remember?" Bow asked.

"We were at breakfast. King Micah was talking about Catra being royal strategist. And then…" She paused. What happened after that? "Mermista and Frosta…they were…they said something about kicking Catra out."

"Adora, they never said anything." Bow corrected, kindly.

"Yeah, they did. They said she didn't deserve to be here for because of Salineas and Princess Prom."

"Hey." Catra pulled her down on the bed, wrapping her arm around her. "It's okay. You said it yourself. I'm not going anywhere, right?"

"Yeah, but they…they wanted to kick you out. I can't lose you again." Adora felt tears welling in her eyes. She never cried like this. She curled her legs up and sniffled. "I can't lose you like I did last time."

"You won't. Didn't we just promise this morning to stay together?" Catra whispered, tapping her fingers on Adora's abdomen.

"Hallucinations?" Micah muttered aloud. "Adora, we'd like you to come to Mystacor..."

"Should she really be traveling right now?"

"Castaspella said there is a great magical presence around her. It might be causing this. It would be better to check everything there."

"Guys, really I'm fine." She wiped her eyes. She had to be strong. She was She-ra. They needed her right now. She was stronger than this. She shouldn't cry like this. Shadow Weaver had been right in that regard, tears didn't fix things.

She sat up and took a deep breath. They didn't need tearful Adora. They needed strong Adora. Adora who would've led the march on Thaymor. Adora who protected her friends. Adora who saved the world. They didn't need her. They needed She-ra. She wasn't going to let them down again.

"You should rest." Bow tried.

"No. I'm fine." Adora let go of Catra's hand for a moment to grab it at a better angle. "What we need to do is take

care of the castle and everything else."

"Adora."

"I'm not resting." She was putting her foot down. She glared at Catra for a second before Catra sighed.

"She's not going to rest."

"Catra, you're not helping!"

"When did I say I would?!" She shrugged. "Adora's set in her ways. Even you should be able to see that at this point."

"Come on, I just want to have a fun day with everyone." Adora tried for a smile. "Aren't we supposed to be celebrating today?"

"Yeah, but…"

"Then let's go. Glimmer, you're always up for a party, aren't you?! We gotta show Catra and the others from the Horde what parties are like in Bright Moon."

She wasn't going to fail again…not like she did at the Heart…

Chapter End Notes

Hehehe. Hope you had fun with that section with no dialogue tags. I know it was probably infuriating. But in my defense...I mean I don't have one really but Adora was unconscious, kinda. It was supposed to give you the feeling of what she was hearing. Let me know if y'all liked or hated it? I might use it again...mwhahaha. I have become way to comfortable

on here in a week. :P Thanks for reading. Chapter 3 will be interesting.

Celebration Part 1: Catra hates dresses

Chapter Notes

Hello everyone. It's been a long week. I hope you enjoy the chapter. :)
Part of this chapter's idea comes from @apples_dashie on Twitter. I took part of their headcannon and mixed it up a little. But I want to give them credit! Thank you for letting me use part of it! The other part of the headcannon will be in the next chapter. :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 3: Catra

Catra sighed as Adora took her hand and led her from the room. Why was she surprised? This was Adora they were talking about. Adora, who didn't know how to relax or think for herself. Catra made a mental note to book them a vacation at some point.

"We are going to enjoy today." Adora grumbled as they walked. Catra couldn't get her mind off of what had happened earlier. Adora just started speaking another language and then collapsed. Her mind went straight to yesterday. Adora's body limp and cooling in her arms. The way she pleaded with her to stay.

She yawned and realized she was being led in a circle. She hadn't been inside Bright Moon's castle much but she was still sure they were lost. She pulled against Adora's hand.

"Hey." Adora ignored her. Catra narrowed her eyes and huffed. She stopped and dug her nails into the ground. Adora jerked to a stop, turning to Catra with an angry look in her eyes. Catra tried to quiet her mind that Adora wasn't angry with her. "What's going on with you?" Adora looked away without a word.

"No." Catra pulled her towards the closest door. She peeked inside, an empty room. She yanked Adora in. Adora sat on the ground, making Catra lean at a weird angle. What was she doing? Catra took a deep breath and sat down beside her. "We need to talk." Adora shook her head.

"I don't want to."

"Adora." Catra warned.

"I don't want to talk about it."

"Well, we're talking." Catra smiled a little. Adora could be stubborn but Catra was more. "I'm not going to anything until you talk to me." Adora pulled her knees up and hid her face. She squeezed Catra's hand a little. Catra understood and moved to sit behind Adora. She curled around the blonde, her tail flicking against Adora's knees.

"I guess we're sitting here now." Catra muttered. She rested her head against Adora's back and purred softly. "Didn't we just talk this morning about staying with each other?" Catra tried after a moment. A knock signaled at the door and Bow peeked his head in. Catra waved him away. He handed her a small note and left.

Castle celebration is in 2 hours. Glimmer and I will leave your outfits in your room. Meet us in the War Room beforehand.

Bow

He had drawn little arrows and hearts around it. Of course, he did. It's Bow, what did she expect.

Adora clearly wasn't going to move. She could feel her breathing finally calming down but didn't move. They were finally together again. Catra was going to cherish that. Everyone else was around the castle, preparing. They were alone so Catra didn't mind being a little more loving than usual.

She laid her head against Adora's back once more and closed her eyes. Peace. Peace was nice.

She awoke to a loud sound outside the door. Her head snapped up in time with Adora's, panic filling in her blue eyes. They both sighed audibly when they realized it was a servant outside.

"Ready to talk?" Catra asked. Adora put her head down again. "You have to talk to me at some point." Catra moved around to sit in front of Adora. She put her hands on top of Adora's knees and waited.

"I'm scared." Adora whispered. "I thought the virus was gone. I thought everything was going to be okay."

"It will be." Catra tried. She wasn't the biggest optimist, but for Adora, she'd try. "Why don't we go and…I don't know…do this celebration thing. We can worry about it later." Catra lied. She was going to worry about it all day and she knew Adora would too. But she had to try something.

"Catra." Adora choked on tears. "I…I don't think I'm supposed to be here."

"Adora."

"No, If I had just done what I should've…" Adora finally looked up and met Catra's eyes. "I should've died in the Heart. If I had just done that then…"

SLAP!

Adora's eyes filled with shock as she looked back at Catra.

"What was that for?!"

"Don't you ever say that again!" Catra grabbed her face and held it so close they could feel the others breath. "You should be alive, like you are right now!" Catra hated that tears fell from Adora's eyes, but she continued. "If you were supposed to die there, then I should've died on Prime's ship."

"No!"

"You don't get to say that then!"

"But it's different!"

"How?!"

"You're Catra!" Adora answered as if that solved everything. Catra scoffed.

"And you're Adora, nice to meet you."

"Catra." Adora looked down. Catra pulled Adora's head to her chest and wrapped her arms around her.

"I won't say anything." Catra felt Adora shifted to sitting on her knees, keeping her head to Catra's chest. Catra felt her cheeks burn a little but it disappeared when Adora shook with a sob. Catra purred and held her close.

How long had it been since they had been able to sit like this? It had been a long three years. Catra sniffled back her own tears. She wasn't going to cry. She was the Horde Leader. She needed to be strong. She rubbed Adora's back the way that Adora always had for her whenever she had cried as a child.

After a while, Adora's cries softened and stopped. She sat up, her cheeks flushed with embarrassment. She wiped at her eyes and tried to meet Catra's eyes with a shy smile.

"Feel better?" Catra tried for a teasing smirk. Adora shoved her back, raising a giggle from both.

"Thanks." Adora sighed.

"We should go. I don't know how long we were in here." She pulled out the note from Bow and handed it to Adora. "They're waiting for us."

"I guess we should." She stood and offered a hand to Catra. She smiled as she accepted it.

"One more thing."

"What?"

"Well, two." Catra titled her head playfully. "One, we tell Glimmer about the bed thing." Adora chuckled and nodded. "Two, after all this today, you and I are gonna talk tonight about what happened."

"I suppose." Adora sighed dramatically. "You're not going to let me out of it."

"Nope." Catra stood a little straighter and teased. "Didn't you hear, I'm the Keeper of She-Ra now." She leaned forward with her hands on her hips. "You're stuck with me." She poked Adora's forehead with her claw.

"Oh, what a cruel fate." Adora laughed. They pushed each other before opening the door. Catra had been right. Servants and others were bustling around.

"Princess Adora." One stopped, despite the trays in her hands. "Thank goodness. Queen Glimmer asked me to find you. There's only an hour left before the ball tonight."

"Ball?" Catra and Adora shared a confused look. "Like Princess Prom type ball?"

"Yes. Well, there's the celebration in the courtyards and villages and it ends with a dance."

"First I've ever heard of this." Adora shook her head. "Let's go get ready?"

"Come on, dummy." Catra took her hand as they walked back towards their room.

As they continued, Catra couldn't help the growing frustration at hearing Princess Adora. Adora wasn't…well, she was a Princess but not like that. That was She-Ra. Catra mentally brushed it off. She was going to have to get used to accepting both, she supposed.

Melog met them at their room, tail swishing happily.

"Is she feeling better?" Melog chirped.

"She's alright." Catra answered. "We apparently have to go to a ball?" Adora opened the door. They walked in, Melog filling Catra in on their adventures during breakfast.

"Catra…" Adora covered her mouth to stifle a laugh.

"What?" Catra turned to look. In front of them laid two dresses. Adora's red one from Princess Prom and a fluffy purple and white dress similar to Glimmer's Princess Prom dress. "No! No! No!" Catra reached forward. Adora giggled behind her.

"It's just for one night?" Adora gave her puppy dogs eyes. "Please?"

"No!" Catra picked up the purple dress. "I'm finding Sparkles."

"She's in her room as of currently." Melog answered helpfully.

"Thank you." Catra clutched the purple dress with disdain. "You get dressed. I'll be back."

"Okay." Adora picked up the dress as Catra opened their door. Catra ignored the stares she got from everyone in the castle as she headed towards Glimmer's room. Melog acted as her guide and talked to her mentally to keep her sane. The hate was clear in some of their eyes. They had every right to hate her. She couldn't argue that.

"Sparkles!" Catra yelled as she entered the room Melog led her to. Glimmer was finishing changing into another purple dress, this one with her light blue cloak around her shoulders.

"Catra!" Glimmer's smile fell as she noticed the dress. "Did it not fit? I thought you and Adora were similar sizes."

"I'm not wearing a dress." Catra threw the dress on the nearby chair. She tapped her foot.

"Well, you can't go like that!" She pointed to the gray shorts and tee she was wearing still.

"Why are you even holding a ball right now?!"

"It's not a full ball." Glimmer turned back to the mirror, pulling her white sleeve on. "It's just a dance at the end of the festival. My dad's been planning it since yesterday."

"We just ended a war and we have bigger things to worry about." Catra was wondering how they really could go about this so casually. Seriously, how was she losing to them?!

"That's why we're taking a day off." Glimmer turned back with a soft look. "We can't work around the clock and we should celebrate everything we've won. Work starts tomorrow. Including you."

"What?"

"We have a meeting at ten tomorrow morning, war room." Glimmer walked to her closet. "I'll need you there with me."

"Why?" Catra's eyes narrowed.

"I did just make you Royal Strategist?" Glimmer put her hands on her hips. "You'll have to come to meetings with me now." Catra groaned and Glimmer laughed. "I don't have anything you'd wear if you don't want to wear a dress."

"No dresses." Catra made an X with her arms.

"Just for one night?!" Glimmer pleaded. "We'll get you something else afterwards!"

"No."

"Come on, Catra. We'll have something made before the next one but just this once?!"

"Yeah, come on, Catra." Adora's voice made Catra spin around. Adora was wearing the red dress and her usual ponytail. "Just one night?"

"You're all insufferable." Catra drew her hands down her face. Glimmer giggled and dove back into her closet. She pulled out a big pink dress that was fit for someone Scorpia's height. "NO!"

"Here, let me help!" Adora ran over and started looking through clothes. Catra sighed heavily and took a seat on the chair. She couldn't help the feeling that coursed through her when she saw Adora's smile. She really didn't want to wear a dress but she almost changed her mind to see that smile. Almost was the key word.

"Hey guys." Mermista greeted as the other four Princesses entered. All of them wore fancy dresses. Perfuma had a blue dress that looked surprisingly good on her. Frosta wore her winter fur dress. Mermista had a suit set with dark blues and Scorpia had her black dress on. "What are you doing?"

"We're finding a dress for Catra." Glimmer poked her head out to answer.

"Oh, Catra in a dress?" Scorpia laughed. "Good luck."

"I'm not wearing a dress!" Catra crossed her arms.

"Perhaps we could find something for you?" Perfuma offered.

"No. You guys can go ahead. I'm not wearing a dress." Catra waved them off. She heard their chatter pick up as they went into the hallway.

"Ooh!" Glimmer danced excitedly. She pulled out a floor length, long sleeved, dark purple dress. "Here!" She tossed the dress to Catra. "No ifs ands or buts! That's the dress!"

"How am I supposed to move in this?" Catra held the dress up. "What part of no dresses do you not understand?"

"Please!!" Adora tried her puppy eyes.

"I'm the Queen and I'm ordering it." Glimmer said.

"No." Catra put the dress next to her. "You're telling me none of you have just a pair of pants and a shirt? No suits or anything?!"

"Not right now." Glimmer looked to Adora. "Come on, you'll look nice!"

"What if we add a jacket or something?!" Adora asked. "I'm sure I saw a black jacket or something in here." She dug through the closet again. Glimmer claimed there were none in there but Adora found something and pulled it out. "Here. This will work." She handed the small black shawl she had found to Catra.

"Adora, convince Catra to wear the dress. I need to go finish up details." Glimmer poofed away as Adora took a seat.

"I'm not wearing it." Catra looked down at the dress.

"You've never even tried one on?!"

"How are you supposed to move around?! I can't jump on things like this!"

"Just try it…" Adora paused. "If you do, I'll ask Glimmer about the bed tonight." Catra glared at her. That was unfair.

"You agreed to that earlier anyways."

"Oh." Adora made a face while she was thinking. Catra shook her head and eyed the dress again. It wasn't bad but she felt out of place. "If you wear it…" Adora tried. "Bow can't call you cute for three days." She held up a three with a smile that said she'd won and knew it.

"You really think that's going to convince me?" Catra laughed. Adora pouted with her arms crossed.

"I really want to see you in the dress!" Adora finally admitted. "Just once?!"

"Why?"

"Because we could wear dresses together! Come on, Catra. We never got to do this in the Horde. Just one night. If you hate it afterwards, you don't ever have to wear a dress again!" Adora clasped her hands in front of her and begged.

She didn't like the idea. But seeing Adora beg was cute. And it would get Adora's mind off of what happened earlier. She supposed to could swallow her pride.

"Can I do something to it?" She held up the dress next to her. Adora nodded eagerly. She grabbed the bottom layer and ripped it off. The dress fell to her knees, about the same length as Adora's. She ripped the left sleeve off and threw it down. She took the shawl and threw it back to the closet. "I'm not wearing that." She pulled the dress over her shoulders and slid it into place on her. She looked down at the slightly puffed skirt.

"It looks really good." Adora added. "Hold on. Wait here!" She ran out of the room, towards theirs.

"Hey Catra." Perfuma stuck her head in.

"I thought you went with the others."

"I wanted to wait for you two." Perfuma smiled. "Oh, you did get a dress. You look very nice."

"I hate it." Catra looked in the mirror. She looked like a Princess. She wasn't a Princess. She was the Horde Leader. She really missed her suit from Princess Prom.

"You look beautiful." Perfuma had walked into the room and stood next to Catra. "May I?" Catra nodded with wary and a dark purple flower appeared in Perfuma's hands. She tucked it behind Catra's ear. "It's not easy to be vulnerable like this. I'm proud of you." They shared a small smile before Adora returned.

"Hey!" She panted. "Perfuma. I thought you went ahead."

"No, not yet." She stepped back and took a seat. She gave Catra a look of confidence.

"Here." Adora held out Catra's leg covers. "I thought they'd match and help." She smiled. Catra looked down at the dark purple covers. She pulled them on and looked back in the mirror. She looked ridiculous.

"Adora, what's that?"

"Bow gave it to me just now." Adora smiled at the golden head piece in her hand. "I guess he made it earlier today."

"He's gotten faster at crafting thing." Perfuma said.

Adora joined Catra in the mirror and tried on the tiara. She set it straight on her head.

"Like this, dummy." Catra took it from her hands. She pulled Adora's ponytail out, despite protests. "If I have to wear a dress, you have to wear your hair down."

"Yeah but." She touched her bangs. Catra rolled her eyes.

"Come here." She bent Adora's head down and licked her bangs into place. Adora laughed as she stood back up.

"How long has it been since you did that?" Catra placed and adjusted the headpiece on her forehead like her She-Ra one laid.

"I don't even know. But long enough." Catra pulled a hair off her tongue. "I remember why I stopped."

"Oh, you two look beautiful." Perfuma stood. "Should we go?"

"You ready?" Adora held out her hand to Catra.

"Let's just get this night over with." Catra took Adora's hand as Perfuma guided them to the courtyard.

Once they were outside, lights had been hung around the buildings. Not that they were lit yet, but decorations of flowers and hearts weaved through strings near the lights. Perfuma had summoned what Catra considered an army's worth of flowers

everywhere. Frosta and Mermista must have made an ice sculpture near one of the fountains. People flooded the area. Catra's instincts went on high alert.

Adora squeezed her arm for comfort. Catra took a shaky breath.

"She-Ra!" Huntara announced to the group. All eyes turned to them and Catra could feel the disdain dripping from people in the crowd. She couldn't help her ears folding down or her tail bushing.

"Hi!" Adora greeted people. She shifted her arm around Catra's waist, keeping her close. Catra flattened her tail and tried not to let it bother her. She put her arm around Adora's waist and let her hand rest on her hip. They had never really held each other like this. She supposed it was because they weren't allowed to be together before.

"Oh, I'm so excited to be here!" She heard a loud male voice speak off to their left. Two men, Catra was fairly sure it was Bow's dads, made their way over to them. "Hi Adora!" One leaned down for a hug, forcing Adora's hand to move. Catra fought the small growl raising in her throat.

"Lance, George! I didn't know you were coming!" Adora laughed as she hugged the other. Catra didn't know who was who so she just stayed quiet. "This is Catra."

"Aren't you the one who led the Horde for the past few years?" The longer haired one asked her. She nodded meekly. Catra felt the panic rising in her. Sounds became distorted as she tried to focus on the ground under her.

"Yep, but she's on our side now and she's with me." Adora's hand brought her back. Adora gave her that stupid look with her eyebrows up that she always did. "Catra, this is Lance." She pointed to the long-haired man. "And this is George." She motioned towards the shorter haired man. "Bow's dads."

"We met on the trackerpad," Catra tried. "during the mission back in the Fright Zone."

"Yes, you were the one who called for help." Lance tapped her chin and smiled at her. "Well, it's nice to meet you, Catra." He extended his hand out. She glanced between his hand and his face. Was…was he being nice to her? He wasn't mad? He didn't resent her?

"Nice to meet you." Catra shook his hand. George simply stood there with his eyes narrowed at her. She flexed her claws to release the tension in them as she looked away from him. Adora tried pulling her closer.

"Ooh, George." Lance turned to his husband. "We should have them all over to the library sometime!" He looked at Catra. "I can make snacks!"

"He does make good snacks." Adora tried. Catra smiled a little and nodded. "And their library is really cool."

"I suppose we could have them over for tea sometime."

"We could be Historians for a day!" Adora laughed after completely butchering the word Historians. The men laughed with her and Catra assumed it was an inside joke between them. "I'll explain later." Adora whispered to her.

"Oh, there's Bow." Lance pointed out. "BOW!" They moved on, leaving Catra and Adora.

Catra looked away. "This is just all really weird." She motioned to the party going on around them. She didn't see any of the clones here, except Wrong Hordak. They were over speaking with Hordak and Entrapta about something. She tugged on the dress. It was tighter and uncomfortable than before. She growled softly at it as if that would do anything.

"She-Ra." Huntara approached them.

"Huntara!" Adora smiled. Catra might have been a little jealous of the smile she gave Huntara. Catra bit her tongue to prevent the nasty remark. Catra didn't listen to the conversation in front of her. Her attention was to most of the party around her. So many people talking and laughing. How many of these lives had she ruined? How many people here hated her?

"Catra?" Adora tugged her back. "Did you hear what she said?"

"No." Catra looked back to see Huntara smirking at her.

"I asked if you planned to return to the Crimson Waste. Your old posse misses you."

"I don't plan on it." Catra answered. She did want to return, in the fact of it was fun running the gang. But that was before she found out Shadow Weaver had left her to go to Adora. Then she opened the portal. Adora hated her for that. Then Prime came because of the portal. Then she…the pool flashed before her eyes.

"Catra?" Adora's voice rang in her ears. She pushed her away and ran. "Catra!" She couldn't do this. Catra ran toward the castle and in the doors. She opened the first door she saw, a closet for random things, and slammed herself inside. Her lungs burned for air. Her fur stood on end. She slid to the ground and pulled her knees shut.

She could hear it. The pool. Her screams. Prime's laughter. Adora. Prime's hive mind. Shadow Weaver's voice spoke in her head. Adora couldn't ever love her. Not when she was like this. She was a distraction. Adora could never want her.

She could see Adora standing before her with that smile. She could feel the chip in her neck and see Adora's pleading eyes.

"Catra!" Adora yelled. Catra felt herself come back to where she was. The closet. With her borrowed clothes and cut

hair and bruised body. She could feel herself shaking without a way to stop it. Tears burned down her cheeks. Her lungs still burned from the lack of air. She could hear Adora's voice traveling down the hall. Leaving her behind.

That's what everyone did, isn't it? Everyone left her behind. No one actually cared. Double Trouble had said it perfectly as Scorpia. She drove them away. Who would want someone like her in their life? Glimmer had said Adora left her, not the Horde. She was the problem. What right did she have to talk to Adora about wanting to live?

She heard voices outside, but she didn't care anymore. She hiccupped as she wiped at tears. She should've died on Prime's ship. She was always going to be that traitor. She would never be able to redeem herself. That's how things were.

The door flew open, Adora standing there breathing heavily. Sweat christened on her brow as her eyes grew.

"Catra, are you okay?"

"Don't touch me!" Catra batted her hand away. Adora sat on her knees, catching her breath. Catra finally released what she had been doing. The dress was in shatters. Claw marks had torn the skirt to pieces and chunks were missing from the top. Her neck was covered in marks. She must have picked at the chip's phantom pains.

"Hey. I'm not mad." Adora spoke. "Let's go get you cleaned up and we can go back out?"

"Just leave me in here." Catra put her head down.

"You didn't leave me earlier. I'm not leaving you now. Scoot over." Catra looked up as Adora forced her way into the closet with her. She pulled the door shut, sealing them into the cramped space.

Adora leaned her head onto Catra's shoulder. She picked up Catra's tail and started poking the end of it. Catra shivered and yanked her tail away.

"You know I hate that."

"Yeah, but I figured it might help?"

"How?"

"I don't know." Adora shrugged. "Maybe that bad feeling would weigh out the rest."

"You suck at this."

"So do you."

"You suck more than I do."

"No, I don't."

"Yeah, you do!"

"Oh, look at me, I'm Catra. I'm so cool with my claws and my ears…"

"I'm Adora. I have a dumb hair poof and feel the need to sacrifice myself at every chance I get."

"Wow, I thought Netossa's comment hurt."

"I just want to know who told her about the water thing."

"I think it's pretty obvious." Adora laughed. Catra felt some of her anxiety finally calm hearing Adora's laugh again. "You ready to go back?"

"Glimmer's going to kill me for this." She motioned to her clothes.

"I'll handle it." Adora shrugged. "She won't fight me on it."

"You know you can't solve everything with brute strength, right?"

"You never know until you try!" Adora showed off her biceps.

"How were we losing to you?!" Catra drew her hand down her face and pinched her nose.

"Come on." Adora opened the door, the two of them spilling out onto the floor. The few people nearby looked on as they giggled before standing. Adora grabbed a random cloth item from the closet and threw it around Catra's shoulders. "I'm sure we can find something to wear." She shut the door.

"I'll just go back to the room."

"It's not even sunset yet! The party hasn't really started."

"It's fine. You'll have more fun without me there anyway."

"Stop that." Adora tapped Catra's nose. She blinked in response before glaring. "I'll only have fun if you're with me. Let's see if we can find something."

"What are you guys doing?" Mermista's voice echoed behind them. They turned. She had lost her jacket and stood with her arms crossed. "Party's the other way."

"Catra needs a different set of clothes." Adora tried.

"I'll deal with it." She walked closer and took Catra's arm. "You go back to the party, Adora. They're looking for you."

"Wait!" Catra protested as she was yanked away. They both gave each other sorrowful looks before someone else hurried Adora away to the party.

Mermista led them into a spare room and released Catra. She jumped back a few feet and kept her back to the wall.

"I, for one, want to go back to the party." Mermista said as she searched through a truck on the floor. "Scorpia said you're not one for dresses."

"No." Catra answered warily.

"Here." She pulled out a set of black slacks and a maroon shirt. "Try these on. I'm hoping they fit."

"Why are you helping me?" Catra couldn't help the suspicion growing in her chest. "I'm the one who destroyed your kingdom. Why don't you hate me?"

"Oh I don't like you." Mermista shifted her weight to one hip. "Seahawk bugged me until I came to find you. He said something about you two burning things yesterday and being friends? I don't really care." She threw the clothes at Catra and turned back to the truck.

"I'm sorry." Catra sighed with her head in her hand. "Is…is there anyway I can make this up? I'm not great at building things but…"

"Oh no," Mermista turned back. "We'll rebuild without your help. You'll stay here in Bright Moon. You can be Glimmer's problem." Catra nodded slowly. It was fair. It was more than fair. Catra didn't deserve her forgiveness anyway. "We can figure out the whole forgiveness thing later. Beside," She stood up and smiled. "You have an 8 foot lady with a sword as your girlfriend."

Catra's cheeks flushed. "We're not…"

"You're totally girlfriends." Mermista chuckled. "but I'd rather not get on her bad side." Mermista moved to another truck. "Let me see if I have shoes."

"I don't wear shoes." Catra said.

"Fine." Mermista groaned. "I'll find accessories." She moved to a dresser top.

Catra was satisfied with the ripping sound the dress made as she tore it off her. She breathed a sigh of relief. Never again. No matter how much Adora begged. She left her leg covers on and pulled the pants over them. She had done the same with her Princess Prom suit. She slipped the maroon shirt on and buttoned it up.

"I didn't find much that would work." Mermista walked over. "You seem to like gloves." She handed her a pair of black fingerless gloves. "And this needs to go. Sorry Perfuma." She ripped the dark purple flower from Catra's ear. "There." She motioned to the mirror over the dresser top. Catra went to look.

She looked so much better. She almost looked regal if she'd say so. She turned around, half realizing Mermista had cut a hole for her tail without having to ask. Catra had forgotten to check in her frustration with the dress.

"Thanks, Mermista." Catra smiled. "And again, I'm sorry for everything."

"Whatever." Mermista waved her off. "Let's get back to the party. They have torches and I don't want Seahawk setting anything on fire."

"Go ahead. I just want a moment." Mermista shrugged and left. Catra sat on the nearest chair and took a deep breath.

"Hey Catra." Melog's voice spoke in her head. Melog shimmered into view next to her. Their mane was almost purple. "Are you alright?"

"How am I even supposed to go back out there?" She had run out like an idiot. That was Adora's job, not hers. She was the smart one.

"What does Adora say?"

"Well, obviously she wants me to go meet her again."

"And you want?"

"To go to sleep." Catra leaned back. "I just want to forget this day ever happened." She thought back to their argument that morning where Adora had pleaded with her to stay. Maybe she didn't want to forget all of it. "I'm worried about Adora and I tried on the dress to get her mind off the whole collapsing thing." She decided she was venting to the room. Melog nodded along as if they were listening. "But now I don't want to go out and make a fool of myself again. I'm not some softie they want me to be!"

"Did Adora ask you to be that?"

"…No…" Catra sat up.

"Then don't worry about it. You are Catra." Melog's tail swished happily as they smiled at her.

"Not that again. What is with you all saying that?"

"You find it comforting to hear, no? You find it nice to hear that someone is accepting of you just for being yourself despite all your self-destructive behaviors and low self-esteem. Is it not comforting to know someone loves you despite all the time you tried to kill them? Is it not…"

"I get it." Catra pinched her nose. "I thought I was mean."

"We are bonded, remember?" Melog chirped.

"So, it's my own, yeah I get it." Catra waved it off with a smile.

"Shall we return?"

"Were you even there?"

"Yes. Perfuma was giving me ear scratches." They stood and Melog filled her in on Perfuma's amazing ear massages as they walked.

Eventually, she found the courtyard again. She stood off to the side, near a plant of Perfuma's. Flowers of purples and reds blossomed over the green foliage.

"Catra." Perfuma greeted her. "What happened to your other clothes?"

"Long story."

"Huntara told us you were upset and ran into the castle. I'm glad you're alright." Huntara! Catra took a controlled breath. This party was just going fantastic for her. Everyone knew she ran out, didn't they?

"I'm fine." Catra ran her hands nervously over the pants. "Where's Adora?"

"On the other side of the crowd. She was talking with Bow and Glimmer, last I saw." Catra felt a pang in her chest. "If you want, we could walk through some meditation sometime. My offer still stands."

"Thanks. I'm not super…yeah." Catra excused herself and forced her way through the crowd. If she had to be here, she was going to stay with Adora.

"Hey…Kitten." She froze. She turned and saw a version of Adora with her normal clothes.

"Double Trouble? I thought they said you were near Dryl." Catra growled lowly.

"I was. But you know me. I love parties." They shifted to their form of Flutterina. "The food is really good. You should try some."

"Listen to me…" Catra grabbed their dress.

"Ah. Ah. Ah-I wouldn't do that if I were you." Flutterina smiled. "After all, you're trying to show you've changed, aren't you?" Flutterina giggled and gave her a conniving look. "You wouldn't want that to be tarnished by hitting a young innocent child…"

"What do you want?"

"I just wanted to check on you." Flutterina stepped back as Catra released them. "You know how to get a hold of me if you need me." They turned away, looking back over their shoulder. "I'm glad you worked out your little trouble with Adora. Good luck, Kitten." They moved through the crowd so quickly Catra lost sight of them.

She shook it off and kept forcing her way through. She finally squeezed through a couple and saw Adora. She had a distant look in her eyes, despite everyone chatting around her. She sat with a drink in her hands, fidgeting uncomfortably.

"She did what?!" Glimmer's voice shrieked a little. She quieted herself and kept talking to Bow. "That was one of my favorites that I never got to wear." Adora chuckled a little before returning to her clearly fascinating drink.

Catra straightened and tried to mentally reassure herself. If Adora hadn't left her after that, she should be fine. She forced herself to think of when she toppled Hordak. She just needed to channel that energy. She ran her hand through her hair and stepped out.

"Hey Adora." She announced her welcome. The change in Adora's eyes was worth the embarrassment.

"Catra!" Glimmer marched forward. "What did you do to the dress?"

"Glimmer." Several laughed around the group. Bow put his hands on her shoulders to pull her back.

"That was one of my nice ones!" Glimmer pouted. Adora finally stood and walked towards Catra. She was giving her that look with her eyebrows up. She stepped forward and they touched foreheads. Adora's hands cupped Catra's ears.

"Hey Catra." She breathed. Catra released a soft purr. Her tail swished happily behind her. "I take back what I said about the dress earlier."

"Yeah, now you do."

"I'm sorry?" Adora's hair swayed in the breeze that had picked up while she was gone. Catra closed her eyes.

"And they say they aren't girlfriends." Bow spoke. Catra frowned and pull away long enough to glare at him. "I'm sorry! It's just so cute!" His voice cracked.

"I thought you said he couldn't call me cute for three days!" Catra looked to Adora, hands on her hips.

"I forgot." Catra facepalmed. Adora chuckled nervously. "I'll make it up!"

"Yeah, you will." Catra grabbed her wrist and dragged her towards the dance floor. Adora protested, her friends wishing her luck. They stepped out as a familiar tune began to play. "Remember this?"

"It's been a while." Adora smirked. "I'm sure I can remember though." They switched hands and turned in circles.

"You should really wear something like that more often. You look really…" Adora lost her words which prompted a loud cackle from Catra.

"Speechless, Princess?" She teased as they spun away. Catra gritted her teeth as she switched partners a few times before finally reuniting with Adora. They both relaxed and continued dancing.

"We never got to finish last time." Adora commented.

"I think my ending was more exciting." Catra gave a smug look.

"Your ending had us falling off the castle."

"Like I said, more exciting." Catra dipped Adora again, same as last time. This time Adora reached up and gave her a peck on the cheek. Adora then yelped as Catra dropped her.

"Wow, dropping me like that." Adora tsked as she stood. People around them looked on but she giggled. "Dancing is really your thing." Adora laid on the sarcasm. Catra returned the favor.

"You know me, taking over the world is more my forte."

"I'll keep it in mind." Adora answered as they came together with the flourish of music. "Thanks for coming back out."

"Sorry for running out in the first place."

"No. I'm sorry." Adora pulled them from the dance floor before the next song began. She cupped Catra's cheek. "I shouldn't have forced the whole dress thing or everything." She sighed until Catra took her hand and pulled her in. They relaxed for a moment.

"I agreed. You didn't force me. Trust me, you'd know if you forced me into it."

"It's been a long day."

"You're not wrong."

"Food?" Adora pointed to a nearby table. "I'm hungry."

"Sure." They laced their fingers and walked together.

"Hey Adora?"

"Hm?"

"A lot of people are looking…and they keep saying we're girlfriends."

"Yeah, I noticed."

"Is…is that what we are?"

"Is that what you want to be?"

"Don't make me pick!"

"Why not?"

"Clearly, I have questionable judgement." Catra threw her hand out, barely missing another person. They laughed out an apologize before snagging an empty table.

"I don't think that."

"I never said you didn't also have questionable judgement. Seriously, who let us be in charge of the war?" They laughed before Adora grew serious.

"I don't want to force anything. I don't really know what this whole girlfriend thing is anyway."

"I don't either." Catra shoved her. "Maybe that library place would have information on it."

"Probably not." Adora snorted. "It's dedicated mainly to First One's history. Though I do still have to sit down and help them re-catalog everything at some point." She put her head on the table.

"There, there." Catra lovingly rubbed her back. They finally stood back up and filled their plates with food. As Catra munched down on something she couldn't remember the name of, she watched the crowd.

Maybe life wouldn't be so bad here. She felt herself smile.

"Whatcha thinking?" Adora tapped her plate. Catra rolled her eyes with a grin.

"I might be able to live here." She picked up another piece of food and popped it in her mouth. "Though a few things need to change."

"Like?"

"First, the bed."

"You really want the fluffy bed." Adora nodded. "I already spoke to Glimmer. She said she'll see if she can have one by tomorrow brought into the room. I guess they repaired the one I killed when I first arrived."

"Secondly, the pastels in the room." Catra placed her head on the table, looking at Adora. "They need to go."

"What do you want instead? Horde Green?"

"No!" Catra shoved her. "I'm not sure yet. But the pastels everywhere is sickening. I can't deal with it."

"I guess I get it." Adora picked at her food. "Third?"

"We're getting new clothes."

"Why?"

"Because you've been wearing the same thing all your life!" Catra pointed out. "This is one of the only times I haven't seen you with that stupid red jacket."

"It's not stupid." Adora muttered resentfully.

"First couple paychecks are going to new outfits for us both." Catra poked Adora's head piece. "I like this thing on you."

"Yeah, it doesn't really bug me as much." Adora touched it lovingly. "Bow rushed to make it for tonight so he said he'll look over it another time to make sure it's solid."

"I'm surprised he had the time." Catra wasn't sure where he had fit it in but she supposed if he already had a prototype. She wasn't going to focus on it. "So, how long do we have to stay here?"

"Glimmer said there's a speech near the end after dusk." Catra groaned. "But after that we should be good. We can walk around if you don't want to be here. There's some gardens nearby that are really pretty."

"I suppose." Catra turned her attention to the dance floor. Scorpia and Perfuma were doing some slow dance together. "I'm glad Scorpia found a good friend like Perfuma."

"I'm glad you came and made friends with everyone."

"Eh, Mermista and Frosta don't like me still."

"You'll grow on them."

"Don't know if I want that."

“It’ll work out.” Adora wrapped her arms around Catra’s stomach and rested her head on her shoulder. “I’m just glad you’re here.”

“So, you keep saying.” Catra turned back, their noses brushing. Moments like this needed to last forever. She was finally happy. She had Adora. Just like she had always wanted. She purred softly. She might like it here in Bright Moon.

Chapter End Notes

So it's a two parter. I didn't want the chapter to be huge with the celebration and it's more fun if you have both perspectives on the day. :)
Also, apologizes this is up as late as it is. 11:45 pm. Whoop! I try to stay at least a few chapters ahead and I was working on Chapter 6 when I realized what I had wasn't going to work and I had to scrap 50 pages of writing. Hence why it's up late. This was written today and it was a doozy. Leave me a comment about it, if you want? I love getting comments. :)
Thank you for reading!

Celebration Part 2: Second Occurrence

Chapter Notes

Thank you to everyone who has left Kudos and comments. You have no idea how happy that makes me. I really didn't think anyone would want to read this. There's somewhat of an explanation to the plot in here though not everything is given away. That wouldn't be fun. :P I hope you enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 4: Adora

Adora couldn't get her mind off of the events of the day. The magic that had run through her earlier had burned and hurt. She had broken down to Catra and they tried to get their minds off it. She was happy when Catra tried the dress but immediately felt bad when it was clear Catra hated it.

Now she sat at a table with Catra, munching on food. Catra was watching people dancing, her tails and ears giving away her interest. Adora couldn't help the smile on her face. Mermista had found her new clothes and Catra looked amazing in them. Adora felt slightly jealous and wondered if she was dressed up enough for Catra.

She hadn't admitted it earlier but her chest still ached. She touched the place the Failsafe had been gingerly. That's where it concentrated and ached. She could vaguely remember the conversation she had overheard. They said she spoke in another language. First One's? They said she was yelling at them and hallucinations…well that's what Micah had said it was.

Catra's laughter brought her back to the moment. She took Catra's hand by the pinky, earning her a loving quick glance. Adora followed Catra's gaze back to the dance floor. Bow and

Glimmer were leading a weird group dance. She laughed and got an idea.

"Come on!" She took Catra's hand and pulled her out to the floor. Catra yelped and struggled for her footing. She wanted to have a fun night. She didn't want to think about it.

"Warning much?" Catra said.

"Here." Adora found them a spot near Glimmer and Frosta. She threw her hands in the air with the rest of the group. Catra crossed her arms and shook her head at Adora. "Dance with me!"

"I don't think this is dancing." Catra motioned to everyone who was jumping around. The music had changed and was more upbeat and faster. Adora laughed and grabbed Catra's arms, spinning her in a circle. Catra sighed before finally joining Adora in the weird jumping dance everyone was doing.

"Catra!" Scorpia laughed as she moved closer. "Isn't this fun?!" Catra gave one of her fanged smiles as they ended up spinning away from each other. Adora spun towards Bow, who caught her before she fell.

She laughed as he helped her upright. She gasped as she was sure she saw Flutterina-well-Double Trouble in the crowd. She searched the crowd again, but they weren't there.

"Are you okay?" Bow smiled. Adora shook her head to clear herself before she ended back with Catra. They spun into each other, almost falling over.

"Adora?" Catra caught her.

"I'm fine. Just dizzy." Adora giggled. Catra led her off the dance floor and back to their seats.

"You're sitting down for a minute."

"You're no fun." Adora playfully pouted.

"Yeah, that's nothing new." Catra teased as she sat Adora down. Catra kept her hand protectively on Adora's back as Adora laid her head on the table. Everything was spinning. She just wanted to have fun with her friends. Tonight was supposed to be a celebration of the end of the 30 year war. They had won! Why didn't Adora feel happy?

"What's wrong?" Catra whispered. Adora appreciated it. She didn't want anyone else being worried about it. "You're trying too hard."

"Nothing."

"Adora." Catra warned.

"Not now?"

"Nope. You sat with me." Catra tapped her claws against Adora's back as she spoke. "So tell me."

"Just thinking about today." Adora cupped her head in her hands. "I think it's just finally hitting me."

"It has been a day." Catra said. They sat in silence, listening to the sounds around them. "Why don't we go walk the gardens?"

"Yeah." They stood and left quietly. Adora guided them towards the gardens, the noise of the party dimming as they walked. Catra took Adora's hand and she felt Catra's tail hitting her leg with every swish.

"Do you want to try talking about it?" Catra asked as they walked by some trees. The garden had been destroyed, not that it surprised Adora. Most of the hedges, plants, and trees were gone. Burned holes sat in their place or severed the connections between them.

The moons were starting to set, flooding cool lights over the area. Stars were beginning to show themselves as small dots in the sky above. She didn't know if she'd ever get tired of seeing the stars now. It reminded her of everything she had gone through and Mara. Mara, who gave her life to seal them in Despondos. The She-Ra before her. All the lies she was told. The Heart of Etheria Project.

"Etheria to Adora." Catra waved a hand in front of her face. "Are you going to just daydream on me?"

"Sorry." Adora noticed a spot for them to sit. A small clearing, thanks to the attacks, where some grass was still present. "Over here?" They stepped over the holes in the ground. Adora sat, crossing her legs and pulled her skirt down. Catra sat on her knees. "Does it feel like nothing is real?"

"Glad it's not just me." Catra bit her lip. "Doesn't really feel like just yesterday we were fighting Prime."

"It's just all so fast." Adora touched her hem of her dress, running the fabric between her fingers. "And then you know, the whole magic collapsing thing…" She tried for a laugh.

"Does it still hurt?"

"More of an ache." Adora admitted. She touched the area where the Failsafe had sat. "I don't know what's happening."

"It might be a side effect of the virus?"

"But the virus was gone. I got rid of it when we…" Her mouth ran dry. She had kissed Catra that morning again during the argument. Why was it such a big deal now? It was Catra after all. She had loved her all her life but never could admit it. She wasn't allowed to think about it. She wasn't allowed things like that.

"What about the Heart itself then?" Catra mused. "You did absorb its magic. Maybe absorbing that much magic did

something.” Oh great. That was just what Adora wanted to think of. Another gift from the First Ones, she supposed. Would she ever escape the destinies people set before her?

“I guess we’ll find out at Mystacor?” Adora shrugged and looked down.

“Yeah.” Catra said. “There’s been a lot that’s happened.”

“No kidding. Failsafe mission-our fight-Heart mission-and now everything today.” Adora threw herself back to look up at the stars. Catra snickered before moving to sit beside Adora. “We haven’t really had time alone since Darla.”

“Those nights were kinda nice…you know, except for the nightmares.”

“When do we not have those?” Adora teased.

“What’s real sleep anymore?” Catra smiled and poked Adora. Adora giggled and poked Catra back.

“Listen here!” Catra pounced on top of Adora, pinning her arms.

“You know I can get out of this at any moment.” Adora smirked. Catra leaned down in her face, noses almost touching. “That’s awfully close.”

“Oh, you know you like it.” Catra purred. Adora grunted as she rolled. She pushed Catra to the ground and leaned over her.

“See, told you.” Adora playfully looked at one of her arms. “I’m much stronger than you.”

“No!” Catra feigned surprise. “You being stronger than me? Never. But we both know I’m smarter.”

"If that's what you want to call it."

"You hit things until it breaks versus thinking of how to beat it."

"Brute Strength is a strategy! Besides, we improv here!"

"I've noticed." Catra reached a hand up, drawing her claw over Adora's face. Adora's face broke into a smile. "You're giving me that stupid smile again."

"I'm just happy you're here." Adora sat up and held out her hand. Catra took it and returned to her sitting position. "I've dreamed of this day for years."

"Yeah." Catra said dejectedly. "You've mentioned."

"Hey." She cupped Catra's cheek and met her eyes. Catra's eyes glowed slightly as the darkness continued to creep on them. "I'm simply happy you're here. We did it." They touched foreheads. Catra purred a little before she pulled Adora's chin up. Adora nodded and Catra pulled her into a kiss.

Adora's stomach fluttered and her skin tingled. The same feeling she had at the Heart. Her hands moved to caress Catra's ears, deepening her kiss. How long had she wanted this…

The pain in her chest burned suddenly. She pulled out of the kiss with a gasp and bent over.

"Adora?!" Catra grabbed her arms and supported her. "What's wrong?" Adora's eyes could barely stay open. She could feel She-Ra's magic flowing through her as if she would transform but it felt wrong. The pain felt like cuts were open all over her body. It burned like fire coursing through her veins.

As sudden as it started, it stopped. She took a deep breath as she sat up. Catra's eyes were full of worry. Her hands

moved up and down Adora's body as if she could find the problem.

"What happened?" Catra said.

"I don't know." Adora looked at her hand.

"Two in one day?" Catra whispered to herself.

"I think it was She-Ra."

"How?"

"I don't know. I just…" Adora felt embarrassed explaining that her love for Catra helped her transform. She knew Catra would tease her. When did Catra not tease her would be the better question but Adora loved their banter. "felt her magic like I was going to transform and it got worse."

"There you guys are!" Glimmer poofed in. She pursed her lips in a smile as she looked at the two. She realized what it looked like, with Catra holding her. Catra grunted and released Adora. She promptly fell over, laughing as Catra reached back out. "It's almost time for the ceremony."

"Ceremony?" Catra raised an eyebrow.

"The speeches!" Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Bow didn't tell you?!"

"No." Catra and Adora answered in unison.

"Ugh. You two are supposed to give a speech about the Heart."

"Now?!" Adora propped herself up.

"Now." Glimmer grabbed their shoulders. "Warning!"

"WAIT!" Catra yelled.

It was too late. They were teleported to the front of the courtyard. Catra slumped over, putting her head to the ground. Adora shifted sides to comfort her. They really needed to figure out how to help with that.

"Bow!" Glimmer called him over with a hiss. "You didn't tell them about the speech?!"

"Oh, I forgot!" Bow held his hands close to his chest.

"Seems a little important." Catra muttered. Adora tried to hide her smile with her hand.

"Catra can do it!" Bow suggested. Catra's ears shot up and her tail puffed.

"What?! Why me?"

"You did stuff like this all the time, did you? You should be a natural!"

"Why can't I do it?" Adora pouted. "I'm a good leader too."

"You think that." Catra patted her arm. Adora's mouth fell open as Bow and Glimmer stifled laughter. "You two are no better!" Catra pointed at them. "All you do is run head first into things!"

"Which is why you're there!" Glimmer grabbed Catra's shoulders. "You can be the planner."

"I'm going to kill your friends." Catra looked at Adora.

"Please don't."

"Come on!" Bow led them to the makeshift stand. The other Princesses stood by, chatting among each other.

"Is everyone making a speech?" Catra asked.

"No, only the four of us, Perfuma and Micah." Bow showed them where to stand. Catra stood next to Scorpia, who gave her a kind smile. Catra tried for one and looked away. Adora was really tired of all the talking about everything but she should talk to Scorpia and Catra about everything.

"Good evening everyone," Glimmer brought the crowds attention to her. There were so many people packed in there from all over Etheria. How did they get so many people here that quickly? Catra interlaced her fingers with Adora and squeezed. Adora squeezed back and gave her a small smile.

Her mind went back to their moment in the garden. She looked at her palm, flexing her fingers. She had felt this pain before. She had this feeling. She hadn't recognized it that morning but this time she did. The first time the Heart was activated. That's what it felt like. All the magic rushing through her body, burning her from the inside. Was Catra right? Was it the magic she absorbed? She was sure she had rid of herself of the virus and the Failsafe yesterday.

"And now, a word from Adora." She barely registered Glimmer's words. She shook out of her head and realized Glimmer was waiting on her to step forward. Regretfully, she stepped forward and let go of Catra's hand. Catra gave her a smile to show it was okay before gripping her arm and standing back. As Adora walked closer, her foot caught on something. She yelped and fell face first into the ground. Gasps collectively sounded as she stood and wiped herself off.

"Hi everyone!" She tried for a laugh. She ran a hand through her hair and took a breath. "Thank you for coming here and celebrating with us tonight. It's been a long war. Many things have happened." Her brain was going blank. She remembered all the fights with Catra over the years. All the times she'd lost. All the times she won. The Portal. Angella's death. Light Hope. Mara.

"Adora?" Glimmer asked from the side. Adora felt her breathing pick up. She was fine. Everything was fine now. She…

she had won. She had done this before. She had spoken to crowds. She had given directions. She was She-Ra. Why was her mouth so dry?

"I believe what she is meaning to say is you have preserved through everything." Catra's voice rang out. She could feel Catra's claws running up and down her forearm in a comforting manner. "I know I'm not one to speak. I've done a lot of bad things during this war. I'm sorry. And I know some of you won't forgive me and you don't have to." Catra continued. Her voice was commanding yet calm. Adora closed her eyes and listened. "I hope to help you rebuild and to fix what I have done." Adora laced her fingers through Catra.

"I'm asking that you give them the same welcome you offered me." Adora spoke with a thankful glance to Catra. "I also grew up in the Horde. I am proof that people can change. Many in the Horde were hurt just like we were. We are only strong when we are together." She looked at Catra. "You can't do it alone." She looked at the crowd. "When I was dying in the Heart, Catra was there for me. She helped me to overcome it and to save everyone. I wouldn't be here without her."

"Which is why I'm announcing forgiveness for all in the Horde. We are planning to help them assimilate into life here if they please." Glimmer chimed in. "The programs start tomorrow and we will rebuild and be stronger than ever!" The crowd cheered as Glimmer raised her fist in the air. Catra and Adora lifted their hand together as the other Princesses joined them. They laughed together before walking off to let Glimmer continue.

"You did a good job." Catra's tail swacked her.

"I vote you do the public talking from now." Adora teased.

"You're She-Ra." Catra mocked. "And you can't give a speech."

"Apparently not." She sighed. During the war, she wasn't terrible at giving orders and running things like that…was she? She was

the one with the Horde training. She was the one who was supposed to be Force Captain, making plans and running things. Catra was right. She was She-Ra and she couldn't even give a speech.

"You've had a long day." Catra waved it off. "Don't worry about it." Catra motioned for Bow. "We're going to bed for the night."

"You're gonna miss the ending."

"I'm sure we'll see it another time." Catra flickered her eyes towards Adora. Adora's heart sank further. Was she really useless without Catra there? She had functioned the last three years without her. Not because she wanted to though.

"Goodnight." Bow waved. Adora could hear Perfuma speaking as they walked back towards the castle.

"Not how I thought today would go." Catra teased as they walked through the empty castle halls. "How many times have we been in these halls today?"

"Too many times." Adora said.

"Stop it." Catra poked her hard with her claws.

"I'm not doing anything."

"I can see it. You're thinking that you're a terrible She-Ra."

"No, I'm not."

"And you just confirmed it." Catra laughed. Adora smiled a little. She just wanted to peel off the dress and go to sleep. As soon as they returned to Adora's room, Catra closed the door behind them. Adora fumbled briefly with the zipper before almost tearing the dress off. Catra stood with her back to the door and just watched. Adora didn't care.

She left the dress in a crumpled mess, even though it was bugging her to not pick up. She placed her tiara on the closest surface. She crawled into the cot where she had been laying hours before and pulled her covers up. She closed her eyes. She didn't have anything to say at the moment. She had been happy yesterday with Catra. She was happy today with Catra and the others but…she was angry with herself.

She heard Catra finally move from the door. She listened as Catra removed her clothes for the day and padded over the bed. She slid into the bed next to Adora but kept her back to her. Catra's tail wrapped around her ankle but otherwise, they laid almost separately in the bed.

Adora rolled over and tapped Catra's arm. Wordlessly, Catra turned. She pulled Adora's head to her chest and purred softly. Adora wanted to laugh. Catra knew she loved her purrs and she differently used it to her advantage.

"I don't know about you but I'm not really in the mood to talk feelings anymore." Catra whispered in her ear.

"Yeah." Adora laughed a humorless laugh. "Same."

They laid there in silence, the only sound being their breathing and the breeze outside the window.

"Thanks for coming back." Adora said.

"Thanks for coming back for me." Catra answered. "You didn't have to."

"I thought we weren't talking feelings tonight?"

"Says the one who started the conversation." Adora chuckled. "Are you happy there?"

"What?" She looked up at Catra, who was giving her a funny look. Catra's eyes motioned to her stomach where Adora realized she was tracing circles into Catra's fur. "Oops."

“Old habits die hard, huh?” Catra giggled.

“Did Glimmer say anything about what plans are for tomorrow?”

“Probably another party knowing you guys.” Catra’s claws brushed through Adora’s hair. “But you have to go to Mysatcor as some point. We need to figure out what’s going on.”

Adora laid there, thinking. She was frustrated with everything going on, though Catra being there was definitely helping. She groaned out loud and covered her face with her hand. She felt Catra shift away for a moment. Great, now even Catra didn’t want to be with her… Too much had happened. If they didn’t need She-Ra anymore…

THUMP!

The pillow smacked Adora on the side of her head. She shot up as Catra started cackling.

“Catra!” THUMP! “Stop!” THUMP! “That’s not fair!” She pushed away from Catra and they slid off in opposite directions. Adora jumped to her feet, seeing Catra already ready for another strike. “That’s playing dirty!”

“When do I not?” Catra threw the pillow. Adora caught it and shot a smirk back. Catra yelped and ducked to the side as the pillow flew at her. “I thought we were done trying to kill each other!”

“That wasn’t that hard!” Adora laughed as she hopped over the bed frame. She reached for a few cushions near the window. Catra dove for the pillow and curled up behind it in time to doge the barrage from Adora.

“Oh, look at me. I’m SHE-RA!” Catra grunted as she threw a cushion back. Adora leaned to the right and threw a cushion at Catra. She jumped to the side and slipped on Adora’s discarded dress, faceplanting into the floor. She scampered to her feet and looked up.

Adora saw her eyes go up to one of the panels that hung from the ceiling. She threw another cushion as Catra jumped and caught herself on the panel. She climbed the fabric, a smaller pillow between her teeth. She spit out the pillow as she hung near the ceiling. “Come on, Adora.”

“And what are you planning to do up there?” Adora put her hands on her hips.

“I guess you’ll have to come up and find out.” Catra cackled. Adora growled a little and grabbed a pillow. She walked to the closest panel of fabric and tried to get her footing. She tried wrapping it around her foot and pulling herself up. “What’s the matter? Is the almighty She-Ra unable to climb up?”

“You have claws, this isn’t fair.” Adora said. She pulled herself up a little higher when the fabric shifted. The loop her foot was in slid up her bare leg and she flipped upside down with a squeal. Catra laughed so hard she started coughing. Adora, cheeks burning, threw the pillow at Catra.

Catra almost choked as she leaned out to avoid the pillow. She let out a squeal herself as one of her hands lost its hold. She readjusted and hung there happily. “Hey Adora.” Catra teased her. “How’s it hanging?”

The memory flashed before her eyes. “Catra. Did you really show up late and let us do all the hard work? That’s low, even for you.” Adora gave another attempt at pulling herself up. The panel slipped through her fingers, and she grunted as she fell back into her position.

“Aw, you know nothing’s too low for me.” Catra quoted as she jumped down. She walked very leisurely over to Adora. “Do you need some help, Princess?”

“No!” Adora tried again, this time successfully grabbing the fabric. “I’m Savior of Etheria. Princess of Power.” She pulled herself upright with each title. “She-Ra and I’m doing just…AH!” She fell

back and hung upside down again. Catra giggled as she walked over to meet Adora's eyes.

"There's a trick to this." She put her hands under Adora's shoulders and helped lift her so Adora could get her hold. "Slide your leg out, dork!" Adora managed to do so after a few failed tries. Catra backed up so Adora could scale down the fabric.

"I'm not doing that-PFFT!" Adora said as the pillow smacked her in the face again. "I just got down!"

"That sounds like a you problem." Adora dove behind the bed. Catra was smart, feigning to help Adora and then attacking. Typical Catra. But Adora had her in strength. All she had to do is get one good hit in. She slid the blanket off the bed and saw another pillow sitting to her left. She needed to ask Glimmer for more pillows for nights like this.

"Are you really going to hide behind the bed for a while?" Catra's voice echoed a little. Adora peeked her head up and saw Catra hanging on the panel again. She had pulled a few cushions up with her, tucked into her lap. Okay, so the blanket plan wasn't going to work right off the bat. She could ambush her, though Catra seemed to have the majority of the pillows. "This isn't any fun if I can't hit you!"

Adora gave her best battle cry as she vaulted over the cot. She slid on her knees as a cushion flew over her. She jumped to her feet and shifted left to dodge another. She was pretty sure Catra only had one more. She ran and grabbed the panel Catra was hanging from.

THUMP! The last cushion hit her square in the face. Adora threw her head to the side to get it off. She grunted as she tore the panel from the ceiling. Catra eeped as she started falling. Adora held out her arms and caught her, Princess style.

"Hey Catra." Adora teased with a smug look. Catra snarled and pushed Adora's shoulders back. "Nope!" Adora tightened her grip,

keeping Catra in place. Catra shot her a look.

"I'm not surrendering."

"You can't surrender if you lose, can you?" Adora stuck out her tongue before yelping. Catra's hand had slid down and tickled her side. Catra dropped to the floor, scampering out of Adora's reach. "REALLY?! I thought we agreed never to use those!"

"I thought we also agreed to run the Horde together." Catra laughed from across the room. "But it sounds like some things might not have worked out that way." Adora picked up the closest cushion and chucked it at Catra. She caught it, surprise in her eyes. Adora blinked in shock. Catra's never caught one before. Catra sneered as she wound up for a good throw.

"Hey guys, are you-GAH!" Glimmer shouted as the pillow hit her dead in the face. Adora gasped and Catra cackled. Glimmer huffed as the pillow fell to the floor. "REALLY?! I came to check on you and you throw a pillow at me?!"

"Sorry, Glimmer." Adora walked over with a nervous smile.

"To be fair, I didn't know you were there." Catra shrugged playfully.

"I'm pretty sure you waited until I showed up to throw it." Glimmer smiled as she threw it back at Catra. "Bow said you left earlier. The party just ended with most people going home for the night. Are you two okay?" Glimmer looked between the two. Adora realized they were both breathing slightly heavy. Catra took a seat on the empty cot.

"Oh, we're fine. I won."

"Nuh-uh!" Adora crossed her arms. "I won."

"I got hits on both you and Sparkles. I win." Catra pointed to them.

"Yes, but I got you pinned down!"

"You tore the curtain from the ceiling. And you let go, so it doesn't count!"

"Adora!" Glimmer looked at the tore curtain. Adora covered her mouth to hide her smile as she took in the room. With all the pillow throwing and dodging, the room was in tatters. Papers and old plans were on the floor everywhere. The curtain Adora had been on was half tore. Pillows laid strewn.

"Sorry?" Adora moved her hand and tried for a smile.

"You know the rule is!" Glimmer said sternly. "If you're going to have a pillow fight…" She shimmered away mid-sentence. Catra shot her a glance and Adora shrugged. Glimmer returned with Bow in tow. He had a small sandwich in hand, surprise and confusion in his eyes. "YOU HAVE TO TELL US!" Glimmer picked up a pillow and threw it at Catra.

THUMP!

Catra flew back off the bed with a "EEP!"

"Alright, Sparkles!" Catra's arms appeared as she pulled herself up. "If that's how it is!"

"WHAT'S GOING ON?!" Bow screeched. Adora pulled him back before Catra's throw took him out.

"Pillow Fight!" Adora yelled. She picked up a cushion and smacked Glimmer's side with it. Glimmer yelled as she picked up another pillow and slammed it into Adora. They traded blows before Catra, who had bounced off a wall, attacked them with a blanket.

She covered them as the three fell to the ground. Laughter came from Adora before she could realize it. Glimmer teleported out, which was totally not fair. Adora realized what Catra was doing. She had taken part of the curtain panel and was tying Adora into the blanket.

“Catra!” Adora struggled to get free, eliciting giggles from Catra.

“Let her go!” Bow shouted. Adora could hear him coming forward before the pillow slammed into her stomach. She grunted as the force took the air from her lungs. “Sorry, Adora!”

“Hitting your own friend?” Catra’s voice sounded from above them. “And I thought I was the evil one.”

“You forget, Catra. This is my forte!” Bow’s voice carried a mischievous tone. Adora heard Catra yelp and things being thrown around her. Fed up with the blanket, she cried out.

“FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!” She-Ra burst from the blanket, standing over them. Bow was still next to her, pillow lost in his throw. Catra was perched on the wall near the waterfall.

“That’s cheating!” Catra pointed at her. “No She-Ra!”

“You never said that!” She-Ra chuckled.

“Hey!” Glimmer teleported next to her with more pillows. “Wow, why is She-Ra here?!” Adora took another pillow.

“Come on, Catra. Let’s play!” She wound up for a good hit, the pillow hitting Catra in the stomach. The force threw her back into the waterfall. Adora laughed as she released She-Ra. She heard a moan from Catra, who wasn’t really moving. “Oh no.” She raced over as Catra’s head hung out of the small pool.

“How hard did you throw that?” Bow asked.

“I don’t think I threw it that hard?” Adora reached her hand out. “Catra?” Catra’s face shot up with a sneer. She pulled Adora forward into the waterfall. Catra jumped out of the water and shook the water towards the other two.

“What did we do?” Glimmer asked as she shielded her eyes. Adora started laughing as she watched. Her face fell as she noticed

Catra flexing her nails and her tail on end. She laughed despite that but Adora could tell it was bothering her.

WHUMP!

A pillow hit Bow as Catra continued. He picked one up and threw it at Glimmer for help.

"That's not fair!" Catra yelped as the two moved in. Glimmer chucked one at her head, which Catra ducked under. She threw it back as Glimmer shimmered away. Bow slammed a pillow into her back, which prompted her to pull his leg out from under him. He fell to the ground with a yelp.

"AH!" Glimmer threw another few pillows. Adora jumped out of the pool and caught one before it hit Catra. Glimmer gasped as Adora threw it back. She shimmered around the room a few times, dodging Adora's random throws. Glimmer paused to breathe near the door. She kept a pillow in hand. Bow and Catra were wrestling over a pillow behind Adora as she grabbed the close cushion.

"No, you don't!" Bow yanked Adora's ankle as she threw the cushion. She grunted as she fell, the air escaping her lungs.

"Bow!" Adora exclaimed in disbelief.

"Sorry!" Bow shot her a grin before avoiding a strike from Catra's pillow. She wrestled him to the side as she sat on top of him, smacking him repeatedly. His arms came up to protect his head and tried to grab the pillow between strikes.

Adora turned back to Glimmer, squealing as the pillow flew by.

"So close!" Glimmer groaned. Her eyes went to the pile in the middle and Adora's followed. She stood, the two diving for the pile of pillows. Adora grabbed one and smacked Glimmer in the side. Glimmer retailed with two smaller pillows, hitting Adora repeatedly.

“How long has it been since we’ve done this?” Glimmer laughed as she fell back.

“Too long.” Adora flopped beside her. She panted for air. She closed her eyes and was just happy for once.

“AH!!” Bow and Catra yelled as they dive-bombed them. Adora grunted as Catra landed on her stomach. Glimmer caught Bow with a laugh. They all sat there, talking together.

“Not bad.” Catra looked at them.

“I didn’t know the Horde had pillow fights.”

“They didn’t.” Catra smirked. “We used weapons.”

“She’s right.” Adora nodded.

“We might have to clean the room tomorrow though.” Bow motioned to the destruction zone around them. Adora chuckled, taking it all in again. “We can do it while they’re in the meeting tomorrow?”

“Sure?” Adora shrugged. It was something to do, she guessed. She could use some time with Bow, just having fun and relaxing.

“Wait, do we still have that meeting?” Catra’s ears shot up.

“Yep.”

“UHH!” Catra flopped back with her hands over her face. “It’s so early.”

“What time?” Adora asked.

“Ten am.” Bow answered.

“That’s not early!” Adora turned to Catra.

“For you, maybe!” Catra sat up and poked Adora’s chest. “Some of us like sleep.”

"I agree with Catra." Glimmer said.

"We agree? Did the world end?" Catra looked at her hands as if they were foreign. "Are we dead?" Adora shoved her over as they all laughed. Catra bounced back into her seated position.

"Are you guys going to be okay tonight?" Bow shifted to a serious question. Catra looked down and away. It was clear she was still hesitant about last night.

"We'll be alright." Adora answered as she took Catra's hand. She felt Catra's fur bristle slightly before she relaxed. "Why don't you go get some rest and we'll meet up for breakfast?"

"Breakfast's at nine." Bow stood and helped Glimmer up. Adora and Catra stood before Bow and Glimmer pulled them into a hug. "Best Friend Squad Hug!"

As they released each other, Glimmer and Bow shimmered away. Adora and Catra sighed at the room around them.

"We should sleep." Adora said.

"I suppose." Catra yawned. She walked over to the window and looked out. Adora followed her, wrapping her arm around Catra's waist.

"That was fun." Adora spoke after a moment.

"Yeah. I guess living here isn't terrible…" Catra paused. "Why don't you get some sleep? I'm not going to bed yet."

"You have the meeting in the morning. I don't." Adora raised her eyebrows. "Shouldn't you sleep first?"

Catra stared out the window in silence. Her hand went to her neck, and she sighed. "I'm used to little sleep. It's fine."

"Catra…"

"It's fine." She sat on the windowsill and curled up. She wouldn't look at Adora. "I'll keep watch."

"We don't have to keep watch anymore." Adora rubbed the back of her neck awkwardly. "Come to bed with me…please?"

Catra looked at her finally, her cheeks red. "Really, that's how you say that?" Adora's eyebrows furrowed. She had jus…Her cheeks went red and she turned away.

"That's not what I meant." Catra's laugh filled the room and put her at ease. She glanced back at Catra. How had she gone the last three years without her? Adora never wanted to do that again.

"I don't think I ever said it." Adora started as she took a seat beside Catra. "But I'm glad you're here."

"You have." Catra smirked. "But I'll take it again."

"I meant!" Adora scrunched her nose at Catra. "I'm glad we're together again. I missed you."

"I missed you too, dork." Catra rolled her eyes.

"Also, I'm not going to bed until you do." Adora sat up proudly.

"You're such an idiot." Catra groaned as she leaned her head back against the wall.

"I love you too." Adora pulled Catra close, waiting for consent. Catra leaned in, kissing her softly. She pulled back after a moment, too soon in Adora's opinion.

"Come on." She took Adora's hand as she stood. Adora allowed herself to be led back to the cot. She paused as she went to grab a pillow or two and the blanket that had been discarded. Catra sat on the edge of the bed, waiting.

Melog appeared at Catra's feet and mewed softly. "No, we're not." Meow. "Melog." Mew Meow. "Listen, you little…"

"Are you good?" Adora pursed her lips in a smile.

"Fine." Catra shot a look at Melog, who laughed. Catra shifted to the other side of the bed and laid with her back to Adora. Adora put the pillows down before laying down herself. Melog jumped onto the end of the bed, curling up by their feet.

"We definitely need the bigger bed." Adora teased as she curled herself around Catra. Catra didn't respond. Melog meowed at her, though she didn't respond. "What's wrong?"

Melog meowed again before hopping off the bed. They went to Catra's face and licked her. Catra recoiled and curled into herself. Melog looked at Adora and chirped. Adora really wished she understood Melog like Catra could.

"Talk to me?" Adora asked. She tightened her grip around Catra. She wasn't letting go of her and she wasn't going to let Catra suffer alone anymore.

"Goodnight." Catra whispered. She didn't speak after that. Her hands went from holding Adora's to covering her face.

Adora felt hurt but she had a feeling she understood. Catra was probably worried about the nightmare returning. Adora didn't blame her. She had been scared herself and worried. But it didn't matter. She wasn't going to let her be alone. Adora took the silence and closed her eyes slowly.

She barely felt Catra's shift to look at her or Catra's hand pull out her ponytail. The only thing she knew was Catra purred as they fell asleep.

Adora could see it. Hear it. Feel it. She didn't want to. The pain coursing through her. The Heart beating above her. Catra calling her name and holding her.

The fountain stood in front of her again. She saw herself staring into it. The white dress with gold accents. The tiara similar to the one Bow made for her on her head. She heard the door open and turned. Catra and Glimmer ran into the room like before.

Adora knew what they were saying. She remembered that but their voices were garbled. Bow entered the room. She noticed the matching earrings and Adora's belt clip on Catra's shirt. The room around them was exactly the same. Catra stood in front of her, hand extended.

"You coming?" Adora felt herself smile and reach out. This time, Catra's hand stayed. She led Adora into the hallway. This part was new. She was almost waiting for Prime's voice to speak. She could hear him in her head. '*A beautiful wish*' he'd say. '*but there will be no future. Not for you*.'

They walked into the ballroom, but suddenly they were in the Fright Zone. Or what used to be the Fright Zone. Everyone was there, dancing, laughing, or talking.

"Hey dork," Catra's laugh captured her attention. "Would you stop spacing out? Scorpia's not going to be happy." Adora turned and look at Catra. She was beautiful. They had made it. Adora felt herself tear up. "Woah, what's wrong?" Adora shook her head.

She led Catra down to the dance floor, where they wrapped arms around each other and swayed to the music.

"You're an idiot." Catra spoke. "That's not the dance we're supposed to do." She motioned to the others. Adora didn't care. She laid her head on Catra's shoulder and sighed happily. Catra leaned her head against Adora's and they swayed with silence between them.

They stayed like that for a while, despite different music changes. Adora didn't care. She was there. She was happy. Catra was with her and they were free.

"Adora." It couldn't be. That voice…She stood straight and turned away from Catra's embrace. She clung to Catra's hand, regret running through her mind at leaving Catra's warm arms.

"Light Hope?" She blinked at the hologram in front of her. How was this happening? Light Hope had disappeared after she broke the sword. "I-I don't understand. How are you here?"

"There is no time. Listen, Adora." The word around them shimmered and broke.

"Catra!" Adora turned back but she was gone. A sob shook her. Not again. She couldn't-

"Adora!" Light Hope grabbed her shoulders.

"How are you?" Adora breathed heavily. "I don't…" She turned to look at Light Hope.

"The Heart is connected to you. You feel the magic in all of Etheria. You must be careful."

"I stopped the Heat with the failsafe. It's doesn't-"

"No. The failsafe stopped the Heart from destroying everything. That is all."

"The Heart…

"Is still active." Adora's eyes widened. Everything they had done. All the sacrifices…

"Is that….is that why I'm getting these…"

"Yes." Light Hope looked around them. "I must be quick. You must find ways to regulate the magic. You are the Heart of Etheria now. She-Ra and the Heart are one." Light Hope's figure began to glitch. "I am out of time. Razz will know."

"Madam Razz?"

"Yes, you must go to her. She will help you. Beware….be-of- mo—one…."

"Light Hope!" Adora reached out as she faded away. "No! Don't go!" Adora heard a crunching sound and looked at her feet. The floor dissolved. She fell into the darkness.

"AH!" She jolted up in bed. Moonlight from the moon's rising hit her eyes as she panted for breath. She recoiled from the light, pulling her arm up to shield her eyes.

"Adora?" Bow's voice sounded to her left. She turned with a small squeak. Bow stood over her with a concerned look. She "Are you okay?" She put a hand to her forehead. What was that dream? Light Hope…Madam Razz…the Heart.

Catra made a small sound as she stretched beside her. Adora turned, crying in relief. She scooped Catra into a hug, which made Catra hiss a little.

"At least let me wake up first." She groaned.

"What time is it?" She turned back to Bow, Catra moaning sleepily in her arms.

"About 9 am. I came to wake you for breakfast. Catra and Glimmer have that meeting."

"Right." Adora shook her head a little. "Thanks. We'll be there in a few."

"Hey." Bow put a hand on her shoulder. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine." Adora didn't know what to think. "We should get going." Catra finally broke from her in embrace and stretched her arms in the air. Adora blinked back the tears in her eyes. Catra was still safe next to her. Everything was okay. It had to be. It was just a dream…right?

Chapter End Notes

So clearly, I can't write party scenes. I've never been to one so yeah, might have to stay away from those in the future. :P The pillow fight scene was probably my favorite to write. I kept using Thesaurus.com to try and find words and I got nothing so sorry if it's a little repetitive. Leave a comment if you wish. :) I'd love to see if you have any running theories? Thank you for reading and I'll see you next week. :)

Learning to Flirt and Meetings

Chapter Notes

Hey,
Sorry I fell off for two weeks. I've been dealing with a lot of trauma and family disowning stuff lately. Gotta love religious family, am I right? I don't really know how to feel about this chapter anymore, I've rewritten it three times and I'm just going to post it and go with it. As well as I changed part of the original plot I had planned for this story.
By that I mean, my girlfriend and I just binged all of season 5 in one day and I realized I forgot to account for a few things and or found a better way to explain. I hope this makes sense to someone.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 5: Catra

Surprisingly, Catra slept through the night with no nightmares. It was the first night in a while, though she could tell by Adora's grip, she couldn't say the same for her. Despite Catra breaking from her grip to stretch, Adora kept her hands on Catra. Bow spoke to them for a moment about the day's plans. Catra and Glimmer had the council meeting in an hour and after that, the group was heading to Mystacor.

Micah was going with them to help Castaspella check Adora's powers. Adora hadn't told them about the mini episode last night when they had kissed in the garden and Catra wondered if that would change things. Adora grimaced when she had heard about the trip to Mystacor. Catra slipped her hand into Adora's and gave a small squeeze. Adora returned the gesture but didn't turn to look at her.

"You are worried." Melog chirped in her mind.

"Wow, you're so smart, Melog." Catra's inner voice dripped with sarcasm. "Can you sense any magic coming from Adora?" She asked after a moment.

"I sense her She-Ra magic." Melog answered. "She radiates magic energy."

"Catra?" Bow's voice pulled her from her conversation with Melog. Melog laughed in her head at her choice words for Bow at the moment. "Does that sound alright with you?" Catra pursed her lips. She had completely missed what he said.

"It should be fine." Adora tried for a smile, though clearly pained. "I'm sure Catra can adjust if needed."

"Sure." Catra threw her hands up in a sarcastic way. "Catra can adjust to anything, can't she?"

"I mean, you're Catra." Adora joked. Catra rolled her eyes and shoved Adora. The blonde fell backwards, though Catra was sure she did it on purpose. Catra hadn't pushed her that hard. Bow cringed as Adora hit the floor with a thud.

"Hey Adora." Catra teased her with her catchphrase as she leaned over the bed. Adora's legs stuck up on either side of her head as Adora's neck craned to look at her.

"Catra." Adora's voice was stern but not meaningfully.

"Are you two fighting or flirting?" Bow asked with a coy smile.

"Flirting?" Adora asked.

"Um…" Bow stuttered. His cheeks blushed slightly. "It's teasing each other because you like the other one…like you love them." Catra felt her cheeks burn and her tail bush when Adora answered with:

"Does that mean I flirt with you all the time?" Bow's mouth opened to answer as Catra fell back laughing. Adora would be that clueless!

"Not like that!" Bow tried. "It's different…like…you…"

"But I do love you guys. I love everyone in the alliance." Adora sat up, rubbing her neck. "So, if I tease them, that's flirting?"

"Not like that!" Bow covered his mouth, trying to think of how to explain.

"He means," Catra leaned down over the bed, her arms caging Adora in. Their faces a breath away from the other. "like this." Catra kissed Adora's cheek and pulled back to her sitting position on the bed. Adora touched her cheek and blinked for a moment.

"I don't get it." Catra and Bow both facepalmed as Adora looked on. "No…" Adora whined. "Angella kissed me."

"She what?!" Catra blinked. Wasn't that Glimmer's mom?

"Like here." Adora pointed to her forehead. "She did it to Glimmer all the time." Adora cupped her chin, thinking. "So, it is like loving everyone else."

"No, it's not." Bow's voice cracked.

"But she just…" Glimmer teleported into the room, interrupting Adora's statement.

"What are you guys doing?" She yawned. "We're waiting on you for breakfast.

"Glimmer!" Adora stood and grabbed Glimmer's arms. "You'd know!"

"Know what?!" Glimmer's eyes grew wide as she looked at Bow. Catra stifled a laugh.

"Didn't you say we needed to get breakfast?" Catra wanted to see this playout.

"We do." Glimmer gave her a look of distrust. "What are you plotting?"

"Nothing." Catra's tail whacked the blanket a few times as she grinned mischievously. "I'm just saying we should go get some food."

"Catra's right!" Bow clearly wanted to change the conversation.

"No!" Adora looked between them with her jaw set. "I want to know!"

"Know what?!" Glimmer looked between them all.

"We'll explain at breakfast!" Catra grabbed Adora's arm and pulled her back to the bed. "Why don't you two go and we'll be there in just a moment to get dressed." She gave them her best smile.

"I don't like that." Glimmer wagged a finger at her. "But fine." They shimmered away and Adora gave her a look.

"What are you hiding?"

"Nothing."

"Sure."

"You heard them." Catra shrugged. "We have to get to breakfast. They're waiting for us." Catra got up and walked to the closet. Thankfully, Entrapta had made them a few sets of clothes while they were still on Darla. She only had the one set left that

didn't have holes or rips in it. "We still need to go shopping for clothes."

"I was kinda hoping you had forgotten." Adora muttered. Catra threw a pair of gray pants at her. Adora giggled as she caught it and pulled them on. Catra rolled her eyes again and pulled out her clothes. As they changed and got ready, there was a peaceful silence between them.

Adora laced her fingers through Catra's as they walked to the dining room moments later. Catra looked out a nearby window on the way, the moons and stars bright in the sky. She ran her free hand through her short hair. She missed her long hair. She tried to focus on something else instead of the memory of her hair being cut against her will. It was unneeded as he had said. Torn from her after her first attempt in the pool.

Then again, her first attempt in the pool had almost killed her. When she had woken from it, Prime had sent her back to a room, a small blanket around her. Fragile creature, he had called her. The second time in the pool, the chip worked but… her throat burned from the breathing tube he had shoved down her throat. She could feel the ropes that bound her the second time, holding her in place despite the electric currents thrashing through her.

She had been proud of herself…resisting still. She clung to the memories of her and Adora as children. She had begged for death in between the pool sessions. She could hear the voices chanting around, the sound only fading beneath her screams and her head going under the water. The worst had been the third time in the pool.

She had broken entirely free from the chip one time. Adora's memory had flashed behind her eyes, bringing her back to Prime's ship. She felt the chip shock her and ravaged through her as Prime tried to control her. Reconditioning. Like Hordak. They had dragged her through the ship, kicking and screaming. She had clawed and bit as much as she could until her claws were

breaking, and her jaw hurt. Her voice broke as she was roughly thrown into the water the third time. Adora's memory faded as the currents coursed. Prime's voice spoke in her head of peace and order. He reminded her how she no longer needed to struggle. Adora had only hurt her. She had hurt Adora. Prime was their peace.

Then Adora came. She was horrified and relieved to see Adora. Why had she come back? Catra didn't matter enough to risk it. Catra should've died. It would've spared them both the trouble. But Adora fought her as weakly as she could, dodging more than hitting her. Adora's eyes had welled with tears and she had pleaded with Catra to come back with her. Catra could feel the hive mind pulling her back, and she could hear Adora's voice at the same time. Then Prime took control and threw her from the cliff. Catra should've died. Adora should've left her there. It was what she deserved for everything she did.

"Catra!" Adora's voice ripped her violently from the memories. They were in Bright Moon. Outside the dining room. Adora was shaking her. Tears had burned Catra's cheeks as she fully came back to where she was. Adora pulled her into a tight hug. "I've got you." Catra stood there shaking, eyes shifting back and forth as she tried to process what had happened. Had she remembered everything that quickly….Her hand reached up to her neck. No chip. She was really there with Adora. This wasn't the hive mind like before.

She sighed and leaned into the hug. She wiped her face and took a breath.

"Sorry." She muttered. Adora pulled back.

"You just stopped walking." Adora took a deep breath herself, trying to remain calm. "You wouldn't respond, and you started crying. Did you remember something?"

"Just…" Catra shook her head. "Just time on the Velvet Glove. That's all."

"You were muttering something about peace."

"Don't worry about it." Catra waved it away. "Let's get food. I'm hungry." Catra ignored the guards' look as she walked into the dining room. Adora followed her, clearly wanting to talk about it.

"There you are!" Frosta's voice was the first she heard. "We've been waiting!"

"You could've started." Catra pointed out. Everyone was in their same seats around the table, food sitting in front of all of them. Most looked up from their plates or conversations upon Frosta's statement. Scorpia had waved to her.

"We wanted to wait." Perfuma gently corrected. "We wanted to eat together one last time."

"Last time?" Adora turned to her.

"We're all heading back to our kingdoms after breakfast to start rebuilding."

"I'm heading to Dryl with Entrapta." Scorpia corrected.

"It's going to be so much fun!" Entrapta squealed. "We can have lots of tiny food and fizzy drinks!" Her hair reached around the table to give Scorpia a high five. "You could come with us, Catra."

"Oh, Super Pal Trio trip!" Scorpia smiled at her. Catra rubbed the back of her neck, still trying to shake off the memories.

"Thanks but I'm going to Mystacor with Adora. Have fun though."

"You'll come visit at some point though?"

"Sure…" Catra tried for a smile. That seemed to make them happy. Bow offered them coffee. Catra hadn't had much of it before. Scorpia had normally brought her tea if anything. After adding some cream and sugar as they had said, Catra was content with her "wake up juice." Glimmer's words.

"Wait!" Adora took a dramatic pose, legs spread apart and crouching. Her arms flew out, stopping Glimmer and Catra from moving. "I want answers."

"What are you talking about?" Mermista furrowed her eyebrows. Adora stood back up straight and looked at Bow. Bow choked on his drink as he realized what she was meaning. Catra felt her mouth curl into a grin.

"It's complicated, Adora." Bow rubbed the back of his neck. "Can we talk about it on the way to Mystacor?"

"No!" Adora clenched her fists. "I don't like not knowing. You said it's not the same but it is."

"What isn't the same?"

"Adora, you're not making sense."

"What are you talking about?" Micah inquired finally. Catra had almost forgotten he was in the room. Glimmer's dad seemed fairly level headed. She had really only met him during their fight at the Failsafe, and he was under the chip at that point. Otherwise, she had known him only two days. She was still fairly wary of him, but the others seemed to trust him.

"Flirting." Adora looked at him with frustration and confusion. She paced back and forth, hands flying through the air as she spoke. "If I'm understanding it correctly, I've been flirting with everyone cause I love everyone here but Catra said it's different but then it's Angella flirting with Glimmer and me and I just don't understand." Adora slumped into her chair with a sigh.

Everyone around the table wore confused looks on their faces as they tried to process what Adora said. Catra took her seat beside Adora and sipped her coffee quietly. She did have to admit, confusion and chaos were a little fun in cases like these.

Micah laced his fingers and rested his chin on them, clearly thinking of how to answer.

"Okay, Adora." He spoke calmly and words chosen carefully. "What have you heard flirting is…just definition wise."

"Bow said it's teasing someone because you like or love them." Adora looked at Bow, who was blushing and holding his head with his hand.

"That's one way to describe it…" Micah said gingerly. "You said Catra said something different?"

Catra's ears went up at the mention of her name. She looked away.

"Catra said it was…" Adora paused trying to think of how to say it. Catra figured she should help her a little. Her idiot. Catra leaned over and pecked a kiss on Adora's cheek, like she had done earlier. She bit her cheek and looked away to avoid blushing. That was the first time she had kissed Adora in front of the others.

Scorpia and Perfuma squealed quietly. Seahawk gave her a thumbs up and Mermista ignored her. Frosta looked disgusted and Entrapta was taking notes, on what Catra had no idea.

"Like that!" Adora pointed to her cheek. "But if that's what flirting is, then Angella was flirting on the time, right?"

"Why do you say that?" Glimmer tried to cover her mouth.

"She was always kissing you on the forehead. And she kissed me on the forehead during the…" Adora stopped, glancing at Catra. Catra's eyebrows furrowed. Why did she look at her like that? Catra wasn't sure what happened to the former Queen of Bright Moon. She had been too busy during the war to look into it. All she had known was Double Trouble had referred to Sparkles as queen during their infiltration mission. She had learned during Princess Prom that the other Princesses ran their kingdoms due to their parents stepping down. She assumed Angella had done the same…though, if that were the case, shouldn't she have run into her by now…

Catra continued musing on the thought, as she heard Micah trying to explain what flirting was to Adora. The fun of the joke was lost on her now. Had something happened to Angella? She disappeared right around the time of the portal.

"Catra's clearly got something on her mind though." Glimmer teased. Catra shook herself from her thoughts and glared at Glimmer.

"Don't we have a meeting to go to?" Catra crossed her arms.

"Actually, we do need to go." Glimmer stood. "It's just down the hall." Catra followed suit, purposefully brushing Adora's hand with her tail. Adora gave her a look of longing before she left. Laughter followed them into the hall as she heard Micah try to explain the differences between flirting that followed with a giant "OH!" from Adora.

Catra and Glimmer shared a look, and continued down the hallway.

"So, Horde Scum." Glimmer smiled. "This council helps run Bright Moon while I'm away. They are made of people my parents chose years ago. They're pretty helpful most of the time."

"That's reassuring." Catra scoffed. Glimmer chuckled and continued.

"But sometimes, they can be a little stubborn. They didn't like Adora when she first arrived, though we didn't tell her that." Catra grimaced. "I've got it under control. But you should be prepared."

"I'm the Horde Leader." Catra muttered to herself, more for confidence that bragging. "They should be prepared." Glimmer grinned and stopped in front of a door. This door was different than the others, having a crown over a picture of the Moon Stone inscribed on the door.

Glimmer pushed the door open. Catra took a steadying breath and entered after Glimmer. She wasn't the crybaby she was around Adora. For now, for her own sake, she needed to be the same person who hurt Scorpia. She hated thinking of it like that, but she couldn't think of any other way to describe it. Her instincts of protecting herself were on high alert.

The room was set up like the War Room, a table with holograms of Etheria in the middle of the room. Chairs lined the table all the way around, filled with older people of varying races and genders. A few in particular stuck out to Catra. An old woman with bird like features and white wings folded against her back in an all-white dress. Her black hair was braided down her shoulder.

Another person had the deer like features Catra had seen in Plumeria during her attacks on Thaymor. They had large antlers protruding from their head and were dressed in dark greens and blacks. More of the Horde colors but Catra guessed people of Etheria could wear those colors too.

"Good morning, everyone." Glimmer spoke. She carried herself with confidence, her staff clicking on the floor in time with her shoes. She took her place at the front of the table, Catra following her. There were no empty seats left so Catra stood to

the right of Glimmer, her hands laced behind her back. “Let’s get right to business.”

“Why is she here?” The person with antlers asked. “She is our enemy.”

“She is on our side now.” Glimmer spoke carefully. “She is my Royal Strategist.”

“How can we be sure she will not betray us?” Another man from the back spoke. “She is from the Horde.” Catra couldn’t blame them for their suspicion. “You said the same of Shadow Weaver, did you not?”

Okay, that was were Catra drew the line. She wasn’t being compared to Shadow Weaver.

Catra felt the growl rising in her throat. Glimmer stuck her hand out, resting against Catra’s torso. Catra’s eyes flashed to Glimmer.

“She is my Royal Strategist.” Glimmer addressed the room as she stood. “I made a mistake with Shadow Weaver. But Catra has proven herself to be on our side.”

“And how has she done that?” The swan woman’s crackly voice asked.

“She saved me from Prime multiple times. If she hadn’t been there, I would’ve been killed upon arrival. She bought us time and eventually saved me at the cost of herself.” Glimmer turned to Catra and flashed a smile. “I think that’s enough for me.” She turned back to the room. “As well as she helped us with the Heart of Etheria project. If she and Melog hadn’t gone with us, we wouldn’t have been able to enter Mystacor to get the failsafe. She saved Adora in the Heart and helped us defeat Prime. Is there anything else she must do?”

“One could argue.” The person with antlers spoke once more. “That these problems wouldn’t have occurred without her.

If she had not brought Prime here, we wouldn't have faced him and the losses we have occurred."

"Yes, because you were doing so well before that." Catra finally spoke. Several gasped as she titled her head up, looking down at them. She felt her lips curl into the smirk she had gotten so good at giving people. "I mean, really. You were barely holding onto Bright Moon's territories and were losing ground to the Horde every day, weren't you? That sounds so much better."

"You will not speak to us in such a manner." They responded to her.

"It looks like I just did though." Catra shifted to her hips and pointed a finger at him. "And what are you going to do…"

"I-."

"Senator Brakenten." Glimmer was clearly trying to resist a smile. "Please." The senator took their seat with a look of malice on their face. Glimmer turned to Catra and gave her a look that said 'good job but tone it down a smidge?'. Catra huffed quietly but stepped back. As much as she hated being told what to do, Glimmer was right in this case. Catra needed to help make amends, not burn bridges before they were even built. Catra needed to play her cards right.

"As I announced last night, our recovery programs for those in the Horde commence today." Glimmer typed into the computer table and a few holograms appeared on the table. Catra recognized Dryl and the Fright Zone on the far end. "The clones from Horde Prime's armies are leaving with Princess Entrapta and Princess Scorpia on their way to Dryl before some will be taken to the Fright Zone to enhabit those areas again." It was weird to hear Princess Scorpia, though she supposed it had been a while since she had heard the title Princess Entrapta.

"Ah, so we are allowing other Horde captains free reign over the clones, that is a smart decision." The same senator

spoke in a booming voice. Catra narrowed her eyes at them. She was really going to hate this person.

"Princess Entrapta is the only person who is capable of removing the Horde chips and Horde programing. Princess Scorpia is helping her before reclaiming her kingdom of the Fright Zone area."

"And how are you certain they will not betray us either? Princess Entrapta has proven to be on the side of whatever she pleases. And Princess Scorpia is an unrecognized princess." The swan woman spoke.

"Weird." Catra answered. "She was recognized at Princess Prom. I mean, that's how we got in the door."

"Clearly, it was a mistake." The woman said with distaste. "You damaged The Kingdom of Snows with your…antics at Princess Prom. I'm sure Princess Frosta does not agree with you."

"Actually." Glimmer stepped in. "Princess Frosta and Princess Mermista have given their blessings for Catra's promotion to Royal Strategist." Catra blinked in surprise. Last she had spoken to Frosta directly, Frosta had punched her and said she didn't like her face. Mermista had been nice last night but also said she didn't like her. Catra wondered if Glimmer was lying. She'd be impressed if it was true.

"Regardless," The woman looked from Glimmer to Catra with disdain. "The council is disapproval of your decision."

"Well, I'm the Queen." Glimmer straightened in her seat. Catra smiled a little. "and what I say goes. Catra is my Royal Strategist and any other complaints can be made to me or will be silent." Sparkles wasn't half bad at this. The room quieted and settled into their seats again.

"Good." Glimmer stood. "Now, something has come up and I will be leaving to Mystacor for a few days at maximum."

"After we've just finished the war?" One person from the back spoke.

"This concerns my friend, Adora. We won't be long." Catra could tell Glimmer was losing her patience, though she was trying to keep her words nice. Which Catra couldn't say anything, she would've already been yelling if this was the Horde like before.

"Ah yes, your She-Ra." Senator Brakenten spoke, raising his hand in the air. "Has she not caused enough issues for our kingdom?" Catra's fur bristled. Slandering her was warranted. She had done bad things. But slandering Adora? That wasn't okay.

"She-Ra is the only reason we are here today." Glimmer's voice held venom. "We wouldn't be anywhere without her. Do not speak of her in such a way again."

"I am simply pointing out that She-Ra has caused many issues since her arrival three years ago. As well as one could blame her for Catra's ascendance through the ranks. Really, isn't she to blame for all of the Horde's advancements for the past three years?"

"Ha-ha!" Catra's high pitched laughter drew the attention she planned. She glared at them. She was done playing nice. Sparkles could yell at her later. "Actually, you should be grateful. If Adora had stayed on our side after finding She-Ra, you would've been wiped out before now. Horde Prime wouldn't have anything to do here because we would've won. The only reason you are here right now is because of Adora." Catra slammed her palm onto the table, shaking it. "And if you're smart, you'll never speak of her like that again."

"Are you threatening me, Catra…"

"So, you are smart enough to understand that?" Catra smirked and crossed her arms in front of her. "And it's Horde Leader Catra or Royal Strategist Catra. Pick one."

"You will not speak like that to me."

"No, you won't speak to me like that." Catra put her hands on the table and leaned forwards. "Or I can very easily recreate Salineas here in Bright Moon." Gasps of horror sounded around her and she could feel the unease rolling off of Glimmer. "If you don't believe me," Catra stood back up and leaned against the chair that Glimmer occupied. "Try me. See if I'm lying." Several around the room traded looks. Catra stood up straight and her eyes flashed to Glimmer. "I'm done here." Without another word, she left the room. Senator Brakenten tried to stop her and was met with a hiss.

As she stepped out of the room, she could hear Glimmer trying to calm the people inside but Catra didn't care. She ran her hands through her hair and felt her breath picking up. Now she had done it. Good job, Catra. Way to get people to listen to you. Threatening them is a great option!

First Adora's nightmare, then her panic attack, the Angella missing thing, now this. And that was only a few hours into the day. She was doing great with this whole being nice thing. She put her head against the wall.

Where was Adora? Back in their room? She started back towards that way. She just needed to see Adora. The words of the Senators stuck in her mind. Adora wasn't a nuisance or a problem. If anything, Adora was stuck with a problem that had the name of Catra more than anything.

Would Adora even want to see her? Catra froze in place, halfway down the hall. Catra was just problem to her after all. Adora wouldn't want to deal with her. Maybe…Catra should stay away from her. She had just caused problems for Glimmer, who was going to be mad at her now. If Sparkles was mad, Bow would be too. And Adora would pick them over her. She had done so for the last three years…why would it be different now? Catra's breath quickened as she felt tears building. Adora wouldn't want

her anymore. This was a mistake. She turned away. She should just leave. It would make their lives easier.

She started walking down the hall, away from Adora's room. She couldn't call it theirs anymore. She didn't belong here. She held herself as she wondered where she could go.

Suddenly a weird feeling tingled behind her ears. She felt pressure, as if someone was caressing them…like Adora would. She almost leaned into the feeling of comfort before realizing no one was in the hall with her. She stared at the floor, thinking.

"Adora is waiting for you." Melog's voice chirped in her head.

"No, she isn't." Catra's voice broke as she spoke out loud. "She wouldn't…"

"I will get more ear scratches to prove it." Melog spoke.

"Wait, that's…" Catra turned before the feeling returned. Adora was loving on Melog…who was sharing the feeling with Catra.

"Hi Melog!" Adora's voice echoed in her head as if it were an empty room. She heard Adora's laugh, which was the best sound in the world to Catra. "You're so loving. I wonder if Catra can feel this." Bow's voice in the background was muddled but Adora laughed at what he said. Catra felt herself calming down, just listening to Adora speak.

"Need I do more?" Melog asked kindly.

Catra's anger at the Senators was still there but she could feel herself calming.

"I had a nightmare last night." Adora's voice echoed in her head again. "I…Catra was with me at Princess Prom…but like…in the

future.” Catra wrapped her arms around her torso, holding herself as she listened. Her ears folded down and she moved to the wall, sitting against it. “Catra and I were dancing. It was so much fun.” Catra closed her eyes. She could almost see it herself. Like they had danced together last night at the party.

Bow’s voice was still mumbled. Maybe Melog was working on just picking up Adora’s voice. They had never said they could do anything like this before. Catra wasn’t complaining though. Adora laughed a little before Catra felt the tingling feeling move down her back.

“But…then Catra disappeared.” Catra’s ears perked up. “I turned away for one second and it was like I had lost her all over again.” She felt the tingling feeling move around again…she was pretty sure Adora was hugging Melog. “I’m so scared Bow. I don’t want to lose her again. What if…what if I’m not good enough to be with her?”

Catra blinked in surprise before laughing out loud. Adora? Not enough for her? Was she kidding? Adora was the world to Catra. If anything, Catra didn’t deserve Adora. Catra was the one who had hurt Adora so many times over the last three years. Catra was the one who deserved the hate, not Adora.

“I mean.” Adora’s voice captured Catra’s attention again. Adora sighed. “I think I really love her, Bow. Like…I said it at the Heart and I meant it. I love Catra. But I don’t know how to do any of this relationship stuff.” She could hear the tears in Adora’s voice. “Catra knows so much more than I do. What if I’m too stupid for her? I can’t even tell the difference between flirting and…” Adora sniffled. “Why would she want to be with someone like me?”

Catra wondered the same thing. How Adora could just forgive her so easily…Catra didn’t think she’d ever understand.

“Catra said she’s fine with going slow. She said she doesn’t know what we are either. She said she loves me.” Bow interrupted her and Catra really wished she could hear what he was saying.

"Yeah, you're right. Thanks, Bow." Adora laughed as Bow said something.

"Are you okay, Catra?" Melog's voice echoed as Adora's faded away. She almost didn't want it to go. "They are waiting for you and Glimmer to return to the room to leave for Mystacor. They want you here, Catra."

Catra took a deep breath. They wanted her here. She had to trust that. She wanted to be with Adora. Besides, she wanted answers to her questions. What was going on with Adora? Was she really forgivable? Would she and Adora ever just be happy? Would she be able to fit in here? She wanted to ask about Angella but they hadn't asked her about Shadow Weaver. She figured it might be a touchy subject and with her actions in the meeting room, she didn't think Glimmer would be too happy with her.

She stood and ran her hands through her hair once more. She really did miss her long hair. She started for Ado-their room. She took sharp breath as she took hold of the handle and forced the door open. Adora and Bow had finished moving the fluffy bed into the room, which was much cleaner than this morning. Most of the pastel curtains were gone and all the pillow from the night before had found new homes in the room. She smiled a little. Maybe she could get used to this.

"Catra!" Adora's happy declaration brought her attention back to her dumb blonde. Adora's face was lit with her comforting smile before she walked over and pulled Catra into a hug. "How'd the meeting go?"

"It…" Catra didn't want to answer that. It'd just upset Adora if she knew that Catra had messed it up again. She had to get better at this…for Adora.

"It went well." Glimmer's voice popped in from behind Adora. Adora released Catra to turn back.

“Really?” Bow wrapped an arm around Glimmer’s waist. Catra bit her lip to avoid saying anything. They’d make a cute couple though.

“Yeah, Catra’s pretty good at this.” Glimmer winked at her. Catra laughed and moved from Adora. She walked to Glimmer and slung her arm around her other side.

“What else did you expect?” She gave Glimmer a side look, which the Queen returned with a smile. Adora giggled and tackled them into a hug.

“Best Friend Squad!” Bow’s voice cracked. They all laughed before Glimmer teleported out of the embrace. They looked between each other, confusion apparent. Catra shrieked as a pillow came down on her head. She crouched and turned to see Glimmer, laughing.

“Oh, you wanna go again?!” Catra grabbed a pillow from the bed and whacked Glimmer off her feet.

“Wait, we just got everything clean!” Bow tried before sighing as Adora grabbed a pillow and joined them. Bow shrugged and joined the fight, all laughing as they fought.

Chapter End Notes

I'd love to hear thoughts on this chapter, if you're willing. Also, question if anyone feels like answering, would anyone care if I change part of the POV style? I'm debating on adding Glimmer and or Bow's POV's in and maybe doing a mixture of POV's instead of the one through the entire chapter. I'm still thinking about it since I don't really want to change it half way through but yeah.
I'm going to try and update next week. I can't promise I will, but I'll try. Thanks for reading.

The Mystacor Trip and New Looks

Chapter Notes

Sorry it's been awhile. Last two weeks have been really rough. I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 6: Adora

After another pillow fight, though not to the same standard as the night before, Adora and others finished getting ready to go to Mystacor. Adora had said goodbye to everyone after breakfast. She wondered how long it would be before they were all together again but so much work needed to be done to repair Etheria. She and Bow had gone back to their room to clean and move things around.

"Catra's going to love this." Bow smiled as they finished setting up the fluffy bed Adora had received when she first arrived in Bright Moon. She still wasn't a huge fan of it but if it was for Catra, she could learn to deal. As they had finished and had taken a seat to relax for a moment, Melog had hopped onto her lap for cuddles.

"Hi Melog." Adora laughed as they licked her face. She scratched their ears in return. "You're so loving. I wonder if Catra can feel this." She and Bow talked briefly about her nightmare, though she didn't share the part about Light Hope. She didn't know what to make of it. Part of her wanted to wait until they were done at Mystacor. Whatever Castaspella and Micah had planned should give them the information they needed…right?

Catra and Glimmer returned at the same time, clearly something happened in the meeting though. The little wink Glimmer gave Catra was enough for Adora to know. Whatever it was, it must have worked out.

Now they were standing outside of the castle, Catra sitting on Melog's back. Glimmer, Bow, and Adora were planning on riding on Swiftwind's back. Micah had said he'd meet them there.

"Are you sure you don't want to ride with us?" Swiftwind offered. "We're going to do loop-de-loops!"

"I'm good." Catra tried for a smile. "Melog and I are just going to go ourselves."

"Race you there?" Adora challenged. Catra looked at Melog, who gave a challenging growl.

"Just don't get upset when we beat you." Catra changed into her riding position on Melog's back and grabbed tight. Melog took off into the Whispering Woods towards Mystacor. Adora felt a pang in her chest, watching Catra leave. It reminded her of their fight a few days ago when Catra had left with Melog.

This was different. She reminded herself that Catra was going to meet her at Mystacor. It was a race.

"Swifty!" Adora turned to her steed with a smile. "We gotta beat them there!"

"Of course!" Swiftwind shook his mane. "What kind of steed would I be if I couldn't!" Adora giggled and hopped onto his back. Glimmer's arms wrapped around her waist and she took a deep breath.

"Let's go!" Swiftwind took a running start and soared into the air.

"How was the meeting?" Bow asked Glimmer again.

"It was fine, Bow." Glimmer laughed. "Catra did great."

"Did she really?" Adora asked. She didn't feel right, doubting Catra but Scorpia had said Catra had really gone

downhill mentally as her leadership of the Horde progressed. She knew it had to be everything going on and Catra was getting better but it didn't stop Adora's worrying thoughts.

"Well…" Glimmer gave an awkward smile. "She did threaten a Senator." Adora and Bow made a noise before Glimmer continued. "If she hadn't, I would've! And I think her threat worked better than mine would've anyway."

"What did she say?" Bow asked.

"She said she'd recreate the Salineas attack on Bright Moon if she had to." Adora felt a cold chill down her back. The Salineas attack had hit them all really hard during the war. It was Catra's biggest hit to them. Double Trouble had wasted their time and Adora had felt like a failure for that. She couldn't even spot a simple spy, though Double Trouble couldn't be categorized as simple. They were a handful.

"Why did she say that in the first place?" Adora said. "She must have had a good reason, right?"

"Actually," Glimmer chuckled. "The Senator made a remark about you."

"Me?" Adora tried to look back at Glimmer before a pain in her neck reminded her that she wasn't that flexible. She looked forward. Catra was defending her?

"Yeah," Glimmer squeezed her arms around Adora's waist. "Catra immediately jumped to your defense and when the Senator pushed it, she threatened them and walked out. It took me a little to calm everyone and I promised another meeting about this when we returned from Mystacor."

"Aw." Bow chimed in from the back.

Adora felt her cheeks blush. Catra defended her. She really did love her…Catra wasn't lying when she said that. Not that Catra had given off the impression of lying…Adora scolded herself

mentally. She needed to trust Catra more. Why had she even doubted Catra? She took a breath and set her jaw. Catra loved her. She loved Catra. They were going to be okay.

"Hey Adora." Swiftwind whispered to her. She leaned forward to hear him. "When we get to Mystacor, I need to talk to you." Adora blinked. Swifty wasn't one to really keep things quiet, but she nodded and patted his neck.

"Of course."

"What are you two plotting?" Bow teased.

"Only how to do the best loop-de-loops!" Swiftwind neighed as he flew higher in the air. He spun them around, Glimmer and Bow yelling happily as they clung to Adora. Adora laughed loudly as Swiftwind took them into another loop-de-loop.

Soon after, with many loop-de-loops and other aerial tricks by Swiftwind, they arrived in Mystacor. Catra and Melog sat next to one of the trees outside. Catra bit into an apple as they arrived.

"Took you long enough to show up." Catra sneered.

"We did loop-de-loops!" Swiftwind admonished.

"Yeah, definitely glad we came separately." Catra shared a look with Melog. Melog meowed happily and nuzzled Catra's leg.

"GLIMMER~!" Casta's voice trilled as she walked towards them. Glimmer groaned and put on a smile.

"Hi Aunt Casta!" Casta swept her into a hug. "We just saw each other yesterday!"

"I just miss my favorite niece!" Casta smiled. Adora couldn't blame her. They had lost a lot during the war. Adora shot

a sideways glance at Catra, who was watching Glimmer and Casta's interaction. Adora had wondered if she was right to not mention Angella in front of Catra. She was pretty sure Catra knew what happened. It didn't really need said. Entrapta had explained it to her so she must have explained it to Catra as well. But she thought it might make Catra feel bad and she didn't want to blame her in front of everyone like that.

"Adora, Bow. It's good to see you again!" Casta finally released Glimmer and pulled the two of them into a hug. She released them quickly and turned to Catra. Catra's eyes grew wide and her tail bushed out. "Would you like a hug too?" Casta tried with a smile. Catra blinked in surprise and looked at Adora. Was she waiting for Adora to okay it? Adora smiled and nodded. Catra closed her hands and looked away. She gave the slightest nod and Casta smiled.

She walked over and embraced Catra lightly. Adora saw Catra straighten and then relax a moment after. Casta stepped back. "It's good to see you." Catra gave a small smile and thanked her. Catra's cheeks flushed a little and Melog chirped happily beside her. Catra swatted at them, which only made Melog laugh. Catra crossed her arms and looked away, her blush growing at whatever Melog had said.

"Well, no time to waste." Casta clapped her hands together. "Adora, I was hoping we could test to see what that magic energy was yesterday. Have you had any more of those attacks?" Casta carefully worded.

Catra and Adora shared a brief look. Catra shrugged a little. Adora had to decide.

"Has my dad arrived yet?" Glimmer interrupted. Thank you, Glimmer!

"Yes." Casta pointed towards one of the hallways. "He wanted to look at something before you arrived."

"Why don't we talk about everything after the tests?" Bow spoke as he squeezed Adora's shoulder. Adora appreciated the support. She wasn't sure how to tell them about the dream. If it was even real.

"Catra!" Glimmer squealed. "We could show you the cloud beach!"

"The what?" Catra's fur bristled. Adora stifled a laugh. Catra must have thought it was water.

"It's a beach…of clouds." Glimmer gave her a funny look. "I know you don't like water, but this should be fine!" Glimmer teleported to Catra's side and looped her arm through Catra's. "Come on, Bow!"

"I wanna go." Adora muttered under her breath.

"We'll go again before we leave!" Bow gave her a comforting smile. "Do you want us to go with you for the tests?"

"No, it's fine." Adora waved them off with a forced smile. Catra narrowed her eyes at Adora. "Go have fun. I'll see you after I'm done."

"Come on, Bow! We gotta go before Catra changes her mind." Bow jogged over. Catra protested loudly before Glimmer shouted "WARNING!" Catra's ears folded down as they disappeared in a cloud of sparkles. Adora hoped Catra was okay. She hated Glimmer's teleports.

"Are you ready to get started?" Casta gave her a kind smile. Adora took a deep breath before she remembered.

"Would you give me a moment? Swifty wanted to ask me something?"

"Of course." She pointed to the same hallway. "I'll be right there."

"Thanks." Adora turned back to Swiftwind. "Is everything okay?"

"I wanted to ask you." Swiftwind's voice was filled with concern. "You know I can feel when something is wrong. These attacks. The magic in you is stronger than before. You had another one last night, didn't you?" Adora looked away. "As your steed, I'm here to support you. But something is happening with your She-Ra magic."

"It is. I don't really know." Adora stared at her hands. Like that would fix her problems. "That's why we're here today. We'll figure this out. I'll come see you after everything's done." Swiftwind nuzzled her face, which drew a laugh. "Thanks, Swifty."

"Anytime." Swiftwind took off into the air again, doing another set of loop-de-loops. She shook her head and started for the hallway to meet Casta.

After several hours of testing, magic tests were not fun, Adora was finally finished. The pain in her chest had grown again and she was having trouble manifesting She-Ra. She had tried everything. Shouting her phrase loudly. Thinking of She-Ra. Meditating. Thinking of Catra and the others had been the most successful but even that didn't help when the pain flared.

Her blood burned through her when it came. She'd bit back screams as her limbs went numb from sharp pains. She almost blacked out at one point from holding She-Ra for three minutes. Three minutes. She panted as she sat on the floor. How was she going to do anything as She-Ra if she couldn't even hold She-Ra for three minutes without passing out?! The room around her was spinning.

Casta, Micah, and the other officials of Mystacor were talking in a group away from her. She didn't even care at this

point. She was too tired and in pain. She hunched over, holding her feet as she sat with her legs in a butterfly shape.

What if Light Hope was right? What if she was now a part of the Heart? Did that mean she was going to be magically overloaded all the time? How was she going to protect her friends? She couldn't do something as simple as that then…what worth did she have? Catra had yelled at her yesterday for having such thoughts but she couldn't get it out of her mind.

"Hey guys!" Bow's voice echoing in the room brought her back to the moment. Catra and Glimmer followed. Micah dismissed the others and he and Casta met them around Adora. She stood and stepped into the circle they had formed, standing next to Catra. She reached out, her fingers brushing Catra's. She kept her eyes on Micah but couldn't help the smile as Catra's fingers intertwined with hers.

"Should we move to another room?" Casta offered.

"No, this is fine." Adora answered. She wanted answers and information.

"Well." Micah took a seat on the ground which everyone else followed suit. Catra retook Adora's hand after they sat. "We aren't sure what to make of this, to be honest."

"What do you mean?" Glimmer asked.

"The magic energy that I sensed in Adora yesterday." Casta paused. "It's just her She-Ra magic. It's stronger than before but nothing else came up."

"How are you feeling, Adora?" Micah turned to her. "You seemed to be in pain during the tests."

"And you just kept going?" Catra bit out.

"At my request." Adora squeezed her hand. "I want to know what's going on." She sighed. She supposed she should tell

them.

"Is it possible this is because of the Failsafe?" Bow said. "Catra had mentioned that was her concern." They had spoken about it? Adora felt pride swell in her that Catra was more and more comfortable with Bow and Glimmer.

"That is our thought process." Casta answered.

"Catra and I were in the garden last night during the party." Adora started. Everyone looked to her and she swallowed hard. She had to keep going before she lost her courage. "We were just talking, looking at the stars. Then…we…we kissed." Adora looked down for a moment. Catra squeezed her hand and offered a small smile. Adora took a breath. "When we did, another smaller attack happened."

"Why didn't you say anything?" Glimmer asked.

"I didn't really know how to bring it up."

"Well, that explains why you were distracted during your speech last night." Bow gave a smile. Catra gave him a look, eliciting laughter from Bow and Glimmer.

"But after that…" Adora continued. "I had a dream last night."

"What happened in the dream, Adora?" Micah prompted gently.

"Well…." She hadn't told them about the vision she'd had during the Heart. "Okay, so hear me out."

"Always." Glimmer took Bow's hand.

"When…when I was in the Heart, trying to use the Failsafe. I…I was infected with Prime's virus. He attacked me with a guardian that was powerful enough to take down She-Ra with one hit." Their faces widened with shock, except Catra. Her face

remained neutral, her eyes focused on Adora and Adora only. For some reason it was comforting.

"I probably would've died right there." Adora laughed humorlessly. "But Catra and Shadow Weaver arrived at that moment. Shadow Weaver took me to the Heart while Catra tried to hold of the Guardian." They looked at Catra for a moment before Adora continued. "But as I approached the Heart, I heard Catra scream and I went back." She finally looked at Catra. They locked eyes and Adora found herself staring into Catra's different colored eyes. How she loved them.

"Shadow Weaver saved us…" Adora's voice choked. "She…she sacrificed herself to defeat the Guardian." Catra wrapped her other hand around the hand she already held. Adora turned back to the group. "Catra and I went to the Heart and that's when we…the virus stopped me from becoming She-Ra."

"But, that was the only way you could've survived it!" Casta interjected.

"I know." Adora touched the place on her chest where the Failsafe had been. Her chest ached just thinking about it. "But there was no time. I had to do something. I had a vision…a dream as I used the Failsafe." She didn't know how to continue really. She wanted that vision to come true. Where they were happy. She glanced back at Catra, tears filling in both of their eyes.

"What was the dream?" Glimmer asked.

"I was in Bright Moon. I was staring into the waterfall in my room. Suddenly, Catra and Glimmer entered the room, chasing each other." She chuckled a little. "Glimmer was trying to brush Catra's hair."

"Never going to happen!" Catra turned sharply to Glimmer.

"Please, I'd never even try that! I know better!" Glimmer put her hands in the air. They laughed for a moment before Adora spoke again.

"Bow entered and said we were late for Scorpia's ball. As Glimmer and Bow left, Catra asked if I was going with her. When…" she paused, choking on her words. She wiped at her eyes a moment and took a shaky breath. "When I tried to take her hand…she glitched and the image became Prime." Catra bristled beside her. The others froze, waiting for the next part. "He told me it was a beautiful wish…but that there would be no future. Not for me." She looked down in silence.

"Was that the end of it?" Bow asked, wiping a few tears from his eyes.

"No." Adora kept her eyes on the floor. "Catra showed up once more. Present Catra, I guess." She blinked hard. "She pleaded with me to stay with her and she…she told me she loved me. She yelled for me to stay and not give up."

Catra stayed silent as everyone looked at her.

"I came back and we kissed after I told her I loved her too." Adora blurted that part out quickly before clearing her throat.

"So how are the two connected?" Glimmer said.

"The dream I had last night was the same as the vision except…Catra didn't disappear this time." Catra grazed her claws lightly over Adora's skin. "And we went to the ball. We danced and had fun with everyone."

"You told me that part earlier." Bow offered a smile.

"Yeah…until everything glitched again." Adora lost her smile. "Light Hope appeared in the dream."

"Light Hope?!" Glimmer stuttered. "I-I thought you said she disappeared after you broke the sword."

"She did." Adora looked back up finally. "This was the first time I had seen her. When I turned to look at her, Catra disappeared again." Catra pressed a little harder with her nails that time, almost as if saying, I'm still here, dummy. Adora smiled. "She said she didn't have much time but that the failsafe only worked to stop the Heart of Etheria from going off."

"Yeah, that's what we knew." Glimmer spoke with her hands. "It stopped the Heart from exploding and saved everyone."

"No." Adora shook her head. "It stopped it from exploding. It's still collecting magic." Casta covered her mouth. Glimmer and Bow shared a concerned look. Catra's hands tightened. "She told me that She-Ra is connected with the Heart."

"You always have been." Catra spoke. "You said it yourself. She-Ra is the key."

"Not like that. She-Ra isn't the key anymore. She's connected to the Heart itself now."

"The failsafe." Micah mused. "Because the failsafe didn't work all the way, it connected the magic to you as its outlet."

"That would explain the magic energy that I found." Casta spoke softly.

"She said I needed to find a way to regulate the magic. She said Madam Razz would know and to beware of something."

"Beware of what?" Glimmer asked.

"I don't know. She glitched out before she could finish. And then I woke up."

"Well." Micah stroked her beard in thought. "That is definitely a lot of information."

"Maybe we should've gone to Razz first then." Bow offered with his hand raised.

"Who's Razz?" Catra raised an eyebrow.

"She's an old woman in the woods who helped me when I first was learning about She-Ra. She knew Mara and kinda lived between the two timelines." Adora rubbed the back of her neck. "She was the way I found my way out of the portal." Adora saw the sad look in Glimmer's eyes.

"We should consult with Madam Razz then." Glimmer spoke first.

"Razz always speaks in circles though." Bow said gingerly. "You said it yourself, she can't keep the timelines straight."

"She's our only clue." Catra's mouth shifted to the side a little as she thought. "You shouldn't use She-Ra until we figure this out then." Adora saw the thought flash behind Catra's eyes before Catra slowly withdrew her hands. Adora wanted to take them back but Catra wasn't always in the mood for physical touch. Adora didn't want to abuse the moments Catra would give her.

"Catra's right." Micah agreed. "She-Ra usage should be kept down until we figure this out."

"Is there anyway that we can disconnect them?" Bow wondered aloud. "If we could disconnect She-Ra from the Heart, it might work."

"The problem is, what happens if the Heart goes out of control again?" Adora clenched her fists and sat them on her lap.

"But you can't just live like this." Glimmer interjected. "We can't let the Heart just rampage through She-Ra's magic."

"What other choice do we have right now?" Adora raised her voice. Glimmer pulled back. Adora sighed and stood. "Obviously, I'm useless either way. Either I have She-Ra and I'm overloaded with magic or I don't and I can't do anything to help my friends. What right do I have to live if I can't help my friends?!"

"Adora!" A few of them called after her as she stalked out of the room. She shouldn't have said anything. It was all a mistake. If she had just kept her mouth quiet, this wouldn't be a problem.

"Catra, do something!" Was the last thing Adora heard as she turned a corner. What was Catra going to do? It was Adora's fault. If she had just died in the Heart like she was supposed to, none of this would be happening. Her friends wouldn't be in danger because of her. Shadow Weaver was right. If she had just died, then her friends would be safe.

Adora's pace picked up until she was running. She found herself an empty room and shut the door. She fell to her knees as sobs shook through her. She was useless if she couldn't do this one thing! She didn't deserve to be alive. Everyone would be better off without her. Adora, the useless She-Ra. She couldn't even save the world correctly.

Meow.

Adora looked up and saw Melog sitting in front of her. Their tail swished softly behind them as they cocked their head at Adora.

"What are you doing?" Adora sat up and curled into a ball against the door. "Aren't you supposed to be with Catra?" Someone should be. Stars knew Adora couldn't be. Adora didn't deserve that spot anymore.

Melog just watched her with their solid blue eyes. Their mane flared red briefly, which rose concern in Adora. It only did that when Catra was upset or angry. Melog stood and curled up next to Adora, resting their head in her lap. They licked her face, eliciting a small laugh. She wrapped her arms around Melog and cried.

"Adora?" Catra's voice echoed in the hall outside the door. Adora stiffened. She looked at Melog, who closed their eyes in a smile. They meowed softly.

"Traitor." Adora sniffled. The door tried to open behind her, stopping against her back. Catra managed to peek her head inside.

"What are you doing?"

"Being a doorstop." Adora looked at the floor. "Might as well be useful for something." Catra guffawed.

"Well, if the Adora-sized doorstop could move for a moment, that'd be nice." Adora waited a moment before scooting forward. She left just enough room for Catra to squeeze through before the door slammed shut again. Adora fell back against the door with a squeak.

"Thanks, buddy." Catra scratched Melog's head, who purred happily in response.

"Traitor." Adora sniffled again. Melog meowed at her.

"They said they aren't a traitor." Catra interpreted. "Also, that's rich coming from you."

"I'm not in the mood for that right now, Catra." Adora put her head down.

"Why didn't you tell me about the dream this morning?"

"You knew about the vision?"

"I was there, dork." Catra shoved her playfully.

"I forgot about that." Adora chuckled before sighing. "I…I don't know."

A conflicted look crossed behind Catra's eyes. She sighed as she moved to sit next to Adora, leaning on her shoulders. Her tail curled around Adora's ankle and Catra purred softly. The few times Adora had cried to Catra as a child, she'd do that. Hold her and purr. It was calming.

"We really need therapy." Catra joked after a moment.

"What's that?" Adora asked, looking up. Catra cocked her head down and smiled.

"Perfuma said it's something were you talk out all your problems. Doesn't really get how that much works…"

"Yeah, you need therapy." Adora teased. She received a slap from Catra's tail. She giggled.

"So do you, dummy." Catra wrapped herself around Adora's shoulders again. "Shadow Weaver really did a number on us."

"Yeah." Adora sighed.

"You're not useless." Catra whispered.

"Neither are you."

"That's debatable."

"Catra!"

"It's true."

"No, it's not."

"Yes, it is."

"No!"

"Yes!"

"You're being stupid!"

"Says the idiot."

"Catra!"

"Adora!"

They started giggling.

"Can we join?" Glimmer's voice interrupted them as she and Bow teleported into the room. Catra answered before Adora could. Glimmer and Bow took seats across from the two. Melog laid happily between Adora and Catra's lap.

"How did you even find us?"

"Well, Catra was supposed to look down this hall quickly and when she didn't return as fast, we assumed she found you." Glimmer offered a smile and shrug.

"Plus, Melog found us and pointed us to the room."

"Melog!" Adora glared at them. Melog looked up at her and chuckled. "You are a little traitor!"

"Stop calling them that." Catra slapped her arm.

"Adora." Glimmer reached out and touched her arm, in the same spot Catra had just smacked her. "We handle these things together. You're not alone in this."

"Best Friend Squad, remember?" Bow offered a smile.

"And trust me," Glimmer's hand went to her chest. "I know a thing or two about doing it alone instead of trusting my friends. That's what got us into this mess."

"Something that wasn't my fault for once?" Catra feigned a shocked look.

"Catra?!" Adora gave her a look, to which Catra stuck her tongue out.

"You both are a part of the Best Friend Squad." Bow took their hands and Glimmer put hers on top. "We do this together." They shared smiles for a moment.

"So, Bow needs therapy too?" Catra teased. Bow and Glimmer shared a look while Adora laughed.

"I think we all do."

"You're not wrong there." Glimmer giggled.

"How'd the cloud beach go?" Adora looked at Catra. Catra looked away and made a disgusted noise.

"She liked it!" Glimmer poked Catra. She hissed and looked away again. "She just doesn't want to admit it."

"Catra was the last one in but also the last one to leave." Bow chuckled. "It was cute!"

"I'm not cute!" Catra sneered.

"But you are!" Bow clasped his hands together. "It's so adorable!"

Catra groaned and laid her head on Adora's shoulder. Adora giggled as Bow and Glimmer continued listing all the ways Catra was cute.

"I'M NOT CUTE!" Catra held up a hand with claws extended. "Next person who says it is getting these."

"Aw, she's trying to threaten us, Bow." Glimmer giggled through her next statement as she feigned a scared pose. "What ever will we do?"

"I don't know." Bow took Glimmer's hands and feigned fear. "I think we'll die of cuteness overload first."

"THAT'S IT!" Catra yelled. She went to stand before Adora grabbed her waist. Adora held her in place as she swiped at the laughing two across from her. "ADORA, LET GO!"

"No!"

"I'M GOING TO KILL YOUR FRIENDS!"

"They're your friends too." Adora reminded her. Catra inhaled sharply, clearly debating something. She opened her mouth to say something when Adora's stomach growled loudly. Adora looked at her torso as the others followed suit before they broke into laughter.

"Well, that's one way to end that." Bow said.

"Let's go get food." Glimmer stood. Bow did the same before they offered their hands to Catra and Adora. "We'll figure everything out as we normally do."

"Brute strength?"

"Almost dying."

"Messing everything up?" Catra smirked.

"No!" Glimmer shoved Catra. "Friendship."

Having decided at lunch to follow the Madam Razz lead, Adora took a walk alone through Mystacor's gardens. She had wanted some time to think and plan.

The gardens were beautiful. Some places were still damaged from the war but overall, it was green and bountiful like the Whispering Woods. Trees sprung up in different areas, with small hedges lining the walkways. A few others walked along the paths, spread out. Adora didn't pay them much attention. She was too lost in her thoughts about the dream and everything that had happened.

She had only had She-Ra back for a while and now she was basically without her again. Though, it was clear She-Ra's magic absorption of the Heart's magic was going to be a problem regardless. Adora hated this feeling. She felt useless. It didn't matter that the others didn't agree. What good was she if not for She-Ra? That's why the Rebellion accepted her in the first place.

Someone bumped into her with enough force to cause Adora to stumble. The person wore a hooded robe that looked like the other robes from Mystacor. Adora regain her footing and they bowed an apologize to her. The person turned to walk away without another word when Adora saw it.

A little gold winged pin. Just like the one she wore on her belt. Though, the one in front of her was more weathered and slightly chipped.

She picked it up and called after them. The person froze in their steps and turned back slowly.

"You dropped this." Adora smiled as she dropped it into their gloved hand. As Adora looked up, she noticed this person had ears poking up in their hood. It reminded her of Catra's ears during their Erelandia mission.

"Thank you." They said softly. "I need this." Their voice sounded familiar. They tucked the pin into their robes in what

Adora assumed was a pocket.

"I have one just like it." She showed hers off. "I didn't know they made more of them." She looked down at it. "My…best friend…." Adora didn't think that word fit as well anymore but she wasn't sure about calling Catra her girlfriend yet… "She found it for me years ago on a mission of ours as kids."

The person was silent, nodding to continue, Adora guessed. "We were just kids on our first mission with our Horde squadron. She found it in the rubble of a building as a gift and I found…" that was the day Adora had found the metal mask Catra had worn for years.

"It sounds like you and this friend of yours…" The person's voice was higher than expected, though Adora thought it sounded too forced. "are close."

"We weren't for a few years, a lot happened but now we're close again." Adora rubbed the back of her neck. She shifted feet. "I mean we said I love you and we've kissed a few times but I don't think it's too romantic yet…" The person chuckled and shifted to the side.

"It sounds like you two have a good relationship. I pray to the stars it works for you."

"Thank you." Adora felt the happiness wane as she remembered Catra pulling away from her in the meeting. "I know that I don't know you, but can I ask you something?"

They waited a moment before nodding.

"I'm kinda dealing with a weird issue here. Like I'm She-Ra?" She made a whooshing noise as she pretended to slash a sword for effect. "But I'm kinda having issues with it and everything that's happened. And my…best friend… she's drawing away from me yet she's not and I don't know what to do."

"There's a library in the Whispering Woods that has a lot of She-Ra lore." The person answered. "Perhaps they would have the information you are searching for."

"Bow's dads…" Adora muttered to herself. "I forgot about the library. They found Darla and they found the Failsafe." Adora felt a swell of hope fill her lungs with new air. Between Madam Razz and George and Lance, she should be able to find an answer. "Thank you!" Adora heard her name being called from behind and when she turned back, the person was gone. Adora blinked. It was weird but Adora shrugged it off. There were too many people here she didn't know to worry about it.

Though Adora didn't know the library was common knowledge.

"Princess Adora?" The acolyte finally caught up with her. "Queen Glimmer and Archmage Castaspella are asking for you."

"Of course. Thank you." She followed them back towards Mystacor's main building. She glanced behind her. The person who she spoke to seemed familiar. Adora couldn't put her finger on it though. Maybe she should ask Castaspella about them. See if anyone knows who it was. Adora scolded herself when she realized she never got an answer to the belt clip they shared.

"There you are, dummy." Catra's voice brought her back to reality after a moment. Adora smiled. She could worry about that person another time.

"Are you feeling better?" Bow asked as he and Glimmer joined them.

"Yeah." Adora shifted awkwardly. "This is just a lot."

"Which is why we're doing this together." Glimmer took her hand. "We're behind you all the way, Adora."

"And we'll say that as many times as we have to." Bow took her other hand. Adora's mind went back to the portal, when she held their hands like this before they disappeared. She frowned without realizing and it wasn't until Catra's tail tickled her side that she realized Catra had joined hands with the other two.

The four of them…all holding hands…Adora had dreamed of this day for years.

"What was it that Bow said…" Catra muttered, a small blush flushing her cheeks. "Best Friend Squad or something…"

Bow gasped, his hands releasing hers and Catra's to cover his mouth. His eyes grew wide and bright.

"She said it!" Glimmer laughed. Catra pouted and looked away.

"I didn't say anything~!"

"No! I heard it!" Bow grinned. He clapped his hands. "GROUP HUG!!" He pulled Catra in, who hissed. Glimmer tackled them from the other side. Catra grumbled curses. Adora felt the soft smile curve her lips.

"Hey." Bow looked at Adora with a stern look.

"What?" Adora blinked.

"I believe I said group hug! That means you too." Adora breathed a laugh and joined in.

"No touching!" Catra hissed. "Let go!"

"Never!" Glimmer laughed as she hugged tighter. Adora pulled herself and Catra out of the hug, Catra brushing her clothes off.

"Bow. Are your dads available for a visit?"

"I'm sure they'd love that. What are you thinking?" Adora bit her lip. She didn't want to discuss the whole thing with the stranger.

"I was thinking about the library and all the She-Ra lore they have gathered there. I wondered if they might have more information on the heart than we thought."

"That's…not a bad idea." Bow pulled out his trackerpad. Catra mumbled a 'where did that come from?'. "I'll see if we can visit soon. I know they are cleaning up the library."

"Did you say you're heading back to help them?" Glimmer asked.

"Yeah." Bow continued typing. "I'm planning on spending the next few weeks helping them rebuilding if I can."

"Maybe we can help?" Adora offered. "They did ask for help recataloging parts of the library."

"Oh, Catra's never been to the library!" Glimmer gave her a side look.

"And?"

"It's exciting! Catra's first visit to the library."

"We're doing something else first." Catra held up a hand.

"What?" Adora gave her a confused look. What else was there to do? They didn't have too many plans for now other than helping with rebuilding and figuring out this whole thing with She-Ra.

Catra closed her eyes, clasping her hands together and took a deep breath.

"We just talked about it this morning." She pointed the tips of her clasped hands at Adora. "I knew you were an idiot but Etheria above."

"Hey, I'm not- oh the clothes thing!" Adora pursed her lips in embarrassment. Oops.

"Clothes?" Bow raised an eyebrow.

"You're telling me Adora's lived here in Bright Moon and all for three years and hasn't changed clothes at all?!" Catra's tail straightened.

"We tried!" Glimmer put her hands up. "She didn't want anything else. Do you know how hard it was to get her ready for Princess Prom three years ago?!"

"Hey!" Adora shot a look at Glimmer. "I was busy!"

"Planning out who was dating who?" Glimmer counted on her fingers. "Or building an obstacle course in your room…or creating flash cards?"

"I was trying to be ready!"

"Adora made flash cards for Princess Prom?" Catra laughed. "That's an Adora thing to do."

"Catra, you're not helping!" Adora bristled. "You're telling me you didn't plan for that?!"

"You're kidding, right?" Catra shoved her. "Scorpia gave me the rundown of the rules on the way."

Adora shoved her back. Catra steadied herself and took a fighting stance. Adora smirked and crouched herself.

"Guys! Don't-" Bow's didn't get the chance to finish before Catra pounced.

Adora grabbed Catra's wrists as Catra took hold of Adora's shoulders. She flipped Catra over her, claws screeching a little as Catra skidded away. She came bounding back, this time she stayed low. Adora yelped as Catra swept her off her feet with a low kick.

Adora quickly threw herself to grab Catra's foot and drag her closer. Catra clawed at Adora's hand, though she didn't do any damage. Catra always knew how to scratch without hurting her. The only time Catra's claws had ever left a scar was… their fight while she was chipped.

Catra's kick to her chest forced her back to the present. Adora tumbled to the left and took a knee. Catra sat crouched across from her, filing one of her nails. She was taunting Adora. She used to do that all the time in the Horde.

She pushed off the ground and tackled Catra. They tumbled. Catra yelped as her back hit the grass. Adora, quickly, wrapped her legs around Catra's and pinned her arms to the ground. Both were breathing heavily as Catra struggled to get out. Adora leaned down into her face with a smug smile.

"Ready to give up?"

"Oh Adora." Catra smiled. "You still do the same thing." Catra shifted under her. Catra's legs suddenly reached up and hooked around Adora's neck. Adora gasped as Catra flipped her and suddenly, Catra was on top of Adora. Adora growled in anger as Catra cackled from her spot on Adora's stomach. "I mean really, after all these years, you'd think you'd fix your footing."

"Are you two done yet?" Glimmer asked with her arms crossed. "Aunt Casta's waiting for us." Adora noticed Glimmer trying to hide her smile as Bow covered his laugh.

"When she admits I won." Catra said with the same smugness Adora had a moment previous.

"In your dreams." Adora dug her heels into the ground and bucked her hips to the side. Catra's hands flew out to catch herself as Adora quickly stood. She grinned at Catra.

"Queen Glimmer." An robed person approached. "Castaspella is ready for you."

"Thank you." Glimmer said. She looked at the two in the grass.

"Fine." Catra sighed dramatically. "We'll pick this up later."

"That sounds like admission of defeat." Adora jogged to keep up with the others, slowing to keep pace with Catra.

"Pssh, yeah right." Catra shoved her.

"Well, it looks like you'll have to go shopping after all." Bow interjected with a chuckle. Adora looked to the point on her he pointed to, realizing there was a nice gash in her sleeve and her white shirt was covered in green marks. She snickered as she looked to Catra, who's shirt had green marks staining it.

"I suppose." Adora played it off. She reached out for Catra's hand. She found it as Catra glanced over with a small smile. The smile quickly fell and she pulled away. Catra elected to fold her arms across her chest instead. She looked everywhere but Adora. Adora couldn't help the hurt. Adora clenched her hands at her side.

Casta had invited them to stay for dinner that night and they did. Adora got to visit Cloud Beach and the Sauna. She had missed both since she didn't really get to enjoy them the first time she had been there. Though, she wasn't really getting to enjoy them now.

Catra kept pulling away after awkward moments. It was like she couldn't decide what to do. They'd be playing around like they always did. Their usual banter. Adora never realized how much she had missed it. And suddenly, Catra would pull back and just stop. Even Glimmer and Bow shot her looks of concern.

After a night of rest, for most, they returned to Bright Moon. Bow had left to see if his dads could help at all and to help rebuild some of the library. He told them he'd send a message when he knew. Glimmer and Catra were busy with meetings. It was clear that the Senators or whoever weren't fans of Catra and likewise. Adora wondered how it would work out.

A week passed with no issues. Adora and Catra were sitting in their room in silence. Catra was perched on the window sill, the window creaking slightly beside her from the breeze. She was looking over papers from one of the meetings with Glimmer about supplies in Bright Moon.

Adora laid on the bed, tossing one of the pillows into the air. Toss. Pause. Catch. Toss. Pause. Catch. She glanced over at Catra. She had dark circles under her eyes. Nightmares had been haunting them both. Adora wondered how bad her eyes looked. Toss. Pause Catch.

Adora had spent most of the week doing nothing. Absoutely nothing. Not even a little bit of anything. Zilch. She had walked Bright Moon's halls at least 50 times. She had circled the gardens so many times, they asked her to leave due to the indented path she had left. She tried cooking, which she was terrible at. Micah had tried to help her. She didn't know cakes could spontaneously combust after icing them. She decided cooking wasn't for her.

Toss. Pause. Catch. Toss. Pause.

She had tried reading in the Bright Moon library. All the books she had read before that point had been strategy for facing

Catra and the Horde. Now that the war was over, she didn't know what to read. She didn't last long in there.

Catch. Toss. Pause. Catch. Toss. Pause. Catch.

Catra had been pulling away all week. She was almost avoiding Adora more than she had in the war. And that was saying something. Glimmer had been busy but when Adora tried to talk to her about it, she said Catra had said she was fine. Adora knew better but was trying to avoid a fight.

Pause. Catch. Toss. Pause. Catch. Toss.

Catra had used her Keeper of She-Ra title to forbid Adora from working out in any way that could trigger an attack. That meant almost everything. Adora was wondering if this whole Keeper of She-Ra thing was really a good thing. She had guard following her to make sure she wasn't doing too much. If Catra or Glimmer weren't watching her, someone was.

Pause. Catch. Toss.

"Adora?" Catra's voice tore her from her thoughts.

SMACK!

Catra's cackle filled the room as Adora grumbled from under the pillow. Adora threw the pillow to the side and looked up at Catra. Catra had moved to the desk, placing the papers down.

"Why don't we go do something?" Catra shifted awkwardly. She grabbed her arm in a way that Adora knew was attempts at comforting herself.

"Yeah!" Adora jumped up. Glimmer had played a board game with her the other night but otherwise everyone had been busy. Adora was itching to do anything at this point. "What do…" Adora paused.

The last thing Catra had said she had wanted to do was go shopping but all the meetings and She-Ra things had gotten in the way of that.

"Why don't we go shopping?" It was Adora's turn to be awkward. She gave Catra her best smile, which made her snort.

"You look like a dork." Catra rolled her eyes.

"You said you wanted to go last week, right?" Adora tried. "So, let's go. Glimmer gave me the name of a good tailor. She said they make good clothes?"

"Sure." Catra petted Melog as they nuzzled her leg. "Let's go." Adora saw Catra grab her small purse of money Glimmer had paid her. Adora made sure to bring some of her own. She looped her staff through her belt. Maybe Adora could find a gift for Catra.

They had never really had gifts in the Horde. The Golden Wing Pin and Catra's Mask had been really the only two gifts they had ever exchanged.

They walked through the halls in the quiet of the day. People bustled by, sometimes making them walk single file. Catra's tail wrapped around Adora's wrist, Adora biting her lip to avoid saying anything.

After awhile, way too long in Adora's opinion, they arrived at the tailor's place. They were located in between Bright Moon and Erelandia.

It was a rather large blue building with two stories. Tree branches wound through different windows and spaces in the building. It looked like it had been built around the branches and vines. Gold trim lined the windows and doorframes. A small balcony looked over the area.

Adora could see the two of them living in a place like this. She could see them sitting on the balcony together. She

could see them jumping over the branches and hanging from the vines like they did in their room at Bright Moon.

She felt Catra tug her along and her feet moved, though her mind was still distracted thinking of the future. Catra knocked on the door. It swung open with a loud creak. Adora and Catra shared a look before they heard a sound coming toward them. Catra crouched, ready to pounce as Adora opened her staff. Since she wasn't allowed to use She-Ra…though she might not have an option…

"Princess Adora~" The voice inside drew her name out. "I was told you were coming." Adora gulped and stood up straight.

"Yes. That's me." She kept her staff out, using it to support herself. Catra's eyes narrowed as she kept her stance.

"Come in, you and your consort are welcome here." Adora and Catra shared another look. Adora had never heard that word before. Catra slowly stood and sniffed the air. Her eyes glanced around in the dark doorway before she looked to Adora. She made a face: I guess it's safe.

Adora retracked her staff and hooked it through her belt again. She stepped into the darkness, Catra on her heels. As Catra crossed the threshold, the door slammed shut behind them. They both squealed and moved back-to-back. Catra hissed as Adora redrew her staff. She heard Catra's claws extended. The only thing Adora could see were Catra's eyes. The room was too dark. Even with the windows and areas where the branches wound through were darkened.

"My apologizes." The voice hissed. A light flickered on, blinding them momentarily. Adora blinked as the room came into view. Some of the branches had been fashioned into furniture before stretching to other places. The ceiling above them had a gaping hole in the middle, allowing the second floor into view.

Most of the room was wooden, flowers growing in small patches across the floor and walls. Fabrics hung from everywhere and small people like statues were cluttered in the corner of the room, unfinished products clinging to their forms. Small wind chimes decorated parts of the ceiling that weren't painted with different designs that Adora couldn't even name. Some of them were First One's writing. She recognized a few of the words. Beautiful. Loved. World. She-ra.

"I don't have many visitors." Catra tapped Adora and pointed to the voice. A large person sat on one of the branch benches. They had a snake like body, with their tail coiling around the room. The upper half of their body was that of a feminine appearance. Black hair curled down their back and framed their face. They wore a dark blue fabric, the same color of the house, with golden constellations sew into the fabric. The tunic wrapped around them and down part of their tail. "I have no need for light so I forgot others do." They chuckled to themselves.

"Are you the tailor, Serpentina?" Adora asked.

"The one and only, darling."

"Major déjà vu." Catra muttered. "They remind me of Double Trouble."

"They are one of my best clients." Serpentina laughed, finally turning to face them. Their face was beautiful. Scales decorated the sides of their face and across the bridge of their nose. The front most curls had spirals of gray twirling down them, though pinned out of their face. Their eyes were an unsettling white, but it was clear they'd had beautiful black eyes at one time.

"I thought you said Glimmer said to come here." Catra hissed in a whisper.

"She did." Adora whispered back.

"I have severed the royal family for many years, my dears. Many of the royals come to me. The red dress Queen

Glimmer gave you, Princess Adora, was one of mine."

"Really?" That dress was one of the only ones Glimmer had been able to get her to wear. It was light enough she was able to fight if needed but girly enough for Glimmer to be content.

"Yes. I am told you are in need of clothes for everyday life and royal events." Adora noticed a hiss on Serpentina's S's. She thought it was pretty.

"How do we know we can trust you?" Catra's eyes narrowed as she put an arm in front of Adora.

"Why would I betray the Queen of Bright Moon and She-Ra's trust? Would they not be able to strike an old serpent down?" She had a fair point. "I would lose all my clientele and my livelihood in doing so. I may be blind, but I am not stupid, Royal Strategist Catra."

Catra's fur stood on end. Adora moved her arm down.

"She's right. It wouldn't make sense for them to do anything to us. Glimmer said we can trust her."

"Yes, because Glimmer's never been wrong before." Catra bit out.

"Which of you would like to be first?" Serpentina moved from her bench towards them. They stopped by a nearby branch couch. "You are my only clients for the day though I do not think you have all day to be here. I'm sure the Royal Strategist and Princess are quite busy."

"I'll go." Adora stepped forward. Catra made a whimpering sound before groaning and covering her face.

"Royal Strategist, you may take a seat anywhere you like. I would appreciate your help."

"Help with what?"

"I am blind." Serpentina said as if it were obvious. "I can make beautiful clothing but I can not see them as you would. You wish your consort to look bad?" Even Adora could recognize the challenge given.

Catra paused for a moment, eyes moving up and down Serpentina. She huffed and took a seat near the door. She crossed her legs and folded her arms over her chest.

"Thank you." Serpentina smiled and turned to face Adora. "Now, I have questions to ask of you both for your clothes to be perfect for you. I will need you both to answer me. Is this acceptable?"

"Yes."

"Sure~" Adora glared at Catra. Catra shrugged and raised her eyebrows. Adora rolled her eyes and turned back.

"How would you describe Adora in one word?"

A: "Loyal."

C: "Stupid."

"How would you describe Catra in one word?"

C: "Clever."

A: "Stubborn."

"What do you wish to convey with these clothes?"

C: "How does this affect anything?"

A: "I'm not sure I understand either. It's just clothing?"

"Not quite, Princess. In the royal families, it is important how one carries themselves. Now that the war is over, most of the nobility will be in play again. You'll be attending many

events as well as seeing to the needs of the people, will you not? How one is clothed impacts how you are perceived."

Adora looked at Catra with a raised eyebrow. Catra nodded reluctantly, agreeing with Serpentina.

"For example, Princess Adora." Serpentina spoke. "Your constant use of your uniform with no major changes for most of your life tells me you are strict on yourself. You can't enjoy life without the need for order and rules. You have very black and white thinking and do not think highly of yourself. You have a severe need to sacrifice yourself to please others without even realizing it stems from the that being the only way to protect yourself and your consort growing up with Shadow Weaver, am I correct?"

Adora's jaw fell open as she just stared wordlessly at Serpentina. Catra cackled in the background.

"And you Royal Strategist." Serpentina turned. "Your uniform is based off your former leader uniform. An attempt to disguise your feelings of self-loathing and feelings of abandonment, yes? Your attempts at climbing up in leadership and proving yourself to show everyone that you have worth yet pushing everyone away to avoid pain. You desperately seek love and validation, only having ever felt it from your partner, who you felt abandoned you and seeking power was the only way to protect yourself from further hurt? The high collar alone is to compensate for your time with Prime, is it not?"

Catra hissed. Adora snorted and bent over laughing.

"Do you see the importance of this now, Royal Strategist? The way you dress is important. I would gather you would like something that gives you confidence in yourself for your meetings, would you not?"

Catra grumbled an answer, fiddling with her nails. Adora couldn't help the feeling that filled her chest. Even when

she was grumpy for an answer she asked for, Catra was everything Adora ever wanted.

"Now, I do feel I have a correct perception of you both?" Serpentina waited for their answers. Adora thought about what she had said. Sacrificing herself was the only way to survive.

Shadow Weaver's words rang in her ears so loudly, she shook her head to rid them.

"One more thing, Princess Adora. We'll need to change your hairstyle."

"Why?" Adora practically whined. She liked her ponytail. Practical. Easy to do. Easy for battles.

"If we don't, I fear you will not have hair for much longer." Catra snickered. Adora shot her a look.

"What? I told you that on Darla!"

"Yeah but…" Adora looked down. She liked her uniform and her ponytail. She didn't really want to change them.

"Royal Strategist." Serpentina beckoned. "Allow me to show you something." Catra stood and joined them as Adora was instructed to sit. Catra pulled her ponytail out, the hair falling to her shoulders. Adora gulped a little.

"Take your hands and do this." Adora could hear Serpentina's instructions and feel Catra's slight tugging on her hair into something.

"Can I at least keep my hair out of my eyes?" Adora pipped up. Serpentina chuckled and had Catra start over. Whatever Catra was doing, she started by pulling Adora's bangs up into the poof Adora had grown to love. Adora could feel her sectioning hair and pulling it in different directions.

She heard her hair tie snap and felt her hair drop against her back. She reached back to touch it. The braid started at the top of her head and wound down to her shoulders in a loose yet tight enough fashion.

"I like it." Catra smirked. Adora stood and tried a few punches and kicks. The braid held. She shrugged.

"You'll get faster as time progresses, and you can show the Princess how to do it herself. There are many ways to keep your hair back if you so wish, Princess. If you change them around, your hair will appreciate you."

"I guess." It felt weird having the hair down but Adora resolved to leave it be. Catra liked it and it was practical enough. And they said she could still have her ponytail. She just had to change it up.

"Princess, come here please." Serpentina slithered to the back of the room, by the bench. Adora followed, Catra taking her previous seat. Adora noticed the light blue fabric they had picked up. They brought it close. "No." Another blue. "Not quite." A darker blue. "No, lighter." They grabbed a fabric that was close to the blue of the ocean. It reminded of her Mermista.

"Royal Strategist. What do you think?" Adora turned around, holding the piece of blue against her torso. Catra stood and bit her lip. She thought for a moment and nodded.

"I think it could work."

"Yes." They muttered as they turned back. They picked up a golden fabric and a black one. "Shall we also start on the Royal Strategist's clothing?"

"Sure." Adora smiled. Catra gave a teasing sigh and joined them.

Serpentina grabbed a crimson red fabric and held it up to Catra. "You seem to be comfortable with this color."

"I mean, I guess." Catra shifted to her hip.

"You wish for a different color?"

"No. It's fine."

"You should pick what makes you happy." Adora pushed her a little. Catra shot her a look.

"How about this one?" They handled a dark purple fabric.

"Yeah. I mean it's close to what I wear already."

Serpentina muttered to themselves for a moment before dismissing them to sit and relax. They would be done soon. They brought the two food before returning to their work bench. Catra and Adora sat on the nearby couches, snacking on the small sandwiches.

"Entrapta would lose her mind over these." Catra chuckled.

"She loves her tiny food." Adora smiled. Catra met her eyes before her expression saddened and she looked away. "Did… did I do something?"

"What?"

"You keep doing that." Adora motioned with her hands. "You keep smiling and having fun with me like normal and then you just stop."

"No, I'm not." Catra made a pshhing noise.

"Yes, you do."

"No. I'm not." Catra glared at her. Adora glared right back.

"Why won't you just talk to me? We were doing so well last week."

"Yeah, sure. Constant nightmares, the ending of the war, panic attacks glore for us both."

"But at least we were working through it together. All week, it feels like you're avoiding me."

"I'm not avoiding you! I'm busy."

"Not all the time! You won't even sleep in the bed, after we changed it for you too!"

"I don't want to disturb you when I come in later."

"What night this week have you come in after I've been asleep?! I've waited up for you every night! And every night, you curl up with Melog by the window!"

"Maybe I just like sleeping by the window!"

"Why won't you just tell me what's bugging you?!"

"Because it's not important!"

"So something is bugging you!"

"Ugh! Why are you like this?!" Catra groaned. Adora huffed and looked down at her sandwich. With the quiet between them again, Adora realized they had been yelling. Serpentina hadn't said anything, just sewing quietly in the background. Guilt gnawed at Adora. They were guests here and they were fighting.

"I'm sorry." Adora sighed. "I'm just worried."

"I am too." Catra played with a piece of her hair. "To both of those."

Adora snorted. "You can't just say I'm sorry, can you?"

"I just did!" Catra's nose scrunched up.

"The only time I've ever heard you apologize was…" Adora trailed off. The memory played behind her eyes. The joy she had unexpectedly hearing Catra's voice. The fear that rose when she realized Catra was there. When Catra sent Glimmer back at the cost of herself, it was the first time in a long time Adora had felt hope about Catra.

After the portal, Adora had realized Catra wouldn't come with her. Sad didn't even begin to explain the feeling of that realization. Adora thought she'd have to live the rest of her life with them as enemies so she could protect her friends and do what she had to. Catra's rescue of Glimmer had proven her wrong in the best way. And now they were here.

"Look, I get it if you don't want to talk to me about it." Adora tried. "But will you talk to someone about it? I don't want us to keep fighting. We did enough of that in the war."

"I suppose that's a fair point." Catra spoke carefully. This time, she was picking at a piece of food. "Seahawk and I are going out tomorrow anyway…"

"Seahawk?!" Adora blinked rapidly. "I…when did you make plans to do that?" This was the first she had heard about anything.

"Mermista called me the other day. Said I owed her for the party. Asked if I'd hang out with Seahawk for a day so she could go to meetings she needed to." Catra shrugged.

"So what are you planning on doing?"

"Seahawk apparently found some more stuff to burn. I guess that's our thing now." Adora giggled.

"Good."

"Do you want to come with us?" Catra asked so softly Adora wasn't sure if she had heard it correctly."

"I won't this time. But thank you. Glimmer and I have plans tomorrow…I was going to invite you."

"It sounds like you both are busy people." Serpentina spoke, spooking both of them. They turned. Serpentina chuckled. "Princess, will you come here?"

Adora shrugged a little and walked towards them. Serpentina handed her a few clothes and a new pair of boots, and showed her an area to change. As Adora grabbed the curtain, Catra received her clothes.

Serpentina was much quickly than planned. Adora thought they'd be there longer. She looked down at the fabrics. She didn't remember asking for new shoes but it couldn't hurt. She smiled a little and pulled off her clothes. As she picked up the black fabric, which she realized where pants, she wondered when Serpentina got their measurements.

She pulled on the pants, amazed at the perfect fit. Not too small or too loose. The black pants were tailored to her legs with the ends tight so she could tuck them into her boots. Adora gasped in amazement. She reached for the shirt. She yanked it over her head and pulled her braid out. She walked to the full length mirror in the small space.

Her hands flew to her mouth. The blue shirt was almost an exact replica of her shirt that she normally wore. This neckline and cuffs are her hands had gold fabric circling them. She turned to look behind her and saw the She-Ra emblem on her back in a golden replica of her sword. It almost looked like she was carrying it between her shoulder blades. She realized there was another piece she had missed. A black belt similar to the one she wore that crossed over her waist with the golden buckle. The boots given to her were golden with blue accents.

"Adora?" Catra's voice called to her. She realized she was tearing up. For the first time in her life, she had new clothes that were made just for her. She actually thought herself beautiful for a moment. She took a shaky breath and calmed herself. She grabbed her belt clip from her jacket and locked the winged pin onto her new belt.

"Catra?" She pulled the curtain back to see Catra talking with Serpentina. Catra's outfit was similar to Adora's. She had a crimson red shirt that kept the boob window Adora had come to love. She had a black trim that covered her neck and a black sleeve down her right arm. Her left arm had a dark purple sleeve that came halfway down her arm. She had a pair of black pants like Adora but her hems were purple like the left sleeve. She had a pair of boots in her hands that were red and purple. Adora realized the black trim around her neck had a detachable cape made of the purple fabric. She looked regal.

Adora realized her jaw had dropped and stuttered. "Hi." Catra turned to her and gave her that smile. Adora's heart was beating too fast.

"You do not like?" Serpentina asked. Adora realized they were asking about Catra's boots.

"I'm not a big shoe person." Catra answered.

"Keep them. You may need them." They seemed pleased with their answer as Catra tucked them under her arm. Adora realized there was a pin on Catra's chest, with the Bright Moon crest on it.

"Enjoying yourself?" Catra purred. She stood with her hand on her hip and a smirk on her lips. Adora couldn't stop looking. Catra was beautiful.

"I think she approves." Serpentina laughed. "And Royal Strategist, do you approve the Princess outfit?" Catra looked up

and down Adora and laughed. She tugged on her fingerless gloves.

"She looks perfect." Adora's heart stopped for a second there.

"Good. I'm glad you're happy." Serpentina clapped her hands. "Now, your royal outfits will take longer to come in and I'll make a few variations for you to wear as you please. You can leave your older outfits here since they are ripped. I'll reuse the fabric."

Adora turned sharply towards the curtain. She had left everything there. She didn't want to part ways with them. She loved the new clothes but did she really have to leave the others behind….

"Adora?" Catra questioned. Adora realized leaving them here would be the last step. It was the last thing she had carried with her since the Horde three years ago. Since finding the sword. She had given up everything else to come to Bright Moon. To do the right thing. Leaving the uniform she had always worn behind would be the final goodbye to her Horde days.

"It's hard." Serpentina spoke lovingly. "That uniform is something you've had all your life. It gives you a sense of purpose, doesn't it? But, you are no longer the Adora bound to that uniform, are you? You are Adora, yourself. You are no longer a weapon for the Horde or for the First Ones…"

"How did you…" Adora looked towards Serpentina with tears in her eyes.

"I hear a lot of gossip from my clients." They chuckled. "But I'm telling you the truth. You have conquered those and who you are now is not who you were before."

"But." Adora looked back toward the curtain. "I…" If she wasn't the same person…then who was she?

"I'm not the only one who changed, Adora." Catra spoke. "We both have…we're not the same kids in the Horde anymore." Adora couldn't bring herself to move as she heard Catra's footsteps. "I thought you wanted new a start…"

"I do but…"

"How's this, Princess?" they both turned to the tailor. "I'll use the fabric to make something you can carry with you. And you can let go of it when you're ready then. It's not a goodbye. It is a until later." Serpentina smiled.

Adora paused for a moment and nodded. "Okay." She knew it wasn't the same fabric that she had worn before. Glimmer and Bow had made new clothes for her in the same style without the Horde symbol when she moved to Bright Moon. But the sentiment was still there.

"By the way, how did you know our measurements?" Adora asked. Serpentina laughed.

"Who do you think made the clothes in there?" Adora blinked. "I did. The Queen asked me to recreate the set without the Horde symbol for a friend of hers. The Royal Strategist? I guessed." Catra's face soured and Serpentina guffawed. "No, I asked Princess Entrapta as she told me she made you spacesuits."

"They did say they worked with a lot of royalty." Catra muttered. "I suppose it paid off."

"Princess Entrapta sent me the measurements to see about recreating spacesuits for you for future endeavors. It seems she was remarkably busy with other experiments."

"Sounds like Entrapta." Adora said. She had really come to love Entrapta during their time on Darla.

"You two should be getting home." Serpentina looked at a clock nearby. "I have kept you here long enough. The Queen should be happy with it."

"Wait, were you stalling us for something?" Catra bristled a little.

"Yes and No. When the Queen told me you were coming, she asked me to keep you here until a certain time. But I also don't rush my projects. I took my time with your clothes so they would be perfect."

"They really are." Adora admired them.

"They are durable for many wears and battle usage. More will be sent shortly. You should be heading back to the castle. The Queen has something fun planned for you."

"Oh goodie." Catra groaned.

"Thank you, Serpentina."

"Anytime. Feel free to come back whenever you need. I'll be here. And no need to worry about payment. Everything is already paid for by the Queen." Adora and Catra walked towards the door and said goodbye once more. As they made their way back to Bright Moon, Adora paused.

"Are you coming?" Catra held out her hand. Adora sat there for a moment. Her heart was beating way too fast for it to be normal. Her cheeks were burning but she had to say it. If she didn't now, she didn't know if she could later. She wasn't the type to get nervous like this…

"I…I think you look really pretty in that, Catra!" Adora shouted. She clenched her fists and eyes at the same time.

Catra's cackle filled the air, leading Adora to open her eyes. Catra was leaning against a tree, trying to catch her breath.

"Why are you laughing at me?!" Embarrassment burned Adora's cheeks redder than Catra's new shirt.

"You're such an idiot!" Catra threw her head back and looked at the sky for a moment. She titled her head to look at Adora. "And you're my idiot."

Adora's breath caught. She released the breath she didn't realize she had been holding and laughed. She got an idea in her head and went with it. She ran up to Catra, making her fur puff.

"Adora?!" Catra's voice raised an octave as Adora grabbed her waist and lifted her into the air. She lowered Catra down into a kiss, Catra's new shoes falling to the ground as she wrapped her arms around Adora's neck.

"I love you." Adora giggled.

"You're such an idiot."

Chapter End Notes

So yeah, pretty long chapter hopefully makes up for the missed week of updates. :P This chapter was a pain to write. I rewrote the scene were Adora tells everyone about the future vision a few times. And I got stuck for over a week. It's great. I love writing. I'm starting chapter 7 now so hopefully they'll be an update next week. :) Until next time. And thanks for the comments. It's really inspiring to know that people enjoy this.

Catra Needs Therapy

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 7: Catra

After they returned to Bright Moon, Glimmer had prepared a special dinner for the three of them. Oh, so Catra thought. Bow surprised them with a visit and update about the library. They had spent the last week repairing the structure of the building and making it sound once more.

Apparently, Lance really liked meeting Catra at the party and was excited to find she was joining them for a visit at some point. Bow asked for at least a week more before they joined him to give them a little more time to fix the last things.

Adora planned to make her visit to Razz within the next few days so it worked out. Glimmer and Catra had plans the next day and more and more meetings to manage. Catra ran a hand through her hair and sighed. She leaned on her elbow, head resting in her palm as she listened to the three of them talk.

Bow was recounting some story how one of the pillars in the library almost fell on them and how he and his family had to fix it. Bow apparently had a large family and there were way too many names for Catra to remember.

Catra was distracted for most of the dinner. Adora's new outfit looked stunning on her and that took half of her attention. Catra wanted nothing more than to rip it off, take Adora and admire her in ways that were not appropriate, but she couldn't. Not with everything going on.

Catra's theory had been right. If she kept her distance from Adora as much as she could, Adora wouldn't transform into She-Ra. Adora would be safe from the Heart's magic. She hadn't had a single attack since they returned from Mystacor. Catra knew she had something to do with Adora's magic. She wasn't sure what, but she knew she was part of the cause.

Nothing hurt her more. She finally had Adora back. They were finally together again and they were happy and now Catra couldn't even touch Adora without fear of causing her pain. Every touch made her wonder if it would be like the Heart. Would Adora collapse in pain into her arms? Catra hadn't admitted it but her visions of Adora dying with green marks had returned. Two mornings in the past week, she had woken up before Adora and was panicked. Melog had stopped her, reminding her it wasn't real.

Melog was the only thing keeping Catra sane. They'd spilt their time between Catra and Adora. When Catra was in meetings or busy, they'd go to Adora and cuddle so Catra would feel it. If Catra was working on something, they'd curl at her feet and purr. She reminded them they could go anywhere if they wanted but the answer was always the same: we are bonded and I am content here.

Laughter returned her to the moment. Bow made a joke about a mission they went on to a haunted city. Alwyn is what they called it. Glimmer and Adora were laughing about something to do with it. Catra smiled a little. Hearing Adora laugh calmed her. It was a sound she had missed for way too long.

"So, I hear you and Seahawk are going out tomorrow morning?" Bow asked her. She nodded and took a bite of her bread. She stirred her soup slowly as she thought of a response.

"Yeah, he wants to go burn stuff."

"Destruction sounds up your alley." Glimmer teased.

"Wow, thanks Sparkles." She wasn't wrong. Catra loved destruction. It was therapeutic.

"Did you two ever decide what you're doing tomorrow?" Bow asked Glimmer.

"Yeah!" Glimmer squealed. "But I'm not saying. It's a surprise."

"Glimmer!" Adora pouted.

"You have to wait. It'll be fun!" Catra chuckled at Adora's pout.

"But wait. I want to see your outfits." Bow clapped. Adora stood up and did a slow turn.

"She said she used a similar design to what I wear normally." Adora stated, as if it wasn't obvious. The outfit is almost the exact same as before but blue, black, and gold versus her old red, white, and gray. Catra preferred the new outfit. Her favorite part was the embroidered sword that went down Adora's back. It was an exact replica of her sword in great detail. The hilt started at the nape of her neck and the point disappeared under her pants at her waist. She didn't think Adora really noticed the golden line that went across her chest, giving the illusion of belt strapping the sword to her back. She certainly hadn't mentioned it when she was admiring the outfit earlier.

Catra stood slowly. Her outfit felt a little weird to her. The purple, red and black combo was her thing but having the different colored sleeves were new. She was happy to have her arms covered again. Ever since the portal, she liked covering her arm that had been corrupted. Entrapta hadn't given her sleeves on the uniforms she had made them and she wasn't going to complain when Entrapta was nice enough to make her clothes. The cape was dramatic. Glimmer loved it.

"I like how the outfits work together. Different enough but they look alike." Bow mused.

"Catra got a cape." Adora teased. "I wanted a cape…"

"You have one with She-Ra!" Catra gave her a look.

"Yeah, but I like yours." Catra's hand went up to grab Adora's face for a joke but she stopped herself. Keep her distance. She pulled back and took her seat.

"The cape detaches for missions. Serpentina said it was mainly for meetings."

"Yeah. I think it makes you look official." Glimmer smiled.

"Are you two getting new clothes too?"

"I don't know." Glimmer touched her leotard. Catra wasn't dumb enough to miss what she was wearing. It was the same as her mother before her. Bow was sporting a light blue sweater that covered her stomach. Catra was shocked to see it when he walked in. Though, there were light stitch patterns across his stomach as if the fabric had been repair. She wondered how many times he had ripped it off previously.

"I think you should." Catra sipped some of her soup. "We did. And I doubt Arrow Boy can wear armor forever, can you?" Her eyes shifted to him, where he gave her a lopsided smile.

"Aw, Catra. Thanks for thinking about me."

"You're ruining it…" She looked back at her soup as they laughed.

"Catra's right though. I haven't really seen you wear anything but your armor, Bow. You should go see Serpentina." Adora took a bite of her bread roughly, tearing the small loaf from her mouth. Catra shook her head. Adora never changed.

"I think about it. Though, I'm sure my dads want me to keep wearing sweaters like these." He tugged on it. "Not that they're bad." He gave them a shocked look. "Lance said I'm not allowed to tear it. He said he can't keep sewing it back." Catra pursed her lips to hold back the laugh. She had been right.

He took a bite of soup as Glimmer agreed with him. Catra sighed softly as their banter continued. Just a while longer. She hoped they'd figure this out soon.

"Catra." Melog's voice popped into her head. "You should speak to Adora about your worries."

"Kinda ruining the moment, Melog." She replied inwardly. She stirred her soup, which was quickly cooling. She dipped a piece of her bread in before popping it into her mouth. "And I can't. Not until this whole She-Ra thing is resolved."

"You are worried and upset. She is your life partner. You should speak to her."

"Life Partner?" Catra sipped.

"Oh, right." Melog chuckled in her mind. "You have a different term here. She would be your…wife, right?" Catra physically spit out her soup on the table. She coughed as Adora reached over to pat her back.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer chuckled nervously.

"Fine." She choked out. Melog giggled in her mind and she reprimanded them harshly.

"Is that not the correct word?" Melog asked smugly.

"Why are you so smug?" Catra bit back, eyes widening as she realized she spoke aloud.

"Who's smug?" Bow asked. Catra cleared her throat and stood.

"I'm heading to bed."

"Its' not even moonset." Adora looked at the nearby window.

"I'm tired." She looked away so they didn't see her face flush. She pushed her chair in, grabbed the last of her bread and walked out.

As she walked down the hall towards their room, her chest hurt. She stuffed the rest of her bread into her mouth and chewed angrily. At least she could do that.

Melog apologized in her mind before materializing beside her. She fought back tears as she slammed the door open. She tore off the stupid cape and flopped onto the bed. She pulled a blanket over her head and curled into a ball.

"Catra." Melog pawed at her hands. She could feel their anxiety rising with hers.

"I'm fine."

"There is no use lying to me."

"I'm not lying!" She growled. She flipped sides and covered her ears.

"Are you not happy that she is your life partner?"

"Of course I am." Catra sat up quickly and turned back to them. "Do you know how long I've wanted this! We're supposed to be happy now. We're supposed to be okay. We got the cute matching outfits I was told we're supposed to get. We have a space together." She motioned to the room around her. "We get to be together all day! And yet…" Catra trailed off.

"You feel as though you will hurt her…" Melog continued. "I understand. This is why you need to speak to her."

"No." Catra flopped back down and pulled the covers up. "That'll only make her feel worse. It's just better if I keep my distance. Once all of this is over…if…" If Adora still wanted her…

Catra ran through scenarios in her mind. She wasn't as strong as Adora or kind as Bow. But she was smart. That was all she had going for her. She could be better but it had never gotten her anywhere. When she applied herself mentally or exploited others or strategized, that was her strong points.

But anyone could see it…Adora might not choose her after this. With how much Catra was trying to pull away. The fact that they didn't know when this would end. What if they didn't find a solution for years and Catra wasn't able to really touch or love Adora for that entire time?

Adora wouldn't pick her again at that point. There were plenty of better people for her to be with. Catra would be a fool to think Adora would pick her. She growled in anger as she stood from the bed. Melog's mane glowed red but still stayed flowing. She grabbed a pillow and threw it at the wall as hard as she could. She grabbed another and tore it in half.

She picked up the cape, balled it up, and threw it at the waterfall. It made a sad plopping sound. She drew her claws through her hair as she paced the room. Her heart was beating so fast it hurt. Her lungs burned for air. Her legs carried the weight of a thousand pounds strapped to them. The room spun around her.

She dropped to her knees and hugged herself, touching her forehead to the floor.

Why was she so stupid to think that anyone would want her? All she did was hurt people. She was hurting Adora right now. She knew she was. What could she do differently? All week, in the meetings she attended, they all ended the same. Someone said something, she yelled and stormed out.

She was a fool to think she could live in Bright Moon. She was an idiot to think that happy moments like their kiss in the woods would be enough for Adora to stay with her. Catra stood and grabbed a bag from Adora's closet.

"You have already tried this a week ago…" Melog meowed. "Why are you running again?"

"I'm not running. I'm doing them a favor." She stuffed the boots inside and a blanket. She grabbed a few of the snack bars Adora kept in the room. She grabbed a small bottle for water. "I don't belong here. All I'm doing is hurting Adora."

"Where will you go?"

"I don't know." Catra admitted, her shoulders falling in defeat. She stared at the floor. The Fright Zone was all she had ever known. She'd find something. She was resourceful and smart. Those were her strengths. "But I know that I can't stay here. Adora needs to find out what this is. If…if she wants me to come back after everything is done…then we'll see." Catra strung the bag across her back. She gulped and went to the window.

The window opened with a small creak. "I don't expect you to come with me. You're free to do what you want." Catra's chest throbbed. She lowered herself out the window and grabbed a hold of the building. She looked back into the room once more with longing. The memories she had made this week would be her favorites.

She began her scale down the wall. Melog's head peaked out over the window, meowing at her to come back. As she finally touched the ground again, Melog appeared beside her. She turned and began to make her way to the bridge. She knew there would be guards but she was allowed to leave if she wished.

"Keeper of She-Ra?" One of the guards asked as she approached. "It's late evening. The moon is setting. Should you not return to your room?"

"I'm collecting something for a meeting tomorrow. I'll return soon." She lied. The guards exchanged looks and nodded. They allowed her through. Melog chastised her with a series of meows that made the guards whisper amongst themselves.

Catra waited until she was deep enough into the woods that no one would see her and began running. Melog was silent as they kept pace. She wove her way through different trees and vines and branches.

"You're a bad friend."

"Didn't need you…left you."

"I won't allow you to jeopardize Adora's future."

"You lost!"

"Little Sister…"

The image of Adora glaring at her after the portal burned tear tracks down her face.

She was doing them all a favor. This would keep Adora safe and happier. She was happier without Catra. Every time Catra had seen Adora during the war, she was happier with them then she had been with her in the Horde.

Catra missed a branch and tripped. She squealed on the way down, skidding along the ground. She groaned as she stood. She rubbed her jaw. Melog nuzzled her leg.

"You should return to Bright Moon, Catra. Adora will worry about you."

"No, she won't." Melog growled angrily at her and pinned her to the ground.

"Melog!" Catra grunted as she tried to get up. "Stop it!"

"What must I do to convince you they love you?" Catra stopped at this question.

"No one loves me."

"Adora does."

"No, she doesn't."

"Are you Adora?"

"No."

"Then how do you know?"

"You're not Adora either."

"But it is evident that she loves you."

"Adora's an idiot."

"Is she not your idiot?"

"She deserves someone better than me."

"She is happy with you."

"I can't be her…life partner or whatever." Catra sighed and laid down against the ground. She covered her eyes with the palms of her hands. "I can't go one week without wanting to run away from everything because it's all new and I…I can't even touch her without guilt and fear that I'll hurt her, Melog. What if I'm what's causing this…What if I'm the reason it didn't work?"

"How so?"

"What if me being at the Heart changed something?"

"Do you regret going to save her?"

"No!"

"Then do not fret over it."

"Melog."

"I'm serious." Melog licked her face. "Adora loves you. She will be sad if she finds you have left. Did you not promise to stay and look out for each other once more?"

"Yes…"

"Then why are you breaking that promise?"

"I-"

"Well, hello, dearie." A voice spoke to their left. Both looked over with widened eyes.

An old woman dressed in pink with long white hair and a staff waved at her. Small white dots flew around her and it looked as if the magic of the woods bent to her will.

"And you are?" Catra blinked as Melog let her up. She stood, shifting her foot back. If she needed to run or fight, she'd be ready.

"What are you talking about? Madam Razz was just talking to you." Catra blinked. This was Madam Razz. The Madam Razz who was supposed to know about Adora's condition.

"No. This is the first we've ever met."

"Ha-ha, you're so funny Catra." Madam Razz laughed. "Now, come. We're having tea!"

"Wait. What?" Catra stuttered.

"Come on, dearie. You've got to find Adora and the others, don't you?" What was she talking about? Catra shared a look with Melog. She shrugged and followed the woman.

"What do you mean, I have to find Adora and the others? Who am I supposed to be looking for?"

"Oh, you know. The Portal, Adora, all ten years. Purrsia, Eternia, and the other stars. Mara would be so proud of the stars. Adora is the new She-Ra. Mara loved Pie." Madam Razz rambled as she walked. Catra was only growing more confused as she followed. She pushed branches and leaves out of the way as Madam Razz seemed to only want to walk through the densest parts of the woods.

"Mara was the previous She-Ra." Catra tried correcting. Adora had said Mara had lived and died over a thousand years ago. Had Madam Razz lived long enough to see both Adora and Mara?

"Yes. Adora is the new She-Ra. She-Ra of Etheria that is."

"Does that mean there's other She-Ra's on other planets?" Catra tried.

"Of course, dearie!" Madam Razz laughed. Catra's eyes widened as she looked to Melog.

"What happened to the other She-Ra's?" Catra picked up her pace to ask.

"They died." Her blood ran cold. "They fought to protect their planets."

"How do you know that?"

"Mara told me." Madam Razz laughed again. That laugh was beginning to weird Catra out. She gulped. "Mara was She-Ra of Etheria. She had the Sword of Protection so she could use the Heart of Etheria." Madam Razz stopped and turned to look at Catra. "But now Adora has the Heart. She needs to free the magic."

"Okay." So Catra's previous theory of freeing magic would free the heart was correct. "How does she do that?"

"She has to find the remaining magic that's trapped."

"How does she find it?"

"She already knows where it is." Madam Razz giggled and whacked Catra's head with her broom. "You ask so many funny questions, Catra. You already know these answers."

"No, I don't." Catra growled as she rubbed her head. That hurt.

"Is it not that time?" Madam Razz pondered for a moment. "You didn't stay for tea last time either. Said you were in a rush to find others. Moonstone is your key this time, dearie."

"The Moonstone?" Catra questioned. Bow and Adora were right. Madam Razz spoke in circles. Catra wasn't understanding anything.

"Yes, the Moonstone! You have to find your friend and go to the moonstone to go forward a year."

"I don't…what are you…. UGH!" Catra drew her hands down her face. "None of this makes sense! Do you know how to free Adora from the Heart or not?!"

"You have to free the magic, Catra." Madam Razz turned back to her with a smile. "If you free the magic, it will go wild for a while. Adora will suffer like Mara did. But it will all work out." Madam Razz turned suddenly and disappeared into the foliage.

"Wait!" Catra called. She sprinted through the woods, leaping over logs and pushing off trees and rocks. She came to a clearing and caught her breath. Melog panted beside her. Madam Razz was nowhere to be seen. Catra punched a tree in frustration.

"Nothing she said made any sense!" She looked at Melog. Melog agreed with her in a sad meow.

"You should return to Bright Moon and see if the others would know."

"I…" Catra sighed. She didn't want to return because she knew they would be mad at her. But if they knew anything about what Madam Razz was saying, she needed to tell them. Adora had to free the magic. Whatever that meant. The Moonstone, Glimmer's Runestone, was involved in this.

The last time one of the runestones was tampered with, it nearly destroyed the woods. She had used it to charge on Bright Moon. If they had to tamper or even destroy a runestone… what would happen this time? Even further…if Adora was connected to this, what would happen to her?

Catra growled in frustration. "Come on, Melog." She hopped on their back and they bounded back to Bright Moon.

Melog flew through the halls until they got back to the dining room. It was empty. Catra and Melog panted heavily as they tried to catch their breath. Of course, they wouldn't be here! She hadn't been gone that long! Her fur bristled as she heard her name.

"Lady Catra." One of the servants called. A young girl with antlers and deer like features walked over. "There you are. Oh, Queen Glimmer will be relieved."

"What are you talking about? Where are they?" Catra spoke. Her mouth was extremely dry and she was getting light headed.

"You've been missing for four hours ma'am." Catra's eyes widened as she turned to the window. She was right. When

Catra left Bright Moon, the moon was setting and now it was just stars. Catra and Melog shared a worried look. They couldn't have been gone that long.

"Where are they?" Catra growled. The girl eeped and Catra felt bad.

"They're in the War Room." She pointed in that direction. Catra took off sprinting towards it.

She slammed open the door. Glimmer, Bow and Adora all looked up in shock. The table was lit with a map of Bright Moon and the surrounding woods. They had been planning something.

"CATRA!" Adora shouted in relief. She flew to Catra's side as Catra approached the table.

"Where have you been?!" Glimmer yelled.

"We've been worried." Bow added.

"I…" Catra choked on her words. She needed water. She heard Adora snap her fingers and catch something from Bow. Adora handed her a water bottle, which she happily accepted. She gulped half of it down in a breath. As she gasped for air, she passed the rest to Melog. She felt Adora pull something from her hair, which she vaguely realized was a small twig.

"Let's try this again." Glimmer clasped her hands and took a breath. "What happened? The guards said you left to do something, but Adora said you had supplies missing." Catra slung the backpack off her back, where said supplies spilled onto the floor.

"Were you trying to leave?" Adora asked, hurt tinging her voice.

"Listen!" Catra slammed a hand on the table. "We need to talk."

"Yeah, we do." Adora's face changed to anger. "Why do you keep-"

"Not about that!" Catra bit out.

"What happened, Catra?" Bow asked. He pulled a seat out for her, to which she slumped into. She put her hands on her temples and tried to breath. Her lungs ached for air. "Are you okay?"

"…That's not important right now." Catra took a shaky breath and grabbed another water. "I met Razz."

"You…you met Madam Razz?" Adora stuttered. She steadied herself on the table. "How…Madam Razz is pretty deep in the woods! What…I…"

"What did Madam Razz say?" Glimmer asked.

"I have no idea what she was saying. She spoke as if we knew each other."

"Madam Razz lives in between timelines." Bow muttered. "Isn't that what you said, Adora?"

"Yeah. But I thought she only lived between Mara and my timelines?"

"There's no reason she wouldn't see the future, would she?" Glimmer asked.

"I. I honestly don't know." Adora deflated.

"She mentioned a portal and Adora and something called Purrsia and…" Catra paused to think. Nothing Madam Razz told her made any sense. "She said something about other She-Ra's."

"Others?" Micah asked as he entered the room.

"Yeah." Catra leaned on her hand, looking at the table. "She said there were others but they died back in Mara's time. She said Mara had the Sword of Protection?"

"That was my old sword." Adora answered. "It was used to connect us to the Heart."

"Right." Catra sat back in the chair. "She said you have to free the magic. That you would know what she was talking about. But then she told me I had to find my friend and go to the Moonstone to advance a year."

"I have no idea what that means." Bow admitted. "Which friend?"

"She didn't say." Catra clenched her fists. "Why your Light Hope told you to talk to her, I have no idea."

"Light Hope said she would know and could help. Madam Razz has helped me several times before!" Adora raised her voice defensively.

"Yeah. Cause she makes so much sense. When could she have possibly helped you?"

"I don't know! How about the Portal you opened for one?!" Adora yelled. She gasped and covered her mouth. Catra's breath caught, and she looked away. She stood without another word and grabbed her bag. "Catra, wait. I'm sorry."

"Where are you going?" Glimmer asked.

"Catra, please don't leave." Bow asked.

"Clearly, it'd be better without me, right?" Catra spat. She slung the bag over her shoulder. Adora grabbed her wrist.

"Wait."

"What?! So, I can mess up again! So, I can end the world or hurt you again?! It was a mistake thinking I could ever live here."

"I never said that~!"

"You didn't have to." Catra shook Adora's hand from hers. She turned and sprinted out of the room.

"Catra!" She heard Adora running after her. She ducked down a hall and headed back for the gates. She was wrong to come back. She should've just kept going. She would never belong here. She would never fit in. They would never be able to accept her.

Glimmer teleported in front of her, Bow at her side. Catra gasped and tried to move, sliding on the floor to avoid knocking into them. She skidded to the side and hit a side table. The plant sitting on top, broke over her head and dowsed her in water.

"Catra. Please." Bow approached with his hands up. She saw the way his bow was slung over his shoulder in a way he could grab it quickly if needed. "Let's talk. Just you and me. Like that first night." The memory of how nice he was to her flashed before her eyes.

"Why?" Panic rose in her chest. Everything blurred between Bright Moon pastels and Velvet Glove white. She couldn't breathe.

"Because I don't think you should be yelled at right now." Adora's footsteps grew louder as she entered the hallway.

"Glimmer." Bow ordered. The queen grabbed Adora and poofed away. "See, just us."

"Just leave me alone." Catra turned away to try to get up. She knew she saw him reach but it wasn't what her mind saw. She saw Prime's hand. The water on her. The hand coming

towards her to shove her down. To choke her until she was willing to do what he wanted. Her body tensed as if waiting for the shock that she half knew wasn't coming.

"Catra." Bow's voice echoed in her head. "Try to breathe."

"Get off!" She screeched. She dragged her claws down the floor, leaving large marks. She needed to go. She tried to get up, but her foot slipped in the water.

"Catra, you're safe." Bow's hands grabbed her arms. She gasped and tried to claw her way out. Bow's grip didn't loosen. She bit his arm and hissed. But he stayed. "I'm not leaving."

Catra's eyes widened. She looked down at his arms. The blood on her hands brought her down and things became real again…Damage. All she was good for. She saw the memory of Adora leaving her at Thaymor. Tears welled in her eyes as she could hear Shadow Weaver's voice in her mind, reminding her how useless she was. All she was good for was breaking and destroying things. She'd never be good enough. The fight left her body, against her will and instinct to run.

"Let's get you cleaned up." Bow's hands tightened enough so he could help her up and loosened as she got on her feet. He wrapped his arm around her, still holding and supporting her. He spoke softly to her as he led her to the nearest room with a first aid kit.

He took her into a sitting room at the corner. As they walked inside, he closed the door with his foot. He led her to a couch and sat her down. She was tired. She didn't feel like fighting anymore. She knew what she was. She couldn't even go one week without breaking down like this.

"Catra." He offered a blanket. When she didn't respond, he placed it around her shoulders kindly. "Can I see your

arm?" She looked down at it, the purple sleeve torn from a shard of the plant cutting her. He cleaned her wound and bandaged it in silence before taking a seat across from her. "Can we talk?"

Catra didn't answer. She stared at the table in front of her. She was tired. She was tired of trying. She was tired of fighting. She listened as he bandaged his arms and spoke.

"Friendships take work." Bow started. "It's not easy. You know, for a while there, Glimmer and Adora were fighting really badly, and I couldn't do anything." Catra glanced up at him before returning her eyes to the table. She didn't know why he was still talking to her. "For that period of time, it felt like I was the only one trying and no matter what I did, it wasn't enough."

That was a feeling she could understand. No matter what she had ever done, it wasn't enough for Shadow Weaver or Hordak and anyone. Why was her existence never enough for anyone? She felt she would never know that answer.

"Glimmer said something that really hurt Adora. Both of them were really hurt and it wasn't until after you saved Glimmer that they made up." Catra remembered Glimmer saying something about that. She had said she was terrible to them, and she'd do anything to go back and fix it, if Catra remembered correctly.

"What'd she say?" she asked softly. Curiosity spoke before she had the chance to hush it inside her.

"She said that if Adora was really helping, then her mom would still be here." Catra gulped. So Angella was gone. She had figured. Most of the staff around the castle didn't talk about it. "It really hurt Adora who was trying to be there for Glimmer. It was right after the attack on Salineas." Oh great, another thing Catra did that didn't help the situation. It was almost as if the stars above were telling her that she just made everything worse. They'd be right but it still hurt.

"When we caught Glimmer and had to go get fuel before we came back, Glimmer apologized and tried to change. It took me a while to get over being angry at her."

"You angry?" Catra scoffed. "I'd pay money to see that."

"What I'm saying is that, we know that you're trying and we don't want you to leave. You're one of us."

"Yeah, well you can't really be friends with someone who only hurts you."

"I would beg to differ." Bow offered her a smile. "You've helped us a lot since you joined us."

"No, I haven't."

"Okay." Bow paused for a moment. Catra's eyebrows furrowed and she looked up at him. "You helped us on Krytis and even fought Melog off before you knew them to save us. You helped us during the Erelandia mission. You and Melog were the only reason we made it back to Etheria and to the Failsafe. You came back and helped Adora survive the Heart." Bow raised an eyebrow at her as he counted on his fingers. When she didn't respond, he continued. "You've been helping Adora since you got back and all of us can tell you care about her and the attacks. Glimmer's gotten more done since you're her Royal Strategist now."

"Yeah, I'd consider me yelling at her senators all day, 'helping'." She said in air quotes.

"Actually yeah." Bow chuckled. "Glimmer could yell at them but having you there helps her. She said because of you, the council's more willing to listen to both of you."

"I doubt that."

"It's true. Would I lie to you?" Bow gave her his wide eyed puppy dog look.

"….maybe." Catra pouted a little.

"I'm hurt, Catra." Bow feigned.

"Get in line." Catra scoffed. Bow laughed. She wasn't expecting that.

"You really don't think you're a good person, do you?" He asked softly. "You discard anything good that you have done… because you…you think you don't deserve anything nice?"

"Don't talk as if you know me!" Catra growled. Everyone was coming for her today. First Serpentina's comments to her and now Bow. "I thought you said you were nice."

"I am. But I also care about my friends." He reached a hand out. She pulled away and he placed his hand back on his leg. "Shadow Weaver told you things like that, didn't she?" Catra hissed at him. "Yeah, I didn't like her."

"HA! I thought all of you in the Rebellion liked her! You all seemed to accept her well enough to come to the Fright Zone!"

"You know when she first arrived here, we kept her locked up and she was interrogated. I had heard stories from Adora of how she tortured you two. I never trusted her." Bow's expression hardened. "I hated that we had to use her magic to go to the Fright Zone. I hated seeing how she used Glimmer's magic to hurt you."

"Oh, because it hurt Sparkles." Catra huffed.

"No, because it was wrong to hurt you." Bow answered. Catra shifted awkwardly. She looked down. "I could hear the pain in your voice when you spoke to her. She betrayed you like she did everyone else."

"Shadow Weaver used me!" Catra shouted. She stood, chest heavily as anger boiled her blood. "She…" She laughed." Shadow Weaver convinced me she cared! She used me to get magic to leave me for Adora! Then she had the audacity to come back and rub it in my face!" She growled the last few words.

"You're right." Catra shook a little as she stared at Bow. He nodded. "You're right. Shadow Weaver was a terrible person." She cocked her head at him.

"You…you're talking bad about her?"

"Yeah. She was mean. Terrible. She betrayed and hurt people because she wanted to. She lied to us to get Adora to take the failsafe. You noticed it before the rest of us."

"Of course, I noticed!" Catra threw her hand out, tossing the blanket out. "You'd be blind not to notice."

"You know it reminds me of something Glimmer said."

"What?" Catra flopped back into her seat.

"Glimmer told me one of the reasons she liked you as her Strategist was because you saw through things like that." Catra's tail stood up. "She said that when you were on Prime's ship together, you saw through the manipulation before she could. She liked how you were able to help her. That's one of the reasons she likes you in the meetings. You know what you're looking for. Glimmer doesn't always."

Catra realized it was true. She had been seeing it all week. The senators kept trying to tell Glimmer what to do without giving her a say or tell her that they knew better. Obviously Catra couldn't stand it and would yell at them. She saw it as she was being mean again. Like how she was to everyone at the Horde.

"Glimmer doesn't mind if you yell at them. She said it's kinda funny." Bow smiled.

"How?"

"Apparently, no one's talked to them like that before. They apparently sit there with their mouths open or stuttering after you leave." Catra chuckled a little at the sight. That Senator Brakenten was her least favorite. Thinking of him like that made her smile.

"See, you do a lot of good here. Can I ask you a question?"

"I haven't been able to stop you so far." Catra retorted. Bow snorted and nodded.

"What is it here that makes you feel so unwelcome?" Catra bristled and drew her feet in. She felt herself curling in.

"I…"

"It seems like you have a lot of these thoughts that you don't deserve to be here or you shouldn't be here. But we want you here. Is it something we say?"

"No…I…" Catra clenched her fists.

"Or is it that thing about not feeling like you deserve anything good?"

"Adora…" Catra started, her chest throbbed at the thought of her. "She…she deserves better than me."

"Why do you say that?" Bow asked softly. He stood and moved to sit beside her. He pulled the blanket back over her shoulders was when she realized she was shivering.

"She was happier before I came."

"Not really." Bow mused. Catra turned to look at him with a confused look. "Yeah, she was happy living here because it was better than the Fright Zone, right?" Catra titled her head back

and forth as a kinda motion. “But she missed you like crazy. She wanted so badly for you to come with her. She asked us to go back for you after we refueled.”

If Bow was telling the truth, then Adora missed her as much as she had missed Adora. Catra shook her head and leaned over her knees.

“Believe it or not, but this is the happiest I’ve ever seen Adora. She really loves you. And you really love her?”

Catra stood, her cheeks flushed and she tensed. She covered her mouth and sat back down. Bow chuckled and touched her leg.

“One more question.”

“You and your many questions.” Catra tried to deflect.

“You’ve been pulling away from her all week because of the She-Ra Heart thing, haven’t you?” Busted. “It’s pretty evident. Do you blame yourself?”

“Wh-Why would you ask that?” Catra looked away from him.

“Because it seems like you won’t let yourself relax around her. You’ll just stop and pull away almost like you’re worried you’ll cause an attack.”

“You.” Catra’s fur puffed against her will. She raised a hand to him, claws extended. “You should stop while you’re ahead.”

“Threatening me only proves my point.” Bow smirked a little. Catra growled.

“Well, she hasn’t had an attack all week so clearly I’m right.” She huffed and turned away.

"Yeah, but she's also been really down all week. She really misses you."

"I'm right here…" Catra tried. She remembered the conversation earlier where Adora said she wanted Catra to share the bed again.

"Yeah, but something's off."

"You didn't see what happened at the Heart." She got defensive again. "She transformed because I told her I loved her. She got her first attack, saying she was defending me. She got the one in the garden because we kissed! As long I…if I just go away, she'll be fine."

"Maybe in that regard but she would be really sad." Bow placed a hand on her shoulder. "Have you talked to her about it?"

"Now you sound like Melog." Catra laughed bitterly.

"Melog seems pretty smart to me." Melog chirped from behind the couch. Bow jumped as Catra cackled.

"How long have they been there!?" His voice broke.

"Since we entered the room." She smirked. Melog had been quiet, letting Bow talk. Though now, they were voicing their agreement. "And they said thank you for the compliment."

"Of course." Melog mewed happily. Bow reached back and petted their head. "Sounds like majority says you should be here." Bow looked back to Catra.

Glimmer, Adora, and Micah suddenly teleported into the room. Micah and Glimmer both were holding Adora's arms. Her hair was falling out of the braid, as if she had been struggling. Even now, she thrashed against their hold.

"Sorry, Bow. I couldn't hold her back any longer." Glimmer apologized. Catra stood, her fur on end. She looked away. Adora broke free using a windmill sweep of her arms and stepped forward with a pleading look.

"Don't do that." Adora pleaded. "Talk to me. Please don't pull away from me!"

"Adora." Bow held his hand out. "Catra, you have a choice to make. Either you trust me and I trust you and you stay here. Or, if you really want to, you can leave Bright Moon."

"BOW!" Adora and Glimmer protested. He shot them a look and continued. "If you really don't think you deserve to be here and there's nothing we can do to convince you otherwise, then we won't stop you. But Bright Moon will always be open to you and you will always have a place here. We all want you to stay but we can't force you to." He held out his hand in his offer. Take it or leave.

Catra stared at his hand. She wanted to stay. She didn't want to hurt Adora anymore but she wanted so badly to be with her. Could she really find a compromise? Was it possible for her to live here? She glanced at Bow's face and saw the loving smile he was giving her. She looked to Adora and Glimmer. Glimmer was trying to be strong and had her hand on Adora's shoulder. Adora's face contorted in fear. She remembered their promise. The very same promise she had told Bow and Glimmer about at the Heart.

You look out for me and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.

I promised her a long time ago that I'd look out for her. It's time I made good on that.

She clenched her fists and turned away. She heard their gasps. She squeezed her eyes shut.

"Catra." Adora's voice broke.

"Sparkles." She spoke before she lost her courage.

"Yeah?" Glimmer answered softly.

Catra took a few breathes before she spoke quickly. "I'll see you in the morning for the meeting." She grabbed her bag and walked out.

"She's staying!" Glimmer yelled happily as Catra entered the hall. She heard their happy laughter.

"Catra." Bow followed her out. She stopped, waiting for him to speak. "Thank you for talking to me tonight. Thank you for being open. Can we do it again sometime?"

"Don't go getting sappy on me." Catra chuckled. "We… sure." She stalked off before she could hear a response. Melog followed on her heels as she went back to the room.

As she entered the room, she threw the bag on the floor. She took off the clothes with as much force as she could without ripping them. Serpentina wouldn't be happy if she destroyed the clothes anymore than she had tonight already. She threw them next to the bag and crawled into the bed with her undergarments leaving her shivering.

She should've changed those as well, but she didn't have the energy. Instead, she curled up into a ball with the blanket over her head. She laughed at the irony of laying in the same way she had earlier before she had tried to leave.

The door creaked open some time later. Melog nuzzled her toes, telling her it was Adora, though that much was obvious. Catra heard Adora trying to enter quietly. She listened as Adora disrobed herself and sneaked over towards the bed. She didn't move as Adora wiggled into the bed beside her. They laid back-to-back. The awkwardness between them permeated the air and crushed Catra under its weight.

Her heart broke as she heard Adora sniffle and try to quiet her crying. Catra didn't move. She didn't have the right to comfort Adora in that moment. Not when she had been the cause of the pain. Adora cried softly, shaking a little.

"I'm sorry." Adora muttered repeatedly. "I shouldn't have yelled."

"I deserved it." Catra finally spoke. She heard Adora's gasp and shift towards her. Catra didn't move. "I'm sorry for trying to leave."

"Is it something I did?" Adora sniffled. "I kept trying to talk to you. I don't know what to do…Bow said you feel responsible for my attacks. Is that true? Cause you're not." As Adora continued, Catra found it harder and harder to keep her back to her. She was trying to keep from crying herself. She wanted nothing more than to turn around and cuddle Adora like before. Catra bit her lip and clenched her fists, hoping the pain would keep her from breaking.

"Can…can we talk about this in the morning?" She finally got out. Adora hiccupped and agreed. Catra reached back and grabbed her hand before she could turn away. Adora, thankfully, understood. She moved closer and cuddled Catra from behind. Her hand, still interlaced with Catra's, rested over Catra's stomach. Catra allowed a small purr as they drifted to sleep. She was dreading the conversation in the morning but they'd figure it out.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you to all of you who have left comments and kudos. I'm working on chapter 9 now so chapter 8 will be up in a week. Sorry this is a day late, midterms called my name. I hope you all enjoyed. Feel free to leave comments. I love getting them.

The Library and Runestones

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 8: Adora

Adora had been worried since Catra's spit take and her bursting out of the room. Her leg bounced as she did everything in her to give Catra space. Clearly, she had been distracted. Adora had thought they were okay. Apart from the whole distance thing. Adora wasn't dumb. She knew something was bothering Catra. Every time she had tried in the last week to talk to her about it or find some sort of solution, Catra had cut the conversation short.

Finally, after enough time had passed, Adora excused herself from the table and went to bed. It had been an hour. That was enough time, right? It had to be. Glimmer had teased her about just wanting to see Catra, which she hadn't been wrong.

As Adora entered their room, it was dark. Moonset had come and gone but whoever got back first normally lit a candle or used the lights. Catra had been a huge fan of candle light after finding out about them a few days ago. Adora opened the door slowly.

"Catra?" She asked hopefully. She could see the sheets were tousled a little and a small lump was under them. Catra had probably gone to sleep then. That would've been the conclusion, except for the mess of the room said otherwise. Adora took in the ripped pillow on the floor, the other sitting near the wall. Catra's new cape was in the waterfall, floating along the little current. She walked to the bed and threw back the blanket, a few stray pillows laying there.

The closet door was open and one of Adora's backpacks was missing. Adora's chest constricted with panic. The magic flared, forcing air from her lungs. Her feet raced to the location of food and water that she kept in the room. Both were gone as was an extra blanket from under the bed. Catra's new boots were missing and the open window that creaked in the wind confirmed Adora's fear.

She sprinted back towards the sitting room, where Bow and Glimmer had said they were reclining for a while. Music coming from the room confirmed it. She burst through the door, the wood slamming into the wall harshly.

"Ah! Adora!" Glimmer squealed. She and Bow had been relaxing on a couch, curled up together. Bow had one of his instruments in hand.

"What's wrong?" Bow asked, seeing the panic Adora knew was written across her face.

"Catra's gone!" Adora's chest heaved. Tears threatened to leak out. "She's gone. I went back to the room and she left!" Her hands shook in front of her.

"Are you sure?" Glimmer asked, standing to comfort Adora.

"She took food, water…a blanket." Adora felt the tears start to fall. After everything, Catra was still running from her. What had she done? She thought their kiss in the woods was a sign that they were working towards fixing it again. This was why Adora wasn't allowed to want things. When she did, it was always ruined by something.

"Okay. Let's see if we can find her." Bow offered a hug. Adora took it and nodded into his shoulder. She could vaguely hear Glimmer commanding the guards to see if Catra had left the castle. It seemed like a dumb thing to do until a few moments later when a guard appeared with information.

"She left the castle a little over an hour ago." The guard informed them. "We asked her where she and her companion were going, she replied with gathering something for a meeting tomorrow."

"If Melog's with her, she could be anywhere." Bow rubbed a circle into Adora's back. She sat with her head in her hands. She needed to try thinking like Catra did.

If Catra didn't want to be found, she would've used Melog to sneak past the guards. But she didn't. Catra must not have been super set on leaving then. Or Melog refused to use their magic to help her in an attempt to stop her. Melog alerting Adora had been how she found Catra leaving after the Failsafe mission.

Where would Catra go? She had been over most of Etheria during her time in the Horde, but Adora didn't think Catra would go anywhere other than the Fright Zone. That was the only one she would know enough to be able to hide but Catra had admitted to hating the Fright Zone. She wouldn't go back. Too many bad memories. Where did that leave? The Woods? Too many variables for Catra.

Catra knew her limits and would pick somewhere safe to go. She was a better strategist than Adora. She wouldn't go too far the first time. Why would she risk being seen with Melog? It didn't add up. She was smarter than that if she had wanted to sneak out.

Glimmer started a search of the castle grounds, just in case. Adora took a climb to the spire she and Catra had gone to the first morning there. Nothing, not that Adora thought she'd be there. Glimmer had some of the guards widen it to the beginning of the woods, after the first sweep turned up empty.

Adora returned to their room to see if she could find anything. Any clue to where Catra might have gone. Horde training taught them to find shelter, food, and water if separated

from their squadron. Catra had food and water covered, at least for a day or two. Long enough for her to enter another kingdom and restock. Shelter would be her concern.

The three of them moved to the War Room, seeing if they could track Melog's magic. Micah had promised to join them after a sweep of the woods. He performed a scrying spell, as he called it, but it came up empty. Glimmer tried the same as Bow typed away on the computer. Adora sat with her legs drawn up in one of the chairs, watching.

'Okay, She-Ra. Now would be a good time to help me.' She thought. 'I know we aren't really doing well but I need to find Catra. Please. I can't lose her again.' Nothing happened. The magic had flared when she had found the empty room but now it was gone. She couldn't feel anything. She groaned and put her head down into her knees.

Two more hours passed with the same results. They began reaching out to the other kingdoms to see if any of them had heard from Catra. Erelandia and Elberon both said they hadn't seen her, though they'd keep a look out. Swiftwind had done a second sweep of both cities and pathways to both with nothing to show. He even checked the road to Serpentina's for Adora's sake, no sign of Catra.

Mermista and Seahawk hadn't heard anything, though Seahawk was sad Catra wouldn't make it to the hangout tomorrow. Perfuma hadn't heard anything but said she'd see if her magic could pick up on Catra in the woods around her. Frosta's guards picked up, as she was busy but reported nothing. Not that Catra would go that far north unless she had to. She hated the cold.

Entrapta and Scorpia were the most worried, sharing that spot with Adora. Entrapta had begun typing away on her keyboard while Scorpia and Adora spoke on screen.

"Did something happen? Oh, Wildcat, where did you go?"

"I don't know. She left dinner after Melog said something to her. When I returned to the room awhile later, she was gone. I should've followed her out."

"She's always liked high places, right? She always used to go to the high points in the Fright Zone to think."

"We checked those spots first." Adora sighed. "Swifty's done a few rounds. Glimmer's done two castle sweeps. We can't trace any of Melog's magic. We haven't detected any changes in the Woods to show where they might be."

"It'll be okay." Scorpia tried for a smile. "We'll send an alert to those in the Fright Zone, if any of them see her, I'll have them send a message. And we'll keep a lookout if she comes to Dryl."

"Melog's magic should be traceable." Entrapta chimed in from the back. "Give me time to see if I can find it. We'll call back with results!" The call ended, Adora feeling as lost as ever.

Her next call, she didn't expect anything from it but it wouldn't hurt. Lance answered the call.

"Adora? Is everything okay? It's awfully late."

"Catra's gone. We're just checking places. Have you seen any sign of her?" George joined Lance on screen as Adora spoke.

"We haven't heard anything. There's been no disturbances here." George answered with a sympathetic look in his eye.

"I figured as much. I thought it wouldn't hurt to check." Adora deflated. She was running out of places to check.

"We'll keep an eye out!" Lance offered. "Let us know if you find anything."

"Of course. Thank you." She ended the call. Where else could Catra find shelter for the night?

"You know, Huntara is still close." Bow offered after a while. "She's pretty good at tracking. We could ask if she'd help us find Catra."

"I don't know. I thought Huntara returned to the Crimson Waste after the party last week."

"She came back for something. She didn't say why, you know Huntara." Glimmer shrugged with a smile.

"Yeah."

"Hey, we'll find her." Bow tried to comfort her again. She was getting sick of hearing it. It brought her no closer to find Catra. They were working it out but she could only do so much. Adora nodded numbly and moved to the table to help. It had been 4 hours since Catra had left dinner AND left the castle. Hope was beginning to wane.

Suddenly, Catra burst through the door with Melog in tow. She was covered in leaves and a small twig stuck upright from her hair.

"Catra!" Adora rushed forward to see her. Thank the stars above, she was alive! The fear that something had happened to her like on Prime's ship had been gnawing at Adora the entire time. Catra was clearly out of breath and Adora snapped for a water from Bow. Adora removed the twig as Catra gulped the water and handed it to Melog.

Micah joined them as Catra recounted her encounter with Madam Razz. The only place Adora hadn't checked. Adora felt so stupid. She and Swiftwind should've gone to check there. They could've found her hours ago!

Adora, anger and hurt over the last few hours building in her chest, yelled at Catra for bad talking Madam Razz. Madam

Razz who had helped Adora when she was first She-Ra. Who was the reason Adora was able to find her way through the Portal. Who helped them find the truth about Mara and the Heart of Etheria. As soon as the words left her mouth, she clasped her hands over her mouth. She hadn't meant to yell.

The damage was done. She saw the look in Catra's eyes. Catra ran out of the room, despite Adora's attempt to stop her. Adora sprinted after her. She wasn't leaving again. She couldn't leave. Adora needed Catra. She wanted her with every bone in her body. The magic flared in response with her desire to see Catra and talk with her. Her blood boiled under her skin, the scream fighting to be released.

She turned the corner, chest heaving. Catra was on the ground, soaked in water with shards of broken pottery and plants over and around her. Bow was kneeling at her side.

"Glimmer." He ordered. Glimmer teleported the two of them back to the War Room.

"GLIMMER!" Adora cried in disbelief. Catra was right there! Adora could've gotten to her.

"Adora, they need a minute." Glimmer held her hands out against Adora's biceps. "And we need to call the others. Let them know we found her."

"I need to talk to her." Adora looked around Glimmer at the door.

"You will. Give Bow a moment with her, okay? Remember how she was okay with him that first night? Let him talk to her. I need your help in here, okay?" Adora should've been grateful to Glimmer and Bow for helping her but all she wanted in that moment was the hold Catra and know she was safe. Adora absent-mindedly nodded and sat in one of the chairs beside Glimmer.

Glimmer began calling the others to let them know Catra was back in Bright Moon and was safe. Scorpia and Entrapta were happy, Entrapta announcing that her new program to track Melog in case this happened again was almost complete. She also told them few tremors had been picked up in the Woods near Bright Moon. Nothing had come from it but she would continue to monitor it. Great, another thing for them to worry about.

Mermista was half asleep and Seahawk congratulated them on finding her. Adora's leg bounced with energy that was pent up for too long. Frosta acknowledged their message before heading back to bed. Perfuma was glad they had found her. Adora stood after their last call to Bow's dads was over. She started for the door.

"Adora!" Glimmer drew out her name in a warning. "Not yet."

"How long am I supposed to wait, Glimmer?!" Adora snapped as she spun on her heels to look at the Queen.

"Until Bow gives us the okay."

"Yeah, cause that'll be any time soon."

"Why can't you trust us? We want to help her too." Glimmer asked, voice tinged with hurt.

"Because…" Adora huffed and looked away. "I. I do trust you but I need to know that sh-"

"She's fine, Adora."

"I'm going to see for myself."

"Adora," Micah opened the door. He had been calling off the searches and dealing with the guards after Catra's return. "Where are you going?"

"To see Catra. I need to know she's okay."

"Dad, tell her she needs to give Bow more time."

"Glimmer." Adora turned, shoulders raising in frustration. "I'm going to see her."

"Adora, I don't think that's wise."

"I'm going!" Adora tried to push past Micah, who grabbed her arm. She twisted his arm, and before she knew it, Micah had gone over her shoulder and slammed into the floor. She gasped when she realized what she had done.

"Adora!" Glimmer cried.

"I. I'm sorry." Adora backed up in panic.

"It's okay." Micah stood, his hands out in a placating fashion. "I'm alright, Adora."

"I can't do this." Adora turned and ran from the room. She didn't know what was wrong with her. She was hurting her friends out of worry and panic but all she could think about was Catra being hurt.

Glimmer and Micah caught up to her, each grabbing an arm. Adora grunted and released a sob as they held her back. The magic flared in her chest. Catra! The word echoed in her mind. Glimmer gasped as suddenly they were teleported into the room with Bow and Catra.

Catra stood and looked away. Adora's eyes saw the bandage on her arm and Bow's arms.

Adora pleaded with her when Bow silenced her with a hand. He gave Catra an ultimatum. Adora stopped breathing as Catra listened and contemplated her decision. She met eyes with Adora before turning away sharply. Adora sobbed for a moment before Catra spoke.

"Sparkles."

"Yeah."

"I'll see you in the morning for the meeting." Catra picked up her bag and rushed out. Adora froze.

"She's staying!!" Glimmer yelled happily. She hugged Adora, who should've been relieved. All Adora could think of was how close she was to losing Catra all over again. Their fight on the Velvet Glove and their moment in the Heart flashed behind her eyes.

"Bow," Glimmer's question forced Adora to look over. Glimmer was looking over the bandages that wrapped their way up Bow's arms to his biceps as he reentered the room.

"I'm alright. Catra got me a little."

"A little?" Glimmer asked. Adora could tell it hurt. She remembered the feeling of Catra's claws digging into her back and dragging down.

"I'm okay. I let her do it." Bow offered a smile. "I wanted her to see that no matter what damage she did, we'd still accept her."

"That's a stupid way to show it." Glimmer playfully punched his stomach. Bow chuckled.

"Catra's really hurting right now. I think adjusting to life here is going worse than we thought it would."

"She was doing really well over the past week." Glimmer said. She stared at her hands. "I've gotten so much done with her help."

"That's what I told her."

"You know." Micah chimed in. "As someone who was also raised by Shadow Weaver, it takes time to heal from that." He

placed a hand on Adora's shoulder. She met his eyes, sparkling with kindness.

"She doesn't think she deserves anything nice. She doesn't think high of herself. She blames herself for Adora's magic attacks."

"Her demeanor during our fights said otherwise about her self-esteem." Glimmer teased.

"Yeah, but so did yours." Bow offered, Glimmer grumbling about a soft spot.

"Adora." Micah asked. "Are you alright?" Adora nodded numbly. She felt exhaustion pulling on her bones. The magic had faded after they entered and between the magic and the long day and worry, she was mentally done.

"Wait, we do need to talk about that!" Glimmer pointed a finger at her. "How did you do that?!"

"Do what?" Bow looked between the two.

"She…I don't know how to describe it." Glimmer stared at her hands before looking back to Adora. "It's like she used my magic. It felt the same as when the Heart activated." Adora's eyes widened.

"You mean, you didn't teleport you three in?"

"No. We were still near the War Room."

Micah mused. "Adora, do you remember what happened?"

Adora mumbled. "I know I felt She-Ra for a second and then we were here."

"Perhaps the magic responded." Micah looked between the two. "If Adora's desire to see Catra was strong enough,

perhaps it overrode Glimmer and forced the usage of her magic."

"But since when could She-Ra do that?"

"There are many things that She-Ra could do and we wouldn't know." Micah reminded his daughter. "There hasn't been a She-Ra in a thousand years. And this situation with the Heart, we didn't know the Heart existed until recently."

"I'm going to bed." Adora sighed. "We'll talk about it in the morning."

"Hey." Bow jogged to stop her before she left. He pulled her into a hug, which she nuzzled her had into his shoulder for a moment. "We got this. No matter what, Best Friend Squad." She nodded numbly as she felt Glimmer and Micah join their hug. She offered them a smile as she walked out and made her way to their room.

As she entered, she saw Melog at the foot of the bed. Catra was clearly curled under the blanket. Melog nudged where her feet where as Adora quietly entered the room. She shut the door before staring at the blanket for a moment. Catra didn't move. Adora was almost scared she was gone again but Melog being here meant Catra was as well.

Adora peeled off her clothes and laid them on the floor near Catra's. She quickly straightened Catra's clothes into a matching neat pile before creeping over the bed. She wiggled in next to Catra, their backs touching. Feeling Catra physically there broke her wall. The last little bit of self control Adora had was gone as she broke. Today had been a lot to handle. She sniffled hard, trying not to get her snotty nose over the sheets.

Catra asked to speak in the morning, which Adora could respect. Joy filled her as Catra's hand laced with hers and pulled her close. She curled herself around Catra's small frame, their hands against her stomach. Adora could wait till the morning and then they'd talk. There was a lot to say.

"I love you." Adora muttered as she fell into the darkness that was her mind.

"Goodbye, my oldest enemy." Horde Prime's voice echoed in her mind. The Heart beat over head in a pulsating rhythm that matched her own heartbeat. She could feel Catra's arms around her as the virus and magic tore its way through her body. Her blood burned. Her arms and legs went numb. She prayed that this would end quickly. This time, the vision didn't come. Catra's embrace faded slowly. Her voice softened as a ringing started in her ears.

"Catra." Adora breathed out. The Failsafe pulsed in time with the Heart of Etheria as her own faded to soft nothingness. She was alone in the dark. She laid there in the darkness, feeling its cold embrace wrap around her. Her eyes opened once more to see Catra sobbing over her body. She saw the Heart rampaging, the failsafe failing to stop it. Her sacrifice in vain. Mara's sacrifice in vain.

She saw Catra as lighting struck her body, crying out in pain. She shook her head and clutched Adora's body closer. The Heart surged and green light filled the room and all its crevices. Etheria exploded.

Adora was left in the darkness. Everything she loved was gone. She stared into the emptiness with a numbness that echoed.

"You were meant to survive." Mara appeared beside her.

"Mara?!" Adora gasped. She struggled to move or speak aloud but nothing happened. Mara continued to speak, facing outward as if Adora wasn't even there.

"The Heart was supposed to kill the user but that's why we created the Failsafe. My squadron gave their lives to make

sure there was a way to stop it. The virus impacted you but you and your partner preserved. You survived." Mara finally turned to look at Adora. "You weren't meant to die, Adora. You were never meant to. Your life is as precious as the others."

Adora felt a tear streak down her cheek. "My friends…"

"Wouldn't have survived without you." Mara motioned to the emptiness that had been Etheria. "No one would've. You saved them. You and you partner are the reason everyone lived. Don't discount yourself, Adora."

"Mara. I don't understand. How are we talking?"

"There's not enough time to explain that. It's taking too much to be here now." Mara's expression changed for a moment to a pained one before she smiled again. "Your partner, Catra, found the next piece for you. But you need to make peace before you can go on. If you don't, you won't survive the next step." Mara took her hands and squeezed. "Make peace with your survival. Your loss of a mother figure. Your relationships. You can't worry about this anymore. You have what you need."

"I have made peace with those."

"Not yet. Your partner and you are not at peace with one another. You will need her. And she will need you. You must make peace with yourselves." The world around them began to lighten. Adora clenched her eyes shut before opening them. She gasped as Etheria stood before them again. "Life will prosper. You will face many challenges but you will overcome them with your partner and friends. You can do this but you can't do it alone." Mara faded as light overcame Adora.

Adora blinked her eyes slowly, light streaming in from the window. She rolled over to get away and realized the space was empty. She sat up quickly and checked the room.

" Hey Adora?" Catra asked from the window sill. Her leg hung out the side as she held a small journal in hand. She raised her eyebrows and glanced over Adora. She realized her undergarments were soaked in sweat.

"You're up early?" Adora gulped as she stood. She wiped at her face as she felt a single tear track on her cheek.

"Meh. Kinda hard to sleep after last night." Catra looked out the window in silence after.

"Yeah." Adora waited a moment. Mara's challenge of making peace with Catra hung over her head. "I'm sorry."

"For what?" Catra laughed bitterly. "I'm the one who caused issues yesterday."

"I should've been doing more." Adora put a hand to her forehead. "I'm supposed to protect you and help you and I haven't been doing any of that. It's been a week after everything and…"

"Adora?" Catra looked back, the moonlight framing her like an angel.

"Yeah?" She answered, half dumbstruck with how beautiful Catra looked in that moment.

"Shut up." Adora's expression soured, Catra laughing at her. She jumped down from the window and walked over to touch her forehead to Adora's. "I'm sorry." She closed her eyes, missing Adora's shocked expression. "I've been pulling away all this past week…I'm scared that I'm the reason for the attacks." Catra spoke quickly, as if she had to get it out before she would be mute.

"You're not and we both know that. Why do you keep running from me?" Adora touched her cheek. Catra leaned into the embrace a little, a small purr vibrating through her. Catra sighed heavily before pulling away. Adora knew the hurt showed on her face as Catra sat on the bed.

"This past week, you haven't had any attacks, right?"

"Right…"

"Because I've stayed away from you…" Catra's hands closed into fists as they rested on her knees.

"I mean, you also ordered me to not do anything. Nothing." Adora made motions with her hands as she spoke, drawing a small chuckle from Catra. "Zilch. I can't even go to the gardens alone!"

"Sorry?" Catra gave her a small smile that made Adora's heart melt.

"What did you and Bow talk about last night?" Catra sighed, the smile fading. Adora almost regretting asking.

"He asked why I don't think I'm able to live here and about Shadow Weaver…He said Glimmer loves having me as her Strategist." Catra flopped back onto the bed.

"But she does." Adora prompted.

"Well, she shouldn't." Catra said curtly.

"Can we make a deal?" Adora asked, changing the topic before she lost momentum.

"What?" Catra's head popped up to look at Adora.

"We agree to try talk things out? Or at least agree to telling the other if we're upset?"

"You, open about feelings?" Catra hopped up and gripped the sides of Adora's head. "Did you hit your head again? Does the dumb hair poof do anything?"

"Catra." Adora laughed her name. "I'm serious." She clasped Catra's hands. Part of her did it because she wanted to

know Catra was here and not like the hologram she saw before the Heart. “And if we can’t talk to each other, we’ll talk to someone else?”

“That’s so much work!” Catra groaned with a smile. “I suppose it’s doable.” Adora giggled for a moment.

“I’m sorry for yelling last night. I was really angry, hurt, and tired and I should’ve have yelled.” Adora had to think of her words. She had been talking with others about getting better with expressing emotions. She felt rather proud of herself for naming a few she felt covered it.

“I’m sorry for leaving again.” Catra sighed. “I was… overwhelmed and upset.”

“No more running away?” She held out her pinky.

“What’s that?” Catra’s eyes flitted between Adora’s face and pinky.

“It’s a pinky promise.” Adora giggled. “Bow told me about them. It’s a very serious vow that you take to the death.”

“Yeah, I’m pretty sure it’s not that serious.”

“No more running away?” Adora repeated, trying to keep a straight face. Catra snorted and rolled her eyes.

“No more self-sacrificing?” Catra raised her one, holding her pinky out.

“Catra?!” Adora gasped. Catra raised her eyebrows in a challenge. Adora pouted a sigh and took Catra’s pinky in hers “I’ll try.”

“Then I’ll try not leaving.” They shared a moment with fingers laced and foreheads touching. The morning moonlight warmed their skin as they relaxed into the other’s embrace. “One more thing.” Catra spoke after a moment.

"What?"

"You have to stop thinking like that." Catra pulled back long enough to poke Adora's forehead, like she always did.

"Like what?"

"That you have to protect me. If this…" Catra's cheeks flushed and she took a breath. "If this girlfriend thing is going to work, then you have to see me as your equal. You can't blame yourself for my actions and you have to stop feeling responsible for me."

"DID YOU JUST CALL US GIRLFRIENDS?!" Adora gasped, her free hand covering her mouth.

"That's what you took away from that?!" Catra snapped, her face falling into the palm of her hand.

"I heard the rest but…" Adora giggled. "Are…are we officially…you know…"

"Girlfriends?" Catra rubbed the back of her neck before meeting Adora's eyes for a fleeting second. "Yeah."

Adora laughed brazenly and pulled Catra in for a kiss. Catra yelped before huffing and embracing the kiss.

"Oh, I wanted to say this. One of the books I tried reading this week talked about it." Adora said proudly. Catra's eyes fluttered shut before she looked at Adora. "You have standing consent," Adora worded carefully to make sure it was right, "to kiss me whenever you want." She smiled, proud at herself for remembering it all.

Catra guffawed, despite the loving look in her eyes. "Okay." She paused for a moment. "I guess I'm okay with it being the same."

"Really?"

"Why do you look so surprised!?"

"I just wasn't expecting to hear it back."

"Wow, thanks for the vote of confidence, Adora." Catra shoved her to the side. Adora giggled as she went to push Catra back, who side stepped her. Adora flopped onto the floor with a thud, laughter filling the air. "Now are you going to get dressed? We have a busy day today and I'm sure Bow and Glimmer are waiting for us."

A whole month passed with the same routines. Adora was still under strict orders from Catra, though some had loosened. Guards still followed her everywhere but she was allowed to go anywhere and do most everything again. She-Ra was still off-limits. Adora still practiced in secret in little moments when she could, not that she could tell the others about it. A few people had begun to talk of rumors of She-Ra begin injured, though Glimmer handled them quickly.

Catra and Adora had spent some of their time working with people Perfuma called Therapists. Catra had been right about that word, which she held over Adora's head for weeks. Perfuma had been establishing something called a Therapy Center in Thaymor to help people after the war. Once a week, Catra and Adora made their way to Thaymor to meet with someone and talk about everything. Adora wasn't sure how she felt about it. The person she spoke with named Lukkia was nice but it was awkward. She preferred to punch her feelings out but that wasn't healthy, according to others.

Otherwise, she had spent most of the time at the Library with Bow and his dad's. They had been cataloging their works with Adora's help while also looking for any information on the Heart. After meetings were done everyday, Glimmer and Catra would join them. Catra picked up reading about She-Ra quickly.

After three weeks in the library, she was able to read almost everything in the library without help from Adora.

"You can already read First One's writing?" George asked her one day. She laughed and responded with:

"When your life depends on being smarter than everyone else, you pick up things quickly."

Most of the time when Catra was there, she read scrolls or books on one of the couches. She took notes as she read through them, making notes of everything she did and didn't understand. Sometimes, Glimmer or Bow would sit with her and work through some of it. Catra would also call over Adora, George, or Lance as needed to help her with a word or phrase.

Adora never realized how fancy First One's Writing was until Catra mentioned how annoying it could be. She was happy Catra had something to focus on and still be part of the group. Nothing made her happier than seeing her be able to interact with everyone without worry of the past in the way. She often found herself sitting with Catra and just admiring her working through the information.

Another few weeks passed, marking two months after the end of the War. After a hectic morning, Adora and Catra were sitting the living room of the library. George and Lance were at the nearby table. Glimmer and Bow had been called to check on a situation in Elberon quickly. The rest of the Alliance was on their way for lunch at the Library. Adora was excited to see them all again after two months apart. She wanted to hear how repairs were going in the other kingdoms when Catra's voice broke her from her thoughts.

"There's nothing in here about the Heart of Etheria!" Catra proclaimed in frustration. She set a book down and leaned back against the couch. She groaned loudly as she ran her hands over her face into her hair.

"We only found out about the Failsafe with the new ruin we had found before Prime arrived." Lance reminded them. "Even then, with how some of our information was mislabeled, there wasn't any information before that. The Heart was a secretive project, I suppose."

"Of course it was." Catra held her hand out, flexing her fingers. "They couldn't have told the Princesses about it. They wouldn't have gone along if they had known the true intentions of the Heart." She paused.

"Catra?" Adora cocked her head.

"The Moonstone is your key." She muttered to herself. Catra's eyes flickered around the scrolls, papers, and books that laid in front of them on the table.

"What does that mean?" George stood and joined them, Lance following. "We've never heard that."

"It's something Madam Razz said." Catra stood, tapping her nails on her cheeks. She walked towards one of the other exhibits. Adora shared a shrug with Lance and followed. "When I spoke to her, she was cryptic. I didn't understand most of it but maybe…"

"We'd love it if you'd explain?" Lance tried. Catra began searching for something through the different books laid out in front of her.

"Hey guys!" Bow and Glimmer announced their return. "We brought snacks from Elberon." Glimmer's cape had been turned around, holding gifts and food. That was Elberon for you. They loved their gifts and parties.

"Hi Bow!" Lance embraced his son in a hug. "Glimmer."

"What's going on?" Glimmer nodded towards Catra, who was still muttering as she searched for something. Glimmer

set the items in her cape down on the table Lance and George had been using a moment previous and refitted her cape.

"We're not sure." George answered. Lance left the room for a moment to finish the food for lunch. Before anyone could speak, the rest of the Princesses arrived.

"Hi!" Adora grinned as she hugged everyone. Perfuma was happy to see her, even though they had talked briefly during her therapy session with Lukkia a few days ago. Mermista and Seahawk were their usual selves. Frosta was telling a story about an Ice Ball tournament they held in the Kingdom of Snows to cheer everyone up. Scorpia and Entrapta were the last in, the two talking about a project they were working on in the Fright Zone.

"Entrapta!" Catra snapped, hushing conversation. Entrapta had jumped a little before using her hair to cross above the crowd. She joined Catra at the table, where Catra whispered something.

"I see she hasn't really changed." Mermista remarked.

"She's doing a lot better, actually." Perfuma offered. "At least that's what her therapist said. It seems Markio was a good fit for her. She only broke one thing this last session! That's improvement." Adora held back her laughter. She knew about Catra's reputation at the Center. "Which reminds me, Mermista, you missed your session last week." Frosta giggled as Mermista paled. The conversation continued, Mermista stammering out an excuse.

Adora glanced back to where Catra and Entrapta spoke quietly. She wanted to go over but something was telling her not to.

"Scorpia!" Catra beckoned. Perfuma gave her a smile before patting her pincer and sending her over. Scorpia hugged Entrapta and Catra, making Adora giggle. Catra was at least a little more accepting of Scorpia's hugs.

"Adora." Glimmer called her over to talk to her and Bow. Adora joined them with a smile. "Is Catra okay?"

"I think so." Adora glanced back as Scorpia laughed boisterously. "It looked like she had found something before everyone arrived, but I don't know."

"My dads said food will be ready in a moment. Wanna help us get ready?" Bow asked.

"Sure." The three took to setting up a giant blanket in the middle of the room. The other Princesses caught on and began helping them set up or bring food out. Catra, Scorpia, and Entrapta stayed to the side, Catra shushing Scorpia several times. Adora felt her anxiety building. What were they talking about? Catra kept pointing to a scroll and an open book in front of them as she talked to Entrapta. Entrapta's hair motioned around in the air as they spoke, though it didn't give Adora any idea to what they were discussing.

"Food!" Lance announced loudly as he brought in the last dish. Everyone had taken their seats, except the three in the corner.

"You three should hurry up," Seahawk called in a mischievous tone. "We might eat everything before you get here."

"Sparkles." Catra called her over. Glimmer and Adora shared a look. Whatever this was, it wasn't good. Glimmer teleported over, joining the circle. Catra spoke before Glimmer yelled a "What?!" Catra covered her mouth, glancing over at Adora. She glared at Glimmer and hissed something quietly. Glimmer nodded and her mouth was uncovered. Glimmer looked between the three of them. Scorpia stood their awkwardly, rubbing the back of her neck. Entrapta sat on a coil of her hair, clearly explaining something.

Catra hugged herself and shot concerned looks between Glimmer and Adora. She grabbed a scroll and held it

close.

"Everything okay?" George asked. Everyone was waiting on them. Glimmer and Catra shared a final look. The four finally joined them on the floor, Catra taking her seat next to Adora. Glimmer sat next to her with Bow on her left. Scorpia plopped down by Perfuma and Entrapta was her left.

"Catra…" Glimmer started before sighing. "Catra found something. I'm going to let the group decide." Glimmer made eye contact with everyone before continuing. "Do you want to hear it now while we eat or do you want to talk after?"

"I say now," Adora chimed in.

"As bad as it seems, it should be now." Perfuma agreed. "I don't think any of us will be able to focus until we know."

"Whatever is it, we'll handle it." Seahawk looked at Mermista, who smiled before turning away with a groan.

"What did the Horde Scum find?" Frosta shot her a grin as she took a bite of food. Catra scrunched her nose at Frosta as she finished her drink.

"We've been spending the last several weeks here in the Library." Catra started. She looked down as she spread out the scroll she held earlier. "We have been looking for any information on the Heart and how Adora's connected to it."

"Right, you guys sent a letter talking about that a month ago." Mermista commented. "How Adora's still connected to the Heart and it's affecting She-Ra."

"Yes." Catra took a deep breath. Adora put her hand on Catra's back, leading to them sharing a small smile before Catra continued. "Adora informed me on how Light Hope explained the Heart and its connections. We also spoke to Madam

Razz a while ago and she said the Moonstone was our key, along with several other cryptic things."

"What does the Moonstone have to do with this?" George asked as he took a bite of his sandwich.

"That's what I've been looking into." Catra motioned to the scroll. "According to this, the Moonstone is the oldest of the Runestones on Etheria. That's the reason Bright Moon stands as the capital of Etheria, right?"

"Yeah, Angella led it for the longest of time." Lance took George's hand. Bow wrapped an arm around Glimmer's shoulders protectively. She gave him a grateful look.

"The way the Heart is powered is via the Runestones. The Runestones and their Princesses," Catra motioned to the room. "are the conduits and She-Ra's magic is the key to powering and deploying the Heart's magic."

"We all know this, Catra." Mermista waved her hand as a get-on-with-it motion. "What's so important about it?"

"Madam Razz said Adora had to free the magic. We thought she had done that with the Failsafe but it didn't work entirely. It stopped the Heart from deploying, but it's still collecting magic and Adora's now connected to it in a dangerous matter."

"A while ago, Adora accidently used my magic." Glimmer's hand sat on her chest. "She didn't mean to, but the magic overwhelmed me and used my teleport."

"That's weird." Frosta shivered. "Is that something you can do now, Adora?"

"We don't know." Bow answered for her, thankfully. "It's only happened once. Nothing's happened for almost two months now."

"That was the same night that you called about Catra?" Entrapta asked, typing away on her Trackerpad.

"Yeah, why?" Bow asked. The two of them shared a look before Entrapta spoke again.

"Adora, did something else happen that night? Any other magic usage?" Adora looked at Catra and the others.

"I…" She remembered entering their room and the panic seeing Catra was gone. The magic had flared as she ran for Glimmer and Bow. "Yeah, for a moment."

Entrapta asked for clarification with the timing before continuing in silence.

"What about it?" Scorpia glanced between them.

"That was the same time we recorded those tremors in the Whispering Woods." Entrapta showed her Trackerpad. "It's happened a few times since, that one being the first. I've been watching it. Though the tremors are far enough away to not cause any real damage. It does correspond with the time Adora said she felt a flare up."

"Adora hasn't had any attacks since then?" Catra questioned.

Adora bit her tongue to keep from saying anything. The truth was, she'd had a few more attacks. Minor ones if she got too emotional over something or put too much effort in training She-Ra in secret. She had seen how her friends had reacted last time and couldn't bring herself to say anything. If she told them, she knew it would add stress to them as is. She wasn't worth the effort. Not that she was worth the effort they were putting in now to figure out the Heart now. The more she worked on controlling She-Ra with this situation the better she was at calming the attacks. She hated not being able to tell them and she didn't like lying to anyone.

"I'm not sure." Entrapta stuck out her tongue as she typed away. "Though, if it happened again and Glimmer was there. It's possible the magic used her instead versus pouring back into the ground and causing a rupture. The others could've been left over magic from the Heart's events two months ago."

"Catra, finish what you were saying." George brought them back.

"Right." Catra took a steadying breath. "I found this scroll that talks about the Moonstone being established along with the others, and life on Etheria around that time."

"You can read that?" Frosta asked. "I thought Adora was the only one who could."

"I learned how to a while ago, keep up." Catra moved the scroll, earning a scoff from Frosta for the dismissal. "Shadow Weaver mentioned this on their way to Mystacor for the Failsafe. The magic had been freed before and the Failsafe would free it all again, or that was the thought. But the Runestones are still here."

"Wait, are you saying the Runestones are harmful?" Perfuma spoke up. Adora grimaced.

"The reason Adora couldn't use the Heart before was because Scorpia wasn't connected to the Garnet. All five Princesses have to be connected for the Heart to be able to draw its magic and be deployed. The Runestones are still collected magic, the Heart is still active."

"Catra." Scorpia asked. "I don't know if this is going to work though."

"That's why I called you over." Catra pinched her nose. "You two were there when we did this last time. You two will know what I'm talking about."

"What are you thinking?" Bow's voice cracked. Adora's nerves coursed with electricity as she listened to Catra's next

statement.

"We have to destroy the Runestones." Catra stared at the paper. "And the Moonstone has to the first to go."

Adora felt the air leave her lungs as if something had sucked her dry. The ringing grew in her ears as the Princesses argued about Catra's controversial statement. No. No. No. She knew what was going to happen. Deep Breaths. She had to remain calm. It had worked the last few times, she could calm it again.

"We can't destroy them!"

"How else we will use our Magic to defend ourselves?"

"We're in the wider universe now! We'll have enemies!"
"

"Catra, you can't possibly think this is a good idea!"

"Hey!" Adora stood, heart pounding. Her lungs ached for air, despite her quickened breathing. She could feel the Heart responding to her. She closed her eyes, trying to quiet it. She wasn't going to have an attack right now. The Princesses went quiet for a second, all eyes on her. "Catra's right. It makes sense."

"Adora, did you not hear anything we just say?"

"We can't do that. We'll be defenseless if something like Horde Prime comes."

"And if we don't, we are risking Adora's life."

"There has to be a different solution."

"Just stop! Enough!" Adora shouted, her hands flying to her temples. The ringing grew to deafening and her head throbbed. She gasped and bent over. No. Not now. She closed her eyes trying to calm it.

She heard her name and a scream. The ringing grew then waned. Something clattered to the floor and the magic ceased. Adora's eyes opened slowly though she couldn't hear much still. She felt like she had been hit by one of the bombing bots from the Horde. She realized the people around her had stood or moved.

"Catra!" Glimmer's voice was the first to return. "Catra, hold on." Adora turned, though she felt like she was moving against time itself. Her eyes widened in horror as she realized what happened.

One of the bookcases had collapsed, the only thing able to be seen under it was Catra's arm sticking out. Bow, Scorpia and Seahawk were struggling to lift it. Glimmer and Perfuma were at the bottom, trying to pull Catra out. Entrapta was standing near Adora, her hair hovering close.

"Adora, what did you do?!" A voice demanded in horror. She couldn't breathe. She had hurt Catra. She realized the voice she'd heard and the scream were Catra's. Catra who reached out to help her. Who had risked herself to help Adora.

The world rang once more as the corners of her vision darkened.

"Adora!" Glimmer's voice called out to her as she fell into the black, something thick wrapping around her body before she hit the floor.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry I'm a little late. It's been a long week. I'm thinking this will be somewhere between 15 to 20 chapters. I'm not sure yet. I hope you enjoyed. Feel free to comment. And thank you for all the kudos! :)

Important Talks and a Found Diary

Chapter Notes

> I'm going to try and leave this formatted to the left vs center. Let me know if you guys like it either way? Depending on if anyone says anything, I'll change the format back at a later date.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 9: Catra

Adora. She was hurt. She needed her. She needed Catra. The last thing Catra remembered was reaching out to her as Adora bent over, the magic radiating golden streams of light from her body. She remembered a scream tearing from her throat as she hit the bookshelf. Pain pulsated through her as it toppled with her, crushing her under its heavy weight and the books. She couldn’t move. Something metallic and heavy was crushing her leg.

Voices outside were calling her name. The bookshelf shifted back and forth, anguish filling her bones. She could feel something pulling her forward. She felt trapped in this darkness, pain radiating in her left leg as she was pulled on. She laid, body unmoving despite her willing it to.

“Adora!” one of the voices called in a panic. She heard another clamor but couldn’t bring herself to open her eyes. They wouldn’t move. She sunk into the blackness that was unconsciousness.

Catra woke a time later, a clock being the first thing she saw. Two hours. The pain in her leg was sharp and concentrated. She realized she was in someone's lap. As her eyes fluttered open, light flowed over her. Scorpia's face came into view.

"Catra!" She shouted, Catra's ears folding down. The sound sent shooting pains through her skull. "Sorry." Scorpia tried to whisper.

"Catra." Glimmer's voice was the next she heard. Catra looked to the side, where Glimmer was sitting. Adora's head was on her lap, a pained expression carved into her features. "Are you okay?"

"What…" Catra tried to push herself out of Scorpia's lap, hands gripping her pincer. "What happened?" As she put her feet under her, the pain in her leg told her she wasn't standing any time soon. She gasped as the pain sent her back into Scorpia's lap with a hiss. She looked to her left leg, which had been splinted like they had taught in the Horde.

"It was the best we could do." Perfuma remarked as she touched up the plants that had been used as rope to hold her leg straight. "Scorpia had to walk us through how to set it."

"Is Adora okay?" Catra asked, ignoring the state of her leg. She had dealt with worse. She was focused on the blonde idiot laying in Glimmer's lap. She wasn't glowing anymore, but it reminded Catra of the Heart. How still Adora's body was. She couldn't lose her again. They hadn't even had a fight or anything in almost two months.

"We don't know." Glimmer grimaced. "She collapsed shortly after you did. Entrapta caught her so she didn't hit her head." Entrapta was sitting on her hair behind Glimmer, legs crossed as she typed into her Trackerpad in silence.

"That was the first in two months." Bow stood, looking over Entrapta's shoulder. "I guess we should be happy it wasn't worse."

"Worse?!" Catra snapped. "Adora's unconscious and clearly hurt!"

"Hey, it's okay. We're working on it." Scorpia tried to calm her.

"It's not okay!" Catra slumped down and covered her eyes. She wasn't going to be emotional right now. She needed to think.

"Entrapta's monitoring her magic levels right now. Give us a minute to see if we can find something." Bow tried to offer.

"Catra. If you're upset, let's talk about it." Perfuma offered. "It doesn't do any good to hold it in."

"There's nothing to say." Catra said bluntly. Adora was her concern right now.

"Holding it in like that is what leads to things like you did in the Horde." Perfuma spoke, slight venom to her voice. Catra flashed back to their first encounter after she joined them. Perfuma reminding her of her treatment of Scorpia. Guilt gripped her heart in a death hold. She bit her lip to refrain from speaking because she had a few choice words for Perfuma.

"Don't do that." Scorpia reprimanded Perfuma. Scorpia stood, jerking Catra a little. "I'll be back." Catra protested as Scorpia took her from the room, she could feel their stares on them. She looked up to Scorpia and saw the same look of determination she'd had during their retreat from the Northern Reach. Catra knew not to fight it. And with her leg, she didn't stand a chance.

Scorpia took her outside the Library. Melog joined them in a shimmer of light and a mew. Scorpia sat Catra on the

steps before sitting beside her. Catra stared out at the Woods around them, glimmering as if all was right with the world. A few Woodland creatures came out to look at them, magic shimmering around them.

"I'm sorry." Scorpia spoke first. "I should've asked if you wanted to leave."

"It's fine." Catra dismissed.

"No." Scorpia said, drawing surprise into Catra's face. "Perfuma and I have been working on boundaries. I should've asked." She nodded to herself. "And I'm sorry for…I'm sorry for how our friendship went in the Horde."

"Scorpia." Catra reached out a hand. She had been meaning to have this discussion. She wished it was a better time. Her attention was mainly with Adora but she needed to talk to Scorpia about what had happened.

She paused and redrew her hand. "I'm sorry." She said after taking a breath. She had been talking with her therapist, Markio about a moment like this. They had rehearsed how to do this so many times, Catra could say it in her sleep. But she also wanted it to be truthful. "The way I treated you in the Horde, especially towards the end, was unacceptable. You were trying to be my friend the entire time and I kept pushing you away."

"I…"

"Please, let me finish?" Catra asked. Scorpia nodded with a small smile and sat in silence. "I…I was really hurt and that doesn't excuse what I said or did. I'm working to fix it. And…what I'm asking is…Can you forgive me?"

"Already done."

"Not like that." Catra sighed heavily. Scorpia cocked her head. "I don't want you to forgive me right away. You have every right to be angry with me. And if you need time, then you

have all you need. I just…please know that I'm sorry." Catra bowed her head a little.

"Wow, Markio really helped you write all that out, didn't they?" Scorpia laughed. Catra sat up straight and stared at her with widened eyes.

"How did-?" Her eyes narrowed. "I thought everything said there was confidential."

"It is!" Scorpia looked out into the woods with a sorrowful type look in her eyes. "It's nice. Being able to talk about everything and work it out. My therapist, Rain, helped me write a similar one." Scorpia pulled a piece of paper from her pocket. "We've both been so busy and the time hasn't been right. I've been meaning to talk to you for a while."

Catra skimmed through the paper. Words like: Forgiveness, Help, Wanting, Boundaries stood out to her. She chuckled dryly as she released the paper. As Scorpia folded it and placed it back in her pocket, Catra pulled out hers. She handed it to Scorpia with a small blush. Not even Adora had read what she had written.

"Markio did really write it." She admitted, twisting a piece of hair by her ear. "Or as they said, helped me write out my 'feelings'." Scorpia laughed.

"I still accept it, under one condition."

"Don't really think I can refuse."

"You forgive me as well and we start again as friends?"

"Yeah, I'd like that." They sat there in a peaceful silence for a moment. "Can I say, our therapists write the worst scripts?"

"They really do." Scorpia's boisterous laugh echoed in the woods. Catra's head throbbed, but she could deal. "That

sounded nothing like you."

"Yeah, that's what I said." Catra cackled herself, momentarily forgetting about the headache. "I asked them to at least let me add an insult and they said it wasn't very forgiving like or whatever that means."

"I know what you mean, Wildcat." Scorpia offered her pincer. Catra gladly took it. "I'm…I'm supposed to tell you one more thing." She scratched the back of her neck. Catra raised her eyebrows, waiting. "So, Perfuma and I….we've been talking…."

"Yeah, and..." Catra knew what she meant but it was too much fun to play dumb in this moment. The masochistic side of her, as Markio had called it, wanted to make Scorpia say it.

"Well, we, might, be together." Scorpia leaned away with one eye closed. She blinked them open and turned back to Catra. "You're not mad?"

"I thought it would take you longer to tell me?" Catra shrugged. "I'm happy for you." And she was. Though, she was hoping to tease Scorpia more.

"Thanks, Catra. I'm happy you and Adora are together." Scorpia started to hug her but paused. Catra gave her a smile and nodded. Scorpia pulled her into a hug and squeezed tightly. She released her after a moment.

Catra laughed. "We should probably head back in." She made the mistake of trying to stand, pain shooting up her leg into her hip.

"Ah." She breathed through it as she fell back onto the steps. Scorpia panicked a little before scooping her up. Catra sighed in defeat. Until the leg healed, she was stuck. Scorpia chuckled as they walked back inside.

As they approached the main room, anxiety over Adora's condition filled Catra's mind again. Melog followed beside them with a comforting chirp and a red mane. Catra was grateful

they showed up to check on her. She briefly filled them in on what was going on. Scorpia knocked on the door with her tail, which Catra had to admit that it was cool. Lance let them back in.

Adora now laid on one of the couches, an ice pack on her forehead. The sleeves of her blue shirt were bunched up near her elbows, and her boots sat neatly on the floor. Her pants had been rolled up to her knees.

"The fever started shortly after you left the room." Bow filled them in. Scorpia, thankfully, placed Catra on the floor next to Adora. Melog curled up at her feet. She took Adora's hand and immediately understood. She was burning up. Her face was still pained. Catra knew the look all too well. Adora was having a nightmare, and the fever and magic overload weren't helping. She traced circles over Adora's hand with her claws, hoping Adora could feel it.

She noticed Scorpia going to Perfuma and what looked like apologizing. Scorpia pointed to her and laughed a little too forced. Perfuma placed her hand on Scorpia's and said something that made Scorpia blush. Perfuma summoned a flower crown on top of Scorpia's hair. They were cute together. Catra had to admit it. She really was happy Scorpia found someone who appreciated her in ways Catra couldn't.

Frosta and Seahawk were in the middle of a game of chess. Mermista was watching as referee, Catra supposed. Glimmer, Bow, and his dads stood off to the side, the only ones seemed to be worried about Adora.

She had been doing so well for the past few weeks. Catra knew what she had said earlier was upsetting. She was talking about destroying the magic that had saved the planet a few months previously. But she had been looking into it. It wouldn't destroy everything.

Catra had spoken to Micah, a fellow survivor of Shadow Weaver, and had learned what Shadow Weaver had

taught him. The magic had been reigned in, unfairly. Etherian magic wasn't meant for that. It was meant to work more like the Sorcerers of Mystacor. The Princesses should, being the key word, keep their magic after the runestones are gone. It might take time to adjust but if they didn't…

Catra wondered how many more of these attacks Adora could survive. The longer they waited, the more at risk Adora was at not waking up from a flare up of magic. The attacks were only getting worse. The first had been the worst, until now.

Entrapta had been surprised when Catra had asked her about their attempt with the Black Garnet earlier. She'd reminded Catra of that experiment's ending, though she did want to try again. Scorpia had been almost horrified when Catra suggested repeating the processes.

Glimmer had been against it entirely. She had yelled at Catra, forcing her to hush the queen. Catra very quickly reminded her of Adora's condition and time limit with the Heart. Entrapta had taken to explaining the science side of it, looking at the Runestones in a tech way versus magic.

A small whimper from Adora caught Catra's attention. She brushed a piece of Adora's hair out of her eyes. Her braid was coming undone. Just as Catra had finally gotten good at not yanking her hair, or her claws getting caught as she braided it every morning. Adora had told her a few days into their new routine that she liked it. Something the two of them could do in the morning to start their day off in a good way. On the days when Catra was too busy, Adora's hair was back in the ponytail.

"You'll have to learn how to braid it yourself." Catra chastised her one morning after falling asleep with a ponytail in. Adora yelped in pain as Catra pulled a strand into the braid.

"But I don't want to." Adora answered. "I like it being your thing." Catra blushed and quietly finished the process.

As they sat there, the library around them, Catra couldn't care less about who was there. Adora was hurt. She didn't care how cute or sappy she looked. Bow and Glimmer could tease her all they wanted.

"Come back to me." Catra whispered as she laid her head against Adora's. She leaned over and planted a peck on Adora's lips. She slumped back into her seat and sighed.

"Always." Adora whispered back. Catra gasped as she moved to her knees. Big mistake. She hissed as her leg gave her the many reasons she shouldn't have done that in the form of throbbing pain. "What's wrong?" Adora tried to sit up, Catra's hand on her chest forcing her back down.

"It's nothing. Rest." Adora gave her a wary glare but laid down. "Are you okay?"

"Sore?" She answered with a half grin. "Hot."

"You always are." Catra teased.

"No, I'm not. Most times I….Catra." Adora narrowed her eyes. Catra snickered.

"I'm glad you're feeling better." Catra tapped her arm with her nails. "What happened?"

"I don't know." Adora whispered, the fear in her voice leaking out. "I've been able to calm the last few."

"Last few?" Catra raised an eyebrow. Adora tsked at herself. Catra felt her expression sour. Adora'd had more. She hadn't said anything. "I thought you said you'd tell me if you had any more."

"They were all small so it wasn't a big deal." Adora shrugged as best as she could. "I was able to calm them before anything happened."

"How many are we talking?" Catra kept her voice down against her will. She didn't want the others knowing quite yet. Catra wouldn't be the only one angry with her and Adora didn't need the whole room against her.

"4." Adora admitted after a moment of silence. Catra stared at her. Adora was a terrible liar, how had she hidden it from them for this long? As well as, Adora had been dealing with it the entire time and hadn't said anything.

"Why didn't you say anything?"

"I'm used to dealing with it alone." Adora spoke sadly. She opened her mouth to say something but was interrupted by a loud: "ADORA!" They turned at the sound of Glimmer's voice. The queen made her way over, everyone joining her around Adora.

"How are you feeling?" George asked first.

"I'm okay." Adora sat up, giving everyone a smile. Catra knew she wasn't being a hundred percent truthful. Adora was still hiding something. She still took Adora's hand and squeezed it tight. Adora squeezed it back hard.

Markio had spoken with her about moments like this. Adora needed her support, not her anger. They could talk about it when they were alone later and figure this out. Markio had said relationships take work, just like healing. Sometimes, she would have to put herself aside to support Adora and Adora would have to do the same. Adora had been doing that for months if not years now. Catra could give up her anger for an afternoon.

"That was the first in almost two months." Bow mused. "I haven't seen one that badly since the first morning back."

"Yeah." Adora admitted, looking down. "I don't really know what happened."

"Entrapta, do you have any ideas?" Glimmer asked. The Science-loving Princess sat on a coil of her hair, like she had

been earlier. She typed away at her Trackerpad, small beeps coming from it.

"Well, it's possible that the…" Entrapta stopped, thinking of how to say it. "I'd need to run more tests." She said with finality. Catra could appreciate that Entrapta put it in terms she'd understand the first time. She made a mental note to speak with Entrapta more. It's probably benefit them both if she learned a little of Entrapta's jargon.

"The important thing is that you're okay." Lance knelt down beside Adora. George squeezed his shoulder in support, both giving loving looks to Adora. "Though, my worry is how will Catra get around for a while?" Adora's head whipped around from them to her then to her leg.

"I'm fine." Catra's hand gripped Adora's cheeks, forcing them to make eye contact. "You didn't hurt me." Catra was hoping to do this later, not in front of everyone.

"That…the bookshelf." Adora looked from the fallen shelf to her leg again. "What have I done?"

"Hey, I'm fine." Catra pulled her back to look at her. "You didn't hurt me." She knew what would be going through her mind. Adora would be blaming herself and going on some thing about not being able to want things due to her hurting the people she loved. "I'm okay."

"I hurt you." Adora's voice broke.

"No, it was an accident." Catra spoke carefully.

"Catra's right. You didn't mean to." Perfuma offered. Catra shot her a look, to which Perfuma soured.

"Don't do that." Catra tapped Adora's cheek. The distant look in Adora's eyes faded a little. "You didn't hurt me. I'm okay. This has nothing to do with you."

"Is there anyway we could heal without She-Ra?" Scorpia asked nobody.

"Not really. The healing we can do is nothing close to what She-Ra is capable of. Catra seems to heal quickly anyway so I doubt she'll be down more than a few weeks." Bow shrugged.

"Weeks?!" Adora saddened. Catra dug one of her nails into Adora's skin. "You…I'm sorry."

"It's fine." Catra insisted. "How many times have we hurt each other worse than this anyway?" She gave Adora a small smile.

Adora chuckled. "I mean, you did electrocute me during the battle of Bright Moon, several times."

"You shocked me during the portal!" Catra exclaimed with a wider grin. "And you punched me~!" She playfully put a hand on her cheek. "That hurt!"

"That hurt?" Adora's voice rose a little as she laughed. "You were hitting me and throwing me around! You clawed my back and arms all the time!" She held out her arms in emphasis. "Not to mention, how many times did you throw me off a building, when we were kids!"

"She threw you off buildings?" Mermista asked in disbelief. Catra wondered if they didn't think of Adora as her 'weaker' self but only thought of her in She-Ra strength. Younger Adora was strong physically but Catra always had the advantage in fights.

"All the time!" Adora looked back at Mermista, her voice vibrant with emotions. "She said it helped me learn how to scale buildings with her. It still hurt!"

"Yeah, well, look at what you can do now. Really, you have me to thank." Catra said smugly. Adora's lips shifted to the side as she furrowed her eyebrows.

"Oh, yes, Catra. Only because we fought and trained and hurt each other all the time am I now strong enough. Thank you."

"You're welcome." Catra stuck out her tongue briefly but a pillow smacked into the side of her head. Her leg twitched in disagreement as she fell to the side briefly, but the smile on Adora's face made her forget about it.

"You two are really close." Frosta commented slowly. Catra wondered how much they really knew about her. She didn't know that much about them so she guessed she couldn't assume Adora had spoken much about her.

"I mean yeah, growing up under Shadow Weaver does that to you." Catra answered. She paused and looked at the floor.

"Catra and I were inseparable growing up." Adora continued, almost obliviously.

"Well, Adora and Catra should both eat something and regain their strength." Lance said in a loving manner. He left the room momentarily before reappearing with two plates. He handed one to each where a sandwich along with a weird purple fruit Catra had never seen before. She sniffed it warily.

Adora, on the other hand, stuffed the fruit into her mouth and almost choked on it. Catra shook her head at the blonde idiot. That was her idiot.

"Okay well, now I wanna hear stories of what it was like growing up in the Horde." Seahawk commented. "Let's share stories of adventure!"

"I mean, most of it was pretty standard." Adora shrugged. "There was the time Octavia chased us around the buildings for a while because of Catra."

Adora proceeded to tell the story of the day Catra and Octavia fought and Adora joined her in calling Octavia a dumb

face. Catra interjected at different points, drawing laughter and smiles from most of the group.

After a while, Glimmer teleported Adora and Catra back to their room in Bright Moon. They both needed the rest and Catra's leg needed to be elevated to help with swelling. Melog curled up at the end of their bed, purring happily. Catra's leg was supported by as many pillows as Adora was able to stuff under it before Catra snapped at her.

The blonde had taken a spot at the desk, looking over old files of hers. Catra had asked her to lay down but Adora was too energized to sit still. Catra ended up laying on the bed herself, watching her dummy mutter to herself.

A knock at the door brought some action back to the moment. Adora opened the door as a few servants entered with boxes. They dropped the crates on the floor and left with a bow to Adora. Adora shot her a look of confusion. Catra motioned to open the boxes.

There were four in total, made of a mahogany wood with a dark blue A or C stamped on the side. As Adora opened the first with an A1 on the side, she picked up a small calling card.

Hello Princess Adora,

I apologize these are as late as they are. It's been a busy time. Here are the rest of the clothes as promised.

-Serpentina.

PS: There's a note for Catra to read.

Adora quickly opened Catra's and found the note. She read it aloud as she had done with the first.

Hello Royal Strategist,

I have reviewed your outfit and given you a few small updates. You may discard the first you have used since we met. That will be the only one of that style. Your new uniform lay inside as well with formals and lounge clothes should you choose to use them.

Good luck on your future endeavors. I am anxious to see your work on Bright Moon.

-Serpentina.

"How come you got a much longer letter than I did?" Adora pouted as she looked at Catra. Catra cackled and shook her head. "Can I see the new one?"

"Yeah?" Catra laughed. Adora dove into the crate, the small letters cast to the side. She pulled out a pair of pants and shirt similar to what she already wore. It took a moment for Catra to realize the difference.

The shirt had changed styles, mimicking more of the style she wore in the Horde and on Darla. The torso part of the shirt was her maroon red, the front cut exposing part of her chest. Above that was black fabric with a high neckline and black long sleeves for both arms. Catra appreciated the high hem on the neck. Golden fabric had been woven into the shoulders and marked the hems down the sleeves. The pants were black with small slits near her legs, mimicking the long leg covers and shorts she used to wear. The new belt was gold with a few holding clips for different items.

The new design seemed closer to what Catra was more comfortable with. She was glad for the change. The cape and random purple in the outfit had felt out of place, though she did like how flashy they were compared to the others.

"I like it!" Adora gushed. "We almost match entirely!" She laid out one of the matching uniforms on the floor, all the

parts on display. “What’s this?” She reached into the crate, pulling out a red dress. The skirt reached around Catra’s knees and had golden accents as Catra was noticing the pattern forming in their clothes. The dress turtlenecked and was tight until the skirt, which flowed as Adora twisted it in the air.

Adora smiled at her. Even though Catra wasn’t a fan of dresses, she could thank Serpentina. The look on Adora’s face was worth it. She made little sounds as she went around and placed their clothes in the drawers and closet. Catra was glad Adora had something to take her mind off what had happened. She knew Adora blamed herself, especially since she had been training in secret to calm the attacks.

Adora had received a few suits and dresses in She-Ra white and gold colors. Adora squealed happily as she pulled out a dress in a similar style to the one Catra had received, a lower neckline and longer skirt in white and gold. Adora compared to the two and muttered to herself about their next ball. She was given a new red hair piece, apparently part of the old jacket fabric. Adora’s main outfits and uniforms stayed the same blue, black, and gold colors that Catra had come to appreciate. Serpentina had done one thing right.

Catra’s outfits were mainly the same new one she had received, which she was happy with. Her new royal or formal outfits were modeled after the outfit Mermista lent her for the party that second night. The shirts were a puffy red fabric that dipped deep and black pants with golden strips down the sides. She received a gold and white jacket that she swore to never wear.

Adora had cried when she unpacked the jacket. Apparently, Adora had sent a letter at some point about her vision’s future outfit and that jacket was among the outfit. Catra rolled her eyes and had Adora hang it in their closet. She watched, her heart content as Adora continued with the clothes.

As Adora left the room to return the crates, Catra shifted. Laying for so long was growing uncomfortable. She reached over to some of the pillows near Adora's side of the bed, when a small black booklet appeared from under one. Catra shot a look to Melog.

"What is it?" Melog asked. Catra grasped it carefully, some of the pages were clearly a few years old and wore with water. She flipped to the beginning.

Dear Catra.

Her cheeks flushed as she realized what she was reading. Adora had written her letters. This first one was dated a week after Adora had defected.

Dear Catra,

I miss you so much. I can't sleep without you at my feet. I keep waking and thinking you'll be there. I don't understand why you didn't come with me. I wish you did. It's lonely here without you. Bow and Glimmer would be happy to have you. At least, I think they would. Queen Angela seemed okay with me…after I.

It skipped a line, a single drop on the paper. Catra could feel the sadness in her words but continued reading.

Anyway, all the food in Bright Moon is amazing! So much better than ration bars! I could never go back to eating those. Bow and Glimmer showed me something called Ice Cream! It's really sweet and cold and amazing! I think you'd like it.

I know you're not a bad person, Catra. I hope you'll think about it and come with me. I can't go back to the Horde. Now that I know what they're doing, I can't. I hope you'll join me soon. I can't wait to show you what Ice Cream is and the Horse that we found! Oh, and parties! I'll show you a party!

Adora.

Catra felt her own tears welling up as she flipped through it. She skimmed through the journal, reading different excerpts.

Dated a few days before they met in the Crimson Waste.

Hey Catra,

So, Shadow Weaver showed up and I don't like it. She said you betrayed her but I know she lies about a lot. I wonder if that's true. She told me about where I came from and Light Hope confirmed it. I don't know what to do. I wonder what you would think about all of this. I think she can change. (Ha! Like that would happen) *I think everyone at the Horde should be given a second chance. I was. I know it's because I'm She-Ra. I can't let them down. But I know that if you came here, you'd like it. I hope you'll take that second chance. I hate fighting you like this.*

Dated two days after the portal incident.

Catra, how could you? You broke the world. Because of you… Catra skipped a few lines. She didn't want the reminder but felt compelled to read.

All I wanted was for you to join me and we could be like before here in Bright Moon. You had to pull the switch. I just wanted you to come with me. Everyone here is saying terrible things. They say things like you'll never change. That you're evil. I can't think like that but. I think that this. I can't let you hurt them. I can't hold out hope that you'll join me. I'll always want it. And if you ever take me up on it, I'll be so happy. But I have to protect them. That's who I am.

Catra couldn't read that one anymore, even though there was a whole another page. She flipped further. The last entry was dated shortly before Catra sent Glimmer to them. She had taken this with her on the ship?!

Hey Catra.

It's been a long time since we've seen each other. It's been a long time since I've written you a letter. I miss you. Glimmer and I were fighting a lot and it reminded me of you. I wish she'd see she was wrong and let us help. She reminds me a lot of you in general. Sometimes it hurts how similar you are. We're on our way to save her now. Even though we fought, I can't leave her behind. I don't want to leave anyone else behind ever again. I can't lose them like I lost you. I don't know where you are. The last intel we had of you was you were holed up in the Horde. They said you hadn't left in months, leading from base instead of the field. I'm hoping you're okay somewhere. Hordak and most of the others haven't been seen since Prime arrived. We've been moving around so much, I barely had time to grab this before we fled Bright Moon.

Is this really what you wanted, Catra? All of this? I don't believe it. I know you better than that. You're a good person deep deep deep deep down inside. I wish you would see that and join me here. I wish we were together again. I wish I knew if you were okay. Maybe in rescuing Glimmer, she'll have heard something.

I guess I'll know soon.

Adora.

Catra wiped at the tears that tracked down her face. Adora really had cared about her the whole time.

"AH!" Adora's scream brought her eyes from the paper. Adora stood, eyes wide in shock and cheeks flushed, pointing at the book in Catra's hands. "Why do you have that?!" She walked to the bed, lips pursued in embarrassment.

"Oh no!" Catra held the book up as if she hadn't been crying over it a moment previous. "I wanna keep reading!"

"No!" Adora shouted. She reached across Catra, where she was holding it just out of reach.

"I wonder what you wrote in here after Princess Prom." Catra giggled mischievously. Adora's entire face flashed red as her eyes confirmed what Catra guessed. Catra turned at her waist to open the book where Adora couldn't get to it. "Let's see."

"Stop!" Adora begged. "Don't!" Catra's eyes flickered between the journal and Adora. The pitiful look in Adora's eyes made her stop. She rolled back into the laying position she had been in, handing the journal over.

"Fine…I guess..." Catra tried to play it off. Adora sat with her back to Catra, clearly hugging the journal close. Now Catra felt bad. She bit her lip as she tried to think. "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have read it."

"It's not that." Adora finally spoke. Her voice quivered like it did when she was upset. "When, when we were enemies…" Adora paused, the word hanging in the air between them. So much had happened in those three years. "I couldn't talk to anyone about it. No one understood. Bow gave me this so I could write down things I wanted to do but it turned into letters to you. Ones I could never send."

"Why was it on the bed?' Catra asked softly.

"I found it this morning before we left for the Library. It had been tucked between something and I threw it on the bed since Glimmer was threatening to teleport us." Catra remembered that morning. Glimmer was impatient as Adora had been running late. It made sense. "I was planning on hiding it but I forgot with everything that happened."

Catra now felt even worse. She knew what that was like. The entire time she had been in the Horde without Adora had been hell. She missed Adora but she couldn't have left with Adora. She had to prove herself. She did what they said she couldn't. In a

weird way, Catra was proud of that but she wasn't proud of the damage she had done to her now friends.

"You know how weird it is to be in love with the leader of the enemy?" Adora finished with a funny tone in her voice before she laughed humorlessly. "Can't really say anything when everyone around you is talking about how to beat them and yeah."

"I'm sorry." Catra sighed. Adora turned on the bed to look at her. She opened her mouth to speak before closing it. She waited a moment and closed her eyes.

"It's done." Adora spoke semi-harshly. "There's nothing I can do to change it. The only thing I can do is move forward. I can't fix everything." She stared at the sheets with an intensity that made Catra bit her cheek to keep from laughing.

"Something from Lukkia?" Catra raised her eyebrow.

"Yeah. She said if I'm feeling bad about something in the past or I'm trying to do too much, I'm supposed to remind myself of that." Adora gave her a look. "It's honestly really weird."

"Yeah, I don't understand Markio's advise half the time either." Catra admitted.

"What does Markio say?" Adora giggled a little, her grip on the book loosening.

"I'm supposed to imagine my inner child?" Catra rolled her eyes and laughed. "Something about protecting her like I wanted to be…" She trailed off.

"Yeah, Lukkia's said something like that too." Adora said. "She said it's a common healing thing for people like us who have…what's the word….childhood trauma?" Adora cocked her head as she spoke the words. Catra giggled.

"Ooh, I'm traumatized!" She wiggled her claws at Adora, who lost the last composure she had. She giggled with Catra. "Be careful, I've heard its transmittable." The book slipped to the floor between Adora's laughing. Adora left it, which made Catra happier than she wanted to admit.

They were working towards being better. Adora's laughter was the best sound in the world to her.

"I do want to know." Catra rested her hands on her stomach. "Why didn't you tell us about the attacks?" Adora's shoulders fell. She reached down for the book and moved it to the desk, placing it in a drawer.

"I knew it would make you all worry." Adora spoke with her back to Catra. "We have enough on our plates. Besides, I've been working on calming them. I've been able to work up to holding She-Ra for almost ten minutes now." Adora's voice held pride and disappointment at the same time.

"We promised to be truthful and talk about it. You have to tell me." Catra reminded her harshly. She didn't want to be mean about it but she needed to know. Adora sighed before turning back to face Catra.

"If I get too emotional or try to summon too much magic. That's what causes them."

"Thank you." Catra gave her a smile. Adora returned the favor, crossing the room to join her on the bed.

"Can I try something?"

"What?"

"I want to try to heal your leg."

"Adora…" Catra's tone warned her.

"Please. Just one try. If it causes anything, I'll stop. I just…I need to try to fix it."

"You don't have to play the hero all the time." Catra cupped Adora's cheek. "I love you regardless." Adora blushed a little and nodded. "I'll be fine for a few weeks." She cast a look at Melog. "Besides, Melog agreed to carry me everywhere until I can walk."

"No, I didn't." Melog growled, though Catra knew they didn't mean it.

"I don't think that's the truth." Adora narrowed her eyes. Catra shrugged.

"They did." Melog growled at her again before licking her cheek.

"I suppose I can assist. If your life partner doesn't do it for me." Melog teased her.

"Listen here, you little…" Catra's eyes flickered to Adora and back to Melog. "You're lucky she's here or I'd say something worse." She pointed a claw at them, Melog snickering at her.

"Be nice, Catra." Adora laughed, pushing her hand down. "Now, can I try it or not?"

"You won't let that go, will you?"

"I broke it. I need to fix it."

"No, you don't." Catra smacked her hand. "You don't have to fix everything. Isn't what that little mantra of yours is supposed to help with?"

"Yeah but…You got hurt BECAUSE of me." Adora looked away. "You only got hurt because you were trying to help me."

"I know how you feel." Catra started, putting a hand on Adora's arm. "But I don't want you to heal it. I'd rather we find out how to fix this first." She motioned up and down Adora's body. "and then we can talk about that. Okay? I don't blame you." Markio had recommended telling herself that phrase, but she figured it applied here as well.

"Fine. So what's your plan to destroy the Moonstone?" Adora crossed her arms playfully.

"Just so you know," Catra sassed. "I was close to it before."

"Close."

"I only didn't get to it because your friends showed up. But otherwise, I would've done it."

"Our friends."

"Yeah, yeah." Catra psshed. "Entrapta, Scorpia and I were discussing it before all of that." Catra made a motion with her hand. "We're wondering if we can destroy one of the runestones without setting off the casualties Entrapta thinks would happen with another event like when we charged the Black Garnet."

"I don't understand?" Adora cocked her head a little. "Why would it be an issue?"

"Because." Catra clasped her hands together. "When we were charging the Black Garnet, we found if we destroy one runestone, it would overload the others. That's why we planned the attack on Bright Moon. It was closest and with the Black Garnet running rampant, we figured it'd be easier to hit. As well as the Runestones are weakened when one is overcharged or destroyed. At least, that's Entrapta's theory."

"I had no idea." Adora pondered. "I mean, I knew some of that but I didn't know about the domino effect it would

have.”

“That’s my main concern.” Catra sighed. “If we destroy one at a time, and we cause those disasters, what happens to you?” Catra watched Adora’s face as it sunk it. Adora would be affected by the runestones.

“But, if one is destroyed, the Heart should turn off.” Adora muttered after a moment. “Before Scorpia connected to the Garnet, the Heart wasn’t accessible. So if we destroy one!”

“You might be disconnected!” Catra finished. “We should ask Entrapta first. She might be able to run calculations on it before we enact on anything.”

“You’re right.” Adora paused. “You’d trust Entrapta to do that?”

“Yeah?” Catra raised an eyebrow before narrowing her eyes. “You never have a lot of faith in me, do you?”

“That’s not what I meant!” Adora exclaimed. “I meant more of a, it’s nice to see everyone getting along. It’s all I’ve wanted for the last three years.” She held her hands to her chest and smiled.

“Entrapta was able to calculate the portal’s impact before I pulled the lever.” Catra mentioned as she looked down. She hated that decision but she had to live with it. “She’s been wrong before, but if she was able to figure out something as big as that and how to fix Darla, she’d probably know about this too.”

“I’ll send her a message on Bow’s trackerpad tonight and ask if she’s available to talk about it at some point. We should’ve asked before we left earlier.”

“We weren’t thinking about it earlier.” Catra added. “We were a little focused on other things.” She motioned to Adora’s chest and her own leg.

“You sure you won’t let me try an-“

“Adora. No.” Catra smacked Adora’s hands as they reached out.

“Ow. You didn’t have to hit me.”

“Well, pain seems to be the only way you listen.” Catra huffed.

“As if you aren’t the same way.”

“No. I’m better than that.”

“Really?” Adora laughed the word.

“Yes, I am.” Catra spoke smugly.

“Well, there was the time you..”

“I get it.” Catra shoved her. Adora giggled as she picked herself up from the floor. “You’re such an idiot.”

“Yeah, I know.” Adora grinned. She curled up next to Catra, careful of her leg. “Is it okay if I…”

“Just cuddle with me, dork.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

Chapter End Notes

Oh god, it's been almost three weeks. I'm so sorry. There's been a lot going on and I lost all motivation to work on this for a while. I've worked on this chapter for hours and hours. I'm not sure how I feel about it but I need to update. I have finals this week so it'll be two weeks at least before I'm able to update. Thank you to all for being patient and continuing to support this!

Fractures and Nightmares

Chapter Notes

> Oh goodness, I'm sorry I haven't updated. I lost a pet this past week as well as got some devastating news. But we're back.
>
> Also, I want to thank luvrkachow. They did a colored redraw of the outfits from chapter 6! I honestly started crying when I saw it. I felt really bad because I changed Catra's costume to match Adora's a little more in chapter 9 and they commented the link like the next morning. If you see this, thank you. You inspired me to keep writing. I changed the outfit because my drawing of them didn't look that good but seeing yours made me regret it almost immediately. I hope you know I go back to the link and I look at it all the time and I show it off to all my friends and family members. I can't thank you enough.
> ON TO THE CHAPTER!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 10: Adora

The next month was hell for Adora. Not only did the magic attacks increase in frequency and intensity, but everyone was also babying her more than they had before. Catra was the only one who wasn't doing it all the time, Glimmer on the other hand. Glimmer and Adora had gotten into several spats of Adora's activities. Apparently, going for runs around the castle with Melog or sparing with the guard was too much. Yes, she had attacks after them sometimes, but she couldn't sit around and do nothing.

Catra's idea of destroying the runestones had earned the ire of everyone around them. Adora had taken to walking her places to make sure she wouldn't be attacked. Not that Bright Moon people seemed to do that but the looks she caught them giving Catra made the idea realistic. Catra didn't seem to mind.

She continued, holding her head high and proceeding in her plans to destroy everything.

Adora wasn't sure how to feel about it. She was happy at the thought of being free from these attacks, so crippling she couldn't leave bed sometimes. But the thought of destroying everything because of her…How could she okay that?

Adora rested on the edge of their bed, watching Catra pack for her trip. Scorpia and Entrapta asked for her to visit for a day or two as they planned and consulted. Catra hadn't agreed to the trip at first until Adora told her she should go. Glimmer, Bow and Adora were having a sleepover and she'd be fine if Catra wanted to go. So, she was going.

"I'm only going for two days max." Catra reminded her as she walked to the closet. "Don't do anything stupid while I'm gone."

"Yes Ma'am." Adora teased. One of her blue shirts slapped her in the face. She giggled, pulling it down to reveal the heavenly grin Catra wore. Catra rolled her eyes and went back to packing her backpack.

"Entrapta and Scorpia are the only ones on board with this idea." Catra sighed heavily as she closed the bag. She turned, leaning against the desk, arms crossed over her chest. "We have to do something. You'll call me if anything happens? Any attacks?"

"I'll be fine, Catra. It's not like we haven't been separated before." Adora waved her hand before falling silent. Wrong thing. Catra's tail thrashed and her ears wiggled slightly. They folded down, her eyes following suit. "Sorry. I didn't mean it like that."

"It's fine." Catra turned back to the desk. Now Adora had done it. She and Catra had fought several times since the library incident. Even though Catra healed insanely quickly, with

the help of a few late night healing sessions that she wasn't aware of, the event was still a black mark on their relationship.

Three months into their relationship and all they could do was fight. Adora wondered if this is what relationships were supposed to be like. Glimmer and Bow rarely fought. Not that Adora and Catra never fought when they were kids.

"I'm not mad at you." Catra said, using one of her lines from therapy. "I'm just tired and frustrated with other things. I'm sorry for taking it out on you." Adora didn't really think she had done that, but she accepted the apology anyway.

"I'm not upset either." Adora tried for her half. Using the lines Lukkia and Markio had suggested felt weird, but she supposed it did help communication. Even if the communication felt staler than a ration bar. "I'm sorry."

"Just promise me you'll be careful." Catra took a seat next to Adora on the bed. "I just got you back. I can't lose you again."

"I doubt being back with me for six months total is…" Adora laughed as Catra slapped her arm. "You have to be careful too. I don't want to lose you either."

"Okay." Catra sighed, laying her head on Adora's shoulder. "I still have to go to that last meeting with Sparkles before Melog and I leave for Dryl." She groaned.

"I'm sure it'll be fine." Adora tried for a smile. She laced her fingers through Catra's, her heart pulsing in her ribs. She felt her cheeks flush a little, like they always did whenever they sat like this. Warmth spread throughout her body, followed by the usual tinge of electric. She ignored it. She and Catra hadn't been able to really cuddle or anything in a month, due to her attacks. Catra kept distancing herself like before, Adora having to pull her close for an attack to separate them. Their nightmares

had returned in full force. Adora wondered how they'd both fare tonight.

Melog meowed as they laid their head on Catra's knees. She sighed, standing slowly. The removal of Catra's pressure brought about a sorrow that extinguish the warmth she had felt.

"I'll walk you to your meeting." Adora offered to hide the disappointment. Catra nodded solemnly. She grabbed her bag and the three of them left for the Council Room. Silence filled the hallways, almost mourning with Adora. It wasn't forever. It wasn't like they weren't going to see each other again. It was just two days. They had been apart longer than that with the war and even now, they sometimes spent days without getting to speak. Though, they would sleep together at night when they could.

The door to the Council Room appeared much sooner than Adora would've liked. They stood awkwardly shifting at the entrance. Adora rubbed Melog's head, the mane glowing amber for a second. Catra shivered, Adora raised an eyebrow.

"I'll see you soon?" Catra reached for the doorknob, looking at Adora over her shoulder.

"Yeah." She nodded, a lump forming in her throat. Melog meowed as they looked between the two of them.

"Melog said they'll stay with you until my meeting's done." Catra laughed softly.

"Oh, okay." Adora pursed her lips as she looked to Melog. "Wanna go on a run around the gardens?" Melog's tail swished happily. Catra's expression soured. "Fine. Wanna go on a walk?" Adora placated.

"Okay, have fun." Catra shook her head at Adora, making no effort to enter the room.

"Yeah, you too." Adora, neither trying to leave.

"Catra!" Glimmer opened the door. "Thank goodness you're here. Come on!" Glimmer grabbed her arm and pulled her into the room. Adora watched in what seemed like forever as Catra's eyes filled with melancholy before the door closed. She found her hand outstretched to comfort her girlfriend before pulling it back to her chest. She held it there for a moment, lip quivering as she tried to be strong. She couldn't break. It was just two days. She was fine.

Melog chirped and rubbed their head on her leg. She sniffled and crouched down to their level.

"Wanna go on that run now?" She tried to smile. She started down the hall towards the gardens. She just needed to get her mind off everything. She would be fine. Bow was bringing snacks from his dads and they were going to do something. What were their plans again? She shook her head. Bow and Glimmer always had a way of cheering her up and despite everything going on, she was trying to have a goodnight with them.

Another brush on her thigh brought her attention to Melog. She petted their head before Melog chirped and disappeared. She gasped as she vanished, her hands suddenly see through. She spun around to see if anyone was there. Why would Melog just suddenly…

The room changed around her in a swirl of color. The room was fairly dark, no natural light filled the room. The walls glowed purple in the light source behind Adora. Different events from Etheria's history were carved into the walls, documenting. Adora saw a few she recognized before a voice drew her attention.

"We're not suggesting it." Catra's voice filled her ears. Adora spun giddily to see her girlfriend, mouth open to respond when another voice cut her off.

"Royal Strategist, we are saying that it is impossible to achieve. To suggest such an act is a treason. We cannot destroy

the Moonstone."

"Can't or won't?" Catra questioned, a dangerous tone in her voice.

"My Queen, you can't be considering this." One of the Senators objected. "Surely, you understand the madness she is suggesting!"

"To destroy the Moonstone would be to destroy our world! Do you not remember what happened the last time someone messed with a Runestone?"

"I do." Catra raised her hand in a mocking tone. "Oh, right. Cause I was the one who did it. I think I understand the risks we're looking at. However, Adora's body won't be able to withstand anymore of these. It's been three months since her first attack and now they're almost three days apart. Each one worse than the last. Are you asking the Savior of Etheria to condemn herself to death for you?!"

"Is that not her job?" A swan woman asked from the side. "She is the She-Ra."

"Her name is Adora." Catra growled. "She's my girlfriend before she is your She-Ra."

"Catra's right." Glimmer stood, finally speaking. "Adora can't stand many more of these attacks. We have to do something."

"My Queen." Several objected, silenced by Glimmer's hand in the air.

"I have my own reasons as to why I'm objecting the Moonstone's destruction. It has led Bright Moon and Etheria for many years with my mother and now me." Glimmer held a hand to her chest. Adora closed her eyes. Angella. "However." Adora's eyes shot back to Glimmer. A look of steel flashed in her eyes.

“Adora is one of my best friends. I’ve already lost her once and I won’t lose her again.”

“How many lives will you sacrifice for your friend, my Queen?” One person, antlers protruding from their head, stood. “Is her one life worth more than your subjects?”

“Senator Brakenten.” Catra warned. This was the Senator Catra had told her of. They disagreed with everything Catra suggested, even if it was helpful. “I suggest you watch your tone.”

“Or what, Horde Leader.” They spat at her. “You’ll hurt me? All you’ve done is hurt people and destroy our lands. Why would we listen to the person who almost conquered our planet?!” They raised their hands outwardly, as if asking the room.

“Almost?” Catra’s high pitched laugh echoed. “I did.” Glimmer shot her a look of confusion but Catra continued. “Sure, my last march on Bright Moon might have failed. But I’m the reason your queen is here today. Because I saved her twice. Horde Prime was going to kill her upon arrival. I convinced him not to. Later on, I returned the queen to Adora and the others at my own personal cost.” Catra’s hands slammed into the table, leaning over it. “Your planet was mine and still is. I make the calls here, not you. We’re destroying the Runestones. The Moonstone was the first created so it’ll be the first to go.”

“You can’t be serious.”

“Watch your tone.”

“Remember your place, Royal Strategist.”

“She’s no Royal Strategist. She’s a fraud.” Senator Brakenten spoke in a booming voice. “She’s practically exposed herself. She never cared about this planet. She’s been out to conquer it since she came to the Rebellion. I wouldn’t be surprised if she were behind the attack on the Fright Zone colony.”

"So, you do recognize it?" Catra leaned back, shifting to her hip and crossing her arms.

"That's not important." The Senator bit. "You're working with those rebels to overthrow us again, I'm sure of it."

"HA!" Catra laughed once. "It's hilarious hearing them being called 'Rebels' by the former Rebellion. And why would I even need to?" Catra spread her arms, wrapping one around Glimmer's shoulders. "I'm already in control."

"Catra. Enough." Glimmer shrugged her off. "Step back."

"Are you going to let them stop us from saving Adora?!" Catra huffed. Her tail whipped the chair loudly, silence ensuing. The two stared the other down, a battle of wills clashing as loud as swords in the quiet.

"I'm not stopping them. I'm stopping you from making a mistake." Glimmer finally spoke. "You're like me. And I'm impulsive and stubborn. This isn't something we can rush."

"Someone's been talking to Micah." Catra muttered under her breath. Glimmer shot her a look. "You know I'm right. You're risking Adora's life because you don't want to upset them."

"I don't care if I upset them!" Glimmer shouted as she threw her hand out, motioning to the room. "What I care about is not making the same mistakes as before!"

"No, what you're concerned about is your standing as queen." Catra poked Glimmer's chest, forcing her to step back. "If you cared about Adora at all, you'd be with me."

"I'm not against you, Catra." Glimmer planted her feet. "I can't just destroy the Moonstone."

"Why not?"

"Because it would be the last thing of my mother!" Glimmer yelled, shocking Catra into silence. Adora realized she was holding her breath, waiting for the pin to drop. Catra's ears flicked and her tail lashed once before dropping. She stood dangerously still. She raised her hand, mouth open and primed to throw insults.

A flash of amber went over Adora's body, Catra's body jerking straight in time with it. Adora covered her mouth with her hand with bated breath. Catra turned and looked directly at her, emotions flying through her eyes. Confusion, Anger, Hurt, Sadness, Dawning and Realization all crossed in a moment. Catra ran her hands through her hair once, instantly calm.

She spun around once more, facing Glimmer and the room.

"Let me make something clear to you. I have spent the last three years of my life, at least the last three years, working myself to death to get what I want. I finally have it. And I'm not losing it again. If you won't work with me, than you're against me. I'll save Adora from this, with or without you."

"Catra." Glimmer reached a hand out as Catra turned to the door. "Don't do this."

"Do what, Sparkles? I'm destined to be the villain at this rate, aren't I?!" she screamed. "We haven't gotten anything done with repairs for weeks because of this room, right here. And now that it's come to it, now that we have to destroy the Moonstone and the others to make sure Adora lives, I'm the one in the wrong? Glimmer, you would do the same thing for Bow, wouldn't you?!"

Glimmer gasped softly and placed a hand to her chest. Her mouth opened and closed, words dying on her tongue to defend herself.

"I'll do it myself if I have to. I'm fine being hated. As long as I have her." Catra's words drew tears from Adora, who resisted sniffling and exposing herself.

"Give me a little bit of time." Glimmer finally spoke. She held up a 2 as Catra began to protest. "Until you return from Dryl. That's all I ask. If I can't find something else by then, we'll go through with your plan."

The Senators, wordlessly, looked between the two. The tension between them suffocated them into silence, Adora included.

"Two days." Catra agreed with disdain clear in her words. "That's it. I'm done waiting." Glimmer nodded. Catra took her seat, the small sounds of the council resuming breaking the tension.

The room disappeared, leaving Adora in the middle of the outside gardens. The babbling brook and the animals around joined the overwhelming symphony that played in Adora's ears. Catra had told her things were going better with the council. She had said they were working things out. That was the opposite of it, if Adora knew anything about them.

She slumped to the ground, Melog supporting her with a mew. She wiped her face on her sleeve. She needed to figure something out. She had to protect Catra and stop her from making mistakes. Adora finally had all of her friends together and she didn't want to change that.

What could she do though? The familiar sting of magic warmed her veins. She closed her eyes, envisioning a box that she could show the magic into. It wasn't very helpful but Lukkia had suggested a mental picturing of the process could help. She took a deep breath, her lungs rattling. The magic's physical tole grew with every passing day. Moving had become painful at times and breathing sometimes required effort. It was like it was sucking her

lifeforce away. A feat that shouldn't be possible anymore but was happening anyway.

She had snuck out to see Madam Razz about it a few days ago, but the older woman had no idea what was happening to her. She kept calling her Mara and didn't seem to remember talking to Catra at all. The Library had no more information on her or anything else to do with the Heart, at least not that she could find. There was nothing to help her figure this out. Nothing to stop her from withering away slowly, she supposed.

Melog licked her face. She smiled at them, loving on them. Another amber flash. Adora paused, this time the amber stayed in their mane. Adora continued loving on them, scratching their ears and rubbing all over their back. Melog seemed to like the under their right ear, Catra's favorite spot. Adora proceeded to rub slow circles there, just like she did for Catra. Melog chirped happily.

"Hey," Glimmer's voice announced their arrival. Catra stumbled but regained her footing quickly. "Did you guys go for a run?"

"Yeah." Adora lied. She didn't like it but she didn't think she could just announce that she attended the meeting. "We just stopped her for some air." Adora rubbed once down Melog's back. Catra shivered.

"You okay?" Glimmer asked. Adora wondered how they two of them were talking as if they hadn't been yelling at each other a while ago.

"Melog. Stop it." Catra narrowed her eyes at them. Melog snickered and the amber faded. Catra shook her body once and smoothed her hair. Glimmer and Adora shared a look before looking back at Catra.

"Wait…is…is Amber Melog doing something to you?!" Glimmer snickered. Melog answered them, everyone looking to

Catra for translation. She rolled her eyes.

"Amber is…Melog sharing sensations with me. That's all." She dismissed as she shifted to her right and turned her head away.

"That's so cool!" Glimmer spoke first. Adora felt a sinister idea rising. She looked to Melog, who understood immediately. They turned on the amber, Catra bristling and turning back. As she opened her mouth to speak, Adora tickled Melog's side. Catra yelped and clutched her stomach. Laughter bubbled from her.

"Adora! Stop!" She swatted at them, Melog bounding away as the amber faded to blue. She panted as Glimmer and Adora took their turn to laugh.

"How'd the meeting go?" Adora asked as if she hadn't seen all of it.

"Catra threatened everyone. We didn't get much done." Glimmer picked a flower and twirled it in her fingers. The petals spun a beautiful red circle before they fell to the ground sadly. "The usual."

"Hey, threats worked in the Horde." Catra teased. "And I got a lot done while I was there. And I'm the one who got the last of Erelandia's repairs finished by threatening them. You can't tell me it doesn't work."

"Yeah, yeah." Glimmer giggled as she waved her free hand. "Though, Erelandia is pretty grateful. I'm glad most of the repairs are done."

"Are they?" Adora asked. They hadn't let her know much about how it was going with the whole She-Ra Heart situation going on.

"Yeah, Most of Bright Moon is done. Elebron is set to finish next week and all of Bright Moon's area will be finished.

The…” Glimmer paused.

“The Fright Zone is the last to be done.” Catra picked up.

“I heard a rumor about a group of people there.” Adora tried to drop casually. Catra glared at her. Glimmer’s eyes widened in surprise. “Some of the servants were talking about it.” Adora waved her hands in the air. She gave a grin that she knew wasn’t helping.

“Yeah.” Glimmer dropped the flower stem, the last of the red petals having fallen onto her cape. It reminded Adora of blood spots for some reason. The thought of her friends hurt because of her made her sick to her stomach. Nausea gripped her tightly, her hand going to her forehead. “It’s not a big thing though. Don’t worry about it. Are you okay?” Glimmer finally noticed what Adora assumed was the worsening of her state. Catra had already moved to her side, supporting her with hands on her back and arm.

“I’m taking you back to bed before I leave.”

“Catra, I’m fine.”

“No.” Catra said once. They locked eyes, the fever Adora felt growing blurrying her vision. She felt herself sickening. She clasped a hand over her mouth to prevent the bile from escaping.

“Are you okay?” Glimmer reached out.

SMACK!

Adora’s eyes widened as she watched Glimmer recoil. Catra’s stern expression with her hand still in the air. Glimmer’s hand, having been slapped back by Catra’s, hung in the air. As if she didn’t know what to do with it.

"We're got it." Catra shifted and picked up Adora seamlessly. "I'll leave a list for Bow before I leave. Melog." Catra's curtness ended the conversation. She began for the castle, a brisk step and an iron grip on Adora.

"What's going on between you two?" Adora asked, trying to calm herself. She needed to get better and stop whatever was happening between them. Catra didn't speak at first, choosing to look straight ahead. Adora's body shook with a cough, Catra gripping her tighter.

"It's fine, Adora. Don't worry about it." Catra answered. Adora recognized the look in Catra's eyes. She was shutting down, emotionless to protect herself. It was a bad habit of Catra's developed under Shadow Weaver's loving care and abuse.

"No." Adora wrestled herself free, Catra forced to stop to prevent Adora dropping the ground. "Something happened."

"Nothing happened, Adora."

"You said you were getting along better. Glimmer doesn't agree. I saw you two fight." Adora cursed internally. Catra's eyes widened and narrowed just as fast.

"What do you mean you saw us fight?"

"I saw you two in the council room." Adora finally admitted. She couldn't do it any longer. "Melog took me into the room. You threatened them, Catra. You said you didn't want things like power anymore."

"I never did!" Catra snapped. Her ears folded down as she sat back on her legs. "What's so wrong with wanting to protect what you love?" She whispered.

"But you can't do it like that." Adora tried. Catra pursed her lips angerly.

"Oh because the way you do it is much better."

"What does that mean?"

"You charge headfirst into things and just hope it works out for you."

"And what's wrong with that?!"

"How do you think I beat you all of those times? It was easy! You go onto a battlefield and just swing your sword around until you're happy."

"No, I don't, Catra." Her fist tightened, pressure building.

"I just want to keep you safe." Catra pleaded. "Why can't you just let me do that?"

"Because you're just going to hurt yourself again that way."

"We both know I don't matter, Adora."

"You matter to me." The room around them changed before Adora's eyes, the flashback having grabbed her without realization. The Velvet Glove flickered, Catra's broken body before her. "I'm going to take you home. It's okay." Adora spoke to the form on the floor. Catra's chest laid still.

"Adora." She could hear her name being called but couldn't bring herself to respond. Anger boiled in her blood. Magic filled the air, she could feel her magic responding to her hatred for Prime. Anyone who dared harm her friends. Her hair lifted into the air, matching the weightless feeling that consumed her nerves.

"Adora! Stop it!" Catra's scream flickered through the room, Bright Moon's halls colorfully taking over again. Adora rubbed her eyes, the floor around her ruptured. Catra sat in front of her, some of her clothes now torn. Melog sat nearby, red mane spiked and a growl deep in their throat.

"Catra." Adora breathed as the world went black. She felt Catra's arms envelop her and her last words echoing in her ears.

"I've got you."

She was back. The white and green around her blurred her sense of space. She stepped forward, drudging her feet through the mudlike atmosphere that seemed to surround her. When she looked at her hands, they were shrouded with a murky aura.

A scream ripped her attention forward. She grunted as she gripped a post on the wall. When did that appear? She shook her head. No matter. The scream continued before giving out monetarily. Her muscles screamed with exhaustion as she forced herself to the door in front of her.

"All beings must suffer to become pure!" She heard the chant before she reached the green energy door that wavered in front of her. It grew in sound, the scream being the only thing to pierce its uniformity.

The door opened before her, a pool of green water mounted in the center of the room. A small body floated on top of the water, limp from the small electric currents that rippled off the water. The chant continued as if she wasn't even present. She forced herself to take another step. As her foot connected with the ground, the pool crackled. The scream filled the air again, so shrill she covered her ears. She couldn't tear her eyes from the horror of the figure shaking in the water.

As sudden as it had started, it all stopped. It went quiet. She watched in horror as two figures went in to drag the body from the water. The smaller figure hung limply between them as they were dragged before the shadow in the seat. The throne had their back to her. But she knew who was there.

“Little Sister.” The words slithered down her spine. The smaller frame responded similarly, shaking and crying. “Have I not offered you peace? Why do you fight me?”

The Little Sister, that she was sure she knew but couldn’t place, shook, words unable to form on their tongue.

“Ah, yes. The oxygen tube has helped greatly.” The left figure ripped a tube from Little Sister’s throat, followed by bile and water. They gagged and coughed.

“Please.” Little Sister’s voice rasped. “I don’t know anything else. She won’t return for me.” The silhouette of Little Sister slumped to their knees. “Just kill me.”

“All beings have their place in Prime’s light, Little Sister.” The shadow in the throne spoke. “Activate it.” The left figure bent to touch the back of Little Sister’s neck. Electricity crackled on the back of their neck, ripping a scream as they curled on themselves. As best as they could with the figures holding their arms back.

“Little Sister.” The shadow called once more. “Join us in the light.”

“ALL BEINGS MUST SUFFER TO BECOME PURE!” The chant sounded once, the uniform cry reverberating through the chamber. The scream stopped as quickly. Little Sister fell on their face, the figures finally releasing them. They sat up in a fluid unnatural movement. They rose to their feet and turned slowly to face the room. Green eyes were the only thing visible on Little Sister’s silhouette.

“Behold, the purest among you.” The throne spoke in a booming voice. Cries of joy filled the chamber.

“Look at what you could’ve prevented.” The words ripped her from the scene. She stood in the locker room she had grown up in. “If you had only stayed.” A figure wrapped in red and

black approached. “If you had done what you were told, this never would’ve happened. It’s all your fault.”

She tried to protest but her words failed her. She clenched her fists, feeling blood leak from the point her nails tore into her palms.

“Prime only found you because you were the worst,” Another figure spoke, a feline shadow with a white line across its face and another across its arm and chest. “All of this is your fault. If you had been better. Angella would still be here.” Flashes of the former queen blinded her as they pulsed brightly on the walls. She crouched to protect herself as they continued. “All of the things Catra did, none of them would’ve happened if you hadn’t left her.” Images of Catra, things she had never even seen herself, flashed. One seemed to pause and play out, zooming in on Catra’s face. She cried, removing her mask and falling to the ground.

“You could have joined us.” The last figure appeared behind her. The same voice as the throne. Their figure loomed over her. “Peace for all the universe and now they will be war. It’s all your fault.” She clenched at her clothes as a mark burned itself across her chest. A heart shaped figure laid in her skin, scarring.

“And now.” The three voice spoke in unison. “The world will end because of you.”

Darkness consumed her.

When Adora woke, the moons were overhead. Melog laid on her chest, their aura amber. Adora rubbed her eyes. Melog was supposed to be in Dryl with Catra, weren’t they?

Melog’s head raised slowly, shifting to the right as they met her eyes. They chirped happily, slowly blinking at her. Adora’s eyebrows furrowed but she waved good morning or whatever it was. Her throat still burned. She uncovered herself from Melog’s

legs and the blankets she had been tucked under. Melog's glow faded back to blue as they hopped off the bed to follow her to the bathroom.

Adora gripped the vanity with unsteadiness as she looked into the mirror. The dark circles under her eyes had grown again. Her face had lost some of its natural glow, as Glimmer put it, and her shoulders sagged. Her hair laid limply around her face. She pulled her hair back into a lower ponytail, anything higher gave her headaches. She splashed water on her face, using a nearby towel to pat it dry. She stared back into the mirror. Everything ached as if she had healed the whole of Bright Moon's guard.

"Adora?" Bow's voice called from the main bedroom.

"In here." She tried to call, her voice rasping. She grabbed the nearby cup and took a swig.

"Hey." Bow spoke kindly as he knocked and entered slowly. "How are you feeling?"

"I'm fine." Adora brushed it off. She couldn't worry him more than he clearly was. "What happened?"

"Catra said you collapsed in the hallway. She carried you back here and called for doctors to check on you. Another magic attack." Bow admitted nervously. Adora sighed heavily, resorting to moving back to the bed. The longer the attacks went on, the more exhausted she was afterwards. Bow followed behind her, clearly trying to resist helping her back to the bed. She sat on the side, cupping her head. Bow sat on the ground where he could see her face and offered a smile. Melog mewed and moved to sit between Adora's legs. They purred as they nuzzled her abdomen.

"How many does that make at this point?" Adora asked half joking.

"Total? 15." Bow answered. "Catra's right. I don't think we have any other choice at this point, Adora."

"Where is Catra?" Adora wondered. Catra would've been in here, waiting for her to wake, like usual. "Or Glimmer." If Catra wasn't here, Glimmer would be.

"They're in Dryl right now." Bow stood to go to the desk, where a small tray of food sat. "Catra didn't want to leave you but Glimmer insisted they go to Dryl for the meetings and such. Melog stayed behind so Catra could monitor your condition." Melog chirped happily, as if announcing they had done their job well. Adora exhaled a laugh and loved on them.

"Okay, so I've been out for a few hours. I didn't think Catra had to leave so soon if Glimmer or Melog was teleporting over to Dryl." Adora muttered to herself. Not usual. But she could sworn the moons hadn't moved from their place in the sky, which they should've at this point…right?

"Actually." Bow handed her a sandwich, one of Lance's creations. She unwrapped it and took a bite as he spoke. "It's been a day and a half." Adora choked, coughing and pounding her chest with her fist. Bow offered her water and rubbed her back as she cleared her airways.

"A day and a half?!" Adora screeched in disbelief. She stared at the ground. She covered her mouth with a hand, her sandwich discarded on the floor. "Why didn't you wake me?!"

"We tried." Bow put his hands in the air. "But we also didn't know what would happen. We were taking shifts watching over you to make sure you were okay." Bow's trackerpad rang. He pulled it from his pocket, answering as Adora took a swing of water.

"She's awake?!" Catra's voice asked from the screen.

"Catra?" Adora asked.

"Thank goodness." Glimmer laughed from the screen. "Catra was about to kill me if I didn't teleport her back to check on you."

"It's not as if you haven't been keeping me here in Dryl or anything!" Catra bit.

"You said you needed to go to Dryl." Glimmer answered.

"Hey, no fighting. We talk things out here." Bow reprimanded. "Adora just woke up and we don't want to overwhelm her."

"How are you feeling?" Glimmer asked.

"I'm fine." Adora said, trying to offer a smile.

"She's not fine." Catra spoke. "She needs water and food."

"How do you know that?" Glimmer asked.

"Her voice. Also, she's dehydrated and hungry as she was asleep for a long time, duh. Ugh, how were we losing to you?!" Melog moved from their place between Adora's legs to sleeping on the bed again.

"Are you two coming back tonight?" Adora moved to be able to see the screen. Catra stood with her arms crossed, dark circles that matched her own. Glimmer held the screen out so both could be seen, looking exhausted but still smiling. Catra shot Glimmer a look.

"I was planning on stopping in to get something, but we might need another day or two."

"What's going on?" Bow asked.

"The…" Glimmer paused, thinking. She sighed before continuing. "The group in the Fright Zone is causing issues. There are threats of an uprising among some of the clones. Scorpia and Entrapta were handling it but…"

"It got out of hand. We're going over tomorrow to settle it."

"I'm coming with you." Adora spoke. Catra shot her idea down quickly.

"Adora, you need to rest." Glimmer said.

"You aren't in any shape to go." Bow tried.

"I can't just lay here. Why don't you get that?!" Adora raised her voice.

"We've got it handled." Glimmer reassured with a smile. "Catra and I can handle it. You need to rest. That's an order."

"Melog." Catra called through the screen. Melog perked up from their place on the bed. "Adora isn't to leave the room. Make sure she rests." Melog meowed in what Adora assumed was agreement. Adora felt her blood pressure rise.

"Catra. Why won't you let me help?"

"Because I need you to get better. I've got this."

"Like you had the meeting?" Catra hissed at Adora's challenge.

"You're in no condition, Adora." Catra grabbed her arm, though Adora knew it wasn't because she was upset. She saw the small flash of pain that crossed her face. "You've been out for a day and a half. You can't just jump back into it."

"Watch me." Adora pouted. She headed towards the door, Bow reaching a hand out to stop her. Melog bounded from their spot and moved to sit in front of the door. Their mane flared red as they sat, waiting for her to make her move. "Catra, tell Melog to move."

Melog shimmered into the air. Adora stood their shocked. She didn't think that would actually work. She went to take another step when Melog shimmered into view again. This time, Catra and Glimmer stood beside them. Catra glared at Adora.

"Ah!" Bow stood abruptly. "You came ba-"

"I'm going, Catra."

"No, you're not." The two locked eyes, daring the other to break. Adora took a step forward, when Catra's foot collided with her chest. Adora flew back, landing on her butt with an OOF! She stared up at Catra, her eyes widening in surprise. Catra stood, her chin in the air and a determined look in her eye.

"Guys." Bow tried before Adora's war cry filled the room. She swept her foot under her, tackling Catra to the ground. They rolled, Catra gasping in pain as her back slammed into the wall. She growled and threw her hands onto Adora's shoulders. She pinned Adora to the ground, locking her legs around Adora's.

"Stop it!" Glimmer shouted, trying to pull Catra off.

"Catra." Adora grunted. She freed her leg, using the momentum to roll them until she was on top. Catra wrestled underneath them, Adora summoning She-Ra's strength to keep her down. "I'm going with you."

"No!" Catra lifted her hand, straining under the weight of Adora's wrist pushing her down. She punched Adora's stomach, causing Adora's form to crumble momentarily. She pushed her until they rolled and Catra sat on top again. She slammed Adora's

shoulders into the ground and got in her face. “I’m not losing you!”

“You’re not losing me!”

“If this continues, I will! I just got you back, Adora! Why are you so determined to rip everything away from me?! You’re no better than Shadow Weaver!” Catra’s face grew slack as her words took hold. Adora fought the tears that threatened to show.

“Enough!” Glimmer grabbed Catra’s arm, teleporting them across the room. Catra slumped to the ground, holding her stomach. “Neither of you are making this call. I am.”

“Glimmer, I don’t think that’s a good idea.” Bow warned.

“Adora, you can go with us…” The outrage from Catra paused her before she continued. “BUT, you have to stay back with Entrapta and Bow. You can’t go out into the field with us.”

“Are you kidding me?!” Catra stood, holding her arm across her chest. She winced in pain before shooting a look to Adora. “We can’t take her with us.”

“Entrapta could look over the data and see if there’s anything new.” Glimmer pointed to Adora, both acting as if she wasn’t standing there. “She has had over a month to look over the data for the Runestone plan. Adora can help her with that.” Catra opened her mouth before closing it. She pondered the idea, eyes flitting between Glimmer and Adora. She crossed her arms and looked away.

“I don’t agree with this.”

“I’m going, Catra. You can’t stop me forever. I can’t just sit here. I have to do something.” Adora spoke before she coughed. Her chest ached with residual magic, the energy forming

in her clenching and unclenching her hands. Her body groaned with any extra movement; the fight didn't help her case.

"I've made my call. Now, we're going back to Dryl to finish up. We'll let them know you're joining us in the morning. Come on." Catra yelped as Glimmer grabbed her arm and they were gone.

Bow grabbed hold of her shoulders, supporting her as he helped her to the bed. He waited as she laid down and pulled the covers over her. Melog settled back into their place, laying across her stomach, a rumble deep in their belly.

Exhaustion took hold once more and into the darkness that was sleep Adora fell.

Chapter End Notes

So, the next few chapters are going to be fun. I originally planned for like 15-20 chapters. Something is telling me it's gonna be closer to 30 at least. The more I try to flesh out this idea and make sure it's as canonically correct as I can be, the more I realize I need a little more time to make it work. :) I'm hoping to update in a week. See you then. Pls Comment if you wish, it's really nice and motivating! Thanks for reading!

Dryl, Fights, and Fright Zone

Chapter Notes

> Sorry, it's so late. Honestly, life has been crazy this year, worse than 2020. I'm working on chapter 12 now and I've been planning out the end of this year! I'm hoping to update next week but I'm going to say two weeks to be safe.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 11: Adora

Wind whistled in her ears as Adora leaned against Swiftwind's neck. Despite sleeping for several more hours, exhaustion still weighed heavily on her body. Bow held his hands around her waist, for security as well as holding Adora in place. Swiftwind had agreed to a "boring" ride as Adora was still out of it.

Catra and Glimmer were waiting on them and whatever was going on wasn't good. Adora stared at the ground below them, watching it pass as she thought about the argument yesterday. She wondered what Catra had done when Glimmer took her back to Dryl. She had wished they'd had the time to talk or something last night. Catra hadn't answered any of her messages. Adora wondered what she was supposed to do.

"Hey, there's Dryl." Bow moved one of his hands from her waist to point. The castle came into view as Swiftwind began their descent. Adora's chest tightened as Glimmer's silhouette appeared. She waved them down from her spot outside the castle gate. Catra wasn't with her.

"Hey!" Glimmer smiled as they landed. Bow slid off first, then offering Adora a hand. She took it, ignoring the comments her mind made about her being weak. She wasn't

weak. Needing her friends to help her wasn't being weak. "I'm glad you two arrived safely. Did you sleep at all?" The question was aimed entirely for Adora.

"Yeah. I'm better." She tried for a smile. She wasn't going to tell them about the continual throbbing in her sternum or the continuous headache that surfaced yesterday. "Where's Catra?"

"When we got back, she went to see Entrapta and Scorpia and wouldn't let me in. She stormed to her room shortly after and I haven't seen her since. I figured it'd be best to give her space." Glimmer shrugged.

"Yeah, Catra doesn't seem to be the type to want company when she's angry…" Bow remarked.

"Where's her room? I want to see her." Adora started for the gate.

"Wait," Glimmer grabbed her arm and sighed. "I'll teleport you there. The castle is still a maze, though the marks Scorpia made help to navigate it. Bow?" He put a hand on Glimmer and Adora's shoulders.

"Adora?" Swiftwind called before they left. "I'll be in the meadows close by, call me if you need me."

"Will do, Swifty. Thanks." Adora smiled to him. He neighed and took to the air, dust kicking up from his position.

"To Catra's room." Bow announced like Seahawk would and the magic enveloped them.

All of the guest rooms in Dryl were supposedly identical, though Adora knew Catra's room could no longer be included in that statement. Claw marks ravaged the walls, moonlight peaked through the shorn curtains. The room itself was nice enough or should've been based on Glimmer's word. A bed sat on the main wall, flanked by two

shelves filled with robot parts and pieces. The shelves were missing shelves, the little pieces and parts scattered across the floor. A pair of sitting chairs and a small table were supposed to be off to the left, based on the carpet marks. One of the chairs had a broken leg and now sat near the dresser and shattered mirror on the right wall, the broken leg mixed with the glass shards. A closet on the left wall between the chairs and bed, sat open, some of the clothes inside torn to pieces and left.

"Woah." Bow was the first to speak.

"Catra?" Adora stepped forward, glass shards crunching underneath her foot. She lifted it in the air, a broken frame lying there. She bent down and shook the picture from the broken glass. Lifting it up, it revealed a poor drawing of Scorpia, Entrapta and Catra. The words Super Pal Trio were written in large letters underneath the figures.

"Scorpia drew it." Glimmer informed them. "Well, she said she recreated it based on one she did when they worked together in the Horde all that time ago. There's one just like it in Scorpia and Entrapta's rooms."

"If Catra's not here…then where is she?" Adora held the picture close to her chest.

"The only other place she would be is Entrapta's lab."

"Let's go." Adora paused, looking at the drawing once more. She reluctantly placed it onto the table and rejoined them. Once again, the imagery shimmered and Entrapta's lab appeared before them.

"AH!" Entrapta's scream filled the air. Bow drew his arrow, nocking it quickly, Glimmer summoned her magic blasts, glowing around her fists. Adora's staff clicked into place.

"I told you to be careful!" Catra snapped, the group turning to the sound of their voices.

"Are you okay?" Scorpia was bent over Entrapta, who was holding something in her hand. Catra stood off to the side, pinching her nose. Her left sleeve was missing, another item Adora was sure ripped in Catra's war path. Several other rips and tears filled her clothes, her hair was pulled back in a small ponytail at the base of her neck.

"It's the same program! I didn't think they'd use the same program but it's the same neural network that I decoded earlier! It shouldn't take me that long this time then!"

"Scorpia," Catra spoke again, pulling their attention. "Go take care of that." She pointed to one of Scorpia's claws.

"I'm good. It doesn't hurt me." Scorpia laughed boisterously. Catra nodded once and turned to look at something on the rack behind them. Scorpia took care of whatever was causing a small stack of smoke by Entrapta's head.

"Hey." Adora called.

"Adora! Bow!" Entrapta laughed. Catra's fur stood on end, clearly startled. She quickly shut a few of the books and programs from the screen. Scorpia and Entrapta walked towards them, despite Catra's attempts at hiding their work.

"Catra?" Adora asked. She shared a look with the others before walking towards the work space.

"Stay over there." Catra barked. Adora blinked and stepped back. "It's dangerous over here. Give me a second." She clicked a few more programs closed, the light fading from Entrapta's screens and rolled shut a map off the central console before turning.

The dark circles under her eyes were still there, sleep clearly evading her. Adora hadn't slept well either, the dream of Little Sister playing over and over in her mind. Catra looked exhausted, looking as bad as Adora felt. She ran her hands over

her hair, brushing some of the pieces framing her face back before they fell back into place.

"Hi." She padded her way over to Adora, arms crossed in the defiance.

"Hey. Did you sleep at all last night?" Adora knew it was a stupid question. "Your room was a mess."

"You went into my room?!" Catra's face contorted in anger. "What were you doing in there?!"

"Glimmer said you went there last night, and I wanted to see you." Adora's fists closed. "Am I not allowed to go looking for my girlfriend?!"

"You didn't think to come here first!?"

"Well, you're clearly hiding something! You wouldn't have closed all of those things first if you weren't!" Adora pointed to the racks Catra had been at. Catra's tail lashed.

"I was trying to make sure it was safe for you to come over."

"Don't lie to me." Catra's eyes widened at Adora's accusation.

"What makes you think I'm lying?"

"You're not telling me everything, clearly."

"I don't have to."

"Yes, you do. We're together now and we're supposed to work together on these kinds of things!" At least that's what Bow and Glimmer said.

"So, I'm the…" Catra stopped, clasping her hands in front of her. She took a deep breath and pointed her fingertips at

Adora. “I’m not arguing with you on this right now. We have stuff to do.”

“We have to deal with it at some point, Catra.” Adora said as Catra tried to walk past her. She gripped Catra’s wrist, Catra’s head whipping around to glare at her. “Stop keeping things from me.”

“I’m not keeping things from you.” Catra scoffed. “You never had a lot of faith in me, you know that. I’m keeping my half of the promise.”

“I’m keeping mine too.”

“Are you?” Catra laughed, the high-pitched sound echoing in the chamber. “You haven’t done anything that would actually help you and anytime we get close to doing something, you call it off.”

“I’m not-”

“How are you supposed to watch out for me if you’re dead?!” Catra screamed, silence ensuing. Both stood there, panting as anger and tension filled the space between them. “I told you, I won’t lose you again.”

“I’m not going to let you do this again, Catra.”

“If I’m going to be the villain, so be it.” Catra spat. Adora recoiled before determination set. She grabbed Catra and pulled her into a bear hug. Lukkia had told her if she wasn’t sure what to do when she was anger and wanted to punch something, to hug it really tight. She said it was just redirecting the force she wanted to exert into something less harmful.

Catra squirmed in her arms, hissing and pushing her away. Adora held her grip until Catra stopped struggling. She stood there, her head against Adora’s chest. It was at this point that Adora realized Glimmer had taken the others to give them space.

"Will you let me help?" Adora asked after a moment passed. A growl purred through Catra's body, Adora feeling her fists clench and unclench against her own legs.

"Please let me go." Catra's voice broke on the last word.

"I want us to talk." Adora felt her grip loosen from sympathy but held fast.

"I need space." Catra shook a little. "Please." Adora released her, Catra stepping several feet back, hugging herself. She sat on the floor, her head nestling into her knees. She took a shaky breath as her hands clamped over her ears. Adora chastised herself for not realizing what she had done.

"I'm sorry." Adora took a seat on the floor, curling into herself in an identical fashion. "I didn't notice."

"It's not your fault." Adora knew it was one of their therapy lines, but she still felt guilty.

"Which one?" She asked, tightening her grip around her legs in preparation.

"The Glove. The marks I left on your back." Catra's voice was soft, but the words hit Adora like a Horde Bot. She remembered the moment, flashing before her eyes.

She grabbed Catra as Prime tried to throw her from the ledge, pulling her close. Tears filled her eyes, replaced with a cry of pain as Catra's claws raked down her back. She could feel the blood pooling as Prime spoke through Catra.

"Oh Adora, how long will you drag this out? You will destroy the ones you love in the process."

Adora yelled and punched the floor, leaving a small crater. She watched the left-over magic trail into the air before the familiar tinge sparked in her body. Her heart raced and her own

body shook with anger and hatred for Prime and what he had done to Catra.

"Can I help?" Adora asked, her voice smaller than before. She watched as Catra trembled, seemingly ignoring her question. "Do you need space?" She ran through the list of things Lukkia had suggested would help during a panic attack.

"Adora," Catra's hands slowly dropped from her ears. She came to meet her eyes, taking a steadying breath. "I can't tell you. I know that if I tell you everything…you'll stop me and I can't do that. I have to do this. You're the only telling me all the time what I have to do. So let me do it."

"Then let me help you. I just…" Adora curled her arms around herself once more. "I don't like being in the dark about things. All of my life I've been kept in the dark. About the Horde and what they were doing. How I was pulled through a portal and I'm really a First One. Even about the Sword and She-Ra herself. No one will tell me anything. Please don't leave me out of this too, Catra."

They locked eyes again, staring into the other in the silence. Catra's fingers tapped against her thigh as she sat there thinking.

"I'm planning on how we're destroying the Runestones." She finally admitted as she rested her head against her knees. She looked to the side, where the others had been. "Entrapta is working on simulations to lower the risks. Scorpia's just helping us. I know that if I told Sparkles or the others, they'd stop me. Her little council is convinced I'm trying to destroy the planet." Catra pouted as she looked back to Adora. "I think I would've done it sooner or just let Prime do it if that was my goal."

Adora giggled a little, despite the severity of the sentence. Catra joined her before silence fell again.

"The attacks are more consistent aches than intensity. I feel like…" Adora paused, searching for the right words. "I'm dying. I'm scared and I can't be. I have to get better. Everyone needs me."

"Adora." Catra shifted to her knees and crawled over to her. Adora spread her legs open to create a space for Catra to cuddle with her. Catra leaned against her chest as Adora wrapped her arms around her. "I need you to trust me and please…" She paused. "Stay?"

"Always."

"Promise?"

"I promise." Adora kissed the top of her head. Catra's body wiggled slightly before she curled into Adora's body further. Adora chuckled before they toppled backwards. Catra laid on top of her chest. Adora couldn't help the smile that built as she wrapped her legs around Catra's. They curled into each other, filling the space the other couldn't.

Before Adora knew it, she was asleep again. The last thing she registered was Catra's purr vibrating through her own body.

When she awoke, she and Catra were in a guest room. Catra's, based on the cluttered mess around them. Catra still slept, her breathing slow and steady in a way that calmed Adora. How long had it been they had both slept like that? She glanced out the window, seeing Moonset creeping upon them. She raised her head as much as she could without waking Catra, seeing two small trays of food on the table.

Very carefully, she untangled herself from Catra, placing clumps of the blanket in Catra's arms to help fill the temporary void. Her stomach growled as she tip-toed over to the trays. Melog's head shot up from the end of the bed, a soft meow

just as Adora picked up one of the knifes from under the tray lid. She turned, almost throwing it at Melog before her brain caught up to her body. She sighed and placed the knife down. She touched her forehead with her palm; she needed to wake up. A small white paper caught her attention.

Adora and Catra,

We made you some food. When we found you two asleep, we didn't want to wake you, so Glimmer took you back to the room. Catra didn't even react to it. (Adora looked back at Catra before continuing) *When you two wake up, feel free to come find us. We'll probably be in Entrapta's lab or in our rooms for the night. Catra should know how to get to them if nothing else.*

Sweet dreams.

Bow, Glimmer, Entrapta, and Scorpia.

Adora couldn't help but smile at the note that sat upon her food. It was small meat buns like Glimmer made them on Darla with a fizzy drink of Entrapta's. Adora sneaked a peak at Catra's tray to see the same plate made for her. She shrugged as she returned the tray down, grabbed a single bun, and re-trayed hers. She turned back to the bed, to see Catra sitting up and stretching. She held the bun in her mouth, frozen at the sight of her girlfriend.

"Hey Ado-" Catra stopped as she laughed at the stupid pose Adora knew she was making. "What are you doing?"

"Nothing." Adora mumbled though the food in her mouth. "How'd you sleep?" She gulped down her bite as Catra stretched on the bed.

"Honestly, best in a while. You?"

"Same." Adora smiled as she sat beside her. Catra shook out her hair and turned to Adora.

"Where?"

"I'll grab it." Adora stood up again.

"I can get it. I was just asking where you got it?" Catra laughed as she watched her girlfriend dance over to the food trays and come back. Adora bowed as she opened one of the trays.

"Princess." Adora giggled before the pillow smacked her head. Catra pouted, her cheeks burning red.

"I told you not to call me that! And you're the Princess, not me."

"It's funny." Adora chuckled as she placed the tray down. Catra snatched a bun and ate it looking away from Adora. Adora took another for herself.

"We slept most of the day…" Catra commented after a moment.

"Yeah." Adora swallowed her food and reached for one of the fizzy drinks. "I guess we'll go down to the Fright Zone thing tomorrow."

"You're staying back with Entrapta." Catra reminded. "She said there's some tests she wants to run while we're gone."

"We're not going to be monitoring you the whole time?!" Adora panicked. What was she supposed to do if they needed her or needed support?

"Hordak will, I guess." Adora sat back, stunned. She had forgotten about Hordak in the whole mess that had been her life. "He's been here the whole time. Apparently, that's part of his recovery path, like mine is the Keeper of She-Ra thing." Catra waved her hand in the air in a rolling motion. "It also took him some time to recover from the whole…" Her voice dropped off as her ears fell. "Yeah."

"So, I'm hanging out with Entrapta and Hordak tomorrow. That'll be fun." Adora tried to lighten the mood. Catra snorted and rolled her eyes.

"Come on, dork. We should try to sleep more while we can." Catra patted the spot next to her. Adora cleared the dishes, replacing them on the table. She walked back to the bed, an evil idea sparking. She smirked and crouched on the mattress. Melog meowed at her, showing the same curiosity that Catra's face held. But Catra realized what it was a second too late.

Adora pounced. Catra yelped as Adora grabbed her waist and tickled her. Catra's giggles filled the air before she broke free of Adora's iron grip. She huffed and set her counterattack. The two spared on top of the bed, Melog jumping off to avoid being hit.

Adora fidgeted in her chair, watching the screen with hawk eyes as the group advanced towards the Fright Zone. Glimmer had teleported Bow, Catra, and Scorpia close to the area and now they were approaching on foot.

Entrapta was running around, giggling manically as she prepared different tests for Adora to complete. Hordak stood off to Adora's right, typing away on the computer. He was dressed in purple attire that Adora wasn't sure how it was all connected. She figured the word Tunic would be the best word based on Bow's description that morning. He looked exhausted but better than she did.

The extra sleep and getting to cuddle with Catra had done her good. Though the small attack she'd had that morning, hidden in the bathroom from Catra, had sapped some of her strength.

"Hordak," Scorpia's voice came over the speakers. "How are we doing?"

"Just fine, Forc-Scorpia." He paused. "Everything appears to work correctly. Please precede."

"That's so weird." Glimmer whispered.

"We can hear you, your majesty." Hordak muttered. Glimmer eeped and moved away from the camera. Catra laughed softly before her hand went out to stop the group.

"We're here." She crouched, the rest following suit.

Entrapta flipped around Adora, hooking her up to a few machines. Adora didn't mind, her attention rapt on the screen.

"I don't see anything?" Glimmer whispered harshly.

"Sh!" Catra silenced. She pointed a finger off to the right. Scorpia panned the shot over as Hordak zoomed in. Adora shuddered with a chill as the camera cleared.

There were at least 200 clones milling about. All of them still in the Horde white uniforms. Prime's flags hung throughout the area and holograms of him flickered around different areas.

"That's just one part of the Fright Zone." Catra said grimly. Adora nodded her head, though she knew the others couldn't know that. If there were 200 here, how many more would there be elsewhere? What did the rest of the Fright Zone look like? "We need to be careful."

"Where can we get in then?" Bow asked as he typed away on his trackerpad. "There should be an entrance nearby." He showed the screen to Catra, who shook her head.

"It's closed."

"Which route?" Adora asked.

"Hallway 374." Bow read off.

"Catra's correct." Hordak spoke. "It's collapsed. You won't be able to access the area. Area sector 173 would be your best bet."

"That's pretty far!" Adora exclaimed. "What do you mean? 374 should be open."

"It collapsed in our...disagreement." Catra shot a look at the camera. "Though we should be able to go in through the nearby weapons bay."

"Oh, I know what you're meaning." Scorpia nodded. "This way." She waved her pincer and the group moved silently through the last of the Whispering Woods.

Adora jumped as Melog brushed her leg, laying their head on her thigh.

"Catra, why is Melog here?" Adora hissed.

"So, I can monitor your condition." Catra waved off her question. "And Glimmer took us so we're fine."

"You didn't think they could help you get through their invisibly?"

"Is this really the time for an argument?" Catra bit at the camera before continuing. Adora huffed and crossed her arms. Her other leg bounced with nervous energy.

Entrapta sat on the side, typing into a screen. She attached a monitor cuff to Adora's bicep before placing a circle with wires on to her head.

"Okay, we're looking to find who's leading this. Keep that in mind." Glimmer whispered.

"No, Sparkles. We're here for movie night with the- Yes, we're here to do that!" Catra snapped.

"I'm just saying." Glimmer bit back. She and Catra glared at one another before Bow interrupted them. He pointed to an open door about 300 feet ahead. Adora recognized it immediately, the weapons bay they could enter with.

"Just be careful. The majority of this area is delicate." Catra whispered as she checked the different directions.

"Don't forget the perch!" Adora hissed. Glimmer shot a confused look to the camera but Catra nodded.

"Already cleared. I'm going first. Bow, cover me." Catra pointed to the perch, a small area one story above the bay door. It was a place that they had often sat and hit passing cadets with rocks or debris for fun as kids. All the cadets knew about it.

Bow nodded and with one last look to the camera, Catra sprinted towards the opening. Adora saw a clone on guard duty approaching from the right. She opened her mouth to say something but Catra skidded to a stop, flinging herself behind a large stack of boxed supplies. She crouched down, ears flickering as she listened.

Adora's fingers gripped the chair in anticipation. The guard moved on, all of them breathing a sigh of relief as they hadn't shown any signs of noticing Catra. Catra motioned two fingers to each side. Scorpia looked and waved her on. Catra nodded and continued, sliding on the ground into the bay. She hooked her fingers around the frame and jumped up to hide behind it. A drone passed overhead a moment later.

A small zap of electricity shocked Adora's arm as she absentmindly realized Entrapta was working on her tests, whatever they were. Adora didn't care. She was too focused on the screen, the feeling of helplessness weighing on her heavily.

Catra stepped into the bay for a moment, disappearing from sight before reappearing. She gave a small thumbs up. The camera turned to static briefly as Glimmer teleported the group across.

"You know we could've just done that."

"If we had, the sensors would've gone off." Catra pointed to a nearby numbered pad. "I still had access and had to disable them so you could."

"If we're just here to talk, why don't we just find the nearest clone?" Glimmer asked.

"We tried that." Scorpia rubbed her jaw. "They didn't like us very much."

"If we find their base, we could find the leader and speak to them though." Bow mused.

"Or shut them down." Catra added. "This way." She led them towards the next door, briefly typing into the pad at the door. The door slid upwards, and they advanced, repeating this process several more times.

"I thought the doors were automatic." Bow asked as they approached Hordak's sanctum.

"They should be." Scorpia answered for Catra. "But I guess they must've changed it."

"It's lockdown procedure from…" Catra trailed off. "We're getting closer so passwords are needed anyway."

"I'm surprised we haven't seen anything yet." Glimmer spoke. She held her fists in front of her, ready to strike at any point. "I was kinda hoping to hit a few of them."

"Join the club." Catra chuckled. The door slid open, revealing the last hallway before Hordak's sanctum.

"I have finally gotten the program to work, please be careful. Several bodies are moving your way." Hordak spoke.

"What program?" Adora asked Entrapta.

"Oh, the thermal. I'm not sure why it wasn't picking them up earlier." Entrapta answered without looking up.

"I had not added the clone's signature yet. That is my mistake." Hordak apologized.

"Hordak." Catra hissed as she turned to the screen. "Did you change the password?" They stood at the door, wide in the open from three halls.

"It is the same as it has always been." Hordak said in confusion.

"Ugh, hold on." She turned and paused, typing in something after a moment. The pad turned green and the door slid open.

"What was it?" Glimmer asked.

"I guessed…" Catra answered, though Adora could tell it wasn't the whole truth. She made a mental note to ask Catra later. "Now we…"

The sight before them shocked them all into silence. Hordak's sanctum was no longer his workshop, most of his work destroyed. Instead, white and green Horde flags filled the room and stadium like seats had been added around the throne. A large wall of screens, like those on the Velvet Glove, sat behind the throne seat now, the sight making Adora sick to her stomach with its similarity.

A large, raised circle sat in the middle of the room, two panels closed over its top. The small, raised sides around it framed it like a wreath. A sinking feeling filled Adora's stomach.

Something was wrong and it had to do with whatever was under those panels.

"What in the…" Glimmer spoke first. Scorpia had kept the camera facing forward so it took a second for Glimmer to step into view. "I thought they had only been here for a week?"

"Clones work very quickly." Hordak reminded them with distaste in his tone. "A few left a month ago, most of them last week. They must have started this as soon as they arrived."

The camera finally paned over to see the group. Bow was using his trackerpad to record information. Glimmer and Catra had gone up to the screens, the small sparkles telling of Glimmer's magic. Scorpia helped Bow as he connected to the nearest computer.

"Oh No." Catra's voice echoed in the chamber, causing Scorpia turn the camera up. She was racing down the stairs, Glimmer on her heels. "We need to go. We need to leave now!"

"What's wrong?" Adora asked.

"Wait, something's loading on the screen. I just need a second." Bow said.

"I don't know." Scorpia looked between them anxiously. "Catra's normally right about this."

"Bow!" Catra screeched as she nearly collided with him, the momentum from running catching up with her. She grabbed the pad and started to pull. "We have to go now!" Panic filled her voice as she locked her eyes on the circle.

"Catra, what's wrong?" Glimmer held her magic up, looking for the enemy to fight.

"There's something here." Bow tried again. He glanced at the camera. "Hordak, Entrapta, are you two seeing this?!"

Hordak proceeded to pull up the screen, allowing Adora to finally join in somehow. The cords connecting to her and Entrapta dropped, forgotten, as Entrapta's hair vaulted her over to Hordak's side.

"Oh, this is fascinating! This looks like data from Horde Prime's system. This is…" Entrapta trailed off as something sounded on the other side of the screen. Adora's breath caught as the doors slammed shut in an ominous fashion.

"GET OUT NOW!" Hordak screamed. But it was too late.

"Brothers." Another clone's voice spoke from somewhere in the sanctum. "How blessed a day for you to join us in Horde Prime's glory!"

"Prime is dead!" Glimmer shot an energy blast towards the right. Scorpia dropped the camera, giving them a sideways view of the room as she fended off an attacking clone.

"No." Catra moaned off screen, tears and hopelessness filling her voice. "Not again."

"Catra. We need to go." Bow spoke, clearly trying to help her. He moved into the screen, picking it up to talk to them. His other arm was wrapped around Catra, holding her up. Her eyes glassed over as tears fell down her face. "Hordak, you have our coordinates right?" An explosion sounded behind them, Glimmer's war cry echoing in the aftermath.

Adora gripped the chair tightly. Melog's mane had turned bright red, showing the obvious truth of Catra's emotions.

"Hello," Prime's voice echoed in the chamber, freezing everyone into place. Adora rose from her chair and stepped towards the screen. It wasn't possible. "You miscalculated, She-Ra." The words slithered down her spine the same they had the first time she had heard them. "If you wish to know what will

happen next…." Prime's voice mused. "Why don't you ask our little sister…"

Hordak jumped. Catra broke from her stupor with a horrified look on her face. Panic filled her eyes in a way Adora had only seen once before.

The panels over the circle shifted loudly, drawing everyone's attention to them. Catra's fur stood on end and her shaking was visible to Adora, whose palms leaked of blood as she tightened her grip further. As the panels pulled back, retracting into the raised sides, a pool of green water opened before them.

The same pool from her dream.

The same pool Little Sister was shocked.

The same pool that Catra saw in her nightmares.

The same pool he tortured her in.

Catra and Little Sister…

Adora's blood turned to ice as it hit her harder than a Horde bot. Why Hordak had told them to get out, Catra's instincts to get out and her horror…the data from the trackerpad.

"ARGH!" Catra's scream ripped her from her thoughts to watch in her own horror as the scene unfolded. Catra had charged the nearest clones, her claws shredding their clothes and skin. Scorpia summoned her lighting, repelling clones nearing her and Bow. Bow, desperately, grabbed for their things and scanned the pad, looking for a way out. Glimmer and Catra attacked, slashed, blasted, and torn through the opponents.

Suddenly, a clone grabbed the back of Catra's neck and threw her to the ground, the air escaping her lungs in the form of a cry. She struggled as two more pinned her legs and arms. Glimmer rushed to her side, to get blindsided by a blast from bot. She tumbled to the side, skidding to a stop with a

groan. Scorpia threw her lighting, keeping Bow close as they tried to move towards them.

"And now, She-Ra." Prime's voice dragged out her title. "Your friends will suffer because of you." The clones pinning Catra raised her, slowed by her struggling. She screamed, clawed and bit, but was clearly overpowered by panic and the multitude of hands.

"No! NO! STOP! GET OFF ME! NOT AGAIN! I-I CAN'T…."

"CATRA!" Adora's scream echoed in the room as the screen went black. The last shot Adora had of her was her hanging over the pool, green highlighting her in a wicked light. Adora's hand stretched out as if she could save Catra from her position in Dryl.

"What happened?" Adora growled to Hordak and Entrapta. Entrapta was typing furiously, engrossed in her work to restore the connection.

"We need to get them out of there!" Hordak spoke. "That's a reconditioning pool."

"A reconditioning pool?" Adora swallowed, her eyes flying between him and the darkened screen. That didn't make sense to her. Why would Catra be thrown into a reconditioning pool before she was chipped?

"Yes, Catra and Scorpia are the most at risk. They will be easily chipped and turned once more." Adora stared at her palms, her heartbeat slowly becoming the only sound she could hear. Hordak's voice drained away as the thumping in her ears grew louder. She could vaguely see the blue glow that enveloped her as She-Ra responded to her anger, her love, her desperation to save them.

Mew!

Adora spun on her heels, her eyes growing wide at the sight of Melog. They wore a determined look in their eyes. They cocked their head, almost begging Adora to understand them. She smiled and cried at the same moment as understanding took hold.

Melog's shimmer enshrouded as the world melted away. Hordak's faint cry to wait was lost as the Fright Zone became their area. The same room Catra and the others were in. The green pool glistened as if it were the only light in the room.

"ADORA!" Catra's yell was the first thing she could hear after Melog's magic had completed. She spun to see her, the clones holding her above the pool, primed to throw her in. The look in Catra's eyes of panic, horror, and anger sprung Adora into action.

"No!" A voice cried as the clones released Catra. The world moved in slow motion around Adora, her heart setting the pace. Each thump echoed in the room, magic pulsing around her. She sprinted, diving over the pool. Her arms outstretched to catch Catra, wrapping around her in anxious relief. They tumbled to the other side as the world resumed its normal time.

The clones stared at her with dumbstruck faces as she stood with Catra in her arms, bridal style. It was then, she realized she was standing before them as She-Ra for the first time in months. Magic raced through her veins, her She-Ra glow increasing. She looked down to Catra, who clung to her clothes and stared into her with a fearful expression.

"Adora?" She asked in a small voice. Adora held her close, lifting her enough to touch foreheads.

"I'm here." She imagined all the good memories they had together, healing magic rushing through her to Catra.

"She-ra!" Glimmer yelled, breaking Adora's concentration. Adora fought the urge to shoot her a nasty look when she remembered where she was and why she was currently

She-Ra. Right, she had a horde of clones to defeat. She snickered inwardly at her joke.

"YEAH!" Scorpia bellowed as red lightning sparked and crackled around the clones. Catra clung to her a little tighter, causing Adora to make a mental note to talk about that later.

"Prime!" Adora's voice as She-Ra echoed in the ceiling. "Let me make it clear." She glared at the remaining clones, the few who still stood among the many fallen. "You will not win. And I will beat you again. And if you EVER" Magic rippled through the room in a shockwave. "touch my friends again…" The threat hung in the air, clearly not needing to be finished.

Prime's laughter shocked them.

"We shall see."

The clones retreated without another word, slinking into the shadows. Their green eyes fading as the last thing to be seen of them. The remaining clones were quickly rounded up by Scorpia and Glimmer and tied to different posts. Bow was able to reconnect with Hordak and Entrapta, shocked by the sudden turn of events.

As Hordak and Bow were finally able to close the pool, Catra relaxed. Melog paced circles around Adora, their aura a muted red. Catra's claws still dug into Adora's skin, clearly not wanting to be let go. Not that Adora was ready to put her down either.

"I guess it was a good thing, Melog stayed behind." Scorpia tried.

"Yeah." Adora huffed. "It was." The reality of events brought tears to her eyes, that she blinked hard to hide them. How was Prime back? She knew she had ended it when she cast out his unconsciousness. She repressed her emotions, choosing to focus on Catra and getting everyone back safely.

"Let's get everyone back here. We'll figure this out another day." Hordak said, agreement an unspoken thing amongst them.

"Come on." Glimmer gathered them around Adora and Catra before teleporting them back to Dryl. The familiar sounds and smells of robotics was comforting compared to the sterile environment she had been hit with previously.

"Adora." Bow touched her arm. "You should transform back."

"I-" She looked down to Catra, who clung to her.

"I'll take her for a second." Bow smiled as he held out his arms, passing his trackerpad to Glimmer. Adora looked between them and Catra, anxiety taking hold. Slowly, Catra's claws retracted enough that Bow could take her for the moment. He held Catra as they waited for Adora to drop She-Ra.

She closed her eyes, fighting all the instincts in her that told her to keep fighting. She needed to beat Prime, but she knew exhaustion from the Heart was coming. She knew it was the only thing that had helped her to get to Catra in time. She hushed the voice in her head and released She-Ra magic for now, shrinking into her normal size.

She opened her eyes, exhaling slowly. She stood there, waiting for any reaction to happen. She looked at her hands and up and down her arms. She turned in a circle and nothing. She wasn't as exhausted or dead inside like she had been the last time she had trained with She-ra.

"Huh." Glimmer put her hands on her hips. "I guess it all worked out. I'm glad you're okay."

"We need to get to work then." Adora turned to look at Catra with a smile. Catra gave her a tiny, tired smile, her hand reaching out. Adora's hand stretched to meet it when-

“AH!” She screamed as the failsafe shone on her body. Her body burned as electricity crackled around her body. She dropped, her face hitting the cold ground.

“ADORA!”

Chapter End Notes

I know this chapter is supposed to be Catra's point of view but it'll make sense soon. :) Another cliffhanger and I'm warning you now, chapter 12 will have a cliffhanger ending as well. Anyways, feel free to leave comments. Thanks for reading and hopefully see y'all soon. :)

Awakening

Chapter Notes

> Hi everyone, I live. I'm sorry for the month absence. I was working on chapter 12 when I went to check the show's lore to make sure I was in canon as much as can be. Well, my entire plotline had to be scrapped. Cue panic and rewrites and planning. So I have spent the last month redoing the entire plotline for this Year and reworking everything that's already been established. When I tell you I've written and scrapped over 100 pages of writing this month...yeah.
> So enjoy this short chapter. Everything will make sense soon.
> :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 12: Adora

The moonlight glittered through the sheer curtain, cloaking the bed in a ray of soft light. Adora grumbled as she sat up, rubbing her eyes. She ran her hands over the sheets, cold and barren. She glanced at the spot where Catra should've been. Looking around, she realized she laid in her own bed in Bright Moon, so Catra should've been there. Yet there was no sign of her or Melog.

Adora brushed the sheets to the side, her feet frozen upon hitting the cold floor. She slid her hand under the pillow for her knife. She tip-toed to the door, double checking her surroundings. She creaked the door open slowly. Glancing into the dark, empty hallway, Adora slipped through and closed the door softly. She sneaked down the hall, sticking close to the wall. Her own light source was the moonlight dripping in from open windows.

She approached the first common room. She cracked open the door and looked inside. Empty. She closed it and

continued to the next. The pattern continued, passing the empty guests rooms and even Glimmer's room was empty. Adora took a shaky breath but continued. Now, she was looking for Catra, Bow and Glimmer. Other questions popped into her mind.

Where was everyone else? No guards?

How had she returned to Bright Moon?

What happened after she passed out?

Had anyone other than Catra been injured at the Fright Zone?

Did Entrapta find anything?

How was Prime back?

Her mind ran a million miles an hour as she tried to continue quietly down the halls. She came to the War Room, pausing at the sight of light coming through the bottom of the door frame. She approached the door, lightly pressing her ear against it. No voices or sounds she could make out. She gulped and reached for the hand. Turning it slowly, she cracked open the door with no sound.

Glimmer sat alone at the table, reviewing something on the screen and papers stern around her. She wore a determined look but Adora couldn't help but noticed the white bandage that wrapped around Glimmer's forehead. A small dark patch confirmed Adora's fear. Glimmer had been injured during the fight. Adora thought back to when Glimmer teleported them back. She hadn't seen any wound then. Had something happened after they got back?

Glimmer sighed loudly, slumping across the table. Adora slinked back into the shadows of the door. She glanced around her, the hallway still empty. Glimmer almost always had guards posted around the place. She was queen. The guards were supposed to help protect her so where were they?

Adora curiosity got the better of her. She pushed the door open slightly, the light forcing her eyes shut. Alarm bells went off in her mind. She couldn't see if something was coming.

"Glimmer?" Adora called. Adora sheathed her knife, using her waist band to hold it to her thigh.

"Adora!" Glimmer's voice riddled with relief. As Adora's eyes adjusted to the bright light fully, she was tackled by the Queen. Glimmer laughed as she hugged Adora tightly. "I'm so glad you're okay."

"Where is everyone else?" Adora asked, returning the hug.

"Catra, Scorpia and Bow are down in the infirmary. Catra was fully healed before you collapsed but they went down to get checked over anyway. Bow and Scorpia weren't really hurt, thank the stars." Glimmer chuckled. "I'm just glad you're awake. How are you feeling?"

"I'm fine. How long was I out this time?" Adora braced herself for an answer she wouldn't like.

"About 8 hours, I think."

"That's it?"

"Yeah, one of the shorter ones. Especially, considering what happened."

"What happened after I passed out?" Adora asked. Glimmer sighed and nodded to the table. Adora took a seat on Glimmer's left.

"It totally scared everyone when you collapsed. We had thought it might happen but we're hopeful. Entrapta got to work running tests, though I don't really know what she was doing. We waited around for about two hours, while Entrapta

worked. Catra paced around the whole time." Glimmer giggled. "It reminded me of you."

Adora smiled sadly. She was tired of being pulled away from Catra. She decided once they figured this whole thing out, they were going to have a day just to themselves. Maybe more than a day. A week. A month? Adora shook her head. Focus, she needed to hear Glimmer's story.

"Entrapta told us she wouldn't know right away so we elected to return to Bright Moon to recover. Scorpia came with us to get aid and we called the rest of the Alliance. They're arriving in the morning." Adora glanced around, finding the only clock in the room. It was the middle of the night. Explained why the castle was dark. "Bow took Catra and Scorpia to get checked out and I've been here since." Glimmer sighed. "I was kinda hoping Catra would come look this over with me but…"

"But what?"

"She was pretty shook up by everything." Glimmer deflated. "I don't blame her. Seeing the Fright Zone like that was… I felt like I was back there." Prime's ship. "It felt so sterile and I felt like he was watching me like before." Adora took Glimmer's hand. "I can't imagine what Catra felt. When we were on that platform and she figured out what was going on…the fear in her eyes." Glimmer shook her head.

"We'll figure this out. He can't hurt us anymore."

"I don't know." Glimmer sniffled. "I don't understand how he's back! I know we beat him three months ago. Everything was getting better."

"I'm going to fix this, Glimmer." Adora squeezed her hand.

"Adora," Glimmer pursed her lips, lost for words. "I don't know if this is something you can fix like that."

"Well, I'll fix it either way." Adora offered a smile. Glimmer huffed.

"We're helping you then. Catra was right, you are really stubborn."

"Am not…" Adora pouted. Glimmer laughed. "What happened to your head?"

"I hit it when one of the clones shot at me. It's not as bad as it looks. I picked at it without thinking earlier and it broke open worse than before." Glimmer chuckled nervously. "I'm okay, really."

"If you say so." Adora said. She yawned.

"Still sleepy?"

"Have you even slept yet?"

"I'm planning on it soon."

"What are you reviewing anyway?" Adora picked up a piece of paper. Information from the three months the clones spent in Dryl were spelled out.

"Anything to help figure out what's going on." Glimmer yawned. "I wanted to be ready when the others arrive."

"You should rest too." Adora pushed. "We can go over everything in the morning." The two shared a look, neither willing to back down. Glimmer eventually sighed.

"Fine. I'll go check on the others and send Catra back to your room. You go back to sleep." Glimmer waved her off.

"Yes Ma'am." Adora teased. Glimmer left in a poof of sparkles, leaving Adora to look over the information. She picked up a paper that sat on the other side of the table. It was Glimmer's handwriting.

Senator B ---------- >Catra

Target?

Connection to Fright Zone?

Adora looked around for any other information, shifting through papers. She sat back and growled a little. Adora had seen for herself how Senator Brakenten treated Catra in the last meeting Melog sneaked her into. Catra had said they didn't get along and openly disliked them. But this implied Catra was being targeted? Or is the connection to the Fright Zone about Catra? Does Glimmer think Catra's targeting Senator B? She wouldn't have drawn the arrow towards Catra's name then.

After another few moments, Adora scratched her head and put the paper down. No matter how much she thought it over, she couldn't figure it out. She'd have to ask Glimmer in the morning. Yawning, she finally headed back to her room. She crawled into the cold bed, curling under the covers. Adora slipped the knife back under her pillow. She'd just wait for Catra to join her. Her eyelids soon grew heavy, so much so she barely noticed the door opening.

The door opened with a creak as the figure entered the room. The dark of night shrouded their face as they approached the bed. Adora's eyes fluttered as she struggled to stay awake. She moaned her lover's name as she rolled over.

Her hair clung to the pillow, exposing the lower half of her neck. The figure, looming over her, bent down. They brushed the last few strands away and pulled the little diamond piece out of their pocket. As they placed it over her spine, she shuddered. Now, everything was complete.

It all begins tonight.

The night was silent once more. And then…

An explosion shook the castle.

6 fatalities confirmed.

Chapter End Notes

I did warn you there would be a major cliffhanger at the end of this chapter! Also, thank you to everyone who's commented! I love getting them and it's really encouraging, knowing people like this story! I know it's not the greatest fic out there so all the support is appreciated! Chapter 13 is already begun and I have 13,14,and 15 already mapped out so an update in two weeks should work!
Thank you! See you soon. :)

Unraveling Part 1: Betrayal

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 13: Catra

Why would anything go in Catra's favor? That would actually be nice. But no. No! Everything always had to go wrong for her! Just one day. That was all she wanted.

Catra leapt over the log in her way, the grunts of the clones growing closer. She pushed past brushes and trees. Melog bounded beside her, their mane spiky red. Her lungs burned for air. Her muscles screamed for rest, but she couldn't stop.

The longer she kept them running after her, the more time Entrapta had to work. Scorpia and Hordak should've gotten everyone out of the castle by now. The Ex-Horde members had been hard at work throughout the night. Catra just wished she had connected it all sooner. Maybe if she had, she would've have reached Adora in time.

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1 Month Previous: Bright Moon

Catra clutched her papers to her chest. She sat in the now empty Council room, waiting for Adora to come get her. The idiot had insisted on carrying her everywhere to make up for breaking her leg at the Library. No matter what she did, Catra couldn't convince Adora to let it go. She had finally given in to letting Adora do as she pleased.

"Horde Leader." The voice she disdained spoke to her from the door frame. Senator Brakenten leaned against the wall,

glaring down at her.

"Senator." Catra tapped her papers against the table to straighten them. "How can I help you?" She was not in the mood to deal with them at all, but this was part of her job now.

"What you're suggesting is ludicrous. To destroy all the Runestones for your precious girlfriend is not a good idea."

"And what have idea do you bring to the table then?" Catra narrowed her eyes, choosing her words carefully. She was working on controlling her anger and she wasn't going to let them provoke her.

"Perhaps it would not be such a bad idea for She-Ra to stay connected to the Heart."

"We are not doing that!" Catra stood, pain shooting up her leg. She growled as she sat down. Her leg throbbed. Melog nudged her arm and glared with her at the senator.

"Why not? It would be better for everyone involved. The reconstruction of cities would not be in vain. The ability to defend our planet against the wider universe is important. Are you suggesting one life is more important that the lives of everyone on this planet?"

"When it's Adora. Yes." Catra answered without missing a beat.

"It would seem to me that your judgement is clouded, Royal Strategist." They spit her title. "Your purpose is to safeguard our queen and our planet above all else. Perhaps you should be removed from your place if you can't do so."

"Are you threatening me? That's not a wise decision." Melog growled for emphasis.

"Call off your alien pet." Senator Brakenten waved their hand. "I'm simply stating a fact. The Queen is blind if she

considers you an ally of hers. You are just like the rest of those Horde soldiers. Waiting for your chance to destroy everything we hold dear. I won't allow that."

"Like you allowed it the first time?" Catra racked her claws down the table. "You didn't do anything to stop me then, and you won't this time either."

"So, you admit you're attempting something."

"Am I?" Catra narrowed her eyes in a challenge.

"I have no time for these games!" They huffed, straightening their robes. "It's almost ready so I suppose I can give you an example." They pulled a small green vial of liquid from their jacket. "I assume you know what this is." Catra's blood turned to ice.

"Where did you get that?" Catra gulped softly. Screams and chants played rounds in her ears.

"Wouldn't you like to know?" They sneered. "But it's just as potent."

"It…it only works..."

"If you have the chip?" Senator Brakenten chuckled. "You think I don't know that." They approached the table, until they loomed over Catra. "I suggest unless you want something to happen to your beloved," Catra's fists clenched, her nails embedded in her palms. "You stay out of my way. A word of this, and well…you know what this means."

"Catra?" Adora's voice called from the hall. Catra's eyes shot to the door.

"Of course, your She-Ra." The senator sneered. "Remember what I said, Horde Leader. I'll know."

"Senator!" Catra snapped as they left. She slammed her fist into the table. She picked up the nearest object, a glass of water, and chucked it at the spot they had occupied previously.

"Hey, it's me." Adora ducked as the glass shattered against the wall.

"Sorry." Catra sighed, pressing her fingers against her temples. They couldn't be serious. Entrapta disabled all of the chips. The fluid wouldn't work. She should check though. Just to be safe.

"What happened?" Adora approached the table. She took the seat next to Catra, waiting for an answer.

"Nothing. Just the usual arguments." Catra fixed the papers she realized she had scattered before turning to Adora. "Ready?"

"Yeah." Adora smiled. "You'd…you'd tell me if something was wrong, right?" Catra pursed her lips. Along with her promise to talk to Adora, Lukkia and Markio had told them they had to be open with each other more but also trust the other to speak when they're ready. Adora was clearly trying to give her the space to vent but Catra knew Adora's mindset. Adora would take it upon herself to fix it and wouldn't stop until she did.

Catra couldn't do that to her. She'd deal with it herself. She didn't even know what she was dealing with yet.

"Yeah." Catra held out an arm. Adora nodded and lifted Catra bridal style. "We have dinner with Sparkles tonight, right?"

"Yep. They're making something new tonight." Catra cursed at the thought. Adora laughed. "It's supposed to be good. It's a recipe Lance gave Bow."

"Lance seems pretty nice. I'm sure it won't be as bad then." Catra admitted with a small smirk. Adora rolled her eyes and proceeded towards their room.

Present Day: Whispering Woods

Catra knew she was getting close. They had been going for hours! She wondered how much longer she could keep them on her tail. She swung around a tree, Melog growling as they swiped at a clone. Catra, using the momentum, flew through the air and took two down to the ground. She jumped onto a tree, shooting off to kick another away from her. They couldn't keep this up much longer.

"Melog." Catra panted, her throat dry. Dehydration was becoming a real concern. Melog meowed and teleported them further into the woods. They collapsed in a heap of limbs, air a sweet and fading luxury.

Catra pushed herself to her feet. She was used to going beyond her limits. Shadow Weaver had loved her physical tasks and training drills. She could keep going. Entrapta would send her a signal as soon as they we-

DING!

The small communicator Catra kept in her pocket rang. As Catra tapped the screen, Entrapta's signal appeared. They had made it safely to the Castle. Now it was just Catra's turn. Another ding brought a map, a small indicator flashing her location. Entrapta was a genius.

"They are close." Melog spoke in her mind. Catra's ears twitched as she heard their approach. She nodded to Melog, taking off in the direction of the castle's indicator.

She prayed Adora could hold on until she got there.

Three Weeks Ago: Salineas

Catra sat on Melog's back, overlooking the last of repairs to the Salineas Seagate. She hadn't told Adora about her small day trip to the gate, but she wanted to oversee the last touches herself. It was fitting. Closure on a black mark in her life. She still remembered the pleasure she had gotten from firing the cannons on the gate and the screams that echoed as her soldiers moved into the city.

"You didn't have to come here." Mermista's voice alerted Catra as the Princess approached. She stood next to Catra, arms crossed. "But it's nice to see it finally fixed."

"We couldn't have done it without the hard work of your people." Catra smiled a little, tapping her at screen. "Thank you for the blueprints to fix the statues."

"I didn't know we had them." Mermista admitted. "I stumbled upon them, cleaning a broken part of the castle."

"The rest of the cities are completed?" Catra marked off a few things in on her papers. Sparkles really needed to appreciate all her documentation.

"Yeah." Mermista smiled. "This was the longest project to complete." As they spoke, cheers arose from the gate. Finally done. Catra sighed happily.

"I'm sorry." She sobered for a moment. "I'm sorry for what I did here."

"I can't forgive you yet." Mermista paused. "But thank you."

"I don't think I can ask for anything more." Catra tried for a chuckle. Mermista rolled her eyes.

"SEAHAWK! Do NOT set that ship on fire!" Mermista yelled down suddenly. Catra followed her finger to see Seahawk atop a Salineas naval ship with a flaming stick. He'd paused mid motion, staring at Mermista. "I have to go stop that." Mermista

groaned. She stepped forward to jump off the cliff they were on when she stopped. “Oh, this is for you.”

Mermista pulled a small white satchel from her pocket, dropping it into Catra’s hand. Catra held it up, hoping to see the contents.

“Thanks?”

“Seahawk said to give it to you.” Mermista shrugged. “I don’t know where he got it or what it is so-SEAHAWK, I SWEAR… UGH, I have to go.” Mermista jumped from the cliff. Catra chuckled. She knew what that feeling was like. Adora pulled the weirdest of stunts in her boredom around Bright Moon.

Catra tucked her papers in the small bag Melog had attached to their side. She opened the stachel. Dumping the contents into her hand, she froze. Another small vial of cold green fluids rolled around in her palm. A white paper was tied around the top.

A reminder.

Catra crunched the note, tossing it into the ocean. She gripped the bottle tightly. But where at Seahawk gotten it from if not Senator Brakenten?! Was this their way of telling her that her friends weren’t safe to speak to about this? Catra growled, tucking the vial away. She needed to give this to Entrapta to analyze. She and Hordak would have some ideas about it. But could she even trust Entrapta with this?

She shook her head to attempt to clear the memories of the pool from surfacing. She couldn’t handle a flashback at this moment. Her chest heaved for air as she could feel herself returning to the place. That retched pool.

Melog meowed, teleporting them a few times until they returned to Bright Moon. She collapsed onto her bed, grateful Adora was at the library for another few hours. She curled

into herself, praying she'd survive the wave of flashbacks as they took hold.

Present Day: Crystal Castle

Catra and Melog finally had made it to the Crystal Castle, the agreed upon meeting place. She fell to her knees, panting for air. Morning was coming. Their long night was finally over. The ramp opened slowly, the darkened hallways appearing before her. She struggled to her feet, sharing a quick look with Melog. They descended and waited for the ramp to close behind them before continuing.

Catra's eyes adjusted seamlessly to the dark. They walked the halls, the memories of their last visit here threatening to surface. Catra held a hand to her chest. She tried to slow the heaving of her chest, silencing herself out of habit.

Voices ahead alerted her to the others. Adora's yell stood out. It took everything Catra had not to bolt in the direction of her lover, but her instincts forced her to keep her painfully slow and silent approach.

"We can't keep this up for much longer." Glimmer's voice strained.

"Well, this wasn't part of the plan." Hordak snapped. "We're working on it."

"Work faster!" Glimmer yelped, followed by a grunt. "Scorpia, can't you knock her out again!"

"I'm not sure…." Scorpia answered meekly. "I've already used it a few times. Anymore…" She trailed off. Catra peeked around the corner. She could only see Bow and Scorpia, standing off the side nervously. Glimmer's cape flew into view, wavering in some wind Catra couldn't see. Entrapta and Hordak stood at their makeshift console, working away on the screen.

Entrapta's group of screens glowed with information and codes that Catra couldn't begin to understand.

"Where's Catra anyway!" Glimmer huffed. "I'm going to…"

"Going to what?" Catra sauntered into the room, temporarily relaxed. All of her cockiness drained from her as she saw the true state of things.

Adora in her She-Ra form stood in the middle of a magic cage. She heaved before growling and striking the wall again with her sword. Micah and Glimmer braced themselves to withstand the hit. She-Ra stumbled back, taking a knee. She finally turned towards Catra, a chill sent down the catgirl's back. Green eyes.

"There you are!" Glimmer panted with effort. "Wanna help us?!" Glimmer spun another magic sigil and forced it to the cage. She-Ra groaned as she was forced to the ground via purple electricity.

"Don't hurt her!" Catra rushed forward, grabbing Glimmer's arm.

"We aren't." Micah spoke first. "It won't hurt her. It's an immobilizing spell." Catra, taking a second look, recognized the spell that had been used on her too many times.

"It still hurts." Catra bit. She flexed her nails. How could she trust Glimmer and Micah if they knew Shadow Weaver's magic? They could use it on her and Adora any moment. She scolded herself for not realizing earlier.

"I'm not trying to but figuring out how to fix this would be a good first step." Glimmer snapped. "You wanna fill us in on your plan?" Catra and Glimmer locked eyes, anger sparking. Catra broke first, spinning on her heels.

"Hordak, status update!" She paced over towards the console. She stared at the screen, first one's writing flying across it. She could read most of the writing if it was written in front of her, but this was too fast for her to understand it yet. She clenched her fists in frustration.

"A chipped She-Ra was not in the plan."

"No, really? I never would've thought of that!" Catra answered sarcastically. Hordak shot her a glare, which she happily returned.

"It's like we said last night." Entrapta finally spoke. "The hive mind was built differently this time." A scream from Adora interrupted them. Catra flew around, watching as Adora curled in on herself. Sparks of green jumped her neck, the chip doing the same as it had done to her months ago. Catra touched her own scar, remembering the pain all too well. "The chip isn't the same. The routeways to the hivemind are broken fragments comparatively."

"Entrapta, speed it up." Catra said through clenched teeth, eyes still watching Adora writhe on the floor. She flinched as she watched Micah cast another spell on Adora, this one apparently calming her. Adora stilled unnaturally on the floor.

"The chip is only half working." Entrapta turned around, her hair holding her a foot off the ground. "The reason Adora's hurting is because it's neural network is struggling to hold itself to her. Which means it'll be easier to get off. The only problem is the chip is forcing her to use She-Ra magic. We'd need her to disengage it to get the chip off."

"We are working on a way to cut it in a matter of seconds." Hordak waved his hand. "If we can do this, She-Ra's magic would only need to stop for a moment. Long enough for someone to zap the chip off."

"Why can't you 'zap' it off now?" Scorpia rubbed her pincers together nervously.

"She-Ra is protected by magic." Hordak gritted his teeth. "We can't just take it off with her healing magic in place. It would reform the neural and nerve pathways before we can remove them."

"But removing it from Adora would be fine." Entrapta added.

"So, how are we going to do that?" Bow said. Catra sighed, running her hands over her hair.

"I have an idea."

Three Weeks P reviously: Bright Moon

Catra walked the bridge towards Bright Moon. After the long week she'd had, she needed this night in with Adora. Glimmer and Bow were at the Library, having dinner with Lance and George. Other than the guards and Micah, the castle was theirs. According to Adora, the plan was to attempt to cook a recipe Micah left for them (so foolproof Glimmer can't mess it up supposedly) followed by cuddles. Catra wasn't too sure about the cooking part, but Micah would be on standby to help put out any fires.

Approaching the castle, Catra greeted the guards. They responded, warming her heart that she was slowly earning her way there. She continued through the hallways. Melog padded along side her happily. Despite what had happened in Salineas a few days ago, Catra still felt hopeful. It was just a fluke. It had to be.

She pushed the kitchen doors open in a grand gesture. The empty kitchen coldly greeted her. She looked to Melog before scanning the room again. A few bowls and random boxes of food

laid scattered across the main island. Cookbooks sat open on the counters that lined the main back countertops. She froze when she noticed the small trail of water sneaking out from behind the island.

She crept over to it. Something was wrong but she couldn't place it. Her claws flexed, ready to tear into whatever laid on the other side. She crouched down, creeping around the corner. She shot up with a gasp as she finally saw.

"ADORA!" Catra crashed to her knees beside her. Adora, curled in the fetal position, held her chest, tears welling in her eyes. She wore a purple apron over her regular clothes. The small trail of water came from the measuring cup she had dropped. Catra scooped her into her arms, brushing the loose hair out of her face. Her features contorted in pain, small breathes coming quickly. "Adora, wake up. What happened?"

"Catra?" Adora wheezed as she struggled to open her eyes. "I-"

"It's okay." Melog came around the other side, nudging Adora's feet. "Melog, can you sense anything?!"

"It's a magic surge." Melog spoke in her mind. "But it's not the usual amount."

"I'm okay." Adora pushed herself up, using Catra's knees for support. She quickly fell back into Catra's arms. Catra held her close.

"We need to find a healer." Catra spoke to Melog. They nodded and bounded for the door. She listened as their footsteps faded. "What happened?" She brushed another piece from Adora's eyes, the persistent little wisp. Her braid slowly coming undone.

"I don't know." Adora tried to wipe her eyes. "I was just trying to get started so it wouldn't take as long. Next thing I…" She sharply inhaled, holding back a whimper. "I was here and it just hurt." The failsafe shimmered pink over her clothes.

"It's okay." Catra repeated, more to calm herself. "I'm right here." She cradled Adora's cheek in her palm. "I'm not going anywhere." Adora's face softened.

"Catra?" Micah's voice called from the hall. Melog practically sprinted back into the room. Micah followed behind quickly. "Adora. What happened?"

"She said she just fell. Melog thinks it's a magic surge." Micah took a knee beside Adora. He began drawing a rune over Adora's body. It was one she had seen him draw over Adora before. Something able to monitor her condition, Catra supposed. She held her breath, fighting all of her instincts telling her to stop the spell. To attack him. He wasn't Shadow Weaver. His spells weren't meant to hurt.

"Adora, did that help?" Micah asked as he finished his spell. Adora seemed to relax slightly, the failsafe fading to a low glimmer.

"Yeah." She pushed herself to a sitting position. Catra kept her hands hovering around Adora's back and waist, ready to catch her if needed. "Thank you. I'm sorry."

"I'm glad I was able to help." Micah smiled. "Have you been drinking that tea?"

"What tea?" Catra's eyes flicked between them.

"It was something they suggested after the Mystacor trip." Adora started.

"Even more so after the library accident a week ago." Micah finished. "It's a concoction of different herbs and potions to help with the magic attacks and their effects."

"Does it help?" Catra racked her brain for any moments she had seen Adora drinking any sort of teas.

"A little bit." Adora coughed. "I normally take it in the morning…after you leave for your meetings." She added for

Catra's sake. Catra rumbled softly as Adora continued talking to Micah. Color returned to her face slower than Catra liked.

"Perhaps more testing would be helpful." Micah spoke. "Mystacor's been working around the clock to look for anything useful."

"That's not really necessary." Adora tried. Catra glared at her, forcing Adora to shut up.

"Well, if it helps. It's not my orders." Micah laughed. "It's Glimmer's. She's ordered that all able and available resources be directed to solving this." That was the first Catra had heard of it. She grimaced. Her mind spiraled.

Glimmer told her they would speak about any actions taken. She was the Keeper of She-Ra and that was her job! If Glimmer was moving behind her back…

A small gleam caught Catra's eye. A tiny glass vial rolled underneath one of the cabinets. Her eyes widened. It couldn't…Melog grabbed it for her, holding the closed bottle in their mouth for now.

Micah suggested Adora should rest for the evening. He would finish dinner and have it brought to their room. Adora thanked him, though she was clearly unsatisfied with this idea. Catra forced her to ride on Melog's back as they returned to their bedroom. Catra's leg was still sore for last week, but she ignored it. She walked beside Melog, Adora sitting with her arms crossed on their back.

"I can walk." Adora pouted. "You're the one with the injured leg." Melog dropped the small vial into her hand, Catra shoving it into her pocket quickly.

"I'm fine." Catra assured her with a lie. Melog chastised her. Catra narrowed her eyes at Melog when Adora wasn't looking. Melog rolled their head at her but continued.

As they approached, Adora jumped to her feet. She dodged as Catra tried to stop her and then burst through the door to the bedroom. She spun around with a smug look to Catra before she stumbled. Catra forced herself to run, trying to catch her. Melog appeared behind Adora, helping lower her to the ground.

"Dummy." Catra sighed as she sank to the floor with Adora. The blonde held her head in her palm and gave an idiotic grin. "Come on. Let's get you to bed."

"No." Adora whined. She pouted, but still stood with help from Catra and Melog. She sulked as she walked to the bed. She flopped onto the mattress, staring down Catra. Catra dropped her head in exasperation. She joined Adora on the bed. She pulled out Adora's braid and ran her fingers through it. Adora sat there patiently as Catra played with her hair.

As Catra's fingers ghosted Adora's back, she felt the heat coming off her. Catra pressed her hand to Adora's back, under her shirt. She grimaced and commanded Adora to remove her shoes. Adora did so and laid down, per Catra's next instruction.

Catra went to the bathroom, mentally reviewing how to care for a fever. Adora rarely came down with anything, at least during their time in the Horde. She grabbed a nearby washcloth and ran it under cold water. After a moment, she wrung the pink cloth out and returned to Adora's side. Melog stretched out over Adora's torso, pinning her to the bed. Adora didn't seem to mind as Melog showered her with wet kisses.

Catra paused, taking in the sweet moment. It was almost enough to make her forget about the glass vial in her pocket. Almost.

Adora's fever lasted another few hours, gradually getting worse. Micah brought them soup and more tea for Adora. Catra sipped her coffee, something telling her she would be

awake for the night. She watched Adora's chest rise and fall peacefully. Melog kept their guard over her, snoozing against her chest. She thought of the last time they were in a moment like this…the day of the Heart mission. She shook her head.

The trackerpad she kept in the room buzzed on the desk beside her. She picked it up and tapped the screen.

Message received.

Entrapta's seal followed the words on the screen. She placed it down, so the glare wouldn't wake Adora. Melog raised their head, nodding to Catra's unspoken request. They teleported the small distance to her side. She glanced back at the trackerpad, making the decision to bring it with her. She replaced it with her coffee mug. Melog meowed as they teleported to Dryl.

Entrapta's lab, which Catra was still semi familiar with, laid before her.

"Unusual request coming from you." The words sent a small shiver down her spine. The memory of her suffocation came back in full force.

"Trust me, if I had any other options, I wouldn't be here." Catra snarled as she turned towards the voice. Hordak sat at one of Entrapta's benches, cords connected all around him. He leaned against the bench, clearly worse for wear than last time they had seen the other. Catra shivered as she realized he looked like Horde Prime in his throne on the Velvet Glove.

"So, what brings you here, Force Captain Catra." Hordak sneered back. Catra shook her head to clear it.

"Horde Leader." Catra guffawed. "I ran the Horde and we both know it."

"You're not helping your case." Hordak tried to stand, falling back down with a pained grunt.

"What happened to you?" Catra crossed her arms, shifting to her hip.

"Entrapta is working to remove the last of Horde Prime…" He trailed off. His eyes drifted off to the side. Catra, following his line of sight, spotted Entrapta. She slumped over one of her benches, sound asleep. Catra wondered when the last time was she had seen Entrapta sleep. "So, what brings you here For-"

"Just call me Catra." She bit out.

"Or perhaps you would prefer Little Sister." Hordak taunted. Catra stiffened, stomping over to him. She grabbed his neck and pulled him close.

"Don't you EVER say that to me again!" She yelled, not caring if Entrapta woke. His eyes flew to her and back to Catra.

"Fine. Catra." He spit her name. "What do you want?" She dropped him to his seat and pulled the vial from her pocket.

"I need to know what's in this."

"Nothing." Hordak answered flatly.

"I know that!" Catra pinched her nose. "I mean what was in it? This is the third vial I've seen. I need to know."

"Where are the other two?" Hordak picked up the vial with two fingers, examining it as if it were deadly.

"One of the Senators had one and the other was given to me by Mermista." Hordak's eyebrows raised. "Someone gave it to Seahawk, who gave it to her, to me." Catra waved her hand. "But this one was found near Adora."

"Your Adora." Hordak muttered as he scooted down. Grabbing a piece of equipment that Catra didn't know of. "How convenient for you that she forgave you."

"I'll go elsewhere if this is how it is." Catra threatened.

"You wouldn't be here if you could go elsewhere." Hordak corrected. Catra snarled and took the seat across from him.

"If what they said is true, Senator Brakenten has a working chip." She whispered, leaning across the table. Hordak's eyes grew wide.

"How do you know?"

"They showed me the first vial as proof. They said if I do anything, they'll do something to Adora." Catra leaned back a little. "So my hands are slightly tied between that and keeping up with regular rebuilding. Can you look into this for me?"

"I suppose." Hordak grumbled. "Anything else, Horde Leader?" He spoke sarcastically.

"Just do it." Catra growled. She stood and returned to Melog's side. "I'll be back within the week."

"Fine." Hordak returned to his tool, examining the vial. Melog's magic washed over them, her room in Bright Moon coming back into view.

Adora's breathing quickened. She panted; her cheeks flushed. Melog pulled part of the covers back as Catra raced for another washcloth. She replaced it, perched on the side of the bed. She patted Adora's forehead slowly, in the way she had seen another do in the infirmary.

Two Weeks Before Present Day: Plumeria

One more. One more stop in Plumeria to Perfuma, and her tasks were completed. Melog teleported them into the middle of her city. The strong scents of flowers assaulted

Catra's nose. She waved her hand in front of her face, glancing around. Melog nudged her leg.

"I know, buddy. Why don't you go have fun?" She smiled at them. They nodded and took off towards a welcoming group of people. They fawned over Melog. Plumeria really loved Melog's visits. Catra shook her head with a smile.

Now to find Flowers. After this, she still had to stop at Dryl to check in with Hordak. It had been a week since she had given him the bottle. Even he should have results by now. Catra started for the main area of the city. According to Adora, the last time they were here together, this was the area she met Perfuma for the first time. Adora had been her dorky self, lifting a cart over her head to impress them. Adora was an idiot. Her idiot but still an idiot.

Perfuma was no where to be seen, as Catra entered the ring of flowers that encircled the area. Several sat around, playing music, or eating Plumerian food. She stopped and asked an elderly woman where Perfuma was; the woman pointed to a building towards the Heart Blossom. Catra nodded her thanks and started forward. As she approached the door, she knocked. No one answered.

She opened the door slowly, the room inside dark. Perfuma didn't strike her the type to sit the dark like that, but Catra entered cautiously. The door slammed behind her loudly. Catra jumped towards the middle of the room, thankful she could kinda see in the dark. Her eyes flitted around. Nothing or no one was there.

A hand wrapped around her mouth, a cloth against her nose. She elbowed behind her hard, the assailant groaning. She turned and raised her leg in a roundhouse kick towards them. They ducked, moving into the shadows. She growled before something tackled her from behind. Where did they come from?! They tumbled before Catra kicked them off. She marked their

chest with her claws on her toes. She counted in her head. At least two were in the room.

She stood, only for the cloth to cover her mouth again. She raised her leg to strike behind her when another grabbed her standing leg. They yanked it out from under her. The three fell to the ground painfully. Catra clawed at the hands holding the cloth to her mouth. They finally removed it, the person crying out in pain. She pushed off the ground and jumped over the group. The door sat mere feet in front of her when a third tackled her to the ground. She growled and bit their hand. They released her, when the second set of hands grabbed her ankles, dragging her back.

Melog appeared with a roar of magic. The assailants tumbled back. Catra threw her arms around Melog's neck as they sprinted for the door. They burst through, the sudden daylight blinding Catra momentarily. Melog took to the woods, not stopping until Plumeria was far from sight.

Catra slid off Melog's back and fell to the ground. She stared at the sky, panting for breath. She could taste whatever was in the cloth on her tongue and she gagged. She retched to the side, wiping her mouth on her sleeve. She realized her clothes ripped during the struggle and she sighed as Adora was now going to worry about her.

"What happened?" Melog asked as they sat. Their chest heaved in time with hers.

"I don't know." Catra growled aloud. "I was told that's where Perfuma was. I walked inside and they attacked."

"Perfuma was on the other side." Melog said. "I found her moments before I came to you. She was searching for you as well." Catra groaned in frustration. She punched the ground beside her.

"I shouldn't be surprised." Catra sighed. "I deserved it anyway."

"I don't think so." Melog stretched out beside her.

"You don't know what I did here, Melog."

"I have seen some of your memories. And I have been told." Melog nuzzled their snout against her cheek. "Even so, you do not deserve to be treated cruelly. There was a saying on my planet."

"What?" Catra asked after they paused.

"Two wrongs do not make a right." Melog finally answered. "Just because you have done wrongs does not make it right for them to return it."

"I don't know." Catra sat up, curling her arms around her knees. "Let's just stop at Dryl so we can go home. I'll visit Plumeria another time."

"When hopefully they do not attack you?" Melog finished the part she didn't want to say out loud. Catra rolled her eyes before mounting their back. Melog chuckled before taking towards Dryl.

As they entered the castle, Melog wove through the maze of Entrapta's castle like it was nothing.

"How do you know your way through here?" Catra asked. Melog had only visited once before, and it had only been to the lab."

"I lived in a labyrinth myself." Melog chirped proudly. "I know how they work. This is nothing."

Catra noticed the claw marks along the walls, Scorpia's doing. She chuckled. Scorpia definitely still wandered lost through the castle, Catra was sure of it.

Entrapta's lab finally opened before them. Entrapta sat in front of her computer, typing away. A small robot butler held a

tray of tiny cupcakes and a large fizzy drink on her right. Hordak sat off to the left, in the same spot he had been last week during her midnight visit.

"CATRA!" Entrapta exclaimed suddenly. "You came!" She used her hair to cross the room in seconds, practically swinging from the rafters. She landed in front of Catra with a wide grin.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia's voice called from further back. She came out, holding a tray of sandwiches. She was tangled in cords connected to stars knew where. Entrapta swung over and helped her untangle her pincers before both joined Catra near Hordak's table.

"What brings you here?" Hordak said with hidden venom.

"She came to see us!" Scorpia smiled. "Right?"

"Uh…" Catra hesitated. "I came to see Hordak about something."

"Oh." Scorpia deflated.

"But doesn't mean I can't hang out…I guess." Catra tried to hide the blush she knew crept into her cheeks. Scorpia and Entrapta shared a laugh and raced off to grab whatever they had planned. Catra groaned but turned her attention back to Hordak.

"I'm still looking into it." Hordak said. He looked down at the small red square in front of him and continued tinkering with it.

"Why aren't you done yet?" Catra hissed.

"I didn't think you wanted the others to know or you wouldn't be here." Hordak bit. "It's a little hard when Entrapta is always hovering over my shoulder or asking for my help to finish

in time. So unless you'd like to fill them in, I suggest you back off."

"Neither of them can keep their mouth shut." Catra paused to think. Adora's condition had worsened rapidly in the past few weeks. "There's nothing from the small vial I gave you? The one I found near Adora?"

"What part of no do you not understand?"

"Because this is important. They could've already done something to Adora!" Catra growled, though she knew her eyes gave her worry away. Her nails carved lines in the table.

"If you want it done faster, than ask Entrapta." Hordak threw a small tool at her. She caught it before it hit her chest. She slammed it on the table, standing.

"Hey…" Scorpia trailed off as they reentered the room. "Everything okay?"

"It's fine." Catra sneered at Hordak. He glared right back.

"No fighting!" Entrapta flew over Scorpia and placed herself between the two. "We're all friends now."

"Entrapta's right." Scorpia joined them, setting down a tray with triple the food and drinks she'd last time. "Let's have some food. This is like our picnic before!" Scorpia smiled at Catra. Guilt hit Catra's chest like a training bot.

"Yeah." Catra picked up a tiny sandwich and popped it in her mouth. Her eyes widened in surprise at the taste. She took a swig of a drink, thankful to finally get the taste of bile out of her mouth.

"I've gotten better! They don't taste like rations anymore." Scorpia said as she took a bite of one. "Perfuma taught me. Baker and Busgirl showed me how to make them tiny."

"Tiny food!" Entrapta squeaked. Catra smiled fondly before wiping it off her face.

"You don't have to do that here." Scorpia pursed her lips. "It's just us." Catra sighed.

"Habit I guess." She rubbed the back of her head nervously. "Thanks."

"So, what are you and Hordak working on?" Entrapta hung upside down by her hair. Her mask covered her face. "Is it a secret?" She drew out the last word. Catra glanced to Hordak, who raised an eyebrow in challenge.

"Actually, we…I could use your help." Catra's shoulders drooped.

"Did something happen?" Scorpia's eyebrows knit in concern. She rubbed her pincers like she did when she was nervous.

"I think someone is trying to restore Prime's systems." The color drained from Scorpia's face and Entrapta dropped to the floor.

"That can't happen, right?" Scorpia looked to Entrapta.

"I shut down his network!" Entrapta's hair wrapped around a rafter and took her to her computer. She typed and schematics popped up. "The program I created destroyed the link between the chips and hivemind. They shouldn't…" Entrapta trailed off, the despair and anger in her voice growing.

"How do you know?" Scorpia held her pincers to her chest.

"Everything I say can't leave this room." Catra spoke harshly. She could see the pain in Scorpia's eyes but continued. "If they find out I've told others, they'll use it on Adora. I can't let that happen."

"What do we do?" Scorpia straightened. Her eyes shone with confidence and determination.

"Entrapta, I need you to work with Hordak. He has a vial that might have been used. It was found near Adora."

"They already got to her?!"

"I don't know yet. I'm being watched like a hawk."

"Who is it?" Entrapta asked.

"Senator Brakenten."

"One of Glimmer's people." Hordak added.

"Someone in the castle." Catra sighed. She pinched her nose.

"They could infect her at any point then." Scorpia took a seat. She covered her face. Entrapta wrapped her arms around herself, clearly unsure of what to do.

"Her condition's gone down high quickly over the last few weeks. The attacks are more frequent and harder on her."

"You think they're connected." Hordak said.

"I don't know."

"Why don't you have her come here?"

"What?" Catra turned to Entrapta.

"I can run tests. Look for anything we may have missed in the last month. We've been researching how the Runestones are affecting her. It would be helpful to study her."

"She is the variable in this." Hordak added to Entrapta. "If we ran tests, it would give us more data than running them on the Runestones themselves."

"If you hurt her..." Catra flexed her nails.

"We won't." Entrapta promised. "As much as we can!"

"It's worth a try…" Scorpia said. Catra dragged her hands down her face. She tapped her fingers together, nervous energy coursing through her.

"The question would be getting her here without the Senator knowing." Hordak reminded.

"Well, we did have that one issue…"

"What issue?" Catra bit towards Scorpia.

"Some of the clones left Dryl. They went to the Fright Zone. They're threatening an uprising. They want to reclaim the Fright Zone for Prime." Scorpia's voice died in her throat. Catra's fur stood on end as memories flashed behind her eyes.

"Why is this the first I've heard of it?" Catra snapped.

"It only happened yesterday." Hordak rubbed his forehead. "No one else knows."

"How many clones?"

"About 30-40 now. But more are planning on going."

"We could bring everyone here for that mission." Catra spoke then paused. That would mean exposing Adora to danger when she can't protect herself. "Adora can't come."

"Why not? That would be the whole point." Scorpia said.

"No. She can't defend herself right now. You haven't seen how bad they are." She could still feel Adora's shaky breaths and see her pained expression from the kitchen incident last

week. “Entrapta, is there a way you could do something while she stays in Bright Moon?”

“I’d need her here.” Entrapta said meekly. Catra groaned and slammed her fist on the table.

“I can’t bring her here…” Catra slumped into her chair. She covered her face with her hands.

“We’ll figure it out.” Scorpia put her pincer on Catra’s shoulder before quickly removing it. She shuffled away, standing awkwardly.

“Thanks, Scorpia.” Catra ran a hand over her hair. She glanced at her pad, cursing at the time. “I have to go. I’ll be back as soon as I can.”

“Hordak and I will work on that and call you!” Entrapta gave her a thumbs up.

“And I’m here if you need a friend.” Scorpia smiled.

“Thanks.” Catra sighed and turned to Melog. “One more jump?” Melog groaned in a joking manner before teleporting them to Bright Moon.

The daylight was just begining to fade yet and Catra was way ahead of schedule. Maybe she could have time with Adora then! Something to get her mind off of all the bad things that had happened today. She amused herself with this thought as she walked towards the War Room to drop her papers.

“Royal Strategist.” A guard greeted as she approached. “We were told to inform you. Princess Adora has been quarantined to her room for the night.”

“Why?” Catra’s brow furrowed. Another attack?

“Queen Glimmer caught her training with some of the guard. They argued before the Queen sentenced her to her

bedroom for the evening. We have orders to deliver dinner after you return."

Only her idiot would be stupid enough to train in a time like this. She knew Adora was feeling antsy, having been off active duty for almost three months. Catra groaned, rubbing her temple.

"Thank you." She pushed the door open, laying her papers and pad in their designated area for the evening. Well, she got her night in with Adora. She supposed Adora would want to cuddle or rant about Sparkles…as long as she rested. Adora's magic attacks liked to prevent them from cuddling but Adora kept trying. She was persistent, Catra had to give her that.

After leaving the room, the guards locking it behind her, she made her way to the kitchen. She'd just grab their dinner herself before heading back to the room. Then they could at least be alone for the night.

As she turned one of the corners, she jumped back. She leaned against the wall, peeking around. Glimmer stood there, talking to Senator Brakenten. Catra's fur bristled. Her ears fell and Melog's mane turned red as she struggled to hold herself in place.

"I agree with you." Glimmer answered. "I'm not too sure about it. Catra's pretty set in her plan." Catra's ears perked at the sound of her name. She leaned closer, Melog turning her invisible. She thanked them mentally and rounded the corner. She approached as close as she felt comfortable. She knelt down near a plant, still hiding in case something was to go wrong.

"I'm glad you see my side, my Queen. I live to serve the kingdom and our great line of Queens." Senator Brakenten bowed ridiculously. "Catra is a great problem that we must deal with. I fear for your life." They placed a hand over their chest in concern. Catra almost gagged at how fake they were.

"Catra wouldn't hurt me." Glimmer laughed. "I don't know how many times I have to tell you this. Catra has saved my life several times now. I trust her." Catra softened at the statement. It was nice to hear. "I haven't told her about some of my decisions, but that's not due to lack of trust."

So, Glimmer was hiding things from her…

"What else could it be, my Lady?" Senator Brakenten said. "She is the former leader of the Horde. Do not forget what she has done to our kingdoms. If your mother had not protected us, we would've lost the war long before." Catra gulped, hoping the sound wasn't as loud as her pounding heart was in her ears. Angella was dead. She cursed herself. No wonder no one had told her what had happened to the former queen. It was probably something Catra had done…Another thing to add to her ever growing list of things to apologize for.

"I'm aware." Glimmer answered slowly, picking her words with caution. "My mother made her decision." Glimmer's voice broke at the end, clearing it before continuing. "However, I promised that I would work with the remaining members of the Horde in our recovery programs to help them adjust to life on Etheria. I plan on keeping that promise."

"Of course, I would never ask you to do anything less."

"Why don't you like Catra?" Glimmer asked the question that burned Catra's tongue.

"Why would I? She destroyed our lives and our homes." The Senator spoke with their hands, motioning to the world around them. "My family had taken refugee in Salineas during the war. Their city was taken by the Horde forces, one of the children injured. Princess Mermista kindly welcomed them to her city. When Catra attacked, they were killed."

Glimmer gasped. Catra stood straighter. They lied. Catra had been there, she had lead the march. There were no

casualites…

"I'd heard there were a few…" Glimmer paused. "No." Glimmer shook her head. "Catra has changed. I'm sorry but I still trust her."

"I understand. I am just looking out for you. I am part of your council. Your mother selected me to help guide you as Queen." Senator Brakenten said. "I apologize for letting my personal life interfere with my advice."

"It's okay." Glimmer smiled. "We're all learning." That was a line Catra had heard Micah say.

"My Queen. If I may." They pulled out a folder full of paper. "Just look this over when you can. It's information you might find useful." Glimmer sighed, eye twitching. She accepted it.

"Fine. If it makes you feel better."

"Thank you for your kindness. I do believe you'll agree with me at some point. Have you done as I asked?" Catra stepped back, something telling her to move. Adrenaline coursed through her, preparing her to fight.

"I have. I've made plans to send Catra to Dryl next week to check in on things there. Entrapta's deadline for her research is coming up. As soon as I know, I'll let the council know of my decision." A deadline? When had Entrapta been given a deadline?

"Of course, all of our plans are coming together." They placed a hand on the back of Glimmer's neck, guiding her away from Catra. "Everyone will understand soon."

Chapter End Notes

Sorry it's been a month. I'm not gonna say it won't be another month before I update. Knowing how it's been this year, it probably will be. I'm starting a new job so hopefully

I'll have more time to write soon but we'll stick with the monthly updates for now. I'm sorry for everyone who was hoping for sooner updates. Thank you to everyone who's continuing to support the story and read it. I hope you know I love you all. :)
This is part 1 of 3. Adora had three chapters so Catra will have three. Lots of plot stuff to come over the next 4-5 chapters. :) We're getting to the fun parts.
Thank you again to everyone who's still reading this. I'll see you next month. Feel free to leave a comment, I love seeing what y'all think.

Unraveling Part 2: Breakdown

Chapter Notes

We are back! I live. My goodness, it's been a while. Thank you to all of you who continue to support this fic. I wouldn't be here without your support. I have a few things I would like to cover before the chapter begins.
-This chapter is nearly double the size of normal chapters, as a heads up. Hopefully, this makes up for the three month wait. For context, most chapters are about 15 pages in my Word doc. Chapter 14 came to 28 pages (just under 13,000 words).
-Secondly, it was made aware to me by Truckeecheeze on TikTok, that Melog uses It/Its pronouns. I have been using they/them this entire time. :(So, I will be going back through and updating all of the chapters for correct pronouns. I apologize for the mistake.
-Thirdly, I'mma date myself here but I didn't know that Authors could respond to Comments. I haven't written anything besides this fic since I was on Fanfiction.net back in 2013-2015 era. And back then, you couldn't (at least not that I knew) so...to all of you who have commented without a response. I'm so sorry. I will do my best to respond to them going forward. :)
-Lastly, I would like to give two shoutouts.
-Kristyland. You have been reading this pretty much since it started. I've seen your comments so many times. Thank you! Your comment just checking in was so sweet and it made my day. It was also the first time I got to respond. I'm so sorry this is up two weeks later than I had planned but thank you for your support. I hope I've exceeded your expectations with this chapter!
-Blondheroeightfoottallgirl. Thank you for your comment! Like Kristyland, you commented on a story that hadn't updated in three months. Your comment about constantly checking in to see updates was so encouraging and really helped me find

the motivation to finish the chapter! Thank you so much for your support. I hope you continue to find happiness in this chapter and in life.

And with all of this out of the way: Here goes Chapter 14: Unraveling Part 2: Breakdown.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 14: Catra

Catra's chest heaved as panic filled her lungs. Glimmer was working with the Senator…the one threatening Adora. If that was the case, Glimmer was no longer safe for Catra to go to.

Catra took off running in the opposite direction. Melog kept her invisible, which she was grateful for. Tears streamed down her face. Living here was a mistake. It didn't matter what she did, how hard she worked. She needed to get Adora and get out.

She slammed into someone as they stepped out of a doorframe. The collision forced her and Melog to separate. She tumbled to the floor with a yelp, groaning as she pushed herself to her knees. Melog jumped in front of her, growling.

"Catra?" Bow's voice caught her attention. Before she could catch herself, she turned to him. His eyes widened and she cursed herself. Her head whipped away, swiping at the cascade of tears that refused to stop. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine." She snapped. She forced herself to her feet, still wobbly. "It's nothing. Goodnight." She tried to step away from him, but he followed her.

"What happened? You're upset." He tried. She shook her head and wrapped her arms around herself. Her nails dug into

her biceps, holding her brokenness together so he wouldn't see. So, no one would see how close she was to shattering.

"I'm going to bed. I'll see you at breakfast." Catra's vocal cords betrayed her, like everyone else did, and broke at the end. She heard Bow's footsteps stop and she unconsciously stopped in place. She wanted to cry. She wanted so badly the comfort she was so scared to receive. Memories of Shadow Weaver and her punishments flooded her mind, reminding her why comfort was never a good thing. Adora. Adora was her one comfort. Her solace from the hell that was her life. She just needed Adora.

"I'm here if you want to talk." Bow spoke patiently. "I know what it's like to feel alone. I don't want anyone to feel like that. Friendships take work and trust." He was Glimmer's boyfriend. They were a couple. "We have to be there for each other." If Glimmer was compromised… "So, if you need me," Then Bow was too. "I'll be here."

Catra's hopes shattered further. Bow had welcomed her with open arms, especially for someone she had thrown from a cliff once. Bow had been so nice and kind and loving to her. He radiated love and kindness in ways that reminded of her Adora. The feeling of home. And once again, it was stolen from her.

"Goodbye." Catra forced her feet to move, each step feeling like a betrayal to all she had done to be forgiven. As soon as she was far enough away, she ran. Ran to her room. Ran from her emotions and the heavy truth.

She threw open her bedroom door, the slamming door rattling against the wall. Adora slept soundly in their bed. Of course, she was sleeping. When Catra needed her most, Adora wasn't there. She slumped to her knees. Melog paced around her and nuzzled her face. It spoke comforting things to her, but she couldn't hear it. Sobs began to rack her body. She folded over herself, grabbing her hair in her fists. She released a guttural cry before falling to her side. Melog curled into her stomach, allowing

her to wrap around it. She vaguely noticed the door shutting slowly but couldn't bring herself to care.

A whimper from the bed brought her attention upwards. She glanced over to Adora, who tossed in the bed. A faint glow radiated from Adora's chest that rose and fell too quickly for Catra's liking. Her skin gleamed softly with magic. She-Ra's form flickered in and out of shape, Adora groaning from the surges. Catra's hand outstretched, her feet struggling to find traction. She stumbled forward and grabbed the bedding. She took Adora's hand in hers, wincing as the magic burned her skin.

"Adora." Her voice broken from crying. She shook her slightly. Adora muttered Catra's name and rolled over to face her. The magic glow faded, leaving them in the dark as the last daylight faded behind them.

"Catra?" Adora muttered again. She reached out her hand, cupping Catra's with both of hers. "You're back."

"Yeah." Catra laughed a little.

"What's wrong?" Adora cupped her cheek, brushing her thumb over Catra's tears.

"Nothing." Catra couldn't worry her. She would figure this out herself. "Just worried about you." She hated lying to Adora. She hated herself more. Shadow Weaver was right. Catra was just like her. Destined to be hated and to die alone.

"I love you." Adora booped her nose and giggled. "Are you gonna cuddle with me?" Adora held her arms open. The look in Adora's eyes told Catra she knew she was lying but still wanted her.

"I probably shouldn't…" Catra drew back. "You nee-" Adora pulled her to a hug, shoving Catra's nose into Adora's side with the weird angle.

"I don't care." Adora's voice gave away her pouting. "I'm tired and I want my Catra." Catra couldn't help the giddy feeling Adora gave her.

"Just tonight. But if you have another attack, I'm moving back to the window."

"Okay." Adora agreed, rubbing her eye.

"I guess we aren't eating dinner tonight." Catra said to Melog. Melog snickered and left to go inform the kitchen staff.

Present Day: Crystal Castle

Catra stood, watching over Entrapta's shoulder. Her fingers tapped against her arm impatiently. Adora's condition worsened by the minute. Much faster than any of the other chipped Princesses. She shimmered in and out of She-Ra. Micah had cast a sleeping spell, but that didn't stop what Catra knew happened in the mind.

"So, are you going to explain this idea of yours?" Glimmer asked in between gulps of water.

Catra watched the queen, biting her tongue to prevent any words from coming out of her mouth. She wanted nothing more than to slap Glimmer. Glimmer who had used Shadow Weaver's magic on Adora. Glimmer who claimed to be her friend but had been working with Senator Brakenten… Catra wondered if she should've brought Glimmer with them at all. She growled and turned away. Now wasn't the time. She'd deal with Glimmer later.

"Micah's magic won't hold forever." Bow reminded. "Whatever you're thinking, we need to know." Catra glanced over at the aforementioned sorcerer. He sat, gulping water, and watching Adora for any signs she'd wake.

"I'm going to go in there." Catra accepted a bottle of water from Bow. Her body craved water, food, and rest. She opened the bottle, bringing it to her lips.

"I'm sorry what?!" Glimmer and Bow exclaimed, voices overlapping.

"I'm going in there." Catra repeated. "I'll get her to come back to me so we can 'zap' the chip off of her." She recapped the water, setting it on the ground.

"She'll kill you. She can't exactly hold herself back this time." Scorpia spoke. "You remember when she almost killed you in the Northern Reach."

"I'll be fine." Catra brushed it off.

"Catra…"

"She did it for me!" Catra snapped. "If she hadn't done it for me, then I would…" She trailed off.

"At least wait until Hordak and Entrapta are ready." Bow handed her a wrapped item, though Catra assumed it was food.

"Bow." Glimmer hissed. "We can't send her in there."

"She's not going to listen to us." Bow sighed before taking a bite of his own food. "But we can make it as safe as possible when she does go in."

"Ugh." Glimmer groaned and munched on her sandwich. Catra unwrapped hers and took a bite. Her stomach rumbled, almost as if saying thank the stars she ate something! Bow and Glimmer had continued to discuss their situation.

As soon as she finished her food, she turned on her heels and stalked towards the open corridor that let her still keep

an eye on Adora. She slid down the wall, curling her legs into her chest. She rested her head against her knees.

Two Weeks Ago: Bright Moon

Adora still slept softly on their bed. Catra sat at the window, watching. Adora's attack last night worried her. They were progressively getting worse and Catra didn't know what to do. Who could she even ask about it? Hordak, Entrapta and Scorpia were the only three she could talk to for now as they were far enough away…right?

She had thought the same about Mermista and Seahawk, but Senator Brakenten had gotten to them too. Frosta still didn't really like her so that was a no go. She was attacked last time she went to Plumeria to see Flowers. Glimmer was working with the Senator so she, Bow and Micah were no longer safe.

Catra sniffled as she hugged herself. What was she supposed to do? There was no one safe for her to talk to. She was all alone again. Double Trouble had told her she pushed people away…that she was the problem. Maybe they were right.

The dam of her emotions threatened to break when Adora mumbled. Catra swiped her tears away and moved to the bed.

"Catra?" Adora asked sleepily, clearly worn from the night before.

"Hey Adora." Catra said softly. She brushed a piece of hair from Adora's cheek, drawing a small giggle from Adora. This woman was going to be the death of her. Adora snuggled into Catra's hand, pulling it to her cheek.

"What's wrong?" She asked as she held Catra's hand captive.

"What do you mean?" Catra tried to keep her voice even.

"You were upset last night, and you're still upset. I can see it in your eyes." Adora shifted to a sitting up position.

Catra bit her lip, weighing her options, wanting so badly to tell Adora everything like they did in the Horde. But, if Adora knew what she was dealing with, Adora would stomp her way down to the Senator and demand answers. Or she'd tell Glimmer and Bow, and the three idiots would go. Either way, Adora's life would be in danger with the Senator knowing she knew about the vials and threats. Catra could handle it alone.

"Just a long day last night." Catra lied again. Each word felt like a knife in her gut. She'd promised to be honest and here she was lying over and over again. The old Catra wouldn't have cared. She wanted what she wanted and would do anything to take it. But she was different now…right?

"Catra." Adora caressed her cheek. "Talk to me, please. Something's going on and no one will tell me. Don't block me out too." Because if she knew, Adora wouldn't be able to sit still. This was a chess game with the Senator and Adora didn't have the patience for that.

"I'm not. Just…Keeper of She-Ra stuff. No one really likes my idea of destroying the Runestones or all of that." Catra looked away. She couldn't meet her eyes. It wasn't an entire lie.

"Well yeah…" Adora snorted. "But I know that's not all." Catra noticed how Adora had stopped asking for specifics of the plans that Catra never shared.

"Just trust me…please." Catra still couldn't meet her eyes. She didn't deserve it. The warmth from Adora's fingers grew, causing her to look back. Adora's eyes closed in concentration. She glowed slightly before fading. Adora panted with exhaustion.

"What did you do?"

"Well, I thought I can heal wounds, right?" Adora gave her a dorky smile. "I thought maybe I could heal mental things as well."

"Stars, Adora." Catra slapped her arm. Adora winced away, giggling. "You're such an idiot."

"Yeah, I know." Almost on cue, her trackerpad vibrated on the desk. Catra groaned as she dragged herself from the bed to retrieve it. A few messages showed awaiting. The first grabbed her attention.

Come to Dryl immediately.

"This early?" Catra groaned. Melog had curled up next to Adora, purred loudly as it licked her hand. Adora scratched its ears, earning a happy mew from Melog. Catra smiled at the sight. She quickly freshened up in the bathroom, listening to the melodic sound of Adora's laughter.

She gave Adora a peck on the cheek before leaving the room, noticing the guards standing outside the door. She resisted the growl growing in her throat and continued. Melog appeared by her side a moment later. It nudged her leg lovingly as the two walked.

A new message appeared. She opened it, a price tag the only text. She groaned as she realized it would eat through most of her funds. But if it helped…

She wired the money and clicked the trackerpad off for now. Between that and Entrapta's team, she'd be fine. It would all be worth it.

She stopped by the kitchen, grabbing a cup of coffee and some sort of breakfast sandwich. She had lived in Bright Moon for a few months, and she still couldn't get over the weird

foods. Rations bars were the bane of her existence but at least the textures weren't all over the place.

"Are you okay to teleport us there?" She asked Melog as she finished, placing the dirty dishes next to a stack.

"Yes." Melog chirped. She knew longer distances took more magic and didn't want to push her magic companion to the point of exhaustion. "Thanks for thinking of me." It teased.

"Come on." Catra chortled. The magic enveloped them in a familiar way. Moments later, Entrapta's lab shimmered into existence.

"Catra!" Entrapta squealed. She padded over via her hair tendrils, landing in front of the cat girl. "You got the message!"

"Yeah. What's up?" Catra tucked the trackerpad under her arm, following Entrapta further into the lab. Hordak and Scorpia were nowhere to be seen. Instead, a few of Entrapta's robots flittered around the place, completed random tasks.

"Hordak and I have been analyzing those vials you asked." Entrapta's hair tapped across the console, pulling up different schematics across the arcing screens.

"Right. They are just the fluid from the pools, right?"

"No." Entrapta's quick answer shocked Catra. "They are diluted versions of them. Totally harmless to us. Hordak even tried a bit of one."

"Ew. Why?"

"Science." Entrapta responded as if that were enough of an answer. Catra sighed and pushed back her frustration. She was friends with Entrapta now. That meant she had to work to understand her friend, not just demand things of her.

"So Adora would be fine?"

"Yeah! Even if she ingested any of the fluids, it's just meant to help sustain the clone bodies. She'd have a stomachache if anything." Entrapta turned around, smiling.

"Thanks, Entrapta." Catra's shoulders drooped with relief.

"That's what friends do!" Entrapta crossed her arms proudly. "At least, that's what Bow says." Catra chuckled.

"Have you and Bow seen each other lately?" In all her business dealing with the Senator, her new duties as Royal Strategist and trying to keep Adora from killing herself from her boredom, she hadn't had too much time to keep up with everyone.

"We chat a lot via trackerpads. Sometimes, Scorpia will bring him via skiff for lunch." Entrapta swung over Catra's head over to one of her workbenches. Entrapta swiped the two empty vials off the bench and dropped them into Catra's hand. "But you should be all good to go!"

"Any updates on the Runestone idea?" Catra asked, realizing she was actually saddened by the idea of leaving so quickly. She realized that with all her visits to Dryl lately, she was coming to enjoy Entrapta's company. Admittedly, she wanted to return to Adora's side but also, she felt alone in the castle. She couldn't rely on Glimmer or Bow anymore, at least now entirely. The hopeful side of her wanted so badly to ask them, tell them, anything! But her cynical side warned her of the dangers impending if she chose wrong.

"Well, the ideas you've presented all would've worked." Entrapta mused, popping a tiny cupcake into her mouth. "But that data is outdated."

"Explain?" Catra asked tentatively. Entrapta paused, clearly thinking of how to put it into words Catra could grasp.

Catra waited, grateful for the effort.

"That data was collected three years ago, before we understood or even knew of the Heart of Etheria. Destroying the Runestones isn't really an option anymore."

"I guess that makes sense." Catra vaguely remembered seeing Glimmer hitting the Black Garnet with magic blasts of sparkles to no avail.

"That said, I've been studying why the Heart would be making Adora hurt." Entrapta turned back, beckoning Catra to join her at the computer once more. "The Heart was never intended to blow up the whole planet, based on what was found on Beast Island."

"Wait, what?" Catra tried to ask, but Entrapta hushed her with a wave of a hand.

"It was more intended to be a canon, draining the magic before focusing it into one blast. Directed by She-ra, of course. But since the Heart was abandoned for a thousand years, the magic built to a point it couldn't be contained."

"Right, which is why we needed the failsafe." The failsafe that didn't work when they needed it most, thanks to Prime. "To deactivate it." Adora's chilling body, motionless in her arms. The crackling of power and magic echoing through and rattling the chamber around them. Catra felt them as if she was still kneeling there, the moment playing endlessly in her mind.

"Adora managed to stabilize the Heart, having siphoned off most of the energy. She used it to revitalize the land and stop Prime's ship." The weird tree wrapped ship came to mind, Catra shivering at the thought.

"But if Adora stabilized the Heart, then why is she still getting these…surges?" Catra waved her hand, reading the information zooming across the screen in front of her.

"Aftershocks." Entrapta's face lit up with excitement. "Like after earthquakes or tsunamis!" Catra recalled reading into them in preparation for the attack on Salineas.

"Those eventually fade." Catra crossed her arms. "But these haven't. If anything, they've worsened."

"Something else must be affecting it." Entrapta's fingers flew across crackling keys. Digits and codes flitted in rows down and across, faster than Catra could understand. "If you could bring her here, I could figure it out."

"I…" Catra paused. She could use the excuse of the Fright Zone colony to bring Adora to Dryl for testing. "I'll consider it. See if there's a way I can pull it off."

"If anyone can, it's you." Entrapta stated the encouragement with a thumbs up.

"I should probably head back. I have a meeting with Glimmer and Micah soon."

"Tell everyone I said hi!" Entrapta waved goodbye.

"Remember," Catra turned once more. "This stays between us. For Adora's sake." Entrapta's hair gave her a thumbs up, the scientist never breaking her stare into her screens. Catra pursed her lips to stifle the smile that tugged at her lips. Melog's magic enveloped her once more.

"It is good that we went this morning." Melog meowed as Bright Moon came into view. They had appeared outside the main living space, a hall from where they needed to be.

"You heard her, Melog. We might actually have a chance. The Runestones, we'll have to look into that more, but Adora might be okay." Hope swelled inside her, straightening her posture and boosting her confidence. She started down the hall before stopping as the conclusion smacked her in the face.

She could actually tell Adora. If she did, the two could come up with a strategy to deal with the Senator. The two of them would work together, maybe even be able to-

"Catra." Glimmer's voice called her. The Queen of Sparkles bounded down the hall towards her. "There you are." Catra grimaced at the interruption but turned to face Glimmer.

"Everything good?" A vision of Adora, whimpering under another surge, flashed behind her eyes. Catra's fists clenched, claws digging into her palms.

"Yeah, Dad is taking care of something else for me, so it'll just be us in the meeting." Glimmer said as she beckoned Catra to follow. Catra and Melog shared a look, unease filling the air.

"You never did tell me what the meeting is for." Catra probed as she followed. She thought of Glimmer and the Senator speaking the night before. Perhaps she could convince Glimmer to give her details without tipping off either party.

"You'll see." Glimmer practically beamed, a little too much in Catra's opinion. Catra's grip around the vials tightened. Melog chirped at her, offering to return the vials to her bedroom. She slipped them into Melog's mouth and off it went.

Glimmer opened the door, the Council Room opening before them. The table sat empty, except for a lone figure. Catra hissed softly as they lifted their head.

"Senator Brakenten!" Glimmer greeted. "Thank you for meeting with us."

"It was short notice but anything for you, my queen." The Senator rose and bowed to Glimmer. Glimmer turned, taking her seat. She shot Catra a weird look, motioning to Catra's chair. Catra took a steadying breath and waited for the door to click behind her. She joined them at the table, locked in a glaring contest with the Senator as they both sat.

"I called this meeting to finalize the reconstruction plans." Glimmer shifted through some of the papers in front of her. "We added in some last-minute changes, and I think you'll like them." Glimmer beamed. Catra's instincts screamed danger, but she restrained herself. She dug her claws into her thighs, still glaring at the Senator. They gave her a smug grin, relaxing in the chair enough to cross their arms. Catra rumbled with a low growl before papers appeared in front of her.

"What's this?" Catra finally broke the glare to read over the pages.

"The new community centers!" Glimmer clapped her hands, before handing another set of pages to Senator Brakenten. "One will be established in the major cities of the kingdoms. All of the Princesses are on board with it!"

Catra thumbed through the information, her sense of danger growing with each new line. All she heard and saw was the reconditioning chamber from the Velvet Glove. She could see the benefits in having them, but something told her not every Princess would be on board with this, as Glimmer had said.

"You don't like it?" Glimmer deflated in her chair a little.

"Where did this come from?" Catra waved the pages in the air for emphasis. "How come I haven't heard of this before?" She was the Royal Strategist and Keeper of She-ra. She was supposed to be among Glimmer's highest council…wasn't she? She narrowed her eyes at the Queen.

Glimmer noticed, her fists curling against the tabletop.

"Senator Brakenten and I came up with it."

"WHAT?!" Catra shot to her feet with a shout.

"What's wrong with that?" Senator Brakenten spoke, a challenging look in their eye.

"What's-" Catra's voice died in her throat. She had overheard them talking the night before. She gritted her teeth, forcing her voice to remain calm. "That still doesn't answer why I haven't heard of them up to this point." She forced herself to look back to Glimmer.

"You were busy with the Runestone plan. Senator Brakenten and I came up with this and did it ourselves. It was going to be a surprise." Glimmer's voice wavered at the end, expressing her disappointment in Catra's reaction. "You seemed to like the first one, so I didn't see any harm in it."

"First one?" Catra's tail bushed, her hand quickly brushing it down.

"The Therapy Center in Plumeria. You and Adora go there weekly?" Glimmer sighed, rubbing her forehead. "I don't see what the problem is. The Therapy Center has helped all of us. Building more of them planet wide isn't a bad idea."

Catra stole a glance to the Senator, their smug smile warning her there was more to it than just a Therapy Center.

"We chose to call them Community Centers as they will double as meeting places for the people. Places of Unity and Peace." Senator Brakenten motioned their arms out in a hugging fashion. "All of Etheria able to come together and heal and be with one another again. What could possibly be so wrong with that, Royal Strategist?" Catra fought the growl rising in her throat, only matched by her effort to not reach across the table and rack her claws through-

"We should stop their construction." Catra stated, running a hand through her hair in an attempt to calm herself. At Glimmer's rising protest, she held a hand up and continued. "Did you read any of the paperwork I've submitted to you?"

"Of course!" Glimmer flipped through her version of the documents in front of her, pulling a page out from the middle.

"I took all of it into account. We had plenty of leftover from the Reconstruction Budget. The other Princesses and their kingdoms pitched in for their centers. I'm still not seeing a problem with this."

"My liege." Senator Brakenten stood, straightening their robes. "Would you mind giving me a moment with the Royal Strategist?"

"Glimmer." Catra's voice betrayed her confidence, the tiniest bit of uncertainty leaking out.

"That's fine." Glimmer gathered her things. "I need to check on Adora anyhow." Glimmer disappeared in a shower of glitter, the room becoming deadly quiet.

"Whatever you're thinking-"

"I'm only thinking of what's best for my planet." Senator Brakenten tidied their papers into a neat pile before meeting her eyes. "Can you say the same…Horde Leader?" The dangerously low tone of voice sent prickles down Catra's spine. Prime's throne chambers flashed before her eyes.

"I will stop these and I will not let you hurt anyone." Catra stated, trying to regain her confidence.

"Is that what all of your trips to Dryl to speak with Princess Entrapta have been for?" Catra's blood ran cold.

"How…how did you…" She stammered out. Dread flooded her mind. Her instincts screamed at her to get away, to protect Adora. But her feet stayed frozen as if Frosta herself were present.

"Did you think I wouldn't notice?" The Senator barked a laugh. "Word travels quickly when the Keeper of She-ra," The title came out in a drawl. "leaves the castle weekly, only to return from Dryl. Especially so late in the night. But no worries, child." Catra fought the tremors as Prime's voice intertwined with Senator

Brakenten's in her mind. "I do not mind. Please continue to see the Princesses in Dryl. I'll even give you some help." They plucked a vial from their robes, rolling it across the table to her.

Her hand moved to catch it, surprising her that she could even move at all. Inside was a blue liquid this time.

"What's this?"

"A diluted version of what you were given earlier. Makes it easier to study. You'll see it has nothing to do with chipping. In fact, when diluted, it can serve to help heal people. This actually was the same formula probably fed to you, while you were on the ship." Catra gagged at the thought. Her body finally breaking through the stupor. She stumbled back, clutching the vial to her chest.

"Why are you doing this?" Catra asked warily. Entrapta had said the other vials were diluted versions of the fluid. So, what did that make the version in her hand?

"Because of peace, child." Senator Brakenten retook their seat for a moment. "Etheria has been at war for too long. We have forgotten what peace looks like."

"This isn't peace. It's torture." Catra choked out.

"Perhaps at first." Senator Brakenten acknowledged. "But the ends justify the means. It might hurt at first but once everything is right, only peace and order will remain."

"No." Catra shook her head. "You weren't chipped. You don't know what it's like!" Her voice raised a decibel. They heard the guards shift outside the room. Senator Brakenten sighed.

"Perhaps. But that doesn't change what it could bring. True peace. The end of suffering." They closed their eyes, as if they could see the future playing out behind their eyelids. "A world where you could exist with your Adora and there would be no amnesty, no wrongdoings between you to separate you again."

Prime had said the same thing to her. Before sticking her back into a reconditioning pool.

"No. You're wrong. That's not true peace. If I told Glimmer what these really were…" Catra stood, trying to portray strength.

"That would break our agreement." Senator Brakenten answered matter of fact. The argument died in Catra's throat.

"You said these don't work." Catra hoped to catch them in their lies.

"Well, those don't." They laughed. "But the others will." Their demeanor changed as they leaned forward. "Let's change our terms, shall we?"

"No. No, Entrapta has found that-"

"If Adora leaves Bright Moon at all," They pointed to the vial. "I will chip her in the same way you were chipped." The vial dropped to the floor, followed by Catra herself. She clung to herself, hysteria taking it hold. They chuckled before gathering their things. "Good day, Horde Leader."

As they reached the door, they stopped. "And remember. If anyone, not just the Queen finds out…well, you understand." The door swung shut behind them, leaving Catra in the cold room alone.

Present Day: Crystal Castle Corridor.

Catra sat with her back to the wall, her eyes glued on Adora's sleeping form. Now that Catra recognized it, this was the same spell she had seen Micah use previously. The thought relaxed her slightly. Slightly.

Glimmer joined her father, exhaustion clearly weighing on both of them. The anger she felt towards Glimmer resurfaced but she needed her strength. She remembered how her fight with Adora had been…when she had been the one chipped. Now they, here they stood, in the other's shoes. Catra's claws dug into the back of her thighs as she curled into herself. She was going to save Adora. She had to. Needed to. She'd slaved over the last month to prevent this. Doing everything she could to prepare or discern the truth about the chips and Prime's resurgence. And somewhere in the fray, she had lost. Her heart ached.

She noticed the figure approaching her too late, Melog's growl rumbling.

Bow slid to the ground next to her. Catra bit back the growl that she *so* badly wanted to release but she knew it was misplaced. Bow had taken the seat on her right, meaning she couldn't watch Adora without looking his way. Smart man.

"Hey." Bow tried with a weary smile. "I thought you could use the extra." He offered her another water bottle. Before she could protest, he held up two more. "I couldn't leave Melog out." Melog chirped happily. Bow handed the water towards it and looked back to Catra.

"You won't convince me otherwise." Catra stated bluntly after her first swig.

"Yeah, I know." Bow answered without missing a beat. "I'm not here for that."

"Then why are you here?" Catra narrowed her eyes at him. Melog's mane wavered.

"Because we both need a friend." Bow pursed his lips, staring at his lap. "It's been a rough couple of days."

"That's putting it lightly." Catra chuckled, stopping abruptly. She stared at her toes, flexing them in boredom and anxiety. Bow fidgeted with the straps on his boots. The motion

drew Catra to notice how bad he looked. Dirt and grim caked his clothes and skin. One of his boots was missing a piece. He had a gash on his arm, courtesy of the clones' attack in the Fright Zone. A smaller version marred his cheek, though it wasn't as deep. The exhaustion in his face made Catra's heart sink further.

Everything she had done for the last month. All of that stress and planning. Sneaking around, hoping to save everyone and try to figure this out. Was it all for nothing? Adora had been chipped because of her lapse in judgement and now here they were. All of them were exhausted or injured.

"The others are on their way." Bow finally spoke. "The other Princesses." He clarified with a hand motion before going back to picking a piece of mud from his left boot.

"Scorpia or Entrapta was supposed to send a message once you all arrived here." Catra answered. She glanced beyond him to see Glimmer and Micah. Glimmer leaned into Micah's embrace. Clearly, they were talking but Catra was a little too far away to hear it.

"Why didn't you say anything?" Bow asked softly. "After everything, did you really think we wouldn't have helped?" The pain and betrayal that tinged his voice reminded her of her own.

"I…" Catra's voice died in her throat. Bow was one of the ones she had wanted to trust. That's why she left Adora to him when Glimmer took her to Dryl. She trusted him to protect Adora in her stead but saying it out loud didn't sound as reassuring as it did in her head. "I'll explain everything once everyone is here and Adora is freed from that stupid chip. Will that work?" Catra turned her head towards Melog, unable to even meet the hurt in his eyes. Melog nudged her face lovingly.

Bow sighed heavily. His clothes rustled as Catra was sure he had placed his head on his knees. She glanced back to

confirm. She opened her mouth to speak when she noticed the small tremors that shook his shoulders.

"Are you okay?" She reached out a hand tentatively, just out of reach of his arm.

"Not really." Bow sniffled but didn't move. "I'm so tired of the fighting. Friendships aren't easy. They are a lot of work, but it just feels like that's all we're doing." Catra withdrew her hand, choosing to wrap her arms around herself. "I thought we were doing better. But I guess that night should've told me differently, huh?" He glanced to her for acknowledgment. She saw the tears that streamed openly down his cheeks, surprised at the genuine emotion. The Horde frowned on open expression of weakness, preferring to trained it away with drills and exercises.

He sighed again when Catra didn't answer. "Something happened that night though. Was it something related to all of this?" Catra closed her eyes, fighting the urge to scream at him to stop asking her questions. To leave like everyone else did. But she couldn't. Not after the look he had given her when everything happened…He was owed at least some of the truth.

"Som-something did happen that night." Catra started slowly, trying to calm her breathing. She flexed her claws to release some of the anxiety building. "It's…it's a long story but—it wasn't anything you did." She stammered out the end. She sighed and threw her head into her lap, groaning. Why was this so hard?!

"I guess I'll understand later then." Bow said with finality. "When you explain everything else?"

"Yeah." Catra answered, muffled. "You're a good friend, Bow." She stuck a hand out, awkwardly patting his leg. "… and I'm sorry." She jolted as she felt his fingers wrap around hers.

"Thanks, Catra. You're a good friend too."

"I doubt that, but thanks." Catra lifted her head enough to give him a small smile. He returned it happily.

"AH!" Entrapta's squeal filled the air, making them both jump to their feet. "It's finished!!" She cooed over the small instrument. They stepped back into towards everyone. Glimmer and Micah stood, intrigued over the loud sound.

"Everything is set." Hordak announced. He cast a look to Catra that she couldn't quite decipher.

"AGH!!" Almost on cue, Adora's chip crackled, forcing She-Ra to her feet. Micah and Glimmer jumped into action, casting magic to reinforce their cage before She-Ra's sword swung towards them. The rainbow-colored magic flowed in an arc from the sword, lashing it in ways to reminded Catra of her old whip from the Crimson Waste.

"Whip." Scorpia murmured weakly as she approached. Catra shot her a weak smile before turning back to Adora. Scorpia's pincer pressed against her back in support as Bow turned to her.

"Are you ready?"

"Don't think I have a choice at this point, Arrow Boy." Catra teased. Bow offered a pursed smile. Melog appeared in front of her, blinking its eyes in question. "Let's go, Melog. Let's go save our idiot."

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4 Days Previous: Crypto Castle Hallway.

"What do you think you're doing?!" Catra stumbled forward, away from Glimmer. She gripped the wall, glaring back.

"What I'm doing is being Queen. I made a decision." Glimmer crossed her arms. "I don't understand why you're so angry about this?!" Glimmer's voice rose an octave. "You heard Entrapta. If Adora comes here than Entrapta and Hordak might be able to figure this out!"

Catra drew her fist closed, nails gouging the wall. Senator Brakenten's threat echoed in her ears. If Adora left Bright Moon at all…

"Did. You. Clear. This. With. Anyone?" Catra enunciated.

"No." Glimmer shifted to her hip, returning Catra's glare. If Adora was joining them in the morning, Bow should be watching over her tonight. Melog was there too.

Catra threw her fist into the wall with as much force as she could, leaving a crater in the metal. She stalked off towards her room, Glimmer's yells fading as the distance grew.

She fought the wheezing of her chest that grew the more she ruminated over the idea of Adora alone in the castle tonight. She punched one of the robots as it approached her, not caring what its function was.

She followed Scorpia's claw marks back to her room, an exaggerated cat face carved into the wall across from her door. She kicked the door open, unable to care. It swung closed behind her loudly.

The room sat open and pristine around her. A set of sitting chairs took up the left front side of the room, a small table between them. Behind them sat an open closet, a few extra pairs of Catra's outfits that Entrapta had prepared for her hanging. A wide bed, bigger than the one she and Adora shared in Bright Moon, sat along the back wall. It was positioned in a straight line back from the door, a set of shelves on each side. The shelves were littered with small pieces and parts from Entrapta's projects, no doubt. She glanced to the right side, noticing her reflection in the mirror beside the dresser.

Her hair sat in an awkwardly with some pieces standing up. Her black sleeves had small tears where Adora's nails had dug into to get traction. Her right pant leg held a few more

rips than before and a large gash marred the left. Sweat had left a sticky shine to her fur despite the dark circles under her eyes. For a moment, she saw her former self in the mirror. The version of her in the height of her reign in the Horde. The mirror smirked down at her. It teased her for her weakness.

She reached for the nearest item, one of the chairs. When she staggered under the full weight, the image laughed at her. She gripped the chair, chucking it at the mirror. The image kept its smirk, until the glass shattered and rained to the floor.

A mad laughter bubbled in her ears as she cupped them to silence it. She screamed as she stumbled forward. She broke off the chair leg with a kick, before using it to beat the glass. The laughter continued.

Is this what you've fallen to?

The great Horde Leader Catra?

All torn up and broken over your sweet lover.

The one you can't even protect.

The one who hates you even more now.

Now who's the useless one?!

"SHUT UP~!" Catra yelled. She started towards the bed, ramming her shin into the corner. She yelped, grabbing her leg. She threw her hand out to catch herself, the shelve with parts her only grip. One of the pieces dug into her fingers.

She screamed as she grabbed the shelves in frustration. She ripped them from the walls, the parts and pieces of forgotten projects scattering behind her. Sobs heaved and burst from her. She flopped onto the bed, screaming into the mattress. Her throat ached as she turned to her back. She stared at the ceiling as tears streamed down.

"Adora." She cried softly, covering her eyes. "Please don't leave me." She curled her legs into herself. "When this is over, I'll be good. I promise." She hiccupped. "Just don't go."

You think you deserve her? Shadow Weaver's voice echoed. *You're a distraction. A Mistake.*

You could've been happy. Prime's voice spoke next. Images flashed behind her eyes of the moments he explored her mind during the chipping process.

Nausea tore through her system. She covered her mouth, rolling off the bed to the opposite side. She stumbled forward, her sense of direction distorting the room. She fell towards the window, her claws racking through the curtains. She retched out the window, pitying anything that might have been below. In attempting to stand, she shorn through the other curtain. She shook her head and held her stomach. She stumbled back, crashing into the other shelves.

Come into the light, Little Sister. Return to me and be at peace.

She swiped her free hand in front of her. As she stepped forward, her mind still swirling, she felt her claws catch on her clothes hanging from the open closet. She ripped the fabric. She couldn't care what it was but the idea of doing the same to Prime and his clones comforted her.

She stumbled forward, dropping to her knees. She curled into a ball and sobbed.

She cursed when she awoke awhile later. She wasn't sure how much time passed.

Adora. She had work to do if she was going to save her. Catra wasn't going to let her down.

Catra stood shakily. She ran a hand threw her hair as she took in the damage she had done to her room. It reminded

her of what she had done after Scorpia had left.

She went to the dresser, slightly surprised she hadn't dealt it more damage. She grabbed a small hair tie from one of the drawers. Entrapta had tried to stock the rooms in preparation for their stay…or had her robots prepare the rooms. Her room, meant to be shared with Adora, had a few extra hair ties. Catra silently thanked Entrapta before pulling her hair back out of her face as much as she could. The longer it got, the more it brought back memories she didn't want to deal with.

She changed into what clothes she could salvage. The only other shirt still intact no longer had a left sleeve but Catra couldn't care less at the moment. She noticed a few of Adora's clothes had been shredded in the mess but most of Adora's extra clothes were in the dresser, thankfully. At least she hadn't ruined everything.

She headed towards the door when she heard a small crunch under her foot. She lifted it, stepped back, and knelt to look at the item. Turning it carefully, the framed picture Scorpia had redrawn for her laid in shattered glass. She closed her eyes as tears welled.

Just another thing broken because of her.

She sighed and left the picture where it sat. She couldn't bring herself to do anything more with it at the moment. She needed to get to Entrapta's lab.

A little bit of navigating and harassing one of the remaining clones to help her, Catra arrived at the lab doors. She knocked.

"We're busy!" Scorpia's voice called. "Catra said she doesn't want to see anyone!"

"How can I say that if I'm standing right here?!" Catra shouted. Sounds of clattering and things crashing echoed before

the door opened. A strand of Entrapta's hair wrapped around Catra's waist. It yanked her in with a yelp.

"There you are!" Scorpia pulled her into a hug just as tight as the hair. "We were wondering when you'd be coming."

"What are you talking about?" Catra asked in a strained voice. Scorpia finally released her, patting her clothes as she spoke.

"Glimmer came by earlier, shortly after you two came back from Bright Moon. She asked for you. Hordak had the idea to say we were busy and you didn't want to be bothered." Scorpia spoke proudly as she motioned back to Hordak.

He dramatically looked away, clearly embarrassed.

"Glimmer tried to apologize through the door." Entrapta picked up the story. "We kept up the story that you didn't want to speak to her and she eventually left."

"Why would you do that?" Catra looked between them.

"You left in a hurry for your Adora." Hordak answered. "It's obvious something happened, and we knew you would return here eventually, demanding we find your answers." Hordak took a tiny cupcake off the tray in front of him.

"What do we do now?" Scorpia asked.

"I'm not sure. But we get ahead." Catra strode towards the main computer. "Entrapta, what about the vial I had Melog bring you?"

"Oh!" Entrapta joined her. "It's a healing potion! It's not even the same thing."

"Catra." Scorpia's voice caused her to turn. Scorpia stood, rubbing her pincers like she did when she was nervous. "What do I do?"

Catra noticed the small drop in Entrapta's shoulders. Hordak even waited for her call.

"You help." Catra answered in a matter-of-fact voice. "I'll need you here." Scorpia's eyes widened, making the same face she gave Catra in the Crimson Waste so long ago. "Stop making that face, I'll take it back." Catra turned slightly.

"I'm not doing anything." Scorpia said with a happy tone. She shuffled forward, joining them as Entrapta brought over one of her workbenches. Catra and Scorpia began grabbing whatever information in files and papers and maps, postering them over the surface.

As the night dragged on, Catra felt her eyes grow heavier but she continued. The burden of knowing Adora could be in danger any second spurred her forward, despite the exhaustion.

"Entrapta, what of the Runestones and the Heart?" Catra asked.

"Are we not destroying them?" Scorpia asked hesitantly.

"No, we found that won't work." Catra waved a hand dismissively. She paused, taking a breath. "Entrapta said the idea is outdated." She tried again. Scorpia gave her a small smile.

"Runestones can't be destroyed but they can be deactivated." Hordak suggested. The three stared at him for a moment.

"That's not a terrible idea." Catra said begrudgingly.

"The Heart could be deactivated in theory." Entrapta added. "But Adora's already done as much as she can in that department." Entrapta joined Hordak at his workbench, the two discussing options.

"Scorpia," Catra sighed. "I have a favor to ask."

"Yeah?"

"If something happens in the next few days, if I need you to…" Catra struggled to phrase it. She had told them Senator Brakenten had threatened Adora but putting the newer threat into words made it real. "I need you to get everyone to safety."

"Do you think it will be like that?" Scorpia asked softly.

"I don't know yet." Catra rubbed her arms, hugging herself. "But the plan would be the head to the Crystal Castle in the Whispering Woods. We'd use that as our meet up point. Your job would be to get Adora and the others to the castle safely. Could-Can I trust that to you?" Catra reworded her request last second, hoping it would portray her intentions better.

"You got it."

Present Day: In the Magic Cage

"ARGH!" Catra grunted as her back slammed into the magic cage. It crackled against her neck and spine in ways she remembered all too well. Melog jumped in front of her protectively, growling loudly.

She-ra stumbled towards them, her green eyes vivid in the looming shadows. As the purple magic crackled and struggled around them, Catra thought...

This is how I die. Killed at the hand of my chipped goddess tier girlfriend.

I suppose there could be worse ways to die.

She-ra raised her sword, summoning energy above her. Catra heard Glimmer and Scorpia's cries as the marks of the

Heart glowed against their skin. Catra grabbed the back of Melog's neck and clung as it bounded out of the way. A blast of the sword decimated the air where they had previously been. Catra panted with effort as Melog continued its pace around the cage. She-ra spun to see them, surging forward.

Catra yelped as Melog jumped onto the wall, cascading them over She-ra. She-ra crumbled against the wall, before staggering onto her feet again. Catra cast a quick glance out.

Bow held Glimmer as she struggled to hold her part of the cage. Micah had taken a knee, the strain of holding the magic cage primarily by himself growing on him. Scorpia leaned against a crystal further back, Entrapta and Hordak by her side.

Catra cursed. This was not going as she had hoped.

"Adora!" She yelled. "Please. I know you can hear me!" She-ra cocked her head before sending another slash of rainbow energy.

Catra yelped as she and Melog were separated, the end of the slash having caught them. Catra tumbled off to the side. She could feel the cuts and scrapes forming as she skidded to a stop. She clambered forward. She snapped her head up, watching as Melog attacked She-ra from behind. She grabbed Melog by the neck and slammed it into the ground.

"Melog!" Catra screamed. She pounced forward, digging her claws into She-ra's side. She used the momentum to swing herself up and around to She-ra's front, barely missing the sword's arc. She-ra snarled as Catra wrapped her hands around her ponytail. She raised her fist to strike at the chip when She-ra grabbed the back of her shirt.

Catra hit the ground with a thud. She struggled to grasp her breath, rolling back to miss another energy blast. She shifted to her hands and knees, heaving. Melog appeared under her, its form moving them out of the way of She-ra's fist.

Catra used its back to jump back to She-ra, digging her claws into She-ra's body. Her expression flickered with pain but otherwise, She-ra's expression never wavered the green-eyed snarl that did not fit her lover.

"Adora!" Catra barked. The command jolted She-ra, Catra dropping as She-ra's form flickered back to the smaller Adora. Catra propped herself up on her elbows quickly.

"Catra! Help-" Adora reached out her hand before gasping. Her head threw back as her body arced, her blue eyes swallowed by green. A burst of light welcomed She-ra's form again, the snarl replacing the cry for help.

Catra's heart ached as she scurried out of the way of She-ra's strike. But in the same moment, her heart swelled with hope.

Adora, like Catra had , was fighting against the chip.

Catra patted her belt, the small instrument from Entrapta still tucked into place. She took a breath as she stood. She-ra panted, staring her down.

"I'm coming." Catra whispered.

The Day Before: Bright Moon Castle

Catra groaned as her eyes fluttered open. Her head pounded in the way it had only a few times before. Scorpia had stung her. She moved her hand to cup her head. Her body ached from their fight in the Fright Zone.

Catra still could feel the horror from when she'd realized the keypads had changed to the same type of passwords aboard the Velvet Glove. How she had seen the screens and the moment she realized it was a trap. That the room was a reconditioning station. The way her mind screamed for her body

to move and yet she had felt as stuck and lifeless as when it had happened the first time.

"You're awake." Bow exclaimed. She looked to the right, seeing Scorpia and Bow sitting with a plate of food. Her surroundings came into focus as she brought herself back to the moment. Bright Moon's infirmary? Her back ached as her mind finally acknowledged the rock-hard cot beneath her.

"You. Stung. Me?" Catra glared at Scorpia as she propped herself up on her elbow.

"I'm sorry." Scorpia grabbed her tail.

"I thought we agreed not to do that anymore." Catra snapped, wincing at her own loud voice. "Why?" She sighed.

"We didn't really have any other options." Bow spoke softly, clearly exhausted. Catra's claws scraped against the fabric underneath her loudly. Bow cast her a look. He returned to his previous action, repairing some of his arrows.

Catra closed her eyes, realizing he was referring to their arrival back to Bright Moon. The return trip via Glimmer's teleport compounded with the events of their day. Under the weight, Catra mentally broke. She remembered screaming and swiping her claws at them. Scorpia restraining her against a wall and a sharp prick in her side were the last things she could recall.

"Where is Sparkles?" Catra asked, hoping to get her mind off the memory.

"She went to deal with the council." Bow answered, not looking up. He held an arrow in the air for better light before bringing a tool to it. "She said she wanted to get ready for when everyone arrives in the morning."

Catra cast a look to Scorpia, who had remained silent. She had several scratches in her armor, something Catra hadn't

seen much of before. She had dark circles under her eyes but still tried to smile at Catra.

Bow had a few gashes but otherwise seemed fine. Adora was no where to be seen.

"Adora?" Catra's voice betrayed her panic.

"Still sleeping. I just checked on her before you woke." Bow slid the arrow back into his quiver, slinging it over his shoulder. "I'll let Glimmer know you're awake. Do you want anything from the kitchen?"

"No, I'm fine." Catra clasped her hands together. Bow nodded and left. She could've sworn that was the first time she had seen him so dejected and quiet. "I'm sorry, Scorpia for snapping at you. Thank you for helping me."

"I'm sorry for stinging you." Scorpia held her tail closer to her chest. "You were attacking everyone, screaming how you weren't going back." Catra winced against the tone in Scorpia's voice. "You screamed at Glimmer, calling her a traitor. When you pounced at her, that's when I…" Scorpia trailed off.

Great…Glimmer wasn't going to ever let her live that down. Catra faceplanted into the pillow. She slammed her fist into the cot, sensing Scorpia's jump at the motion. Catra pushed herself back up, kicking her legs over the side. She clasped her hands, taking a breath.

"I'm sorry. Thank you." Scorpia nodded. "Did Glimmer say anything?" Catra clenched her fists as she realized the weight of what she had said. If Glimmer said anything to Senator Brakenten…

"She was concerned for you. She figured you were flashing back to Prime…She said she was too." A pang of guilt hit Catra hard. She hadn't even thought about how it would've affected Glimmer. "She said she wouldn't mention it to anyone else, for your sake. She asked us to do the same."

"Thanks." Catra rubbed her head, her headache growing in intensity.

"You should rest a little." Scorpia shot a look to the door. "It's only been a few hours."

"I need to…"

"Entrapta said to return a little later." Scorpia whispered. Catra's eyes grew wide. Scorpia being secretive and sneaky around? She narrowed her eyes, wondering if Double Trouble was the one here instead. "She said she needed a little more time but you and Melog should go back in about another 2-3 hours."

Catra exhaled harshly. "Let me see my trackerpad." Scorpia handed it over. Well, that explained why Scorpia was acting so nervous. She was as bad as Adora when it came to acting or lying. Seahawk had said she had performed a song about being a spy, while she was on a mission. That was Scorpia for you.

Catra quickly reviewed any information. She had a new message, a simple confirmation of the meeting place should things go south. Catra confirmed and moved on. Entrapta's message about returning later popped up, confirming Scorpia's story.

"What about the Senator?" Catra asked in a hushed tone. The door clicked; Catra cursed.

Catra shoved the trackerpad under her pillow as Bow re-entered the room. Scorpia shot her a silent question.

Catra's eyes flashed to him and back to Scorpia's. She gave a small shake of the head. Bow was still in the gray zone. She couldn't tell if it was safe. She had trusted him a few times now to watch Adora while she was gone but…this was different. Wasn't it?

Bow retook his seat, retrieving another arrow and tinkering with it. She recognized it as one of his sonic arrows.

"What about the clone situation?" Catra hoped he had more information.

"We haven't heard much. Entrapta is supposed to contact us in a few hours with an update. She and Hordak said they would watch it and call if anything went wrong." Bow answered absent-mindedly.

Catra groaned and flopped back on the cot. She stared at the ceiling.

"Catra." Melog's voice spoke in her head. Her eyes widened in surprise.

"Where are you?" She whispered as not to be heard by the others.

"I am with Adora." It responded. "She is okay, for now."

"Are you okay?"

"Yes." Catra breathed a sigh of relief.

Silence permeated the room for a while. Bow eventually fell asleep, much to Catra's delight. She asked Scorpia to watch over Bow. She retrieved her trackerpad from under the pillow. As she snuck out of the infirmary, she noticed the lack of guards. The quiet of the palace added to her uneasiness. She continued until she reached their bedroom.

Cracking the door open, Melog's head popped up from the bed. It had sprawled over Adora's body in its usual way. Adora laid, the failsafe shimmering over her chest. Catra grimaced and entered the room, against her better judgement.

Adora's labored breathing unsettled her. Catra sat on the bed, placing her hand against Adora's forehead. Her fever had returned. Adora muttered in her sleep, turning over. Catra retrieved a wet cloth from the bathroom and patted her face. Adora's murmurs were the same as the other times, the language that none of them understood.

She sat with Adora for a time before receiving a message on her trackerpad.

Entrapta's seal.

She stood slowly.

"Ready?" She asked. Melog chirped.

The lab materialized around them, the change in lighting momentarily blinding them. As her eyes cleared, she noticed Entrapta and Hordak sitting at the workbench on the left.

"Hey." Catra breathed.

"You're back." Entrapta greeted. She did a quick look over before dragging Catra to the computer with her.

"Everyone else is okay too." Catra said. Entrapta paused, her eyes dropping for a second. "Just thought you'd want the update."

"Thanks. I'm glad." Entrapta smiled before launching into her rant.

"I ran a BUNCH of tests on Adora before and after the events." Entrapta's eyes shined. "I got so much data that I didn't have before! Adora hasn't really let me run-" She stopped at Catra's expression. "Focus!" Entrapta's twin tendrils smacked her cheeks.

"Did you find anything?"

"I found something *REALLY INTERESTING*!" Entrapta squealed, pulling up her charts and data. "We talked before about how the Heart isn't technically active anymore. But it is the aftershocks that Adora is dealing with, right!?"

"Right~…"

"When I started the tests on Adora, almost all of her signs came up normal at first. But when everything started happening and Adora left, I didn't get to finish the last tests. When you all came back and Adora collapsed, I started over to compare the two data points."

"What did you find?" Catra pressed.

"Adora's magic levels, once they had decreased, were still insanely high." Catra watched as a graph appeared in front of her. On the left, the bars were all the same height at a fairly high point in the graph. On the right, the bars started higher than the graph showed before equalizing to the same level as the other. "Adora's magic shouldn't be this high." Entrapta used her hair to lift herself level with the screen.

"What are you comparing it to?" Catra crossed her arms.

"Some data I collected on Darla!" Entrapta answered before motioning to the first part. "See how the graph is even here. Adora's magic should be here." Entrapta dropped a majority of the chart, pointing to a spot one third of the actual bar. "But it's all the way up here." Entrapta raised herself back up, pointing to the spot the bar actually sat.

"What's causing it?" Catra asked.

"Look at this!" Entrapta cooed, sliding to the right side. "This is when Adora collapsed after you all returned. Her magic is off the charts, literally!" Entrapta chortled. "But! Instead of returning down to this point," Entrapta dropped to the lower point on the graph. "It stays at the higher level!"

Catra took a deep breath and looked to Entrapta to continue. The Princess lowered herself to the ground and clasped her hands in front of her.

"Do you see what I mean?!"

"Gonna be honest, not really." Entrapta pouted slightly, looking back at her graphs.

"Entrapta." Hordak finally spoke in a semi sarcastic tone that Catra knew was meant for her. Catra had almost forgotten he was there. "Why is it that high?"

"Oh, because Adora was poisoned." Entrapta said dismissively.

"WHAT?!" Catra screeched. She grabbed Entrapta's shoulders, not missing the small wince as Catra's claws dug in without intent. "What do you mean she was poisoned?!"

"Just that. She was poisoned." Entrapta stated. "I showed you all the data."

"Entrapta…" Catra hung her head. "I don't understand." She gritted her teeth, trying not to yell like she used to. "How does any of that," Catra pointed at the screen. "Explain Adora being poisoned?"

Entrapta took a breath and lifted herself out of Catra's reach. She crossed her arms, staring at the screen.

"The magic levels being that high meant something was causing Adora to be using magic at a constant unsustainable rate." Hordak answered. "When Adora returned and Entrapta proceeded with her tests," Entrapta came down and brought up a toxicology report. "Traces of poison were found in her system."

"What type of poison? How did this happen?!" Catra hoped the horror didn't sneak into her voice. Hordak rattled off a name she didn't know.

"I would suspect she would've been poisoned daily for months for it to be this bad." Hordak joined Entrapta at the computer. He placed a hand on her shoulder, the move of compassion surprising Catra. Entrapta smiled up at him.

"How would she-" Catra blood ran cold for a moment.

"Have you been drinking that tea?"

"What tea?" Catra's eyes flicked between them.

"It was something they suggested after the Mystacor trip." Adora started.

"Even more so after the library accident a week ago." Micah finished. "It's a concoction of different herbs and potions to help with the magic attacks and their effects."

"Does it help?" Catra racked her brain for any moments she had seen Adora drinking any sort of teas.

"A little bit." Adora coughed. "I normally take it in the morning…after you leave for your meetings."

"No." Tears tracked down her cheeks. After everything she had done…Adora had been poisoned right in front of her this entire time… Before the threats started. Before Senator Brakenten had really been on her radar. She'd lost before she even began.

"There you are!" Glimmer's voice jolted her. "Really? Entrapta was supposed to-"

"We have to go back to Bright Moon!" Catra yelled as she grabbed Glimmer's arms. Melog's mane spiked red to her side.

"What? Why? We haven't even-"

"Glimmer! We have to go now!" Catra's voice broke. Glimmer's eyes widened. "Entrapta, you and Hordak get

everything ready. Meet Scorpia there!" Entrapta and Hordak nodded solemnly. "Melog!"

Dryl faded as Bright Moon's halls came into view. Glimmer shoved Catra back.

"What is going on?!"

"Listen," Catra grabbed her wrists. "Scorpia knows what to do. Find her and Bow in the infirmary. Get as many people as you can out and follow Scorpia! I'll get Adora!"

"Catra, tell me what's going on!" A shudder rumbled through the building, splitting the ground beneath their feet.

"Later! Go!!" Catra shoved her towards the infirmary. She and Melog sprinted in the opposite direction.

Catra pleaded to anyone or anything that might have been listening that she made it in time…or that she was extremely wrong.

As she turned the hall, their bedroom door exploded open. The blast knocked Catra and Melog back.

Catra clutched her ears, the ringing shrill in her ears.

"Well, hello. Horde Scum." Senator Brakenten loomed over her. The ringing in her ears decreased but not fast enough for her liking. Their voice distorted in her ears. "I did tell you. If Adora left Bright Moon at all…"

"What did you do?!" Catra suppressed a whimper as green glowing eyes lit the darkened hall. They slowly closed in around the three.

"I told you before, I'm bringing peace to Etheria. Order. Finally, we shall know something other than war and death."

"This isn't the way! You don't know what you're…"

"I know exactly what I am doing."

A scream cut short echoed from behind. Catra gasped for air, dread and fear running rampant.

"Take her and the alien." Senator Brakenten commanded the clones. "Preferably alive." They cast a look back to her. "Though, if you struggled too much…" Sounds of fighting and yelling filled their air behind them. One of those sounded too familiar.

"Catra." Melog growled. Catra understood, wrapping herself around its neck.

Melog roared. Though Catra thought that was putting it lightly. It was effective though. The clones skidded backwards, the Senator thrown off guard.

"GET THEM!" Senator Brakenten yelled. Clones stumbled to their feet as Melog took off towards the infirmary.

"Melog, we have to find Adora!!" Catra yelled over the noise in her ears.

Suddenly, Bow appeared around the corner, ready with an arrow.

"Woah!" Catra yelped, Melog skidding to a stop.

"Catra!" Scorpia's voice overlapped Bow's. Catra shot a look down the hall. Scorpia held Adora over her shoulder, Adora's body hanging limp like a rag doll. Micah held Glimmer in his arms. Clearly the Queen had taken another hit as she groaned.

"Scorpia, go! Get to the Rendezvous point!" A blast shattered the wall on her left. She glanced back to see the clones gaining.

"What about you?!"

"I'll buy you time! GO!!" Scorpia frowned, clearly conflicted but nodded.

"Come on!" Scorpia motioned. Micah followed as they started in the opposite direction.

Bow shared a look with Catra. Despite the hurt and confusion that filled his eyes, he still gave her a soft caring look. Catra couldn't explain but it was comforting.

"Please." Catra pleaded. Bow nodded before sprinting to join the others.

Melog turned to face the clones.

"They are going that way, so we need to go the other." Catra muttered more to herself. Her job was keeping the clones and the Senator busy long enough for Scorpia's group to get out of the castle.

This was going to be a long night….

Present Day: Magic Cage

Catra's claws screeched as she skidded to a stop. She panted, her lungs burning for air. Her head snapped up at the sound of roaring water. She jumped to the left, hugging the side of the cage as water blasted by her. She gritted her teeth, looking at its source.

She-ra's green eyes turned to her. She raised her free hand and vines sprouted from the ground.

Catra cursed as she slashed at them. She-ra apparently had the abilities of all of the other Princesses?! Not to

mention, the ability to call on them at will. Since when was that a thing?!~

Finally free, she ran to the other side. She jumped over and slashed at the vines and roots trying to snag her. She slid to her knees, helping Melog out of its bind. A bolt of lightning fried the air above her.

The only thing that was semi comforting to Catra about this was She-ra's attacks were slowing. Catra knew first hand the chip didn't care about physical limits. She could still feel the phantom pains in her wrist sometimes. But that wasn't what this was.

It meant that Adora was making a dent.

Adora was purposefully delaying shots or missing by a fraction.

Catra laughed at the irony.

Adora, who was top of their cadet class. Purposefully missing to help her.

Though, Catra supposed, Adora did hold back a lot in their fights during those three years.

A vine tackled her side, slamming her and Melog into one of the walls. That was what she got for thinking in one place too long.

Ice circled the air around them, blocking them against the wall. Melog growled and turned the two invisible. It pulled them outside the barrier, but it didn't matter.

She-ra unleashed another shot of sparkling energy. The two tumbled off to the side. Catra huffed as she pushed herself up.

"Melog." It chirped, disappearing into the air. She stood to face She-ra. She risked another glance outside to the others.

Glimmer and Scorpia had both passed out from the magic draining them. She didn't have time to focus on the others as she saw She-ra's sword raise in the air.

"Adora, I know this isn't you." She tried. The memory of Adora's distorted voice played in her head. "Come back to me."

"No." She-ra's voice rumbled with the voices of many, sending chills down Catra's spine. Other than when Adora herself had appeared, She-ra had remained silent. "We will not return. We are at peace. Peace only Prime can bring."

Catra felt her heart pick up, dread filling her. Prime's voice rang in her ears. All the whispers as he tortured her. All the times he told her to call out his name to save her from the pain. All the horrible things he did to her.

"Adora. That's not you. You know this isn't peace." Catra said, extending her hands. "You saved me from this."

"We…" She-ra's mouth stuck open as if she had frozen.

"Adora?" Catra took a step forward, her hand extending.

She-ra flickered down to Adora's size. Adora's hands flew to the back of her neck. She cried out as it sparked against her.

"Catra." She opened one of her eyes, extending her right hand.

"I'm not leaving. I'm right here." Catra took another step, another. Another. Their fingers brushed as Adora screamed. She bent at the waist, She-ra's form lighting the cage. "NO!" Catra rushed forward to grab Adora, as if that would keep her present.

She-ra backhanded her, sending her crashing back into the wall. Catra was beginning to hate the walls. She coughed hard, the air gone.

"He has brought us peace." She-ra's voice echoed through the cage. "Return to this peace with us."

"Never." Catra spat to the side as she regained her footing. She-ra growled and surged forward. Catra jumped at the last moment, using She-ra's lowered shoulder to push herself up. She followed the momentum, She-ra crashing head first into the magic wall. She slumped down for the briefest of moments.

"MELOG!" Catra screamed, whipping out Entrapta's device. It appeared in the air, biting She-ra's nape. She-ra screamed an array of distorted sounds.

The sound broke Catra's heart. She steeled herself as Melog jumped back. The chip exposed and sparked from the damage of Melog's teeth. Catra lined up the instrument when She-ra shot up. The motion threw Catra off. She held the device close to her chest to not damage it.

She growled as she looked up. She-ra held her nape, leaning against the wall. Her green eyes glared at Catra.

"Melog." Catra called. It appeared beside her.

"We have moments before she recovers." It spoke. "We must succeed."

"Let's go." Catra dug her foot under her, propelling herself forward. Melog, who had faded, appeared at She-ra's arm. It dug its teeth in, pulling her down to the ground.

She-ra raised her fist to strike as Catra pounced. She swung up, the device locked and loaded. She aimed for it when suddenly she couldn't move. She stared at the green marks flooding the veins around the chip. Fear froze her in place as

memories flooded back. She-ra grabbed her shirt, pulling her around before slamming her into Melog.

Catra's head swam with blurry spots from all the times she had hit her head in this fight alone. She groaned as she saw She-ra's sword raise over her.

"Adora, no!" Bow's voice rang out. She-ra paused, staring out the cage. Catra sat stunned for a moment herself. He had been surprisingly quiet this whole time. Catra realized what he was doing. Melog shimmered the two of them out of range, still invisible as they came to a rest on the other side. "Please. Adora, you're our friend." Bow's speech about friendship continued, Catra catching her breath momentarily.

"We must move now if we wish to hit the chip before she heals it." Melog reminded. Catra nodded but couldn't bring herself to move.

"I…" Her voice died.

"We're the Best Friend Squad." Bow's final line rang true. Catra looked up to him, to find him looking right at her. Momentary panic filled her brain as she wondered if they were visible. Bow returned his eyes to She-ra. "You want to talk about coming back? Come back to us."

Catra and Melog agreed silently, racing towards the memorized She-ra. Was it a ploy? Catra pushed the thought aside. No, she had been able to stop herself a few times under the chip. Adora was doing the same.

She-ra's sword swung towards them in incredible speed, ice and vines following it.

Melog and Catra leapt right, one of the vines catching Catra's ankle. She hissed as pain tore through it. She slashed it free when a blast of water hit her dead in the chest.

She sputtered as she tumbled back. She coughed up the water, as darkness overcame her.

She-ra loomed over her, bent at the waist to look at Catra. Her green eyes shone vividly in the shadows. Catra couldn't stop the shakiness of her breath as She-ra cocked her head at her.

A breath passed as She-ra faded once more. Adora collapsed onto Catra. Catra grunted under the sudden weight.

"Catra, do it now!" Bow called. Catra reached for her device, it jammed between her leg and the ground. She growled, forcing it out. She heard the ripping of fabric but didn't care.

"I'm sorry." Catra muttered, sure this wasn't going to be pleasant.

"Catra." Adora's broken voice paused her. "I love you."

"What…"

"I can't keep…" Adora choked, her skin glowing already. "I can't…"

"Yes, you can!" Catra grabbed Adora's cheeks. "You're Adora and you never give up on anything! You didn't give up on me! You PROMISED you would stay! So stay with me!" Catra yelled the last part, not caring how close they were.

Adora opened her mouth to respond as green flushed the blue from her eyes. She-ra's hand grabbed her throat, lifting her as she stood.

Catra gasped, her hands clawing at She-ra's arm in protest. She choked out Adora's name, the device still looped around her fingers.

"No!" Several voices rang out. Catra tried kicking, biting, pounding her fist but nothing loosened the grip around her

neck. “Catra!” Catra released a small cry. She was sure that was the first time in a while, that someone had called her name like that…someone that wasn’t Adora.

“I love you too.” Catra used the last of her breath to say. If she were going to die, she wanted Adora to know. At least she wanted her last words to be the expression of love that Adora deserved.

The grip loosened, Catra dropping to the ground. She gasped like a fish out of water, air her sweet and fading luxury.

Adora, herself again, stumbled back. She screamed and cried out as she pounded at her own neck.

“I will NOT hurt anyone else!” Adora yelled.

“Melog!” Catra saw her chance. Melog appeared, tackling Adora to the ground. They pinned her there as Catra scurried over. Adora cried out as her chip fought her. The glow of She-ra faded in and out as Adora fought for control.

Catra lined up the device, pulling it as fast as she could. A shot of purple liquid splashed over the chip. It crackled and fizzed out. Adora’s cry dropped to a whimper before silence. Catra stood, her heart pounding in her chest.

She turned to Bow and the others as she saw the magic cage begin to fade.

“I did it.” She called. She moved to step towards them as Bow and Micah waited for the last of the magic to fade. “I…”

The world faded to black as Catra felt her body hit the ground.

“Catra!”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for getting to this point.
This might sound a little crazy but this is kinda the end of Act 1 (for lack of better wording) Act 2 will begin with Catra's POV for her third chapter in Chapter 15.
I can't thank you all enough for the time you have spent reading and supporting this fic with comments, kudos, and bookmarks. I won't make any promises of when chapter 15 will be posted as I have learned if I say one date, it ends up being double that. :P That said, I am beginning chapter 15 now and will post it as soon as I can.
Until next chapter! :)

Picking Up the Pieces

Chapter Notes

> Oh my god, I'm alive. Thank you to everyone who's been waiting 6 months for this update. I'll have a longer note at the end of the chapter. I don't want to hold you up for those of you who have been waiting so long for this. I have worked on this chapter for a month now and I don't feel it holds up in comparison to Chapter 14 in the slightest but hopefully you all enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 15: Catra

Catra groaned, pressing her fingers into her temples. The lights around her shone way too brightly in her opinion. Her head throbbed as she pushed herself up. Melog's head perked up from its place against her leg.

The makeshift bed under her felt cool in the places she hadn't been, wondering how long she had been laying there. The crystals overhead glowed and glittered different colors. Catra surveyed her surroundings.

A sort of fabric created walls around her, similar to the medical tent they'd had during the War. Catra slid her feet off, the movement sending waves of nausea. She covered her mouth and forced herself to stand. Hugging her arm around her stomach, she stumbled forward.

She pushed the fabric to the side and stepped out into the main area. The makeshift camp bustled with people performing care tasks and preparing for something, what Catra had no idea. Catra and Melog shifted and moved through the flow of people until they found Entrapta.

The Princess of Dryl sat tucked away in her own corner of the area. Sparks flew as she welded or worked on something. Catra chastised herself for not knowing exactly what she was doing yet.

"Entrapta?" Catra's voice came out raspy. She touched her throat and made a mental note to find water. But the sound was adequate. Entrapta turned and flipped her mask up. Her face lit up as she lurched forward to wrap Catra in a hug.

"HA! You're awake!" Entrapta squealed. Melog's mane flared red as Catra's senses went into overdrive. She pushed Entrapta off. She stepped back and wrapped her arms around herself. Melog stepped in front, clearly torn between protecting her and greeting their friend. "Right! Sorry, you don't do hugs. But I'm glad you're awake."

"How long was I out?" Catra rubbed her arms subconsciously and looked out to the view around them.

"Three days." Entrapta sat on a hair tendril curled beneath her.

"Thre-" Catra choked, coughing. She smacked her chest once and looked at Entrapta. "Three days?!"

"Yep." The other hair tendril offered Catra a fizzy drink. Better than nothing, Catra supposed. She took a swig, wincing as the liquid fizzed against her sore throat. "Everyone arrived shortly after you collapsed."

"Where's Adora?" Catra asked. She cursed herself for not asking sooner.

"She's fine!" Entrapta waved her hands in the air before pausing. "Relatively." Entrapta swung to her feet and led Catra back towards the medic area. They moved through the curtains, passing Catra's cot. In the space next to hers, laid the sleeping Adora. Catra rushed to her side, dropping to her knees beside the cot.

“She’s breathing.” Melog spoke. It propped itself up on the opposite side of the bed.

“Magic levels?” Catra asked to none in particular. She tugged at the medical gown Adora wore, noticing her regular clothes folded in a small pile on the chair in the corner.

“Regular. She hasn’t had a flare up since we removed the chip.” Entrapta said with a smile.

“She is exhausted. The fight drained a majority of her magic. She needs rest.” Melog added.

“She’s been out the whole time too?”

“Yeah. You both just dropped.” Entrapta motioned with her hair tendrils. “The others were really worried.” She paused. “I was worried too, but I couldn’t really help with that. So, I worked on other things!” Entrapta perked up. Catra closed her eyes briefly and gave a wry smile.

“You wanna tell me?”

“You want to hear it?!”

“Sure.” Catra stood. She wanted to stay with Adora, but she had things to do. She had been out for three days. Stars only knew what had become of her plans in that time. “Where’s Scorpia?”

“She’s in the planning area.” Entrapta pointed with a tendril. “You should probably go there.”

“I’ll loop back.” Catra patted Entrapta’s shoulder. “I wanna hear what you’ve been working on.” Entrapta nodded with a smile. Melog laid itself over Adora’s body, taking up its guard for Catra’s sake. Catra thanked it before heading towards the ‘planning area’. Entrapta parted ways at her section.

Catra wrapped her arms around herself as she weaved through the crowds. She resisted the urge to wilt under the glares she felt surrounding her. She was Horde Lea- the Royal Strategist. She forced herself to straighten and walk with her head high.

She paused as her fingers curled around the fabric marking off the 'planning area'. Time to face the music. At least this time there wasn't a war overlord torturing and brainwashing her? She shook her head and pulled back the curtain.

"CATRA!" The chorus echoed before she was tackled. She squealed as they fell to the ground.

"Thank stars you're awake!" Glimmer exclaimed.

"We were so worried." Bow pulled Glimmer back, the three sitting on the floor. Catra stared at them in shock, pushing them off her. She scurried to her feet. Her claws extended and her tail bushed out.

"Are you okay?" Micah's voice brought her attention to behind the couple. Micah sat at a table with the other princesses and Juliet. A map stretched out over their makeshift table. Several of the princesses wore bandages wrapped around them in different locations.

"CATRA!" Scorpia jumped up from her seat and came over. She held out her arms before stopping and wrapping one around the other. "I'm glad to see you're okay." Catra's ears twitched in annoyance as she ran a hand over her tail. She rescinded her claws and held out her arms, looking off to the side. Scorpia gasped happily. Catra yelped as Scorpia pulled her into a tight embrace. She released her just as quickly. Catra straightened her outfit.

"Glad to see you're okay." Perfuma smiled. She had a set of bandages wrapped around her head and her left arm. It was definitely weird seeing her without a flower crown for once. Frosta sat next to her, one of the only ones at the table with no

injuries. Mermista wore the most bandages, half leaning against Seahawk and the table. Her braid spilled halfway from its constraints and her clothes were littered with tears and holes. She glared at Catra, yet Catra didn't feel a sense of anger from her. If anything, she felt a sense of loss coming from the princess.

"Catra?" Bow's soft touch on her arm brought her attention back to his worried expression. "Are you feeling okay?"

"Why are you being nice to me?" She snapped, smacking his hand away.

"Why wouldn't we be?" Glimmer asked.

"Wh-" Catra guffawed. "After everything that's happened over the last month, you suddenly just trust me still?! I doubt it. You're probably planning on sending me to Beast Island right now!" Catra caught the wince Micah tried to hide, his eyes shifting down.

"No!" Glimmer's face warped in horror. "Catra, you saved us! In a roundabout way but you did save us! We wouldn't be planning to send you away, regardless!"

"Catra, take a deep breath." Bow held his hands up. "I promise you; no one here wants to hurt you. We're all glad you're okay."

"You're lying." Catra wrapped an arm around herself.

"I'm not and you know that."

"You-" Catra's eyes flew around the room, looking for something to anchor herself on, something to throw her anger at. She picked a random spot in the back left corner, behind Seahawk. She stared at it while they spoke to her. She resisted the urge to draw her claws, to dig them into the people before her. That's what she was good at, wasn't it? Destroying everything good in her life?!

"Good." Bow coaxed. "You're safe."

"What's-What have you been planning in my absence?" Catra ran a hand through her hair, finally breaking her glare at the corner.

"That's what we were discussing now." Glimmer motioned to the table.

"Why don't we take a break?" Micah offered. "I think Catra needs another minute. Let's take five and we go get some food?"

"Sounds good to me." Frosta stood and helped Perfuma out. Scorpia took a seat on the floor, watching the others. As the rest filed out, only the four remained.

"Scorpia, fill me in." Catra ordered as she dropped into a chair. "Please?"

"Well, it's been three days since that whole thing went down." Scorpia started. Glimmer teleported away without a word. She came back with a cape full of food and water for the four. Scorpia continued her recap while Catra ate.

After Adora was freed from the chip and she and Catra both dropped, things got better. Glimmer and Scorpia improved from the symptoms of being drained and Micah was able to recover quickly as well. The other Princesses had gotten Entrapta's message and arrived hours after the fight. They began setting up camp again, rescuing as many from different cities as they could.

"What's the plan now?" Glimmer asked with a gulp of water.

"I…" Catra pauses. She blanched as she realized she hadn't gotten that far. She had been so concerned on the current threat, that for the first time in a long time, she hadn't thought further ahead. She mentally slapped herself for being so stupid.

“I’ll explain everything when Adora wakes up.” She had to buy time somehow.

“Catra, you can’t keep us in the dark like this anymore.” Glimmer huffed. “We barely made it out of Bright Moon and it took everything to subdue Adora under the chip because we had no idea what was going on!”

“As if you didn’t keep me in the dark about certain things.” Catra bit with an emphasis on certain things.

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Glimmer narrowed her eyes.

“I think you know.”

“Okay!” Bow stood and moved between them. “Fighting right now doesn’t help anyone.” Catra rose to her feet, claws flexing. Glimmer’s fists glowed. Scorpia pulled Catra back as Bow shoved Glimmer away. “Enough!” Catra swiped away Scorpia’s hand with a loud huff before glaring back to Glimmer. She shook her head and stormed out of the tent.

“Catra~!” Scorpia called before lumbering after her.

“Who needs her?” Catra grumbled to herself. “We did ALL of this without them.” Catra stopped as she realized Scorpia wasn’t following her. The princess stood, rubbing her pincers together, clearly torn between friends. Catra sighed heavily. “I’m sorry. You’ve been helping me a lot and I’m sure you dealt with a lot while I was…”

“It’s…” Scorpia struggled for words before speaking in a soft voice. “Perfuma asked why I hadn’t said anything to her.” Catra exhaled and pursed her lips. Of course, Perfuma and Scorpia were dating now. Flowers was all about being open and trusting friendships and Catra had forced Scorpia to betray her. Typical Catra, ruining everything.

"You didn't say anything." Catra stated. "Even when I was out?"

"Entrapta and Hordak insisted on waiting until you woke. They agreed and convinced everyone it would be best to hear it all at once from you." Hordak must have known that would've bought them time until Catra woke so they wouldn't be hounded for questions. "No one was a really fan of it at first until Mermista agreed with the idea." Catra blinked in surprise. Not the princess she would've thought to speak up for her but today was full of surprises.

"Speaking of our geek princess," Catra turned away. "Let's meet up with Entrapta. I told her I'd come back." Scorpia agreed and silence permeated the air as they walked.

Catra needed the update on the chip and to know what exactly they were up against if she was to come up with a plan in the time it took Adora to wake.

Entrapta fidgeted with the gadget Catra had used against Adora's chip as they approached. Her face lit up as she saw them, a high pitch squeal emitting what Catra supposed was a greeting. Scorpia smiled and seemed to relax a little.

"Well," Catra pulled over a stool from the nearby makeshift desk. "We need to get to work."

"That's our Catra." Scorpia teased.

"Yes, sir!" Entrapta's hair tendril saluted as the two giggled. Catra smiled and shook her head, glad they didn't feel she was bossing them around and were able to joke with her. The Catra before wouldn't have taken any of it and snapped. The Catra now smiled and laughed with them as she picked up her Trackerpad and waved a finger jokingly.

"Entrapta, what have you found out about the chips while I was out?"

"Oh!" Entrapta said excitedly. "They are different this time. That's how they got around the network shutdown when we defeated Prime the first time!"

"Different how?" Scorpia rubbed the back of her neck. Catra felt a phantom tug at her nape, shuddering at the sensation.

"It's an incomplete network. There's no head." Entrapta smiled in a slightly creepy way. "With Prime's system, he served as the main entity. The core of the system. But this system has no core. Or it didn't."

"What do you mean?" Catra asked nervously. Entrapta picked up a chip and Catra immediately recognized it as Adora's.

"This was the main chip. This chip was meant to connect Adora to the rest of them and have her serve as the core for the network." Entrapta's excitement waned at the seriousness of the topic. "This is why it affected Adora more harshly than the others."

"That explains why she had all those voices when she spoke under the chip." Scorpia added.

"Adora was probably picked due to her She-Ra abilities. With the healing powers, they must have assumed her body would be able to withstand the strain of the network. But anyone who knows about She-Ra would know Adora can't maintain it permanently. Eventually, she would've died from the strain."

"I'm going to find that Senator and-" Catra froze, her claws extended and in the motion of choking someone. She cleared her throat and rested her hands down again. "Continue."

"The network will fall much easier now that the main chip has failed and been disabled. All we need to do is shut down the power sources and get the chips off people."

"Much easier than last time." Scorpia tried.

"What about Adora?" Catra asked. "She'll recover, right?"

"She should make a full recovery!" Entrapta reassured. "Once she wakes, she'll probably be a little tired and sick at first from the strain of everything but otherwise, my calculations show she'll be just fine." Entrapta's tendril patted Catra's arm. Catra took a deep breath and smiled her gratitude.

"I don't suppose I've gotten any messages on this thing since I was out?"

"Nope, not that I've seen." Entrapta looked to Scorpia, who echoed in agreement. Catra swiped through the trackerpad but to her dismay, no message from the party she needed to hear from appeared. She growled in frustration and put the trackerpad down beside her.

"Well, we need to figure out what's going on outside. I need intel to plan." Catra mused. "I've been one step behind Brakenten this entire time. I thought we were at least catching up but, they had the endgame planned out before it even started."

"How are we going to do that?" Scorpia asked. Catra opened her mouth as she stood when a wave of dizziness hit her. Melog spoke in her mind as she slumped forward. Scorpia's pincers wrapped around her. She vaguely heard Entrapta and Scorpia discussing what was happening before she lost consciousness.

Catra's eyes fluttered open, staring back at the ceiling like before. She groaned as she forced herself to sit up. Her head pounded as her body ached.

"Careful, you shouldn't push it." Glimmer's voice drew her eyes to the end of the bed. The queen stood with her arms

crossed and a small pout on her lip. “You might hurt yourself again.”

“Gee, thanks.” Catra rolled her eyes before pausing. She looked back to the person before her. “Double Trouble, you’re late.”

“Wow, Kitten, you’ve gotten better at this.” Double Trouble chuckled as they sauntered over to sit by her. “But seriously, what did you do to yourself this time?” Double Trouble poked her arm. “I leave you alone for a little while and you start another war.”

“I…” Catra felt herself pale at the words. “Another war. What do you mean?”

“I mean, another war.” Double Trouble, still wearing Glimmer’s appearance, made a fake sympathetic look. “Don’t tell me you didn’t know! Senator’s been having a blast without you there.”

“I’m sure.” Catra rubbed her head. “What’s the status on people in the cities?”

“I’m still working on that part.” Double Trouble paused at Catra’s glare. “What, there’s a lot of those and it’s been a little difficult to get around.”

“The great spy Double Trouble having trouble getting around…what has this world come to?” Catra’s words dripped with sarcasm. “How ever will we survive?”

“I’m not the mastermind this time, am I?” Double Trouble poked her nose. Catra crinkled it in response.

“Don’t do that looking like her.”

“You two on bad terms again?”

“Definitely not great terms.” Catra muttered.

"Well, perhaps that's something you should fix before going back out there. Not a smart idea facing off with this Senator of yours with a broken team, Kitten." Fabric rustled around them. Double Trouble took their chance to stand. They patted her leg a few times. "I'll be back in a few days with your update on the cities. Try and stay sane until then."

"Thanks." Catra watched as they shifted to a random person's form and sauntered out of the tent.

Catra stood to get ready when her eyes caught a small white object fluttering to the ground. She squatted and snatched up the slip of paper.

READ ME LATER.

Catra rolled her eyes and shoved it in her pocket when the curtain shoved back abruptly.

"Catra!" Bow's shoulders drooped in relief. "Glad to see you're awake. Are you feeling okay?"

"I'm fine." Catra brushed off her pants as she stood. "Sparkles?"

"She's fine." Bow smiled. "You're the one who collapsed. You ready to go?"

Three days passed as Catra worked with the others to recover. Endless meeting for resources and attempts at reconnaissance blurred the days together.

At the dawn of the fourth morning, Catra stood running over plans to mobilize and gather supplies from the closest town. Catra yawned as she picked up the list of those going. She leaned both hands on the table and hung her head.

Every day, they demanded answers from her, and every day she told them to wait. They wanted plans she didn't

have. Double Trouble hadn't returned with her intel, and she was in the dark. She had worked with worse conditions with the Horde but generally, she had at least intel from foot soldiers and cadets.

"Catra!" Glimmer burst in with a gleam of sparkles. Catra jumped and drew a hand back to slash when she realized.

"Sparkles." Catra sighed as she pinched her nose. "What is it?"

"Come on!" She grabbed Catra's arm with a knowing wink.

"Wait, no-" Catra yelped as magic enveloped them. The meeting area phased out as the medical tents came into view. Catra slumped to the ground with a groan. The little food she had managed to eat over the last few days threatened to come back up. She held a hand to her mouth as she forced herself to her feet. Glimmer beckoned her forward excitedly. Catra narrowed her eyes but followed. She noticed the crowd of people gathering around one section. Glimmer turned to her with a knowing smile.

Catra sprinted forward before her mind caught up to what she was doing. She pushed through the crowd, though most of them let her through when they saw her. Catra gasped as she took in the sight.

Adora laughed as Bow said something. Adora stood on her own two feet with no assistance. The color was back to her face, her cheeks red with laughter. She wore her blue uniform, not the medical gown she had been wearing the last week. Catra's eyes welled with tears, betraying her tough leader persona.

"Catra!" Bow said. Adora spun, a smile sparkling with the blue of her eyes.

Unspoken, the two rushed forward and collided into a hug. Catra grabbed hold of whatever she could, losing herself in Adora's presence. Several people cooed and clapped. Adora snatched Catra's waist, lifting and spinning her around, eliciting a

laugh Catra hadn't given in weeks. Adora was back. Her Adora was back. As her feet touched the ground, her arms wrapped back around Adora. She buried her face in her shoulder.

"I told you it was a good idea to wait to get Catra." Glimmer remarked as she joined them.

"Wait to get me?" Catra pulled back and narrowed a glare at the Queen. "How long has she been awake?" To Adora, "How long have you been awake?!"

"Not long." Adora giggled. "They just gave me time to get dressed first before calling everyone over." Adora brushed a piece of hair from Catra's eyes. "Why, were you worried?" Adora raised an eyebrow teasingly.

"Not at all." Catra played along.

"Don't lie!" Catra caught Frosta's voice. "She was totally worried about you all week."

"Hey!" Catra started to turn when Adora grabbed her shirt. She pulled her in for a kiss. Catra let out a small sound and flushed as everyone cheered. As Adora released her, she looked towards the ground and covered her mouth with the back of her hand.

"Alright, alright." Micah called as he entered the area. "Let's give her some space to breath."

"Your Majesty." Adora smiled before embracing him.

"Welcome back." He turned to speak to the group. "Let's get her some food and catch up on everything."

"Thank you." Adora sighed happily. Several people came forward to continue saying hello. Catra stepped back to allow space, wrapping her arms around herself. Melog brushed against her leg with a soft mew.

"Did I do well?" Melog asked.

"The best." Catra petted its head. "Thank you for everything."

Adora was led to the main area by several of her friends while Catra had to return to the meeting tent. She and Micah reviewed the last-minute details before sending the team off to gather supplies.

After another hour, Catra's nails tapped anxiously against the table. She wanted to go see Adora. To embrace her. To never let her out of sight again! The idiot had been out for a week and Catra had been left to deal with the emotions of that alone.

Melog'd followed Adora around for Catra as Bow led her around the camp. It had been providing commentary.

"Adora ran into a pole face first."

"Adora saw Swiftwind again. They are loud together."

"Adora ate food. She had a sandwich which she said was good."

"Adora asked about you. She said she wants to see you."

"Adora ran into a pole again and the tent fell on her." Catra nearly spit out her coffee before laying her head on the table. She snickered as she envisioned the sight of her idiot under a collapsed tent.

"Catra?" Micah asked. She shot up and cleared her throat. "Are you alright?"

"I think someone's excited to see their girlfriend." Glimmer teased.

"Your majesty," a guard stepped in. "She-Ra just knocked down one of the supply tents."

"Adora!" Glimmer exclaimed before laughing. Micah smiled and shook his head. Glimmer looked to Catra.

"Melog told me." Catra smirked.

"I should've known." Glimmer sighed. "No one is hurt, right?"

"No." The guard seemed to struggle not to smile. "Just providing the update you asked for."

"Thank you." Micah dismissed the guard. They bowed and stepped out. "Why don't we call it a meeting for now? We are waiting for the supplies to arrive. We'll regroup after everyone is here."

"Sounds good to me." Glimmer threw her head back in exhaustion before snapping back to look at Catra. "Where's Adora now?" Catra's eyes shifted to the side as she asked Melog mentally.

"Main area."

"Let's go." Glimmer pushed out of her seat and headed for the door.

"Have fun." Micah called as they leave the tent. They walked in silence towards the main area. Set up similar to their last camp, before the final showdown with Prime, blankets marked seating areas circled in a half moon around the main console. She-Ra's glass mural shone down on the space, illuminating it with bright colors. Adora sat at the foot of the console, laughing with Scorpia and Bow. Glimmer rushed forward and dove into a hug with Adora and Bow. Laughter and gasps of surprise filled the air.

"Hey, you coming?" Glimmer turned to Catra. Catra rolled her eyes and joined them, taking a seat between Adora and Scorpia.

"Where are the others?" Adora asked.

"Mermista, Frosta and Perfuma are a part of the group sent to grab supplies."

"Is Mermista well enough for that?" Scorpia asked.

"She insisted." Glimmer answered. "She said she was sick of waiting around, doing nothing."

"Well, now that Adora's awake," Bow smiled. "We can get to work on actually taking ground back."

"Wait, you haven't done anything?" Adora asked.

"No." Catra closed her eyes. "On my orders. I said we would wait for you to wake before we made any moves."

"Firstly though." Glimmer's expression softened as she hesitated. She set her jaw and said, "Catra, you said you would explain everything when Adora woke."

"I know." Catra looked away. "Once the group returns with supplies…I will."

"Explain what?" Adora's voice tinged with hurt and confusion.

"Catra knew something was going on for the last month." Bow said hesitantly. "She was working in the background with…others to try and handle this herself. BUT!" Bow paused. "We wouldn't be here if it wasn't for her."

"I knew something was going on!" Adora stood and turned on her heels to face Catra. "I kept asking you to talk to me. I told you not to leave me in the dark anymore, Catra."

"I had my reasons." Catra bit each word.

"Of course, you did." Adora huffed. "I thought we were building trust. I thought you would've at least told me." Adora's voice broke at the end. Catra bit the inside of her lip to keep from responding. "What reasons did you have?" Shocked at the anger in Adora's voice, Catra looked at her with widened eyes. Adora's eyebrows furrowed, and her fists clenched at her sides.

"Adora, she said she would explain in a little bit." Glimmer tried.

"What reason did you have to not tell me?!" Adora put a hand to her chest. "We agreed to talk things out, Catra. That meant not keeping secrets. I kept trying to give you space as Lukkia advised. I have been trying all of things Lukkia said to get you to talk to me. What have *you* done?!"

"I couldn't tell you." Catra muttered.

"What?"

"I couldn't tell you, Adora!" Catra snapped, standing. Adora stepped back, shock filling her features. "I wanted to! You think I didn't?! It took everything in me not to tell you."

"What stopped you from telling me?" Adora whispered. Catra grabbed her arm in an attempt to comfort herself.

"I…I said I would explain when everyone else gets back." Catra cleared her throat and turned her back to Adora. "I only want to say it once, so you'll have to wait."

"Don't shut me out." Adora said.

"I just said I'll tell you soon." Catra tried to shut down the conversation. She pushed past Adora. This was a mistake. She knew she should've waited to talk to Adora until after she explained. She was an idiot for thinking Adora might not be furious with her. Of course, she would be.

"Catra. Please." Adora grabbed her wrist and stopped her. "I'm trying."

"I know. I am too." Catra took a shaky breath.

"Let's calm down." Bow stood and placed a hand on Adora's shoulder. "The others will be back soon."

"I'm sorry." Glimmer said. "I shouldn't have brought it up."

"It's fine, Glimmer." Adora pursed her lips before retaking her seat. "It was going to come up later anyway."

"I'll be back." Catra stalked off before anyone could speak. She wrapped her arms around herself before finding a small area to cram herself into. She took a shaky breath and placed her head between her knees. Melog appeared beside her with a meow. It nuzzled into her lap, forcing her to wrap around it.

"Adora is not angry with you."

"Yes, she is. You saw her, Melog."

"She is disappointed." Melog tried. "There is a difference."

"Not really." Catra sighed. "I don't know why I expected anything else. I've lost my touch, Melog."

"I do not think so."

"I didn't catch that Senator Brakenten was poisoning Adora from the beginning. I was late getting back to her and that resulted in her being chipped. Now, I can't even bring myself to face them and I'm ten steps behind where I need to be. I wasn't like this in the Horde. I've…I've gone soft." Catra gagged.

"I do not agree."

"Hard to not agree with that statement." Catra snorted.

"I do not believe you have gone soft. I believe you are in a safe environment…as safe as can be right now…" Catra chuckled at its correction. "You were so on top of things in the Horde because you had to be to survive. You were surviving Shadow Weaver, Hordak, and Prime." Melog growled Prime's name. "Now that those threats have passed, your body is catching up to you."

"You have got to stop hanging out at the Therapy Center with Markio." Catra said before she sniffled.

"Markio is smart." Melog laughed. "They are correct. You have not lost your touch. Your ability to save everyone you did by planning under duress is the reason we are here now. If you had lost your touch, as you say, we would not be here." It licked her face. "On Krytis, we acknowledged when we needed rest. We could not create or work all day. Our bodies could not maintain it. Your body is the same."

"I'm an alien?" Catra sassed. Melog crinkled its nose with a meow.

"And here I am, trying to be nice." It started to remove itself from her lap.

"Wait, don't go." It froze and looked at her in silence for a moment. It snickered and laid back down.

"I would never."

"That was for the sassy alien comment, wasn't it?"

"Obviously."

"Fine, I take it back."

"We do not take back words on Krytis. I do not accept."

"Then what am I supposed to do?"

"I do not know."

"Wow. Just leave me in the dark…"

"I will not comment on that." It snickered. "However, I will say that you have done well getting everyone here and keeping them safe. You should give yourself that credit."

"I guess."

"Catra?" Adora's voice called.

"Perhaps, you should try again. Communication never has been your strong suits…either of you."

"Gee, thanks."

"Not that it is your fault. Shadow Weaver was not a good mother figure. Good mothers give lots of headbutts and cuddles." Catra laughed at the phrase. How long ago had it been since Melog first said that to her on Bright Moon's balcony?

"Catra?" It gave her a look before glancing to where Adora's voice came from before looing back to her.

"Ugh! Fine. I'll go try and talk to her." Catra huffed as she crawled out of her hiding spot. "I blame you."

"I welcome the blame." Melog snickered. Catra ran a hand over her hair and dusted off her uniform before stepping out into the open area again.

"There you are." Adora relaxed a little.

"Oh, you found me." Catra held up her hands sarcastically.

"I always will." Adora smiled. "I'm sorry for earlier."

“Me too.” Catra rubbed her arm nervously. “I’m sure, like everyone else, you hate me now.” Catra laughed bitterly.

“What? No!”

“Don’t lie to me.” Catra’s expression soured, Adora’s following suit. “I know you’re angry with me.”

“Anger and hatred aren’t the same, Catra.”

“I disagree.”

“Then you hated me before?” Adora stepped back in shock. “When we were enemies?!”

“No. I mean, I wanted to.” Catra growled and stepped away. “I’m not trying to fight.”

“Then what are you trying to do?” Adora crossed her arms.

“I don’t know!” Catra threw her hands in the air.

“Why won’t you just trust me and tell me what’s going on? I could’ve been helping you this whole time?!”

“I already told you I had reasons.”

“That doesn’t tell me anything.”

“I wouldn’t have wanted your help anyway.”

“You don’t mean that.”

“Maybe I do.”

“Catra, we can’t keep doing this!”

“Doing what? This is our usual, isn’t it?”

“I don’t want to keep fighting with you.”

"Sure doesn't seem like it to me."

"Then how, how would I have been in your way? Give me one reason and I'll drop it." Lies. Adora couldn't drop something like this to save her life!

"Because this sort of thing is my job!"

"What?!"

"This!" Catra motioned to the leader's meeting area. "This is what I do best. I'm a planner. I'm a strategist. I can fight just like you, but I excel here and this is my position!"

"Then what's my job?" Adora set her jaw.

"Your job is to smile and swing that stupid She-Ra sword around!" Catra snapped and turned her back to Adora. "I don't know. I just know I have to be the one who does this sort of thing for you."

"I did just fine in the war without you doing this for me!" Adora yelled.

"Sure, falling for all of my taunts and traps was working so well for you." Catra waved her hands in the air for emphasis.

"Why are you so obsessed with that idea that I couldn't help here? I have strategist training too."

"Because…"

"What?"

"Because if you did," Catra spun around, unable to hold back the hot tears that burned down her cheeks. "then you wouldn't need me anymore..."



Chapter End Notes

Welp, here we be. Thank you to all of you who commented over the last 6 months. Truth is, I actually kinda abandoned this fic back in March, after posting chapter 14. I was so burnt out from writing it for a year and my friend introduced me to a new fandom and I've been hyperfocused on that one since. (Such a good show with such good music). But it was seeing your comments and seeing how much you all loved and supported this story that made me remember why I started it and brought back my motivation to continue. I started planning and rereading. (I'm planning a rewatch of the show at this point since I feel I've forgotten certain things I need. :P) But for real, I wouldn't be here posting without all of you, so thank you. I have cried reading some of the comments you have all left as they are so sweet and supportive. I can't thank you all enough for reminding me why I love She-Ra and for bringing me back.

That said, I truly feel Chapter 15 is a disservice to this series. Unfortunately, as the chapter following 14, which was the end of Act 1, chapter 15 feels bland and boring to me. I've rewritten scenes 5,6 times, hoping to make it better. So if it's a disappointment, I'm sorry. Truly. I feel you all deserve better for waiting 6 months for an update and to come back to this is...lackluster. However, I also try to remember that almost all Act 2 opening chapters/episodes/etc seem boring compared to the Act 1 ending. So I hope you will all give me a little grace on this and keep supporting the story. I've got some interesting plot points coming in future chapters so that should make up for it. Keyword, should.

Now, I wasn't going to point out any specific reviews this time but Keeva, you asked in your comment if I had the pictures another commenter spoke over for the outfits I created in Chapter 6. I do as I took screenshots before the artist removed them. (I didn't know and I was just excited to show my bestie. :P) I don't want to upload those as I don't have permission from the artist so out of respect for their hard

work, I won't. HOWEVER! I figured I couldn't leave you hanging! So...I opened my Procreate app and ATTEMPTED (Keyword Attempted) to draw my own version. It's terrible and I'm so sorry for how bad it turned out. I spent like 4-5 hours on it (I had never used Procreate before this. Did y'all know layers are like the best thing in the world with digital art! I wish I had found them sooner than I did with the picture but that's in the past). But I couldn't just update the chapter and not give y'all a peek at what the outfits are supposed to kinda look like. (Full disclaimer, I took a shot from the show: specifically Heart part 2 where they are looking at the Heart before Adora uses the failsafe, and used that as a tracing base and then colored over it. Also, I know Adora's hair looks bad. I didn't know how to draw the braid I gave her. :(Forgive me for the atrocity!)
https://www.tumblr.com/blog/view/yukinesoundofsnowfalling-blog/694514040766169088?source=share (Also no, comments on my Tumblr name. I haven't used it in forever but didn't have anywhere else to put the image so I could share it on A03.)
I will be honest with you and I am not sure when the next chapter will come. I am hoping by the end of October by the latest. Things have been really rough for me lately and it's made writing a little difficult, as well as some pain in my hands makes typing for long periods of time hard. I hope y'all will hang in there with me. Thank you for your support all of this time. I know I said this but we wouldn't be here without all of you. Thank you from the bottom of my heart.
-Luna

Differing Perspectives

Chapter Notes

Look at me, updating a week later than I said...what else is new. I did a thing and finished a chapter! It's not as polished as I had hoped and I wrote a lot of characters I hadn't for a while. Pls be kind. I'm sorry if this isn't the best. I'm trying to get back in to this. I hope you enjoy this.

The basic gist of this chapter? Adora gets some therapy and Catra recounts her traumas for the group. GREAT TIMES.

OH! I CHANGED THE TITLE TO AFTERSHOCK! I DID LEAVE A NOTE IN THE SUMMARY!! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 16: Adora

"I promised her!" Adora shouted, her white dress flaring out as she sharply turned to look at them. "I promised her I'd find her. I'd always find her. No matter what. No matter how far." Adora took in the ruined room around them, black cracks marring the floor and walls. "I can't accept this future. I can't…not without Catra."

"Adora. It'll be okay. We'll figure this out." Glimmer stepped forward. Glimmer's jewelry clinked in the deafening silence as she stretched out her hand.

"No!" Adora hugged herself and stepped back as tears burned down her cheeks. "No! I'm not losing anyone else, especially not my wife!" A small tug of her skirt drew Adora's eyes down. Small blue eyes overflowing with tears stared up at her.

She had just gotten her family back. She wasn't losing them again. "I'm going after her. Please. Take care of everyone." She looked to Bow and Glimmer once more.

"Of course." Glimmer scooped up the small being at Adora's side.

"Bring her back." Bow and Glimmer hugged her tightly before everyone stepped away. Adora turned to face the letter that sat atop the dresser. Catra's handwriting was still drying, tears staining the paper.

"I promised you my life and you promised me yours, Catra. I will find you." Adora closed her eyes as she summoned all of the magic she could. She-Ra glowed as the world around her warped. "I promise."

Adora's eyes flew open as she shot up from the bed with a gasp. She placed a hand over her chest. She struggled to breath. What was that? A dream? It felt too real to be a dream. It…it felt like a memory. Like when she saw Mara's memories through She-Ra. Adora touched her forehead gingerly, as if doing so would cause her to shatter.

"OH, MY STARS!" Adora winced as someone shouted. "SHE'S AWAKE!" She watched as the person ran off to tell… someone.

A purr drew her eyes down to the creature that stretched over her legs. Melog's bright blue eyes stared up at her, reminding of her the being from her dream. It wasn't Melog though…was it? She closed her eyes and tried to remember.

"Adora!" She looked back towards the entrance as her friends burst into the room.

"Why are you so obsessed with that idea that I couldn't help here? I have strategist training too."

"Because…"

"What?"

"Because if you did," Catra spun around, tears streaking down her cheeks. "then you wouldn't need me anymore..."

"I…" Adora's mouth fell open in shock. Is that what Catra thought? Is…was…was Catra worrying about this the whole time? "I…I need you, Catra."

"Don't lie." Catra snapped, clearly retreating into her anger. "We both know it's not like that…" Catra's voice dropped to a whisper. "despite how much we both wish it was."

"What do I have to do to get it through to you?" Adora grabbed Catra's wrists. Catra hissed, but her eyes widened with shock. "I need you with me, Catra. And we promised not to leave each other anymore."

"Let me go." Catra struggled against Adora's grip weakly.

"I will when you stop saying that!" Melog joined them, its red spiky mane embodying Catra's emotions. Melog jumped up and used its paws to separate them. Melog meowed at Catra as she stumbled back.

"I did try, Melog!" Catra bit out as she held herself and looked away. Melog growled a little, surprising Adora. Catra looked at it with a furious glare. Her expression fell as she exhaled harshly. "Fine, we'll do that." Catra motioned to it. "Happy?!"

"Do what?" Adora put her hands on her hips.

"Melog said to take a break and come back to this when we've calmed down."

"That's ridiculous. We can solve this now if you'll just talk to me."

"Adora, we both know it's right." Catra took a breath. Adora tried to speak as Catra interrupted. "Remember what Markio said? Arguing like this doesn't work for us and leads to miscommunications like…like Thaymor." Adora gripped her shirt, a weight on chest type feeling stealing her breath. "So." Catra growled and clapped her hands together, forcing a more neutral look on her face. "Let's… break for 20 minutes and I'll meet you back the leader's meeting area. Deal?"

Adora pursed her lips as she considered the deal. Lukkia's words about their relationship echoed in her ears.

"You and Catra are prone to friendship ending type miscommunications and arguments. Catra seems to have a lot of insecurities about your commitment to her based on her past experiences. You feel you have an obligation to protect people-yes I understand as She-Ra you do but we aren't talking about She-Ra at the moment. You and Catra are going to have issues communicating when upset while you both learn how to argue and communicate better. Breaks in arguments, having a trusted friend play mediator, etc. This will take time and you'll probably argue a lot, but it will get better as you two learn to talk to each other in a healthier manner."

"Fine." Adora agreed with a grumble. "20 minutes." Catra stalked off immediately, annoying Adora at how quickly she left. Adora exhaled harshly, resisting the urge to yell as she went towards the leader's meeting area. She'd wait for Catra there and then they would fix this.

Adora took a seat on the ground and curled into herself. Why was this so difficult? Why hadn't Catra trusted her? What was it about Adora that made her untrustworthy? Adora was the one who had gotten herself chipped. Adora had caused Catra to do whatever she had done. Catra wouldn't have acted like this

if Adora had just taken care of everything herself. All of this was her fault.

"Adora, you need to realize something." Lukkia removed her glasses and tapped one of the stems to her lips. "You cannot fix everything and everyone yourself. You need support from other people and that doesn't make you a bad person. The Horde had Force Captains, right?" Adora nodded. "And those Force Captains had people helping them, didn't they? EVEN if it was other Force Captains?" Adora nodded again. "So, if the Force Captains needed support in their roles, why wouldn't you?"

"Because I'm She-Ra!" Adora emphasized her words as she held out her hands.

"Okay. Let's put it this way. The Heart required all of the Princess to activate, correct? It's not something you could activate by yourself."

"That's not the same thing."

"How is it not the same?"

"That was a death machine meant to destroy the planet and everyone on it?! I almost died." Adora paused. "I…I almost died."

"Let's take a second and try some breathing exercises." Lukkia placed her glasses and notepad to the side. "That's a pretty big deal and we need to release the emotions around that."

"I'm fine." Adora crossed her arms and looked away.

"Is that because you are actually fine, or is it the constant pressure you feel to be fine for everyone's sake?"

"You don't understand."

"Is this because you had to be good enough to protect Catra from Shadow Weaver?"

"I just…" Adora huffed as tears streaked down her cheeks. She stood and walked away from the chair. Lukkia sat back in her seat and watched as Adora paced back and forth. Adora wiped furiously at her face. "I shouldn't be crying. I just have to be good enough. I have to be. I'm She-Ra. You didn't see the looks everyone gave me when I lost her. People need She-Ra."

"Do your friends not need Adora too?" Lukkia's question stopped Adora in her tracks. She stared at Lukkia for a moment. "Let me rephrase. Why did your friends become your friends?"

"Because I'm She-Ra. That was the only reason I was accepted into the Rebellion because of She-Ra."

"Okay. So, most of your friends started being your friends because of that... What about Catra? Catra was your friend before you were She-Ra. When you were in the Horde? Why was she your friend?"

"Catra…" Adora paused. The two had just become friends when Catra was found in box of applesauce. Adora had immediately claimed Catra as her friend. Shadow Weaver had begrudgingly allowed Catra to stay in the Horde as a cadet. "I don't know. Catra just became my friend when I found her."

"Catra just became your friend?"

"That's what I just said."

"Which would mean Catra became friends with you as Adora. Not because of anything you could do. But because you're Adora." Lukkia smirked. "So, not ALL of your friends became your friend because of what you could do."

"I guess."

"You guess?" Lukkia prompted. Adora sighed heavily and retook her seat. Her leg bounced nervously as she crossed her arms. Lukkia wrote something on her pad and then looked to Adora again. "So, let's go back to what we started with. If you aren't able to activate…that…alone, then even She-Ra needs support, right?"

"I guess."

"Guessing again? What if I say it's a yes or no question?" Lukkia asked.

"Adora?" Bow's voice shook her from the memory before she could remember how she answered Lukkia's question. "Are you alright?" Glimmer stood behind Bow as he gingerly touched Adora's arm.

"Where's Catra?" Glimmer asked.

"She asked for some time before we tried to talk." Adora sighed and rubbed her eyes. "We got in a fight about everything."

"I'm sorry, Adora." Glimmer spoke. "I shouldn't have brought that up when I did."

"Glimmer." Bow took her hand.

"I can't really snap at Catra for not trying if I'm doing the same thing I used to." Glimmer took Adora's outstretched hand and squeezed. "I should apologize to her too."

Adora squeezed her hands back and smiled. Maybe Lukkia was right. Maybe her friends did like for Adora, and not just as She-Ra. Maybe she had a purpose. Maybe Adora as herself was enough.

"Hey!" A guard called to them. "We are gathering at the main area."

"Wait, what? Why?" Glimmer asked.

"The Scout Group led by Princess Mermista just returned. Royal Strategist Catra has requested all of the Alliance convene in the main area immediately."

"She just…" Adora growled before taking a deep breath. "Let's go."

Upon returning to the main area once more, Adora noticed they were the last to arrive. The rest of the Alliance sat in a crescent shape facing the console. Some of the guard and other people from the castle sat behind the Alliance members. The giant mural loomed over them, the pressure of She-Ra becoming heavier by the second. Adora turned her attention to her girlfriend if they were still even that.

Catra stood at the center console, peering over Entrapta's shoulder at a screen. She ran a hand through her hair and crouched down to point to something on screen. Adora followed Bow's gentle prompting to take a seat near the center of the crescent. Bow sat to her left and Glimmer to her right. They sat straight in front of Catra and Entrapta. Catra clearly had noticed their seating choice, her tail twitching with annoyance.

"Thank you all for coming." Catra drew their attention to herself. She made eye contact with Adora. Catra looked away immediately, choosing to sweep her gaze across the group as a whole. "I told you all I would explain everything that has happened up to this point," Catra waved towards her feet, gestured to the moment in time. "on the condition we waited until Adora was awake and everyone was here."

"Don't start that yet, Darling." A voice interrupted. They turned to see the same guard that had approached them about meeting in the main area approach Catra.

"Who are you?" Frosta asked as she looked them up and down.

"So rude." The guard flicked their wrist toward the ice princess. "To think you wouldn't remember me." The guard looked at Glimmer as their eyes flickered green. Their outfit glowed black as they shifted into their normal form, Double Trouble.

"You!" Perfuma exclaimed. "Why are you here?"

"Good to see you too. At least this time we aren't in an underwater bubble while you all fight." Double Trouble flipped their hair over their shoulder as they turned to see Catra. "Hello, Kitten."

"I told you not to call me that!" Catra snarled.

"Yes, yes. Do you want your update or not?" Double Trouble asked.

Update? Had…Had Catra trusted Double Trouble over her? Catra trusted a lying shapeshifter over her own girlfriend? Adora's chest ached as she wondered what she had done to Catra to deserve this.

"Come with me." Catra growled as she started to leave the area. "Just give me a minute!" she called to the rest. Adora watched as Catra and Double Trouble spoke. She wished she could hear what they were saying. Based on their body language and hand movements, it was clearly a heated conversation. Catra ended the conversation abruptly and handed them a bag of money.

Returning, she brushed her hair from her eyes and clasped her hands.

"Are we just going to ignore the clearly illegal activity here?" Mermista asked the group.

"As if you aren't dating an arsonist." Catra retorted. "Can I continue?" Mermista waved her hand away. Catra took a steading breath.

"Since our victory over Prime, there was a grave threat looming over this…planet." Catra motioned to the stars carved into the ceiling. "I was made aware of this threat after the library… incident…and I chose to ensnare Scorpia, Entrapta, and Hordak in this with me. They are not to blame. If you want to be angry…be angry with me and not them. They were simply following my orders under my authority as a part of Queen Glimmer's council. I threatened that not following my orders would mean severe punishment as those I inflicted in the Horde."

Adora noticed as Scorpia covered her mouth and looked away. Entrapta's expression fell as she returned to her screens. A tendril pushed her mask over her face.

"Okay, but what was this grave threat?" Mermista crossed her arms defensively. "And that still doesn't explain why you couldn't tell us about it."

Catra's tail flicked back and forth as her ears twitched. She closed her eyes in an attempt to calm down.

"Let's be kind." Micah spoke. "I understand we are all upset at this, and we have lost a lot. We do have to keep in mind we would not be here, alive, and safe, without Catra's efforts." Micah offered Catra a soft look. "While I do not agree with Catra's silence on the matter, I am sure she had a good reason for it."

"How can you say that, your Majesty?" Juliet asked.

"I have worked with Catra personally over the last several months since she joined us. I can attest to her good nature. And my daughter advocated for her and chose Catra as part of her council. I trust my daughter and I trust Catra." Micah said proudly.

"Dad." Glimmer smiled.

"Please continue." Micah prompted.

"Thank you." Catra collected herself. "Though, I'm not sure you should say that." Catra hesitated, and her eyes flicked over to Glimmer. "Considering who was behind the threat..."

"What do you mean?" Bow asked.

"Just say it!" Frosta stated as she threw her arms open. Before Catra could respond, voices from the group behind the Alliance erupted with angry cries.

"Are you saying it was someone in the castle?"

"You're accusing someone close to us being behind this?"

"Everyone here wouldn't do something like that, except for you!"

"I knew accepting the *Horde* was a terrible idea."

"We should've banished them to another planet for their actions."

"ENOUGH!" Adora yelled as she stood. "You all accepted me and I'm from the Horde."

"You're She-Ra! It's different." Adora gasped slightly. Several echoed the answer, but she couldn't hear them anymore. The world spun around her.

"Hey!" Catra shouted. Everyone quieted. "Do you want your explanation or not?! If so, sit down and shut up! Also, whoever said it's because she's She-Ra…say that again." Catra flexed her claws. A deathly silence flooded the area. "Thank you." Adora retook her seat and clasped her hands over her lap.

"The…The person whose cause all of this is…" Catra took a steady breath. "Senator Brakenten."

"The Senator?!"

"They would never!"

"This is all a plot to distract us from her plans."

"This is Horde tech; it was properly Princess Entrapta and that Horde scum beside her."

"DO NOT" Catra yelled again. "BRING THEM INTO THIS." They quieted for a moment. "I forced them to help me. I know it sounds crazy, but I promise." Catra made eye contact with Adora, a pleading look in her eyes. "Senator Brakenten is to blame for this."

"Wait!" Glimmer stood to face everyone and held up a hand before the crowd could start again. "Entrapta is our friend, and we know she wouldn't do this. The same applies to Princess Scorpia. They agreed to take in those left from Horde Prime to help them on MY orders." Glimmer paused and looked to Catra. "I don't think I will like this…but" Glimmer set her jaw. "I'm ordering you as Queen to continue and to tell us everything."

"Wow, and they say I abuse my power." Catra teased as she crossed her arms. She smirked at Glimmer but agreed. "Like I was saying." Glimmer retook her seat and squeezed Adora's hand. "Senator Brakenten approached me after the Library accident. They found me in the council room alone while I was waiting for Adora." Adora squeezed Glimmer's hand tighter. "They brought me a vial of liquid." Catra paused, clearly resisting panic. She cleared her throat and continued.

"That vial was the same as what was in the conditioning pools used by Prime." Several gasps sounded around the area.

"Where did they even get a hold on that?"

"It was all destroyed when She-Ra defeated Horde Prime."

"The Horde clones must have had more."

"That Hordak is probably leading it."

"Hordak was not involved!" Entrapta snapped, throwing her mask up. "He's innocent in this!"

"Let Catra continue." Glimmer called for quiet. She motioned to Catra.

"The Senator told me that if…if I didn't want Adora to be chipped, I had to stay out of their way." The realization struck Adora and forced a soft cry from her lips. She covered her mouth to muffle the sound as she looked away.

"I couldn't tell you, Adora!" Catra snapped, standing. Adora stepped back, shock filling her features. "I wanted to! You think I didn't?! It took everything in me not to tell you."

Catra had been trying to protect her. And all Adora had done was yelled at her…

"With that threat in mind, I began investigating to see what exactly the Senator was planning. I had to be careful not to get caught and risk Adora and others getting chipped." Catra continued. "The next incident was the trip to see Salineas' gate completion." Catra looked to Mermista. "The vial you gave me before you went to stop Seahawk from burning a boat…It was another vial with the liquid from the pools. It contained a note that it was a reminder." Mermista covered her mouth in horror, sharing a look with Seahawk.

"A vial was found near Adora during one of her magic episodes." Catra continued as she looked at Micah. "The night you helped us in the kitchen, a vial was found beside her."

"You mean, Adora had ingested the liquid?" Bow asked.

"It wasn't clear." Catra answered. "That was the night I brought Hordak into the mix. I knew he would have more information on the vials then I would. Melog and I traveled to see

him at midnight, hoping to escape detection. I gave him a few days to find me an answer without telling anyone else, right?" Catra asked Hordak. He nodded.

"The next was in Plumeria." Catra turned toward Perfuma. "We were ambushed during a visit there to speak to Perfuma."

"That's why you didn't show up that day?" Perfuma asked in a small voice. Catra nodded.

"No vial was found there, but it was clearly an attempt to stop me from looking further. We returned to Entrapta's castle to check in with Hordak. He stated he would require Entrapta's assistance and technology to analyze the vials further. I decided to force Entrapta and Scorpia to join in finding answers. With them being further away, I hoped it would be easier to sneak around without being found."

Adora heard Perfuma whisper, "You were forced?" Scorpia clearly hesitated to answer.

"Entrapta was sure the network had been shut down with her tech and based on her research, it had been. This made it harder to figure out if the chips were a true threat. Entrapta advised if I would allow Adora to undergo tests, we could figure out if the Senator had done anything. The same time, Scorpia alerted me to the Horde clones returning to the Fright Zone for an unknown reason."

"So, we made a plan. We would bring Adora with us for the Fright Zone mission and use that guise as a way to run tests. It was a great idea…or so I thought. That night as I returned to Bright Moon, I found Senator Brakenten talking to Glimmer. Seeing Glimmer planning with the Senator…it showed me that no one was safe to trust." Catra finished slowly.

"That explains why you were so upset." Bow spoke softly. "I'm sorry I didn't notice."

"It's fine, Bow. I don't blame you." Catra grabbed a drink of water. "The next morning, Glimmer pulled me into a meeting to tell me about the Community Centers they were working on. After Glimmer left, the Senator revised their threat. Originally, the threat was if I got involved or stopped them. But they caught on to my trips to see Entrapta. The treat became if Adora leaved Bright Moon for any reason, they would…" Catra choked up, turning around to take a breath. "They would chip her through the same tortuous methods that…that I was chipped."

The silence that ensued in light of Catra's words was deafening. Adora remembered their fight before the Fright Zone trip. Catra had been adamant Adora stay in Bright Moon and had even physically fought her to prevent the trip. The damage done to Catra's room when they arrived later. All of Catra's actions made sense and the only thing that lingered in place of Adora's anger was shame. Shame for doubting her girlfriend this whole time. Shame for not even attempting to understand Catra's actions or side of the story. Shame for the way she jumped straight to anger…like Shadow Weaver used to.

"I fought them," Catra motioning to Adora's area. "to keep her from going to the Fright Zone, knowing that now meant the threat was much more real."

"What…" Glimmer asked.

"You still haven't figured it out, Sparkles? Those Community Centers of yours were chipping centers with conversion pools." Catra said somberly. Glimmer gasped and looked down.

"I caused this?"

"Glimmer, no. You…" Could Adora actually say Glimmer wasn't at fault? But none of them had noticed.

"Why would they tell you?" Adora asked.

"I don't know." Catra sighed and crossed her arms. "They hate me, so I guess it was an attempt to mess with me, hurt me?"

"I put so much work into those." Glimmer cried as she turned into Bow's arms. "I can't believe I messed up again." Adora clenched her fists.

Why…Catra knew all of this was going on…and she didn't stop it. Visions of the destruction caused by Prime and all the lives lost flashed by her eyes. Anger welled in her, all earlier sentiments gone.

"Why didn't you stop them?!" Adora snapped. "You knew this was going on the whole time?! And you didn't do anything to stop them? Everyone on the planet was put in danger and you did nothing?!"

"Adora, wait." Scorpia held out a pincer.

"I did nothing?!" Catra guffawed. "I kept you alive. I worked my tail off to keep everyone as safe as I could."

"You're proud of that?! You chose my life over everyone else!"

"Of course I did!"

"My life doesn't matter like that."

"IT DOES TO ME!" Catra yelled, silence following. "It does to me! And it always will! I will ALWAYS pick you over anyone and everyone else!" Adora shut her mouth. "How many times do I have to tell you that?"

"I…"

"What?"

"I can't be like that, Catra." Adora smacked her hand against her chest. "I'm She-Ra. I have to put everyone above myself. I have to keep them safe. I can't afford to be so…selfish!"

"Then I'll be selfish enough for the both of us!" Catra retorted loudly before she blushed.

"What?" Adora blinked rapidly in surprise.

"I…" Catra cleared her throat before walking to Adora. She grabbed a fistful of Adora's shirt and pulled her close. "I will always choose your life first. Before anyone else. Before mine. If you can't be selfish, then I will be selfish for you."

"If she wasn't an evil mastermind, I'd say that's the most romantic thing I've heard." A voice from the crowd called. Catra's face flushed red, still holding Adora's shirt, as she yelled.

"Who said that?!" Laughter erupted as Catra covered her face with the back of her hand.

"Back to the topic on hand." Micah called as the laughter died down. "Adora, I think it's important we recognize what Catra has said on to why she didn't tell anyone. The attack in Plumeria would've meant Perfuma couldn't be trusted. The vial in Salineas meant Mermista and Seahawk weren't safe. If Glimmer was working with the Senator unknowingly, Glimmer, Bow, Juliet, myself, we wouldn't be safe to trust either. And if Adora was being threatened and couldn't be told, who would that have left?" The group sat in the awkward silence as the truth of the situation lingered.

"Wait." Frosta spoke. "I wasn't on that list!"

"You punched me when we met!" Catra jabbed a finger her way.

"That's…" Frosta pouted and mumbled. "You still could've come to me."

"At that point in time, I was already risking so much ask-forcing those 3 to work for me. I didn't want to bring anyone else in who could get hurt." Catra answered as she rubbed her arm.

"Catra." Scorpia cleared her throat. "Stop saying that. You didn't force us to help you." She spoke to the crowd. "We helped Catra with her plans of our own free will. Right?!" She looked to Entrapta and Hordak.

"Yeah!" Entrapta agreed.

"I might have been forced." Hordak smirked at Catra. "But I suppose we can't blame her."

"Wha-" Catra panicked.

"We aren't letting you take the blame for this alone." Scorpia smiled. "You worked so hard to prevent this and help everyone. Without your planning and hard work, we wouldn't be here."

"And you got me so much new data!" Entrapta squealed.

"Without Catra's work, we wouldn't have the antidote to the chips. You should be grateful to her." Hordak commanded.

"Wow, even Hordak stood up for you." Scorpia laughed. "He doesn't do that often."

"Do not lump me in with those emotional-"

"It's okay, Hordak." Entrapta cooed. "You're still my lab partner, right?! That's all that matters."

"Yes, I suppose it does." Hordak collected himself and returned to his brooding silence.

"I think there is still part of the story left…" Micah asked. After a moment, Catra nodded. Everyone who had stood moved back to their seats. Catra took a deep breath.

"Thank you." She said to Scorpia, Entrapta, and Hordak. "In Dryl, Entrapta ran tests on Adora while we faced the ambush in Fright Zone."

"Wait, the voices we heard, Prime's voice…was that the Senator?"

"I'm not sure, Bow." Catra answered. "I'm sure it was. Truthfully, that wasn't what I focused on. The test results for Adora and…" Catra shuddered. "Seeing the pools again… I couldn't care about the Prime's voice in that moment. I'm sure it was a created recording meant to scare us."

"It definitely did the job." Glimmer remarked, earning a smirk from Catra.

"When we eventually returned to the castle, Scorpia and I began planning what to do since the Senator's rule had been broken and Adora was in danger. Entrapta asked me to return to Dryl to discuss the test results. So Melog and I snuck out."

"Ooh! Can I say this part?!" Entrapta jumped up.

"Sure." Catra sat at the base of the console as Entrapta moved towards the open area.

"Okay! I might have kinda done some testing on Adora while we were in space, going to rescue Glimmer. So, when I ran tests on Adora in Dryl during the Fright Zone mission and then again when Adora collapsed after the mission, I compared those to the data I took on Darla!" Entrapta motioned to Hordak. Hordak pressed a few buttons and a holographic chart cast over the mural.

"See," Entrapta used her hair to push herself in the air. Catra snickered slightly, though Adora wasn't sure why. "Adora's magic level should be here!" Entrapta pointed to a spot very low on the chart.

"I'm not *that* weak." Adora grumbled.

"This," Entrapta moved up to the highest points on the chart. "is where Adora's magic was after she collapsed. "The only other time I've seen it this high was when the Heart was activated!" Catra's eyes widened and narrowed. Maybe Entrapta hadn't told her that part…

"Her magic was literally off the charts!" Entrapta squealed. But when the Heart was stopped, the magic levels dropped again. This time," the graph shifted. "her magic levels dropped but not to the same level. Her magic was still active." Entrapta clapped her hands together.

"Active how?" Glimmer looked to Adora. "Wouldn't you have noticed that? Or she would've been glowing?" Glimmer turned to Entrapta.

"Not necessarily." Entrapta dropped to the ground. "After Hordak and I looked over everything, we concluded that something else was causing this. That's when we found it~!" Entrapta paused for dramatics. "POSION!"

"What?!" Adora stood. "I would've known if I was poisoned!"

"The magic levels being that high meant something was causing Adora to be using magic at a constant unsustainable rate." Hordak answered. "When Adora returned and Entrapta proceeded with her tests," Entrapta brought up a toxicology report on her screen. "Traces of poison were found in her system.

"How…" Adora muttered.

"You're telling me that the Senator had found a way to poison her and none of us knew?!" Glimmer spoke as horror filled her features.

"She would've been poisoned daily for months for it to be that bad." Hordak said.

"Like the tea?" Catra said somberly.

"The tea?" Bow asked. Adora crashed to her knees. The tea. She knew she had felt off since taking it. When she asked about it, the mage she had seen had told her that meant it was working.

"Adora!" Several voices cried out. Murmurs filled the crowd as Catra sat silently, watching Adora. A guard approached her and Catra whispered something to them. She sent them off with a wave.

"This whole time."

"The poison was a low enough dose Adora wouldn't have outright noticed it." Hordak continued. "However, over time the effect was double."

"So…was the poison behind Adora's magic episodes?" Perfuma questioned.

"Oh, we didn't talk about that yet." Entrapta smiled. "Those were aftershocks! From the Heart. Adora was still attached to it and since the Heart wasn't fully activated, the magic had to go somewhere. The episodes should have fizzled out and gotten less drastic as the magic was dispersed."

"That makes sense." Bow said thoughtfully. "If the poisoning started right around the timeframe the attacks would have lessened, that explains why they never got better. She-Ra was in a constant state of healing and drawing magic from the Heart to keep you alive." Bow squeezed her shoulder.

"Right around the time Entrapta and Hordak finished explaining this to me, Glimmer showed up."

"That's why you wanted to return so fast. Adora really was in danger."

"By the time we got back, it was too late. Adora had been chipped and was under the Senator's control. Scorpia had orders to get everyone out alive and get them here. Entrapta and Hordak would meet them and begin sending out messages to all the others to gather here versus Bright Moon. I lead the clones on a chase all night into the morning when Entrapta finally sent me a signal that everything was safe."

"And then there was the fight with Chipped She-Ra." Glimmer sighed. "By the way, you are never to do that again. Queen's orders."

"You think I wanted that?!~" Adora exclaimed. "It…it was among the worst pain I've felt. I couldn't control myself."

"I get that." Mermista echoed.

"It'll get better." Scorpia tried.

"Eventually, the nightmares and phantoms fade to a less drastic level." Catra added before swinging her arms out. "That's how we got here."

Adora looked around as she realized most of the crowd had left. She listened as the sounds of people preparing and building things echoed in the chamber.

"And now, we have the latest update to discuss." Catra sighed.

"You mean, what Double Trouble told you about?" Frosta asked.

“Yeah. I think you all should sit down for it though.” Catra motioned for them to sit. Adora looked to Catra, who kept her eyes on the ground. “I’ve had Double Trouble looking into the situation for me since I involved the others. They kept an eye on the Senator and learned what they could for me. They came to check in a few days ago, while I was in the infirmary. They told me we had another war on our hands.”

“War?!” Several of the remaining muttered amongst themselves.

“This latest update was regarding the state of the cities.” Catra spoke nervously, her tail curled around her leg. Her ears fell. “Double Trouble reported that all of Bright Moon, Salineas and Plumeria have fallen and are chipped.”

Chapter End Notes

Dun Dun Dun... Act 2 has officially kicked off! I hope this chapter wasn't too terrible. I know it was kinda of a recap of everything but also it's been a long year so I felt it still kinda worked. And more importantly, we got to see Adora's half of it and reactions to what Catra went through. My goal is to update by the end of December. Would that mean chapter 17 is a holiday gift to y'all? Who knows?! See you soon!

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